No love, No Light

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25732411.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M, Other

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Angella/Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), George/Lance (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Angella & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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Angella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Princess Alliance (She-Ra) - Character, Huntara (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bright Moon General (She-Ra), Juliet (She-Ra), Flutterina (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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by OracleOfDestiny

Summary

Shadow Weaver appears in Bright Moon hoping to gain the Rebellion's help for her vengeance on Hordak and discovers some shocking truths about herself. With the help of Queen Angella, she learns that power comes in many forms. Is it too late for her to learn them?

Notes

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Spoilers: I’m picking and choosing what canon plotlines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, “Light Spinner” will be pretty spoilery.

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Author’s Note: This is inspired by fan art, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine’s song “No Light, No Light” along with Five Finger Death Punch’s “Wrong Side of Heaven.” My brain couldn’t leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

Big thanks to @faithlessfate for giving this chapter a quick look. We are both human, so any mistakes I claim as my own.

See the end of the work for more notes

Prologue: I Was Disappearing In Plain Sight

Chapter Summary

In the beginning....

Prologue: I Was Disappearing In Plain Sight

Mystacor was known for having unusual magical occurrences throughout its island but when the Angelic Beings arrived in Mystacor it was an almost dull day. The tall pale purple cobblestone buildings remained reaching high towards the bright sky. Every edge of the floating island still had a plethora of fluffy clouds obscuring them from the outside world.

Norwyn had insisted all the head sorcerers and apprentices come out to the arched entrance as a welcoming party. Bundles of dried basil, iris, and wisteria decorated the entrance arch, perfuming the slightly chilled air with a combination of sweet and earthy scents.

With afternoon lessons canceled, an all-consuming delight spread throughout the Mystacor inhabitants. Without warning, a single floating cluster of sparkling lights gleamed through the arch. It grew larger and larger until its glow was too much to gaze upon. Everyone shielded their eyes until the display was over.

“Sorcerers and apprentices of Mystacor allow me to formally welcome Queen Nigella and Princess Angella of Empyrean,” Norwyn announced with a flourish of his hand as the population of Mystacor continued to gape at the blinding radiance that was

the Angelic Beings upon their plane. The congregation bowed and greeted the royal matriarchs without hesitation.

The monarch's combined oppressive presence was gluey and steamy like a hot summer day after a thunderstorm. It clung to the air around them and seemed to dull the sorcerer's senses. Light Spinner glanced around and saw most of Mystacor was staring slack-jawed at their beauty.

Queen Nigella had a silver sunburst crown that floated above her head of cascading plum tinted curls. The ivory cape she wore draped only over one shoulder. She donned an elegant periwinkle mid-calf length gown with butterfly sleeves. White elbow-length gloves encased her arms. Her double set of wings were much larger than her daughter's and her presence seemed to take up the expanse of the area. The Queen's piercing, hawk-like gaze darted around, scrutinizing every detail of the crowd in front of them.

Light Spinner's first opinion of Princess Angella was that she looked young. Far too young to be the heir apparent for the Empyrean throne. She was a near mirror image of her mother, the only difference being the teardrop pearls dangling from her ears and the ombre hair of light pink and lavender pulled into a carefully curled high ponytail on the back of her head.

Returning her attention to the Angelic Beings, Light Spinner noticed the Queen appeared unconcerned with the reception but Princess Angella's fingers twitched. Queen Nigella's eyes moved to Angella and the Princess stiffened. Light Spinner raised a questioning ebony eyebrow at the falter.

The Princess stared back in challenge despite the darkening of her cheeks. Light Spinner decided to take pity on the ombre haired angel and moved her eyes to the other figures accompanying them. Their entourage only held three other beings in simple clothing. They wore identical, single-breasted off white robes. The long sleeve robes had snowy trim on all sides. Large hoods

obscured the trio's faces. Silky, ash white wings flowed from their back.

"Queen Nigella, It's been too long," Norwyn said, walking forward.

The robed figure nearest the Queen tensed but made no other moves to advance.

Queen Nigella shook her head once in a near indiscernible motion as Norwyn approached. He bowed and waited for her to acknowledge him. She nodded before reaching out, placing her limp hand in Norwyn's outstretched one. "Master Norwyn, thank you for your hospitality," she answered in a lilting posh accent.

Light Spinner had concluded the robed being's purpose moments before Queen Nigella's actions confirmed her hunch. The power in that slight movement was immense. It was obvious there was no need for them to be intimidating, because the guards could handle any threat.

"Let me show you where you'll be staying." Norwyn led the group away.

Light Spinner made no move to follow them. She had other duties to attend to that evening. The lilac eyes of Princess Angella landed on her once more, watching her curiously just before the entourage disappeared. Once the Angelic Beings were out of sight, the crowd of apprentices began to disperse, deciding that a walk to sleeping quarters was where their enjoyment ended.

"Light Spinner!" Micah shouted excitedly.

"Yes, Micah?" Light Spinner asked calmly.

Micah clasped his hands together. "Will you please take me to meet the Princess? She's the most beautiful girl I've ever seen." He pleaded with wide eyes.

"They are here for an extended stay, Micah. You will have plenty of time to speak with the Princess and relay that information to

her," Light Spinner said, walking to the main hall. The duty of lighting the Imbolc candles this evening fell to her since Norwyn and his followers were attending to their honored guests.

"But this is the only day I'll have a full afternoon of free time!" Micah called after her.

Light Spinner woke with the dawning moonlight every morning out of habit. It was one of the only times one could be alone in Mystacor. She performed her morning stretches and ablutions to wake up her body and mind then headed to the kitchens for her daily morning ritual.

Unfortunately, luck was not on her side today as there was a royal interloper to her private time. She almost dropped the scroll she'd brought for light reading in her surprise.

"Good morning, Light Spinner," Angella said, beaming at her from her seat.

"Good morning, Princess. Are you having trouble sleeping?" Light Spinner busied herself by looking for her teacup in the arrangement of dishes on the counter.

"It's taking some time to adjust to how dark it gets here," Angella admitted, sipping from the very teacup Light Spinner was looking for.

"Why are you drinking from that one?" Light Spinner asked with a frown.

"I just picked it," Angella said as she rubbed a careful finger down the small imperfection on the rim. "It has character." She glanced up and started at the near accusatory gaze directed at her. "I'm sorry. I didn't know this was yours."

“They aren’t assigned,” Light Spinner bit out, grabbing a different teacup.

It was true that the dishes weren’t assigned but it was also an unspoken rule that she always drank from the one with the chip left of the handle. She was given the cup as a taunt from the one and the only day her mask failed to cover her face during her early apprentice years. She used the teacup out of spite and was annoyed that it being in Angella’s hands even bothered her so much.

Light Spinner took a calming breath then waved her hand to heat her water. Once the steam curled from the cup, she opened the hidden tin with prepared sacks of her tea blend.

“Oh, do you make your own tea?” Angella asked.

“I prefer my tea a certain way and this is the easiest way to ensure its freshness.” Light Spinner spoke without inflection as she patiently steeped the tea.

After adding two sugar cubes, Light Spinner brought the cup to her nose and inhaled the soothing spicy, earthy scent of her ginger tea. She started to the table nearest the door.

“There’s plenty of room here.” Angella offered.

Light Spinner nodded in acknowledgment but continued to her intended table and settled with her scroll. With a practiced hand, she sipped her tea without removing the veil covering her mouth. She sensed eyes on her every move. After a few more moments of this, she decided to say something. “You’re staring,” the sorcerer said without looking up.

“Oh my goodness, I have to meet my mother this morning to discuss the affairs back home,” Angella said suddenly, ducking her head. She stood and glided to a distant cart used for soiled dishes. Her wings moved gracefully as she turned in midair and continued out the door.

Everyone in Mystacor knew that the rose garden was Light Spinner's domain. Its resplendent beauty was the envy of multiple kingdoms. The garden bloomed to greet the early afternoon moonlight as their sweet smells enticed the large bumblebees that frequented the plants. Their fuzzy bodies dipped from flower to flower to gather pollen.

Light Spinner walked past the gathered insects calmly with a bundle of muslin in her arms. She carried it to a small gardening shed located a couple of feet from the orange roses. She discarded the soiled cloth from the chestnut cupboard and meticulously cut pieces out for each wooden drawer.

"Light Spinner." Angella called from the doorway after a courtesy knock. "How are you today?"

"Hello, Princess. My day is fair," Light Spinner said. Using her gardening shears, she trimmed the frayed edges from the muslin.

Angella touched one of the tied stalks of lavender. "It smells lovely in here. Are you preparing one of your tea blends?"

"It is my turn to dry the herbs for Mystacor." Light Spinner carefully placed the bundles of sage and rosemary onto the clean muslin.

"It's so peaceful in here," Angella said with a happy sigh.

"Indeed." Light Spinner closed the first drawer filled with fresh herb stalks.

"It's definitely not like the rest of Mystacor," Princess Angella said, brushing her fingers over a nearby jar of fennel. "Everyone wants all of my time."

Ever since arriving in Mystacor, Princess Angella never traveled without an entourage of her own. It seemed no one was immune to her allure. If Micah wasn't attending lessons he was wherever Angella happened to be.

As if summoned by Light Spinner's thoughts, Micah ran to the door. "Princess Angella, I'm so glad I found you." He panted. "I wanted to know if you would be willing to accompany me to the dining hall?"

"Light Spinner would you like to join us?" Princess Angella glanced at the sorcerer.

Light Spinner watched the amusing combination of confusion and disappointment creep across Micah's face. She smirked internally and debated whether or not to take her time responding. "No, thank you, Princess," she said, turning back to her task.

"Maybe I'll see you later?" Princess Angella asked.

Light Spinner hummed noncommittally.

Mystacor was known not only for its magic tutelage but also its renowned library. The books were preserved by hand. There was no stasis enchantment invented that would preserve the information and not damage the book bindings. Light Spinner grabbed two large books in her arms, stirring the sweet, woody aroma from the ancient writings. Making her way up the ladder, she placed the books one by one in the proper place.

"She has quite the little fan club." An amused voice whispered up to her.

"Acqui," Light Spinner said in greeting. Even as she reached the ground, the brunette didn't turn around to see who the *she* in

question was. She fought against the tension threatening to overtake her. Once or twice was definitely a coincidence, but this was more than simple chance. She had her suspicions before but now she was certain the Princess was seeking her out. “What could possibly bring you to the library?” she asked, brushing the dust off the hardcover of *Rune Lexicons* .

Acqui’s pierced nose twitched. They waved their hands to clear the air. “I do read.” They protested.

“Color me surprised,” Light Spinner said, climbing up the ladder.

“Keep being catty and I won’t share what I’ve learned.” Acqui brushed their bangs out of their eyes.

Light Spinner knew the threat was a ruse. She slowly turned over another weathered tome in her palm. Acqui lived for gossip. Their glee in oversharing was almost compulsive. All Light Spinner had to do was wait until their patience ran out.

“Queen Nigella has been asking about you.” Acqui steadied the ladder.

Light Spinner sent a book floating further away to the shelf behind her. “The Queen asked about me?” she asked.

Acqui smirked. “I only had the best things to say about you, of course.”

“I’m sure,” Light Spinner said, returning to her book cart.

“You should know Master Norwyn’s not happy with you.” Acqui stood in front of the cart.

“When is he ever?” Light Spinner responded. She steered around Acqui and refilled it at the desk.

Acqui stepped almost indecently close. “Can I see you later?” they asked.

“Not tonight,” Light Spinner said. She glanced to see if they were hidden between the desk and the reference alcove.

“You have a better offer?” Acqui asked with a frown and fake pout of their bottom lip.

Light Spinner knew better. Acqui had been hinting for quite some time they wanted a closer relationship. She wished they understood their emotional scheming was useless on her. “I am not in the mood.”

“You haven’t been in the mood for a while. Give me a chance to convince you.” Acqui flashed Light Spinner a flirtatious smile.

“I have to finish shelving,” Light Spinner said, pushing the cart of books to the next stack.

“You can’t be serious. This is busy work for sixth and seventh years. Get one of them to do it.” Acqui touch Light Spinner’s wrist. They used a thumb to rub soothing circles across it gently.

Light Spinner grabbed Acqui’s wrist in a vice grip. “Never in public.”

“Of course, we can’t let anyone know the mighty Light Spinner might have feelings.” Acqui rolled her eyes.

“You knew this was a casual arrangement when we started.” Light Spinner shoved their wrist away.

“Relax, it’s not like anyone is looking. They are under the Princess’s thrall,” Acqui said, rubbing their wrist. “If I had known the last time was it I would have savored it more.”

Light Spinner glanced around the room. Angella averted her eyes. The brunette narrowed her own and pulled Acqui behind the nearest bookshelf, making sure they were completely out of sight. “I have to test the level of enchantments in the Steam Grotto after this. Meet me in our usual place later,” she said.

The corner of Acqui's tugged upwards into another smirk. "You won't be disappointed."

Light Spinner's fingers pumped in and out of Acqui at a rapid pace. Her other hand kept a tight seal across their mouth. "Be quiet. You don't want anyone to stumble onto us." She slowed down her movements. "Or maybe you want someone to see you laid bare and at my mercy."

"Oh no!" Someone gasped behind them. "I'm sorry. I didn't see a thing," they said and slammed the door.

Light Spinner turned around just in time to see the flash of silky ombré hair disappearing around the doorframe.

Acqui clutched at Light Spinner's hand as she tried to pull away. "Don't stop," they gasped, rocking their hips forward.

Light Spinner's jaw tightened. "Have you lost it?" she hissed.

"I almost did." Acqui sighed with slumped shoulders.

"You were supposed to ward the door," Light Spinner said, wiping her fingers on Acqui's discarded robe sleeve. She tossed the garment at the other sorcerer.

"It was more fun this way," Acqui said with the robe bundled under their arm.

"I hope you enjoyed yourself, because I am ending our arrangement," Light Spinner said, straightening her robes.

"Why? Because of the fluffy pink Princess out there?" Acqui asked.

“You have nothing to blame but your own recklessness,” Light Spinner said and stormed out. She nearly ran into Angella in her haste.

Angella waved her hands. Wisps of pink and purple hair frizzed around her inflamed face as she spoke quickly. “One thousand apologies, Light Spinner. I didn’t mean to interrupt you.”

“There was *nothing* to interrupt.” Light Spinner insisted with squinted eyes.

“Well, whatever it was I’m sorry.” Angella repeated.

“It is quite alright, Princess. Think nothing more of it,” Light Spinner said. She heard Acqui’s frustrated clomping behind her and decided to make herself scarce before they took the opportunity to cause a scene. “Have a goodnight, Princess.”

“To you as well, Light Spinner,” Angella said and hurried off to her room.

Ever since that night’s encounter, Princess Angella had decided to be a near constant shadow on Light Spinner’s schedule. Light Spinner tried to be as polite as she dared when they interacted but kept herself distant and occupied.

The sorcerer was not unused to unhealthy attachments from teenagers. Having seen the star-struck look on many apprentices she knew what was to follow. The mystique of her masked visage bred intrigue which often led to superficial infatuation.

The Princess’s interest in her would bring her nothing but trouble and she was restricted with how she could discourage the attachment. Norwyn would not appreciate her handling the situation with her normal methods. She also could not risk

offending Queen Nigella lest she relished the loss of her life. Even for an Angelic Being, the Queen gained a reputation for being fearsome.

Light Spinner thought it best just to keep herself as absent as possible until Angella's fascination had run its course or until Queen Nigella's business at Mystacor had concluded.

No one, not even Norwyn, knew the true reason why the Angelic Beings were at Mystacor. The rumors were everything from a mysterious illness befalling the Queen to taking on a sorcerer apprentice of their own.

Light Spinner had read ancient texts about the 'apprentices' the Angelic court elects and they were nothing more than glorified court jesters. With the info she received from Acqui, it was safe to conclude the Empyrean royals decided she was their new pet project.

How utterly inconvenient.

She shook her mind free of the thoughts and began her demonstration of a complex light illusion to her advanced third-year class. Thankfully, the class only consisted of Micah, Berwick, and Vi. Berwick was the shortest of the group with a knit cap they wore tight over their bushy curls. Vi stood taller and leaner. Tiny, straight horns jutting up from her neat bob. Her large ears hanged down by her face like flat ponytails.

Light Spinner walked to the edge of the platform and drew the rune across the air in front of her. In an instant, a gilded Phoenix erupted from her hands and circled the halls of Mystacor. Its massive wings wafted a strong wind of gardenias and toasted sugar, signaling her royal follower had once again arrived to observe her. It seemed the Princess's interest hadn't wavered which was unfortunate for Micah who tried to impress her at every turn.

Micah waved at Angella from her hiding spot. He closed his eyes and cast a flawless two-tailed ram illusion. It charged the Phoenix, shattering the spell with a bleat. Angella used a hand to cover her mouth as she laughed. Micah grinned and let his ram perform a few acrobatic tricks in the air.

Suddenly, Light Spinner towered over Micah. He looked away from Angella and chuckled nervously at his instructor. With a gesture of her finger, Light Spinner's phoenix rose again and conquered the ram with a dive.

"Impressive casting Micah," Light Spinner praised. "But you allowed yourself to become distracted," she continued, glancing pointedly at Angella in the distance.

The other children teased Micah as he tried to appeal to Light Spinner with a blatant attempt at flattery.

"Light illusions require your full concentration. I want focus as you try it on your own," Light Spinner explained, facing the rest of the class.

"Light Spinner, wait."

"What is it this time, Micah?"

"I'm bored. I've been casting light illusion since before I could walk."

"You've never objected to the lesson plans before. Are you sure your recent boredom has nothing to do with our royal guests?" Light Spinner asked as she adjusted the amateur enchantments of Vi and Berwick.

"No, I just want to be taught something different," Micah answered too quickly. "I want to do real magic like levitation, traveling through mirrors, and shapeshifting. All the cool stuff."

Light Spinner shook her head. "You are a third year apprentice. The Guild decided third years are forbidden from learning such

things. You already know that Micah."

Micah cast a short and stout one-dimensional illusion Master Norwyn. "The Guild prides itself on being strict sorcerers stuck in the past glories of magic. We wouldn't want anyone knowing real magic."

"That's a poor depiction of Master Norwyn," Light Spinner remarked over her shoulder.

"Then teach me shapeshifting!" Micah insisted, dispelling the flimsy illusion.

"Patience, Micah. You must start at the beginning." Light Spinner turned, making eye contact with Micah. "Since you're so proficient at light illusions, you are dismissed from the lesson early. When you return, I expect at least three new forms this time next week."

"Of course," Micah said and ran off. He predictably headed to the alcove Light Spinner observed Angella before.

Vi finally managed to conjure a stag from her rune. It trotted along the platform then flickered out of sight. "Aww."

"Good work, Vi. The spell's longevity will come with practice. Tighten your movements on the counterclockwise turn," Light Spinner suggested.

Berwick's light illusion was a near shapeless blob of teal at first then slowly formed a cat-like body before it fizzled out of existence.

"You're nearly there, Berwick. Let's try together." Light Spinner recast the spell slowly and waited. After a few adjustments of her apprentices' hands, a lion prowled out of Berwick's rune. Vi's stag came out onto the platform but bolted when it spotted the illusory predator.

"Yes!" Berwick smiled with pride and stopped their spell.

“I have no doubt you’ll have solid light illusions in no time. Review the texts and practice your hand movements.” Light Spinner patted Berwick’s shoulder and nodded to Vi. “You’re both dismissed.”

“Thank you, Light Spinner,” Berwick and Vi said at the same time. They ran just as the lunch bell chimed across Mystacor.

“Good day, Light Spinner.”

“Princess Angella.” Light Spinner inclined her head and left the platform.

“Just Angella, please.” Angella smiled, following the sorcerer. “Those were beautiful illusions. I wish I could command magic as you do.”

“As I understand it, Angelic Beings have their own magics but thank you all the same.” Light Spinner never halted in her walk.

“Are you heading to another lesson?” Angella hastened her steps.

“No.”

“Oh, that’s good,” Angella said. She clasped her hands together and tensed them in a quick squeeze. Pursing her lips, she hummed noncommittally and went silent.

“Does the coy princess routine normally get you the results you seek?” Light Spinner stopped and regarded the Princess.

“Pardon?” Angella blinked slowly. “I’m not sure what you mean.”

Light Spinner narrowed her eyes at the Princess. Her eyes were bright and held no ill will within them. “Nevermind.”

“I just came to ask if you would be willing to show me around Mystacor?” Angella asked with a hopeful smile.

“There are many that would be ecstatic to give you a tour,” Light Spinner said, walking backward.

“I don’t want them to show me anything.” Angella shook her head and stepped closer to Light Spinner. “It’s exhausting being around the others. They stare at me like I suspended all the moons in Etheria’s sky. When I speak they react like the very syllables of my words are accented with precious gems. You don’t seem to care that I’m an Angelic Being or a Princess, so I want you to show me the wonders of Mystacor. Please.” She added.

“Well, we must make sure the Princess gets what she wants, mustn’t we?” Light Spinner drawled. “Come we have much to see.”

The grass was lush and thick under their feet as they walked through the courtyard. An elderly sorceress was showing apprentices how to cast using staffs. Some first-years ran by casting harmless sparkles.

Light Spinner deftly sidestepped the younger apprentices, pulling Angella with her. “Yara. Gert. Careful of our guest.”

“Yes, Light Spinner,” Gert said quickly with wide eyes.

Yara nodded repeatedly as she apologized. “Sorry, Light Spinner.”

Both children curtsied to Princess Angella and gave them a wide berth before resuming their play. Angella and Light Spinner arrived at a room with a tall vaulted ceiling. The ceiling was open with what looked like shields floating in midair.

“The most important room in Mystacor is the Lunarium. Up there are the Lunar lenses that keep Mystacor’s force field going every month.” Light Spinner pointed. “The lenses have to be balanced during the lunar cycle or we would no longer be hidden or protected.”

Angella stared in delight at the Lunar lenses as they sparkled merrily in the afternoon moonlight. “Could I take a closer look?”

“I suppose that would be alright, Princess. Just be careful not to touch them. The enchantments protecting their surface are extremely delicate,” Light Spinner cautioned as she watched Angella extend her wings.

Angella flew up, circling the lunar lenses. A glare caught the lenses and reflected it through it Angella’s hair, making her look ethereal.

“They’re magnificent.” Angella looked down at Light Spinner with a grin.

“Yes, they are,” Light Spinner said softly as she held her gaze. Her eyes darted away and she cleared her throat. “You’re already familiar with the Hall of Sorcerers, the dining hall, the gardens, and the library,” she said, walking quickly through the door.

Angella swooped and landed next to Light Spinner as they made it to the next destination.

“That is the Steam Grotto,” Light Spinner said, passing by the foggy door. “The pools are full of magical healing minerals. Sorcerers use them to cleanse themselves of worry and fear before big ceremonies or spells.” She pointed to the east where a small island sat alone in the pink clouds. “That’s the watchtower. If the force field comes down it sends a klaxon to every inch of Mystacor.”

“Wow, really?”

“It’s my personal spell.” Light Spinner couldn’t help but boast. “One can never be too careful when it comes to safety.”

“Do the smaller island towers have a purpose?” Angella pointed over the horizon.

“We store the more dangerous First Ones’ magical texts away from impressionable apprentices.” Light Spinner stated and noticed the sky beginning to darken around them. “The beach will

be our final destination on the tour. It's unlike any other on Etheria."

"I love the beach. There aren't any on Empyrean." Angella said, grinning. "If I lived so close to one I would go all the time. How often do you visit?"

"I usually avoid the beach if I can, but it is mandatory to cast spells here during the summer solstice."

After a few minutes of quiet contemplation in front of the frothy pastel pink tide, they left the beach and made their way back to the main hall. The crowd of older apprentices parted for Light Spinner and Angella as they moved toward the corridor of quarters.

"Is there anything we haven't seen?" Angella asked.

"Of course. There are hundreds of miles of underground tunnels under Mystacor that lead directly to ancient First Ones' relics and architecture. Unfortunately, for the purposes of our tour, only the head sorcerers are allowed inside and never alone."

"It's remarkable that you know so much about Mystacor and its history."

"Being knowledgeable never hurts. I believe one cannot make use of anything unless you understand it to its entirety, so I spent my life studying the secrets of Mystacor," Light Spinner said, coming to stand beside a set of double doors.

"I could listen to you speak about Mystacor for hours and hours. It's fascinating," Angella said, staring at the doors. Its arch held pink gems embedded in its surface. In the center serving as its door handles was a glyph of the moon cycle holding the doors closed.

"You caught me on a rare moment of free time." Light Spinner explained. "Any other questions you may have, I encourage you to revisit our library."

“I don’t want to take up more of your time, but I would love to discuss Mystacor more if you invite me in.”

“I don’t think that would be wise, Princess.”

“Would you prefer your conversation out here? At least inside we would be able to sit.”

It appeared Light Spinner’s plan had backfired. From the recesses of her mind, she recalled a quote about absence breeding more fondness. The Princess obviously had no idea how to approach her, so perhaps embarrassment would be a better motivator to disillusion her from her interests.

“So forward, Angella.” Light Spinner gently grabbed Angella’s hand in hers, backing up towards the door behind her and pulling the Princess with her. “What will people say if the Princess of Empyrean was seen leaving my room at night?”

Angella’s cheeks darkened when she recalled her last few sentences. “That’s not what I meant,” she said in a rush.

“Perception is everything, Princess.” Light Spinner released Angella’s hands and stepped back to a more respectable distance.

“So I’ve heard.” Angella sighed and placed her hand on the other woman’s forearm before she retreated too far. “Light Spinner, this has been a lovely time. Thank you so much for the tour, but I have a confession to make.”

“What is it, Princess?”

Angella looked away. “Master Norwyn gave our entourage an abbreviated tour when we arrived.”

Light Spinner chuckled at the distraught look on Angella’s face. “I suspected as much. There’s not much that happens in Mystacor that I’m unaware of.”

“You!” Angella started to yell. She paused, exhaled sharply through her nose, and started again. “You knew and you let me toil in my guilt.”

“Your guilt is your own. I was just trying to be a helpful representative of Mystacor,” Light Spinner said in an innocent tone.

“I take back my apology,” Angella sputtered.

“You may have it back, Princess.” Light Spinner shrugged and crossed her arms loosely.

“You’re infuriating.” Angella flexed her wings in irritation. “I know you’ve been avoiding me.”

Light Spinner tilted her head. “Did you never stop to ask yourself why?”

“I’m going to be at Mystacor for the foreseeable future and I want to get to know you. Why is that such an offensive notion to you?”

“Well, you’re off to a great start with the tour ruse. You’re more manipulative than I gave you credit for.” Light Spinner arched an eyebrow. “Well done. I’m not usually misled so effortlessly.”

“I’m not trying to-”

“There you are Princess Angella,” A guard appeared, bowing low at the waist. “Queen Nigella wishes to see you at once.”

“Duty calls it seems.” Light Spinner opened the door to her quarters.

“It never stops,” Angella responded and nodded to the guard. “Thank you again for the lovely evening. Until next time, Light Spinner.”

“Goodnight, Princess.”

The Spell of Obtainment was a dangerous venture but a worthy one if a sorcerer could pull it off. There were a lot of risks to invoke the darkness of the First Ones' magical energy. That was why Light Spinner needed to be as careful as possible.

Ever since she became aware of the emerging force known as the Horde, she started to look into ways sorcerers could help the Princesses of Power. There had to be some kind of modification possible for the spell to be safer to cast. Its success rate was minuscule. She had been working on this project off and on for some time and all the necessary elements were finally aligned. The moons of enchantment would be in alignment at the exact stroke of midnight during this upcoming Samhain.

Light Spinner's research table was completely covered in spellbooks. She poured over the texts in front of her, making notations about each rune's symbolic characteristics. The sorcerer's eyes widened in panic at the sudden knock on her door. She knew she wasn't expecting any visitors.

"Just a moment," Light Spinner called out and banished the books and scrolls to their original hiding spot. She couldn't risk gossip of her research making it back to Norwyn.

She tossed out her hair and opened the door. Angella walked forward nearly bowling her over in her abrupt entry.

Light Spinner moved in front of the door, stopping Micah in his tracks. "Can I help you, Micah?"

"Good evening, Light Spinner, um, didn't we have any lessons tonight?" Micah asked, rubbing the back of his head.

"You know that's tomorrow evening, Micah. Now run along. You don't want to be caught outside during curfew," Light Spinner

said, closing the door on his response.

“Thank you. He followed me from the dining hall and was very helpful with my direction back to your quarters but I couldn’t seem to shake him after that.”

“Micah means well but is easily excitable.” Light Spinner moved to her desk and began to grind herbs for a cleansing spell. “Just be firm with him.”

Angella shrugged with a sigh. “I’m still working on the line between being firm and being cruel.”

“You’re trying very hard to please everyone and you don’t want to hurt Micah, because he’s obviously smitten with you.” Light Spinner spun on the stool, looking at Angella.

Angella hunched her shoulders and avoided her eyes.

“Princess…” Light Spinner intoned in warning.

“Of course, I’ve noticed his interest. He’s sweet and handsome but very young,” Angella said.

“Young?” Light Spinner blinked owlishly. “I would think age would be relative to a being that lives forever.”

Angella rolled her eyes as she explained. “That’s what everyone believes but I know you’re aware that there’s more to age than just the physical attributes. Mental and emotional maturity are important to me in a relationship. Micah and I are too far apart in either case.”

“But you couldn’t be more than seventeen.” Light Spinner wondered aloud.

“I’m twenty years old.” Angella laughed as she studied Light Spinner. Her eyes held a sudden understanding that Light Spinner couldn’t begin to puzzle at the moment. “Though technically under Etheria’s calendar I’m closer to fifty.”

“I know Angelic beings age differently but so much is kept secret. I’d love to read more about it.” Light Spinner realized Angella was still standing awkwardly near the door. “You may set the tray down on the table.” She gestured behind her.

“I wanted to bring you dinner. You weren’t in the dining hall and Micah said sometimes you take your meals in your quarters.”

“I tend to take my dinner later than the others.”

“I’m intruding,” Angella concluded.

“Princess, this has to stop.” Light Spinner returned to her grinding. “I’m well aware that there are very few reasons why Angelic beings leave Empyrean to come to Etheria. It’s not the year for the Grand Eclipse which means you came to select a ‘champion’ to be your royal entertainment. I won’t be a part of it.”

“Is this your reaction to someone doing something nice for you?” Angella asked exasperatedly. “I thought we were making progress these past weeks. I know you don’t believe me but that’s not why we’re here and that’s not why I’m here.”

“Truly?” Light Spinner stopped her grinding and turned once more. “Enlighten me, Princess.”

“I would like us to be friends,” Angella said with a smile that was pure joy.

“Friends?” Light Spinner’s mouth moved over the word as if it was in an unfamiliar language.

“You know what a friend is, right?” Angella asked. “Friends rely on each other and inspire bravery within you. It’s someone to bounce ideas off of.”

Light Spinner waved her hand dismissively. “That’s what I have colleagues for.”

Angella shook her head. “Friends are different from colleagues or acquaintances. They also encourage dreams and exchange silly stories or devise schemes for mischief. You are fascinating, intelligent, and complex. I’d love to spend more time with you.”

“I haven’t had many friends,” Light Spinner admitted truthfully. Even as a child in Mystacor the other children thought her strange with her maturity beyond her years and covered face. Once she began to excel they no longer decided she was worth knowing beyond their academic interactions.

Light Spinner imagined being a part of the Sorcerers Guild council would be more refreshing but the shunning continued. It just happened on a more polite scale that adults perfect to convince themselves that they were better than the children that surrounded them.

“I’d like that.” Light Spinner finally answered and was surprised to realize she meant it. As annoyed as she was initially by the younger woman’s presence, she had come to look forward to their interactions. “To refer back to your earlier statement, No, you were not intruding. You are royalty. A queen is never intruding, she is always exactly where she is meant to be.”

“You sound like my mother. A queen is never late, Ella, everyone else is merely early.” Angella imitated her mother with her wings stiff and her back ramrod straight. “I know the lessons. Etiquette has been drilled into me every day since I was a cherub. Sometimes it’s too much.”

“The same can be said about anyone with responsibility.”

“Don’t you ever want to disappear? Just leave and forget who you are for a few hours or days?”

“I’ve had to work hard for my position as a head sorcerer. I’ve been an anonymous, faceless name in the crowd for many years,” Light Spinner said, coming to stand in Angella’s personal space. The sorcerer moved a strand of hair from Angella’s forehead and

brushed her hand down the Princess' cheek. Angella swayed forward, following the touch like a lure then started when Light Spinner spoke again. "Believe me, Princess, recognition is not a burden but a gift. Learn to make use of it."

"How can I make use of a predestined life?" Angella sat into the nearest chair. "I'm late enough on the timeline as it is."

"What timeline?" Light Spinner inquired.

"It's not important," Angella said quickly, waving a hand. "What do you desire, Light Spinner? Hypothetically, if a First One appeared in front of you and said they would grant you anything in this world, what would it be?"

Light Spinner was confused at the sudden change of topic. "What on Etheria?"

"Indulge your new friend?" Angella fluttered her eyelashes.

"Am I to expect more of these kinds of conversations?"

"Sometimes, but that's part of the fun."

"More power would be my answer."

"Why power?"

"You did not say I would be required to explain my answer." Light Spinner removed the cloche covering her dinner. A succulent roasted chicken breast sat on a plate with roasted potatoes, blistered tomatoes, and a small bunch of sautéed asparagus.

Angella snagged a spear of asparagus and nibbled on it as she responded, "I just want to understand your answer. Of all the infinite things in space and time you could ask for, you asked for power. You are already so talented in magic so power is not an issue for you. It sounds like a wasted wish."

“If we are going into specifics I want to unlock my potential.” Light Spinner gave the unrepentant Princess a look as she moved the tray away from Angella’s reach and replaced the cloche. “I’ve often felt as though something is holding me back. Spells and rituals have revealed no blockades but if a First One ever appeared before me I know they would be able to obliterate any unknown barriers. Magical or otherwise,” she finished. “And just what would you ask for?”

“More wishes of course,” Angella said as she bit into the dinner roll she removed from the tray.

“There’s no possibility they would grant you more wishes,” Light Spinner argued.

“Stipulations weren’t named in my hypothetical.”

“I suppose not.” Light Spinner agreed. She lightly smacked Angella’s hand as it reached for the tray yet again. “If you were hungry why didn’t you bring your own food?”

“Hey, now friends are supposed to share.”

“I’m already beginning to think you’re using me for extra portions at the Mystacor kitchen.” Light Spinner leveled her with a glare that held no malice.

Angella was enraptured by the intense emerald gaze directed at her. Finally, she looked away to a distant gem on the opposite edge of the table. It looked to have First Ones’ languages running across the top. “Is that a Runestone shard?”

Light Spinner stood, walking over. “Yes,” she said simply and beckoned the stone towards her. It moved smoothly across the table.

“I thought sorcerers couldn’t command Runestones?”

“They cannot normally.” Light Spinner placed it in a nearby drawer.

“See? This proves my earlier assessment. You’re more powerful and accomplished than your peers. You don’t need more power,” Angella said, balancing her chin in a hand. “I want you to choose something else.”

“My answer has not changed.”

“There must be something else you want. Children, a puppy, or perhaps a chocolate bar as big as your statue!”

“Clearly you’re taking this seriously,” Light Spinner pointed out sarcastically.

“Nothing else in this world but power appeals to you?” Angella asked, tossing her hands in the air as she stood.

Something in Angella called to Light Spinner and made her want to see this young queen in training off balance.

“If some ancient magical being is granting wishes then, yes, I want power. In the real world of Etheria, what I’d really desire is...” Light Spinner walked around Angella, brushing the ombre haired woman lightly. She smirked at the resulting shiver, “dinner,” she finished and used two fingers to move Angella's gaze back to her own. “Friends tease do they not?”

“Always,” Angella breathed out with a shaky grin. “But seriously don’t be mean. I brought plenty of food. We could eat together.”

“Maybe you should take the food for yourself.” Light Spinner unconsciously reached for the satin mask covering the lower half of her face.

“Do you only take off your mask to eat?” Angella asked and cringed as she watched the other woman stiffen. “Please, don’t be upset with me. I didn’t mean to offend.”

“You didn’t. Goodnight, Princess,” Light Spinner said in clear dismissal.

“That’s a lie and once again I’ve asked you to call me Angella, please.” The younger woman sounded more disappointed in the possible fib than the possibility of her offense.

“It’s not. Truly,” Light Spinner said. “I have a lot of reading to complete before bed and early lessons with the first years tomorrow,” she explained. “Thank you for the dinner, Angella.”

Of all the things Light Spinner had expected to hear from Angella when she opened her door, ‘Light Spinner, how would you like to go to the beach this evening?’ Was not on the list.

“No, thank you,” Light Spinner said at once, stepping away from the door so Angella could enter.

Angella huffed, placing the wicker basket on the table. “You know when someone shows up at your door and offers to take you on an adventure the answer should always be ‘yes please.’”

“It’s not if that person is your friend and you don’t want to lie to them. You know I don’t enjoy the beach,” Light Spinner countered.

“I’m going to convert you one day.”

“Only if you manage to find a beach without sand.”

“The sand squishing between your toes is the best part!” Angella argued.

Light Spinner shuddered, returning to the Runestone she was balancing on its point. It rotated like a spinning top as it skimmed across the table’s surface.

“You can come with me or you can starve.” Angella picked up the basket once more. “I know you haven’t eaten yet and I have dinner.” She smiled, knowing she’d won when the Runestone abruptly rolled on its side. Its wide random movements were halted by Light Spinner’s hand.

“Lead on,” Light Spinner said with a sigh. They walked out of the door and she paused for a moment warding her door.

“You never told me how you got the Runestone,” Angella whispered.

“I found it just before my sorcerer’s coronation. Master Norwyn said the Runestone was likely useless and asked me to destroy it.”

“Obviously, you didn’t.”

“I could not. There was so much unknown about how the elemental magics that Princesses wield to throw away a possible link to understanding that would be unwise,” Light Spinner said as they reached the main entrance of Mystacor. The pillars were being wrapped in swathes of red, green, white, and silver fabric in preparations for next week’s Beltane celebration.

“How is your research going?” Angella asked as they walked through the halls toward the beach.

“It’s slow. Modification of a spell always is, but it’s crucial for this spell’s success.”

“Are you ready to tell me what it is yet?”

“Not yet, I have to have a more concrete answer for Master Norwyn before I can reveal it to anyone.”

Angella nodded and handed Light Spinner the blanket. With a smoothly drawn rune, Light Spinner levitated the blanket onto the sand.

“Have you ever tried to use that spell to fly?” Angella kneeled on the blanket and began to unpack their picnic.

“Levitation spells have limits and sorcerers are not blessed with your wings. You can only stay in the air as long as the caster has complete concentration.”

“Surely, sorcerers have tried?”

“Every several months, apprentices try to fly too close to the moons and the infirmary and steam grotto becomes a highly-populated area.”

“So, back to my original question: Did you ever try to fly?”

“I tried only once. I found a small alcove not more than three feet from the ground but quickly discovered I could not sustain the height,” Light Spinner said, settling onto the blanket. “Some of the younger apprentices’ mistakes are that they think height will give them a better result. Luckily, I decided that I’m better suited to the ground.”

“You can’t stop the curiosity of an active mind,” Angella said, pouring two cups of apple cider.

“Indeed,” Light Spinner said, picking up a strawberry.

They ate in silence as the sky gradually darkened to shades of pearled lavender with magenta highlights and the moons waned in the distance. The ever present cloud cover cast them in near darkness. Angella created a small orb of light between then and released it. It floated just above their heads like a small sun. Light Spinner’s eyes adjusted to the bright light and looked down noticing how close their hands were on the blanket.

“Now, would be the perfect time for dessert,” Angella said, scooting back to the abandoned wicker basket. “I baked this myself,” she said, removing a small wrapped platter of sliced gingerbread.

Light Spinner grabbed a slice and took a bite.

“I just hope my earring is not in that one,” Angella said with a furrowed brow.

Light Spinner paused in her chewing, slowly lowering the bread.

“I’m kidding,” Angella said with a giggle.

Light Spinner swallowed her mouthful and sipped the apple cider from her mug. “It’s delicious.”

“Really? You’re not just saying that?”

“Have no fear. If it was terrible I would tell you.”

Angella’s resulting smile was brighter than the light orb and almost enough to illuminate the night sky. “The cook assured me it would be easy but I’m happy it turned out okay.”

“More than,” Light Spinner said, reaching for another slice. She held up the gingerbread for Angella and waited. “You should enjoy the fruits of your labor as well.”

The younger woman leaned forward, keeping her eyes locked on Light Spinner as her even white teeth sank into the soft gingerbread.

Angella closed her eyes, chewing and moaned her enjoyment. “I guess the tenth time is the charm.”

Light Spinner tried to ignore the way her stomach clenched at the sound as she cleared her throat. She pinched a piece from the gingerbread in her hands. “This was your tenth bake?” She asked, amused.

“Mhm. I was determined to make it. I hear from a very reliable source that it’s your favorite.” Angella pulled Light Spinner’s wrist closer, taking the smaller morsel between her lips before Light Spinner had a chance to claim it.

Light Spinner returned the larger piece to the platter with shaking hands. “You already do so much for me as my friend, I’d like to return the favor.”

“That’s the beauty of friendship, Light Spinner. You don’t have to expect anything in return for kindness.”

“I can’t believe that. Friendships should be equal, Angella. Ask me anything and if it’s in my power to grant you will have it.” Light Spinner used her thumb to brush the crumbs away from the corner of Angella’s mouth.

Angella grabbed the retreating hand and looked down. “There is only one thing I would ask that would make this night perfect. Could I-” She bit her lip and grimaced unsure how to word her request. “What I want to ask is could I see your face?”

As soon as the Princess finally managed to get the words out she felt the anticipation inside her rise to nearly unbearable heights. She spent many hours fantasizing about what Light Spinner may look like. She wasn’t sure why the woman felt the need to hide her face and Angella didn’t care. Light Spinner was silent and unmoving making Angella’s thoughts race by at hundreds of miles per hour. “I’m sorry, Light Spinner.”

“Why?”

“Because I hurt you with my request and for that, I’m truly sorry.” Angella began to pack the basket for something to occupy her hands.

Light Spinner placed her a hand over Angella’s. “Why would you want to see me?”

“I want to see my best friend,” Angella answered immediately.

“You see me now.”

“Before me sits Light Spinner, great mentor to overachieving apprentices and one of the head sorcerers of Mystacor. I want to

see *you* ."

Light Spinner reached up to the first gold clasp then the other and pulled them away. The mask fluttered to the blanket between them.

Angella gasped as her face was revealed. She had a slender face with a strong jawline and a perky nose. Her light grey skin was mostly smooth and clear. There was scar tissue on the left side of her face that made her heart-shaped lips flare up into a permanent snarl. It bared one long ivory canine.

"Staring seems to be your friendly pastime."

Angella's cheeks were stained pink as she mumbled, "I can't help it. You're so beautiful."

"You don't have to flatter me, Princess," Light Spinner said, reaching for the mask.

"No, please. Don't reattach it just yet," Angella pleaded. "Why do you keep your face covered?"

"It's easier than hexing everyone who stares at the monster."

"Don't ever say that again," Angella demanded as she scooted closer. "You're not a monster." They slowly gravitated towards each other.

Light Spinner placed her hands on Angella's waist and pulled her nearer still. Angella felt her heart start to beat faster and faster as Light Spinner's face came closer. Finally, she slanted her lips over Angella's. It was just a tentative brush of lips before Light Spinner pulled back. Angella blinked to focus her eyes on Light Spinner who was looking at her in concern.

Light Spinner's dazzling green eyes seemed to glow in the moonlight. "Did I misread?"

Angella shook her head. “No,” she said and pulled Light Spinner forward into another kiss. It sent a pleasant zing through her body. It was clumsy at first until their lips found a compatible rhythm. Angella felt completely unburdened as if the world paused for them at this moment.

Light Spinner was never without her quick wit or even quicker mind but as she sank into the kiss she found herself unable to think or speak. She could only feel the softness of Angella’s lips against her own, the urgency of her body’s need for more contact. She laid down on the blanket, pulling Angella down with her. Light Spinner deepened the kiss with a swipe of her tongue against slightly parted lips.

They kissed over and over. The movements melted together until they were clinging to each other on the blanket across the sand. Angella began to notice she was craning her head too far to reach Light Spinner and finally opened her eyes.

Light Spinner looked at Angella with a dimpled grin. “As far as kisses go, I can honestly say I never had that effect before.”

Angella realized she was several inches off the ground and allowed herself to float down onto Light Spinner. The Princess snuggled closer to the sorcerer with a pleased hum.

“We should go inside.” Light Spinner suggested.

“Not yet. I want to enjoy this. I’ve wanted to kiss you since I first brought you dinner.”

“Is that why you were asking me about my desires?” Light Spinner asked.

“Like you didn’t know. ‘Friends tease each other do they not?’ ” Angella mocked.

“If you recall I did suspect you were up to something.”

“Yes and you accused me of trying to draft you as a court jester. You just live to torment and tease me.”

“You make it far too easy.” Light Spinner moved and felt the shift of the wet sand near their feet. “There’s going to be sand everywhere.”

“Don’t ruin the moment, my darling.” Angella heard Light Spinner’s disgruntled noise but the sorcerer otherwise remained silent as she combed her fingers through Angella’s hair.

The soothing touch lulled Angella to drowsiness as she watched the foamy, pink tides continuously roll over the shore. She hummed contentedly, vowing to only rest her eyes for a moment. Just after she extinguished the light, her eyes closed.

“Angella, wake up,” Light Spinner shook Angella’s shoulder.

“No, go away I’m comfy.” Angella waved her arm in the air and pulled her ponytail over her eyes to shield them from the morning moonlight.

“We fell asleep on the beach, I can’t find my mask, and by the time I bathe and change I’m going to be late for my lessons.” Light Spinner sounded near hysterics.

Angella’s eyes slammed open as she sat up. “It’s morning?”

“Yes, the time that happens after night. Remember it?” Light Spinner asked as she ruffled the blanket in her frantic movements.

“Light Spinner, I’ll help you look. Just, please, take a breath,” Angella said, cupping the sorcerer’s face in her hands. She kissed

her softly, smiling against Light Spinner's lips as the brunette relaxed. "There now. It couldn't have gotten far."

Angella glanced around the beach when she saw glinting near the surf. A wave moved it backward and she saw the red wine-colored satin soaked with seawater and sand.

"It's ruined." Light Spinner spat, snatching up the veil.

"No, it's not. It just needs to be washed. You have spares don't you?"

"Yes, in my room but I can't get there without being seen."

It nearly broke Angella's heart to see Light Spinner so distraught. She trusted her with her face and it was her fault they didn't leave the beach before falling asleep last night. There had to be some way they could get back to Light Spinner's quarters without running into anyone. "You said there are secret passages under Mystacor. Are there any doorways near here?"

Light Spinner stopped trying to shake the veil free of sand and smiled in relief. "There is one about ten yards away."

"I thought you said no one is allowed down here without approval and another sorcerer?"

"I may have been down here once or twice alone," Light Spinner confessed casually.

"How rebellious," Angella said, leaning into Light Spinner and fawning dramatically.

Light Spinner gave Angella's hand a gentle squeeze but didn't let go. "Don't distract me. We need to get back. There are illusions and traps down here so stick close," she said and moved along the wall on the left.

"What are you doing?"

“It’s an odd fail-safe I found through trial and error. If you walk along with the catacombs but staying toward the left side the whole time you can bypass nearly all of the traps.”

Angella released Light Spinner’s hand and stepped towards an ominous electric blue glow. “What's this room?” she asked, stopping over a rune that glowed a baleful crimson.

“Angella!” Light Spinner reached in and pulled her back. There was no burn or pain. She hugged Angella tight. “Please, stay close to me. I don’t want anything to happen to you.”

“I’m okay,” Angella assured Light Spinner, clinging to her.

Light Spinner drew a spell in the air and directed it over the flames. The phony fire burned out at once and they were able to walk into the room. “This is the Crystal of Arxia. I tried to find out everything I could but there’s still a lot of mystery surrounding it. What I’ve figured out thus far is that it has to do with the legendary Princess She-Ra.”

“It’s massive, what do you think it does?”

“I have never been able to open it. Perhaps, it activates a First Ones’ gateway or gives the user powers to rival the She-Ra. I don’t completely know yet.”

All around them three loud chimes sounded like doldrums against the wall.

“Are we too late? Which bell is that?” Angella asked in alarm.

“I have plenty of time. It’s the first call for breakfast but the acoustics down here have always made everything sound odd. We’ll take this next right. There’s a shortcut through that corridor.” Light Spinner gestured with a toss of her head.

Angella poked her head out to make sure the coast was clear once they exited the final door. She and Light Spinner ran quickly to the door. Once they were inside they collapsed into giggles.

"That was certainly an adventurous morning," Light Spinner said when the laughs tapered off.

"It's certainly not what I envisioned would happen next as I laid with you last night."

"I thoroughly enjoyed last night."

"Me too." Angella's grin fell as her eyes fell to the sodden piece of satin in Light Spinner's hand. "You shouldn't have to hide your face. You're beautiful. I'll show you that every day until you believe it."

"With your assistance, I have enough time to prepare for the day and just make it to my first class. Thank you for escorting me to my room, Angella," Light Spinner said, giving the other woman a chaste kiss.

"I was more than happy to help. I better let you get ready." Angella moved to the door. She touched the handle and turned around. "I love you, Light Spinner." She rushed forward to put her hand over the sorcerer's mouth. "You don't have to say it back. I needed to tell you or I would have burst. Last night was perfect for me and if you want I'd want nothing more than to officially court you."

"Angella, I care for you deeply but…" She trailed off, letting the words linger in the air.

"I understand," Angella whispered brokenly. "Thank you for being honest."

Light Spinner stood in front of the door. "Love is completely alien to me. I'm not sure what my feelings are just yet but I know my

days seem longer and dismal when you're not near. My...affections grow every day and I hope to be brave enough to repeat those words someday. Is that enough?"

"It's more than enough," Angella said, jumping into Light Spinner's arms and kissing her fiercely. "You know this means I'll probably sneak into your rooms to leave gingerbread."

"I'll change my wards." Light Spinner caressed Angella's hair.

Light Spinner handed a rose to Berwick, Vi, and Micah. "The Accuratio spell is about control and precision. You will need this to execute your magic. You will use your magic to carefully remove the petals from the rose and move them to the basin provided in front of you." She drew the rune in the air and the flower floated.

The petals separated from the stem completely intact and drifted across the platform like crimson leaves in a breeze. Before they hit the ground, the petals moved to the dish.

"Are there any questions before we begin?" Light Spinner asked. She looked at her students' stunned faces staring past her shoulder and realized the children were no longer paying her any attention. As soon as she ceased her casting, the air became clammy and heavy with power. "Children, you remember Queen Nigella from Empyrean," she introduced without turning around.

The children gasped and began chattering excitedly, bouncing in place. Nigella chuckled softly, holding her hands up. The smile emphasized the laugh lines on her otherwise stern face. "I'm afraid I only have two ears."

Light Spinner clapped her hands once. The children fell silent. "You may each ask a question that is if Queen Nigella does not object?"

“Not at all.” Queen Nigella shook her head.

“How high can you fly?” Berwick asked quickly.

“As high and as far as the winds take me, sweet one,” Nigella said with a quick tap to their nose.

Berwick giggled at the touch.

Vi stepped forward. “How do you get your crown to stay?”

Nigella winked, sending a glitter of light across the platform. “Magic.”

They gasped, watching it disappear in a shower of sparkles.

“How long have you lived?” Micah blurted the question and immediately turned red.

“Micah, I know you have more manners than that,” Light Spinner said with narrowed eyes.

“Forgive me, your majesty.” Micah bowed lowly.

“Micah, remember that a lady never likes her age questioned even when she’s been alive as long as I have.”

“That concludes today’s lesson. I want everyone to read up on the techniques used in the Accuratio spell,” Light Spinner said. She watched as the apprentices bid them goodbye before running away excited to tell their friends about their encounter with the Queen. “You’ve certainly charmed Mystacor.”

“You are not so easily mesmerized with us.” Queen Nigella raised an eyebrow.

“I have read up on Angelic beings and their magics.” Light Spinner admitted.

“I expected as much, Angella tells me you’re learned.”

“She flatters me.” Light Spinner deflected.

Queen Nigella walked along the gravel path, leading to the gardens. “I’ve had the pleasure of going through your accomplishments here in Mystacor. Your knowledge of magic is extraordinary.” She didn’t bother turning to check if Light Spinner was following.

Light Spinner found it odd that the trio of guards followed Queen Nigella every move but she had not once sensed their presence in the months that Angella walked the halls of Mystacor except for the night of the tour. “It’s an honor to meet you properly Queen Nigella.” The sorcerer nodded her head.

“You mean finally after all this time? I know the rumors have me afflicted with some sort of otherworldly illness. It’s much simpler than that. Traveling through the planes of consciousness every day is tiring work.”

“Traveling planes?” Light Spinner asked in awe. “You have been using corporeal astral projection this entire time?”

“Ah, so there is something that can astound the unflappable Light Spinner,” Nigella said with a laugh that sounded like wind chimes. “It’s a simple solution. I cannot leave the throne of Empyrean unattended and I trust my guard to handle any issues that would arise. They are more than capable of getting Angella out quickly and safely if her life was ever threatened.”

“Simple but tiring. Why expend more of your energy to come to see me?”

“I’ve learned a lot in my time here,” Queen Nigella said vaguely. “And it seems that Light Spinner is all Angella can speak of these past few weeks, so I had to speak to the woman that has so enraptured my daughter.”

“‘Enraptured’ seems like a strong word.”

“You two have become close very quickly. What word would you use?”

“We are friends,” Light Spinner said casually.

“Friends, yes.” Nigella’s resulting smile possessed no warmth. Her eyes grew hard as she seemed to peer directly through Light Spinner. “We are two intelligent women are we not?”

“Yes, your majesty.”

“Then let’s agree not to try and delude each other of the contrary, yes? What do you think of Angella?”

“She’s a wonderful young woman.” Light Spinner answered honestly.

“Would you be willing to spend more time with her outside of the setting of Mystacor?”

This is exactly what Light Spinner was afraid of and she needed to act quickly. “My queen, might I speak frankly?”

Queen Nigella inclined her head. “I would prefer it.”

“Why all the interest in me? Why the subterfuge? Has Angella been sent in as a lure to soften my resolve? I’ve told her and now I’m telling you. I don’t want a position in your court as your pet magician,” Light Spinner said in a rush.

“My, what you must think of us.” Nigella’s laugh once again tinkled across the garden. “The secrecy is necessary for our continued survival. We have come to Mystacor to find Angella a suitable match for marriage and a bonding union.”

“You’re gonna bond her with an Etherian?” Light Spinner asked in confusion. A heavy weight filled her chest. Surely, Queen Nigella had come to inform her that she and Angella’s involvement could not continue. “Micah must be thrilled.”

“Micah?” Queen Nigella asked then nodded. “Oh yes, I’ve heard much less about him. That’s your protégé, no?”

“Yes, your majesty. He’s extremely talented and with my tutoring, he will be the most accomplished sorcerer in all of Etheria.”

“And what of your future?” Queen Nigella stopped, facing the sorcerer.

Light Spinner held Queen Nigella’s gaze. “I’m not sure I understand?”

“Are you preparing to linger in the shadows of Micah’s exploits for the rest of your life? Will you teach his children? Where does your story begin, Light Spinner?”

“Angelic beings don’t typically get involved in mortal conflicts, why now?”

“Angella has formed a connection with the Moonstone and Empyrean law dictates that she must be married to stay on this plane. In the times ahead, she will need someone to challenge her and bring out her courage. I have observed your burgeoning fondness for each other, and I’m convinced it would be the start of a magnificent match.”

“You’re suggesting I marry Angella?” Light Spinner asked and was not the least bit ashamed as the tightness in her chest eased.

“You are not like the others here, Light Spinner. They would be happy to rot in this bubble of artifices for all eternity, but we both know that is not an option. I can see it in your eyes that you are following the events in Scorporous. This alien, Hordak, tried something similar in a different kingdom years ago. It was a devastating failure though it did not discourage him.”

Light Spinner had not expected her day going like this. The Angelic Queen of Empyrean was giving the sorcerer her blessing to marry her daughter and offering her the opportunity to become ruler of Bright Moon. They had only just expressed their mutual

interest for each other and while Light Spinner never expected to be blindsided by her attachment for Angella, she could easily see herself spending the rest of her days with the younger woman. "This is the timeline Angella spoke of isn't it?"

"I know it's all very sudden but Angella knew what she was getting into with this trip. Time is of the essence, Light Spinner. Are you ready to stop the growing darkness or become part of it?" Queen Nigella asked before disappearing from view.

Light Spinner closed her door with a sigh. Today was a long day filled with menial tasks. She had no one to blame but herself as she agreed to them when she was still trying to avoid Angella. She frowned to herself when she realized she'd hardly seen Angella today save for the quick stolen kisses in the Steam Grotto earlier that afternoon.

A tray of food was waiting for her on her desk just ahead. She smiled, knowing Angella must have dropped the dinner off before attending the meeting with her mother and Norwyn. Light Spinner wished she could have been with Angella but it was enough to know the Princess was thinking about her.

Norwyn kept tabs on the fountain in the Lunarium of this Light Spinner was well aware. It took patience and determination but she finally secured enough water to make her own Font of Focus. The small bowl was made of lapis lazuli crystal. She dipped her finger in the liquid and traced it around the edge. A soothing tone emanated from the bowl and the water rippled in time with her pulse.

She promised to stay away from the meeting with Norwyn as per Queen Nigella's request but it wasn't explicitly forbidden that she

couldn’t observe. “Show me.” The water swirled and formed the image of Norwyn’s office.

Norwyn was pacing and shaking his head. Light Spinner poured more magic into the liquid and the sound flowed forth.

“Queen Nigella, please, choose someone else. Anyone else. Light Spinner would be a poor match.” Norwyn was all but begging the seated Queen.

“I see no issues. She’s an intelligent, dedicated, and well-respected sorceress.” Queen Nigella counted on her fingers. “Angella adores her.”

“Is there no one you find more suitable?” Norwyn asked. “Micah and Angella would be an equally wondrous match.”

“We would have to wait for Micah for another five years to be of marrying age. That is time we do not have.” Queen Nigella shook her head and stood. “Master Norwyn, I have come to you merely as a formality. My decision is final and unless Angella has any objections, Light Spinner will be her spouse by the end of the next lunar cycle.”

Light Spinner ended the spell with a pleased smile spreading across her face. Bright Moon’s library nearly rivaled Mystacor’s. She would be Queen and rule beside Angella using all the magic at her disposal to crush the Horde and support the Princesses.

Standing suddenly, she began to take inventory of her quarters. There was a lot of preparation to complete. She would finally move out of Norwyn’s shadow. The fact that she was doing it with the woman she loved was a definite bonus.

Light Spinner paused and the scrolls she was arranging rolled from her hands to the floor. “I love her,” she whispered. A second later, Light Spinner’s door banged open as she rushed through the halls of Mystacor. She arrived at Angella’s suite and opened the door without knocking. “Angella!”

She frowned and glanced at the space in confusion. The room was empty and clean. It was far too clean for someone who had been staying there for months. Her first thought is that there was some emergency. She sprinted across Mystacor towards Norwyn's office when she spotted Angella, walking towards the exit arch.

"Angella, where are you going? Is your mother okay? Has something happened?" Light Spinner asked, placing a hand on the other woman's shoulder.

"Yes, of course, something happened." Angella jerked from under her hand and hissed. "I'm thinking clearly for the first time in weeks. I could never love you. It was just a silly childhood crush. A passing infatuation."

"What?" Light Spinner choked out, holding a hand to her mouth. Her stomach roiled.

"It wasn't real," Angella said, turning away.

"Angella, I know you don't mean that." Light Spinner grabbed Angella's hand in a bruising grip for something to hold onto. It was hard to breathe and Light Spinner felt her head start to pound.

"Don't touch me. Don't look for me. I never want to speak to you again," Angella said, snatching her hand back as she ran away.

Angella's figure was obscured by the tears in her eyes. She blinked to clear her vision and they ran down her cheeks. Light Spinner didn't know how long she stayed there on the ground staring at nothing. She felt numb and the edges of her vision were fuzzy like the entire world existed in a dream.

Then a wave of rage enveloped her. She didn't need love. There was no power in it and she would never make that mistake again. In one month, she needed to argue her case to the Sorcerers Guild about the modified Spell of Obtainment. She and Micah had a lot of work to do.

*I edited this chapter just a bit. It should read a little smoother.

A Revelation in the Light of Day

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver arrives in Bright Moon.

Chapter Notes

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Spoilers: I’m picking and choosing what canon plot lines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, “Light Spinner” will be pretty spoilery.

Disclaimer: She-Ra and the Princesses of Power belong to DreamWorks and the wonderful Noelle Stevenson. Any and all other brand names that might appear here belong to their respective owners. I do not make any money on this story. Please don’t sue; you only stand to gain outstanding student loans for your troubles.

Author’s Note: This is inspired by fanart, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine’s song “No Light, No Light” along with Five Finger Death Punch’s “Wrong Side of Heaven.” My brain couldn’t leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

All mistakes I claim as my own.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It is said that when one is dying their life flashes before them. The mind’s way of reconciling a recent trauma and preparing you for the inevitable nothingness of death.

Shadow Weaver had often thought it was more likely that this so-called phenomenon occurred because the body was shutting down and using less oxygen. The dizzying effect of asphyxiation could account for the dreamlike hallucinations, but she had been proven wrong. Every time she closed her eyes her past cascaded before her, compelling her to face her most significant life decisions.

She relived every touch, every smell, and every emotion carried in her memories.

Shadow Weaver blinked her heavy eyelids as the last images of the memory escaped her. 'No power in love' indeed. She thought she had proved it. She manipulated everyone around her that longed for her adoration. She fought and toiled every day for her power only to watch others just have it handed to them. First Micah, then Adora emerged as the legendary She-Ra. What did any of her efforts matter now? In the end, the vignettes of her life showed her that she traded one master for another in her pursuit for power with nothing to show for it but shackles and a broken mask.

Shadow Weaver seized the sorcerer's badge from the slop on the carelessly dropped tray. The sorcerer was not yet ready to concede. Her memories also reminded her that she was a survivor and that there was still one more chance to live. The Moons of Enchantment were finally aligned and there was no more time to waste.

Shadow Weaver used her left arm to steady her right and desperately made the rune needed for her freedom. She still had a couple of hours until curfew but by then she would ensure a flawless mirage. It took just a bit too much of her remaining magic to cast the illusion. She hoped it would allow her enough time to slip out unnoticed. The throbbing behind her eyes began

and she knew she had no time to spare before she was even more vulnerable in her weakened state.

The shadows peeled away from the corners of her cells forming a burst of harmless flames around her body and then she was gone. An imperial purple enchantment slowly lit the floor of Adora's room. Shadow Weaver emerged from the enchantment etching the floor of Adora's room. The sorcerer stood tall, relieved that she arrived in Bright Moon, though it was not her exact intended destination.

Shadow Weaver silently approached the bed, observing her former ward. Adora looked at peace in her sleep. Not unlike the baby that grasped at her gloves all those years ago. The blonde grunted quietly in her sleep as if intuitively sensing Shadow Weaver's presence. Fatigue settled over Shadow Weaver like a weight. She was finding it difficult to stay upright. She reached out to stroke Adora's hair or rouse her awake, but the blonde was up in an instant. The hero flipped from the bed immediately wielding her sword.

"Adora," Shadow Weaver rasped. She didn't know if the name was a warning or a plea as her consciousness slipped away from her like loose soil. She had come too far for her body to give up on her now. She desperately tried to speak once more to tell Adora something, anything but only managed to groan before she fainted.

Darkness slid away to an unseen realm, revealing a new location. Shadow Weaver was surprised to awaken at all. As she slowly sat up, she held onto the broken mask, confirming its presence. She attempted to blink but even that seemed to be too challenging a task. Eyes widened behind her mask as her mind finally trudged

through her most recent events. Adora. The teleportation spell had worked, but at what cost?

A shoddy containment spell was the next thing she noticed. If she was at full strength she would be able to shred through the wards like a thin scroll but that was a matter for another time.

“Where am I?” She asked, pressing her hand against the barrier. Predictably, it shocked her. She groaned in pain, sneering in disgust at the thoughtless construction.

“You’re in the Bright Moon prison.” A regal and familiar voice informed her from the shaded area of the room. Angella and Castaspella stepped forward into the glow of the spell.

Shadow Weaver regarded the ‘prison.’ Even including Mystacor, the room was lovelier than anything she had previously resided in. “This is your prison?” She asked.

“Why does everyone keep-? Of course, this is a prison,” Angella huffed out.

“Ah, I see Glimmer came by the shrill screaming honestly,” Shadow Weaver snarked, biting down the affectionate amusement of Angella’s flustered state.

“How dare you...” Angella moved closer to the imprisonment spell.

“Shadow Weaver, you will answer for the crimes you committed during your time as my brother’s teacher.” Castaspella interrupted.

“Oh, yes. Sweet, talented Micah,” Shadow Weaver drawled tauntingly.

“You will not speak his name.” Angella bared her teeth.

Shadow Weaver pressed a hand to her chest. “I’m not the one that got him killed.”

Angella growled under her breath, stomping forward. Castaspella held up an arm, restraining her. Shadow Weaver wheezed, a harsh cough wracked her body. Darkness slicked down her form.

“Tell us why you’re here,” Angella demanded.

“I have vital information to defeat the Horde, but I will only talk to Adora.”

“Out of the question!” Angella spat immediately.

“Oh, how I’ve missed that fire,” Shadow Weaver rasped. “How fortunate that I am to spend my time in imprisonment looking at you. At least I can’t say the view won’t be pleasing.” She emphasized the last word as she coughed through her laughter. Lazy energy fell from her body, dissipating when it hit the barrier.

Angella blinked then frowned, crossing her arms. “What game are you playing?”

“Whatever you’re trying to do won’t work.” Castaspella interrupted

once more. She straightened her arms and started the incantation for a truth spell. “For the last time, tell us what you know.”

Shadow Weaver ignored the threatening tone, tracing the containment cell’s enchantment. She knew now that this sorcerer cast it. Shadow Weaver would normally use her magic to sense the integrity of the spell such as this but in this case, it was imperative to fall back to basics. Tracing the spell work on the floor, she knew everything she needed to know from the containment’s attributes. It was a standard magic dampening field used to keep her in place. Magic users that sought to cause her harm would likely be repelled but that restriction was not likely to be an intentional addition.

At least the Mystacor ruler was consistent. The same flaws she spotted on the floor were in the exact same location of the truth spell hovering above her. This was a small mistake that could be fixed with a minute adjustment but it was more fun to goad the younger woman before her.

“I know that when you cast a truth spell, you should make sure that you’ve drawn it correctly,” Shadow Weaver finally looked up, pointing out the broken lines of Castaspella’s glyph. “Sloppy work. Are you sure you’re Micah’s sister?”

Castaspella snarled, dispelling her magic as she rushed toward the barrier.

Angella stopped her just before she could make contact. “She’s trying to get under our skin.”

“You could spare yourself some trouble if you would just let me talk to Adora.” Shadow Weaver suggested helpfully.

Angella shook her head. “No, you’ve put that girl through enough. Now tell us the truth. Why did the Horde send you here? What are you planning?”

A bitter laugh escaped Shadow Weaver. “You think Hordak sent me? I escaped from Hordak and paid the price for it,” she groaned.

Angella’s eyes softened. “You’re dying aren’t you?” She would never forget the beautifully confident and respectable Light Spinner who had now become the fearsome and mysterious Shadow Weaver. It was hard to reconcile either image by this broken shell of a woman kneeling before her.

Castaspella glanced between Angella and the captive sorcerer. “Angella, can I speak with you for a moment?” The two queens walked silently back into the hallway. “This isn’t working,” she said once the door was shut behind them. “We’ve tried everything I can think of short of torturing her for her ‘vital information’ plus her condition is growing worse.”

“We are better than torture. We are not Her. Besides, you just said her condition is deteriorating. I can’t imagine violence or threat of violence would do much good at this point.”

“Perhaps we should let Adora-” Castaspella suggested.

Angella held up her hand. “That is not going to happen. Isn’t there something you can do? Is there a healing spell we could try until we figure our next step?”

“You want to heal her? Are you serious? Angella, you cannot let your feelings get in the way of what needs to be done. That’s not Light Spinner in there.” Castaspella practically shouted.

“I told you that in confidence!” Angella hissed as her eyes darted across the hall. She wasn’t worried about her guards. They were discreet and stayed in the background as they should. She trusted her guards implicitly and they trusted her. Adora or Glimmer could be lurking nearby and that’s just a complication she didn’t need right now. Seeing no one than the guard on duty, the queen slowly allowed the tension in her shoulders to drain away. “She’s dying, Castaspella.” She breathed out.

“I know, Angella. We can’t give her exposure to more magic than the containment field. After she performed the Spell of Obtainment, Shadow Weaver is like a sponge. She’ll suck up whatever power she comes in contact with. Micah told me she absorbed Norwyn and his magic with a wave of her hand.”

“Then we should consult with Princess Alliance before we go further,” Angella stated, glancing back at the door to the prison.

“Your majesties. Hey. So, who wants to see a magic trick?” Bow asked with a grin, shuffling a deck of cards. The only response to his inquiry was two perplexed looks.

Shadow Weaver laid on her bicep, fighting to stay awake. The rest of her body was scrunched in a nearly fetal position. She had learned the hard way what the spell’s defenses felt like on her unprotected feet. Adora should have arrived by now. Of course,

she'd heard the commotion outside the supposed prison. Adora was being thwarted at every angle by Glimmer and her archer.

The sorcerer was not sure how much longer she could hold on, but if she did not live through the next few hours, she would finally agree to give Angella all of the information if for no other reason than to hear her voice one last time. Death was making her far too melancholy for her tastes. A flash of glittering pink happened in her peripheral and she slowly sat up. "Adora," she said as the blonde approached her.

"Listen up, lady. After all your kidnapping and mind-wiping, I am just looking for a reason to serve up a little payback," Glimmer said, holding up a glowing fist. "So, if you do anything to hurt Adora-"

"Glimmer, I've got this," Adora said, walking forward.

Glimmer continued to scowl at Shadow Weaver over her best friend's shoulder. She gestured to the sorcerer that she was watching her every move.

"Look at you, my Adora." Shadow Weaver spoke lightly, her voice steady and soothing.

"You snuck into Bright Moon. I want to know why. That's the only reason we're speaking."

"To see you. You're the only one I can trust. I've missed you, my child." Shadow Weaver changed her voice to a frailer tone.

"We're past that. Try again." Adora shook her head.

“Clever.” Shadow Weaver observed. If she had the energy to spare, she would have been more impressed with Adora’s emotional growth. “You always were. From the moment I laid eyes on you. I knew you were different. You were-”

“I was what? Special?” Adora finished her sentence with an eye roll. “No, what you always told me was that I didn’t matter. I was special only as long as I obeyed you.” She walked around the perimeter of the magical barricade before stopping directly in front of Shadow Weaver. “Why are you here?” She inquired again.

Shadow Weaver glanced at Glimmer, noting that the Princess looked tremendously satisfied at the course of the conversation. The older woman opened her mouth to reply but an inky mass spilled to the floor from her cracked mask.

“What’s-what’s happening to you?” Adora asked with terror etched on her face.

“It took all of my magical power to come to you. I am dying, Adora.” Shadow Weaver explained after catching her breath.

“You’re lying.” Adora recoiled with a frown. She felt a prickling in the corner of her eyes. She hated Shadow Weaver’s methods and manipulation but she didn’t want her dead. Try as she might, the blonde couldn’t shake the bit of affection for the woman that raised her.

“Adora.” Glimmer stood, coming closer to her retreating friend. “I don’t think she’s lying about this.”

Shadow Weaver continued to hack. She felt the shadows escaping from every pore. The demon presence that bound with her all those years ago whispered its suggestion of submission to her ailing body as it abandoned her. She gasped for breath, her fists beating the floor as she fought to stop these shallow breaths from being her last.

Despite her relentless quest for power and accomplishments, she didn't want to die this way. She had come to stop Hordak and rain her vengeance upon him by any means necessary. Even if she arrived too late to change anything for the Rebellion, she had come to help.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora said quickly. "I don't know why you're here, but I won't let you suffer like this." She pointed the sword at the older woman. "I'm going to heal you, Shadow Weaver, and then you will answer our questions."

Glimmer pulled her friend away from the containment. "Adora, you don't know how to heal," she whispered.

"I can figure it out." She-Ra rushed out in one breath. "She'll die if I don't."

"Maybe I can help." Shadow Weaver interjected. She turned her body so she was facing them. "I was once a teacher of magic in Mystacor. I trained your father, Princess." Her rasp tapered to a wheeze. "I can help you control your magic, Adora but first…you must trust me."

"Fine, but in return, you trust me. Trust that I'm not stupid. Trust that I'll see right through your mind games. Stop lying for once

and trust me with the truth.” She-Ra demanded, slicing the sword through the air. “No more half-truths and no more flowery riddles.”

Shadow Weaver regarded the young woman before her and nodded her agreement. “Let’s begin. You are a Princess, so you have a Runestone. Yours dwells there within your sword.” She pointed to the clear gem in the middle of the crossguard and grip of the sword. “With it, you claim the elemental magic of Etheria. Let it flow through the sword and into you.” She paused, allowing She-Ra a moment to comprehend the lesson. “You must learn to concentrate. Focus your power.”

She-Ra grunted, shaking her head in annoyance. “I’ve tried that before. I can’t get it to work.” She exclaimed, falling to her knees. “What do I do, point the sword at you or what?”

“Calm down. Your frustration will cause the energy you produce to become destructive if you’re not careful. There must be peace in your mind if you are to heal. Come closer and allow me to help you.” Shadow Weaver offered, holding out her hand.

She-Ra stood with a sigh. She slowly walked forward to breach the barrier and kneeled again in front of Shadow Weaver.

“You are afraid, but you refuse to admit it. Afraid of your power, of it spiraling out of control. Sometimes restraint is necessary but not in this case. Use that fear. Feel it, acknowledge it, and move past it.” Shadow Weaver hissed, the choking itch of the coughing fits were coming quicker now. “You are greater than your fear.”

Pure, golden energy escaped the sword as She-Ra closed her eyes. The sword pulsed and lifted from her hands, bathing the room in a dazzling glow.

“What are you doing?” Angella asked as she slammed the door open. Castaspella entered the room right on her heels.

Bow could be seen in the doorway, arms flailing to catch all the playing cards flipping through the air. He gave up and followed the queens through the door. She-Ra leaned forward and placed her hands on either side of Shadow Weaver’s mask. The sorcerer gasped at the tremendous feeling of the sublime magic of Etheria flowing through her. Suddenly, a cerise beam of light arched through the air from an unseen source and appeared over Shadow Weaver. She levitated into the air with a yell. Everyone shielded their eyes from the final burst of She-Ra’s magic. Adora stumbled from the barrier, using the sword as a crutch.

“Adora!” Glimmer exclaimed. “What happened? The last bit of the healing sounded a little painful.”

“I don’t know. I healed Shadow Weaver but there was a second presence in there with us.” Adora shook her head, frowning. “It didn’t come from the sword or She-Ra.”

“This is precisely why I told you, girls, to stay out of here.” Angella approached Glimmer and Adora, helping them to their feet. “Castaspella, will you check the barrier?”

Castaspella raised her hands, allowing her magic to retrace the glyphs. She tested and retested the spell holding Shadow Weaver. “There are no signs of tampering or flaws. She hasn’t done anything.”

“You could have just asked.” Shadow Weaver pointed out.

“You have yet to prove that we can trust anything you say, ” Castaspella said.

“We’ll have to come back to this at another time?” Adora asked, pinching the bridge of her nose. “I held up my end. Now you hold up yours. Why are you here?”

“You want the truth?” Shadow Weaver asked, chuckling as she stretched to her full height. “The truth is I have nowhere left to go. Catra betrayed me. Hordak cast me aside.” She shook her clenched fist. “I want to take them down. And helping you is the best way to do it. Hordak has been working for years to build a machine capable of opening a portal through the fabric of space. He intends to bring the rest of the Horde’s armies through this portal and use them to conquer Etheria, once and for all.”

“Armies?” Angella breathed, walking closer. “There’s more of the Horde?”

Shadow Weaver nodded. “The force is so large you cannot even comprehend it. You have struggled to hold off Hordak’s paltry troops for years. You will stand no chance against the full might of the Horde.”

“What makes you think he’s getting close doing this now?” Adora inquired.

“Because now he has a Princess who knows how to combine First Ones’ technology with the Horde’s machines.” Shadow Weaver pointed out.

“Entrapta.” Bow shook his head, brow knitted. “That’s why she’s been after all that First Ones’ tech.”

“How stupid do you think we are?” Glimmer shouted at Shadow Weaver before turning to the rest of the group. “She knows the Horde is losing and she’s trying to scare us. Portals to other worlds? That’s ridiculous.”

“I know how this must sound. We on Etheria have no concept of a universe beyond our reach. And yet, the evidence stands before us.” Shadow Weaver revealed, pointing at Adora.

Adora glanced at everyone and looked back at Shadow Weaver. “Me?”

“Years ago, Hordak opened a portal. It was only for a moment. And in that, a child came through. That child was you, Adora. You were brought through a portal from another world.”

The blonde was silent, staring ahead to no particular point. “What?” she finally exhaled.

“Leave her alone,” Glimmer snapped. “You’re lying, we all know it. You lie about everything.”

“I have not lied about anything since I’ve been here, Princess and I gain nothing from it,” Shadow Weaver said quickly. “Adora is different from us. Do you think just anyone could bring a dying woman back to life?” She clasped her hands together only addressing Adora. “Not quite the reunion either of us pictured, is

it? I understand how hard it is to believe. Perhaps, you would have preferred the comfort of lies."

"I think that's quite enough." Castaspella spat.

"Don't listen to her, Adora." Bow pleaded, reaching for his friend.

Adora's chin wobbled as she struggled to keep her tears at bay. She pivoted and ran out of the room at top speed.

"Adora!" Glimmer yelled.

"Why are you so hateful?" Bow shouted at Shadow Weaver before he ran after his friend.

"Alright, Shadow Weaver. I warned you," Glimmer said, both hands tensed at her side. She raised her fist which was now encased in her signature rosy light. The Princess reared her arm back.

Castaspella seized her niece's wrist. "Glimmer, no. If you throw anything at her, it may break the containment."

"Everyone out," Angella commanded quietly.

"Angella, do you really think you should be alone with her?" Castaspella glanced at her sister in law.

"Out!" Angella shouted, her wings flaring behind her.

Castaspella tugged a sullen Glimmer behind her to the door. It was quickly shut by a guard. The room fell to an uncomfortable silence. Angella regarded her prisoner now that Shadow Weaver was healthy. This was the proud woman she remembered, a presence that seemed to add an additional three feet to her frame. She carried herself elegantly and even managed to make the disheveled sable locks look sophisticated.

The queen walked slowly, her heeled boots loud in the silence. She continued to watch Shadow Weaver while the other woman waited patiently with her own unwavering gaze. "If your intention was to hurt your only ally, congratulations you've succeeded. I hope you're happy with your achievement."

"I feel a great many things, but I can honestly say happiness does not make the list."

"You counted on this, didn't you? Counted on your loyalty achieved through abuse to override her sense of self-preservation. You knew Adora could help you."

"What I counted on was Adora's unwavering curiosity." The masked woman countered. "I had a theory about She-Ra's healing abilities, but I wasn't positive. I have miscalculated about so many things lately. I was telling the truth when I said that I had nowhere else to go. I mostly relied on your nature and the Rebellion's. That you all were better than me despite your contempt for my actions."

"Don't you think you've done enough to Adora?"

"When I teleported, I thought of you. I did aim for your location

but I underestimated the magic I had left." Shadow Weaver admitted. "Before I knew it, I appeared in Adora's room and collapsed."

"Why did you do it?" Angella asked, walking around the containment in measured steps.

Shadow Weaver turned, tracking Angella's movements. "Adora had a right to know where she comes from, especially now that she may be our only way to defeat the Horde."

Angella stopped in front of the woman. "You know what I'm asking about."

"I'm afraid I'm at a loss. To what are you referring?"

"You tortured Glimmer. Why?" Angella ground out between gritted teeth.

"Torture?" Shadow Weaver's eyes widened. "I did not torture Glimmer. I held her in magical restraints using the power of the Black Garnet. Her Moonstone elemental power did not mix with the Black Garnet's and the result was her glitches when she tried to teleport away."

"Why?"

"When I saw the opportunity to bring you out of your gilded cage to the Fright Zone, I selfishly took it." Shadow Weaver explained.

"After how you treated me, you expect me to believe you still care

for me?” Angella asked, her eyes glittered with anger as she glared daggers at Shadow Weaver.

“I never stopped. I tried to cut my attachment away like a lame limb but it was no use. I could never stop caring for you.”

“That’s wonderful news,” Angella scoffed, placing her hands on her hips. “Is that supposed to make me fall into your arms? You have put me and my family through endless grief. This is not a fairytale and there are no happy endings for monsters.”

Shadow Weaver reared back. “...monster?” she fought to keep her voice steady.

“I-I didn’t mean that.” Angella stumbled back, holding a hand to her mouth. Her back hit the door and she swiftly threw it open and fled.

“Come now, your majesty, have some conviction in your words. Nigella would be so disappointed.” Shadow Weaver called after her.

The next day of Shadow Weaver’s captivity was marginally better than the previous one. She didn’t bother trying to sleep. There was too much energy buzzing below the surface of her skin and she was wholly unfamiliar with the source. It was surprisingly genial for the amount of potential she felt in it. Perhaps after she managed to secure her place as an ally she would be allowed to study the effects of She-Ra’s healing powers more closely.

Light began to stream through the large windows, painting the room in a cacophony of colors. She stood and stretched her hands over her head. She heard the queen's footfalls come closer and the rustling of her feathers moments before the door opened.

"Good morning." Shadow Weaver greeted.

Angella nodded in acknowledgment and approached the barrier with a serving tray. "Step back from the edge."

"Step back to where? If you have not noticed there's barely enough room for me to breathe." Shadow Weaver responded.

Lilac eyes peered at Shadow Weaver. "I will see what can be done about that," Angella said as she kneeled and pushed the tray inside the containment spell. "My guards scoured every inch of the castle twice. How did you get into Bright Moon?"

"Your wards are very subjective. I was able to bypass them because I didn't wish any harm to its inhabitants." Shadow Weaver answered simply. It's truly a wonder how the Rebellion had lasted this long. Surely Micah didn't create the wards protecting the Bright Moon Palace. He would have known better.

Angella spoke, breaking Shadow Weaver's musing. "You have your breakfast. I'll return to collect it in half an hour."

Shadow Weaver studied the bowl in front of her. It was filled with a hot cereal made with grains and topped with plump, ripe berries for sweetness. Fruit juice and water accompanied the meal on the tray. While the meal wouldn't have been her first choice, she was

surprised to be eating so well. Bright Moon, it seemed, is even nauseatingly nice to its prisoners.

After breakfast, she felt more alert and was ready to gauge the damage to her magic. Angella had come and gone apparently deciding it wiser to ignore her than engage her further. Raising to her full height, she inhaled, holding the breath until her lungs burned and exhaled slowly. She was in control.

Inhale.

The power was all around her to take. She felt it and invited it within herself lifting her hands in front of her, waiting. Nothing happened. It did not come. The darkness and shadows stayed flat and inert in their corners. They did not answer her call. She refocused her efforts, seeking further within.

There at her core was a tiny, pitiable seed exuding feeble palpitations of energy. That was her only indication that she was not completely without magic as she originally thought, but she might as well be. She held no more power than a lowly apprentice at Mystacor. There was no way the magic dampening enchantment was affecting her so. She was too experienced and far too talented to be neutered in such a manner.

It seemed almost too calculated, too poignant. Defecting and leaving herself at the mercy of the Rebellion at the direct sacrifice of her magic. She chuckled to herself. It seemed even she could not outrun her consequences. Norwyn, that bastard, must be rejoicing from his eternal resting place.

Shadow Weaver looked down at her hands and had begun to consider her options when two knocks sounded at the door. After

a couple of beats of silence, Angella entered the room with a spray bottle.

"Have I been so naughty that you've chosen to discipline me like a poor pussycat?"

Angella was once again mute as she floated from plant to plant misting it with the spray bottle. Disappointed in not being able to speak with the queen Shadow Weaver continued to reflect about yesterday. While trying to put on a brave front and even managing to wound her with words, Angella's eyes had been and still are extremely expressive. As much as she tried to dismiss the sorcerer's feelings, her own shone through with intensity.

From the rest of them, hostility seemed to be their chosen method of dealing with her. Merely a reflex to what she'd done in the past. The Rebellion would need to move past it quickly as they needed her help to defeat the Horde so she could take her revenge on Hordak. He probably foresaw this very situation and that's why he wanted her exiled to Beast Island. Best not disappoint her former co-conspirator's expectations. Shadow Weaver grinned to herself.

She was useless in this confinement field and with Angella currently deciding not to speak with her unless it was absolutely necessary, she had no way of convincing her that talents would be better outside of this prison.

"Princess," Shadow Weaver drawled teasingly.

"That is Queen Angella of Bright Moon to you," Angella said, her voice sharp and brittle. The effect was softened by the clear spray bottle crinkling in her grasp.

“You are still in command of the Moonstone, so you are technically still a Princess.” Shadow Weaver couldn’t help but needle her. She noticed the queen stayed several steps away from the barrier. “If you’re worried about the integrity of the spell, don’t be. I can assure you it will not harm you. It’s attuned to sorcerers only.” she pointed to one of the circular symbols on the floor. “Have you given any thought to my role in your attack on the Fright Zone?”

Angella didn’t get closer but she did seem less tense around her shoulders. Really this would be too easy to achieve. “I don’t see a point in extending our interactions more than this.”

“Don’t want to get too close, is that it? Despite the rumors, I have not succeeded in possession,” Shadow Weaver taunted. She was alarmed when four guards and Castaspella spilled into the room without knocking. An impromptu execution was her initial thought, but the Bright Moon Guards just spread out around the corners of the room, standing at attention. They then all but ignored her presence.

“What did you say to her?” Castaspella asked at once. “I’m supposed to make this larger but there’s no other way to do that without taking it down. So, these guards,” she nodded in their general direction, “Are here to make sure you behave.”

There was more movement at the door and three people walked inside. One of the strangers was a harried, bespectacled man that kept tripping over a large bundle of fabrics in his hands. There was another larger Elberon man, pulling a ladder into the room. He paled as he spotted Shadow Weaver and he continued to stare at her with a wide unblinking gaze.

“There is a way to expand its limits without removing the spell completely if you want to learn.” Shadow Weaver returned her gaze back to Castaspella. She was aware of the man with the ladder who had finally broken his stupor, inching past her. It was comical how he thought his shuffling steps would go unnoticed.

“As if I would take advice from you! What are you up to now?”

“Temper, temper, if you don’t calm down you’ll just cast a disastrous funnel of magic.” Shadow Weaver tutted.

“If anyone would know you would.” Castaspella felt her magic tingling across her fingers.

“Correct. So, either release your anger through a more harmless spell or listen to my instruction.” Shadow Weaver steepled her fingers. “Mystacor teaches that magic is permanent and that there are limitations to its capabilities once it’s expelled from the caster. That is not accurate. Spells are ever-changing.”

Angella stood beside Castaspella, staring at Shadow Weaver wearily. “If this is another one of your attempts to get to Adora…”

“There’s no trick. If I’m wrong or make any moves against your magic, you still have your well-armed friends here to protect you.” Shadow Weaver pointed at the guards watching her every move.

Castaspella hated to admit it, even to herself, but Shadow Weaver had a point. It would be infinitely safer for everyone if the spell was intact. “Fine, show me.”

“Shut out your distractions. Feel the magic and focus.”

“I’m not a first-year apprentice,” Castaspella said, crossing her arms. “I’m an accomplished sorcerer, just tell me what to do.”

“Be that as it may you have not done anything such as this,” Shadow Weaver said as she called on her reserve of patience that she developed as a teacher. “Now, that irritation you feel for me? Ignore it. You must be calm.” She emphasized.

Castaspella scowled but remained silent. Her shoulders slumped just a bit as she took a deep breath but she still appeared tense.

“This enchantment needs to be changed.” Shadow Weaver pointed to two faded glyphs along the floor. “Start as though you’re testing the barrier and seek this pair out. Isolate them and bend them to your magic.”

Closing her eyes, Castaspella concentrated. She immediately saw what Shadow Weaver was talking about. She poured more shielding into the weaker of the two spell elements and coaxed the second one into a more complex symbol. When Castaspella finally opened her eyes, the confinement cell had now nearly tripled in size. Shadow Weaver had not moved from her original spot and the magical prison was as strong as ever.

“I did it,” Castaspella said quietly. “I mean of course I did. I am the Queen of Mystacor after all.”

“Of course,” Shadow Weaver agreed mockingly. She glanced around the room and spotted yet the third person, a woman,

pushing an overstuffed armchair towards the circle. Shadow Weaver slowly sauntered to the very edge of the new barrier's edge as the workers were now distracted with their work. "Boo."

The ladder man from earlier happened to be too close to the confinement's new barrier line. His resulting scream nearly cracked the crystal lights dangling from the ceiling. The ladder hit the floor with a crash. More guards appeared in the doorway ready to take down the threat but were surprised to find nothing amiss besides the interior design workers tidying up their work.

"Why did you do that?" Angella asked, shaking her head in disapproval.

"I detest frivolous tarrying," Shadow Weaver stated, settling into the new chair like it was the finest throne. "You have nothing to fear from me."

"It's larger and you have someplace to sleep. I hope you find your prison cozy," Castaspella said as Angella dismissed all of the guards.

Shadow Weaver looked at the mostly empty space. "It's splendid. I was thinking of inviting some friends over for tea and pastries."

Angella and Castaspella glanced at each other then looked back to Shadow Weaver. Angella's eyes widened as she stifled her laugh behind her hand. Castaspella had no such qualms and cackled gleefully.

"Was my statement really that humorous?" Shadow Weaver tilted her head in question.

“Not the statement per se,” Castaspella clarified, her chuckles tapered off. “Just the idea of you having friends.”

“You can consider your possible invitation revoked.”

“Oh, well there go my plans for the evening. How will I go on now with this crippling disappointment?” Castaspella asked as more laughter punctuated her rhetorical question.

“Your sarcasm was not needed nor requested,” Shadow Weaver said plainly, settling once more on her chair.

The rest of the day was not nearly as eventful as her morning. Angella returned with her lunch and dinner but instead of silence, she was mostly monosyllabic unless the situation demanded more. Shadow Weaver was delighted at the progress. Two polite knocks sounded from the door, announcing Angella’s return.

“Back so soon after supper, your majesty?” Shadow Weaver asked with her feet reclined on the arm of the chair. She was fortunate that her dress covered her feet from view.

“We’re not giving you the chance to terrorize another member of my staff. I’m surprised that poor man didn’t quit the second he was in the hallway,” Angella said without preamble.

“I assumed I would have no other interactions besides a guard

that drew the short straw so those three guests, however brief, were a welcome surprise."

Angella continued as if Shadow Weaver hadn't spoken. "We're trying to figure out a way for you to bathe. We're definitely not giving you free rein of this room."

"It is rather counterproductive to clean my body only to put this filthy garment back on, don't you think?" Shadow Weaver pinched the corner of her dress with fingers.

"Well, I definitely don't want her sitting here skyclad. No need to give anybody nightmares," Castaspella said as she barged into the room.

"Castaspella, please don't get her started," Angella said, halting Shadow Weaver's response as she glanced at the woman beside her. "I'll take your dress to be cleaned during your bath."

"And what will I wear in the meantime?" Shadow Weaver replied cautiously.

Angella gave her an appraising look. "I'm sure I have something that will fit you."

"Still can't wait to get me out of my clothes?" Shadow Weaver teased. She glanced at the aghast expression from Castaspella and gloated internally.

"I'm not dignifying that with a response." Angella's back stiffened and she could no longer meet Shadow Weaver's gaze.

“You don’t have to dirty up one of your dresses, Angella. Please allow me. I know just the thing,” Castaspella said, hurrying off to find clothing. When she returned she was still shaking with giggles. She stepped carefully as she was carrying a bundle of towels under a big bowl filled with suds.

Angella moved the changing screen inside the barrier while Castaspella pushed the water and towels just past the line. Moments later, Shadow Weaver’s old dress appeared over the top of the screen. Angella gathered the cloth in her hands watching as Castaspella walked out of the room.

“Is there something else? Are you standing guard to make sure I don’t escape with a bar of soap?” Shadow Weaver asked when she didn’t hear the second set of footsteps retreating from the room.

“Right, yes. I’ll leave you to your privacy,” Angella said, coughing into her hand. She confirmed the dress was not dragging along the floor and turned to leave but caught sight of movement from a lithe silhouette out of the corner of her eye. The smooth enthralling voice, long and lustrous hair, coupled with the intense jade eyes she remembered made her face feel warm. Shaking herself from the thoughts she cursed the fact there were too many blasted windows in here. She cleared her throat. “I’ll be right outside. Call when you’re ready.”

Shadow Weaver combed a clean hand through her tousled hair and admitted she did feel more like herself after the bath. She was infinitely thankful for the comb that was provided in the

towels. After detangling the wet strands, she took the bundle of hair from the comb and placed it on the handle.

If her theory was correct, the newly recharged barrier should react to the dormant essence of her even in a piece so insignificant as hair. Taking a deep breath, she braced herself and pressed the comb to the barrier. There was an electric spark as the hair burned becoming gnarled with the treatment. The smell was nauseating but she held her hand steady until there was no trace of her hair.

Castaspella was the first one through the door. She used magic to blast the changing screen out of the circle. "What on Etheria are you doing!?"

"Powerful spells can be cast using the essence of the person. I'm eliminating that option." Shadow Weaver removed the comb away from the spell's surface.

"Are you seriously accusing us of wanting to touch your dead hair to cast a spell on you?" Castaspella scoffed, looking disgusted.

"I did not live this long by being careless. Whether or not that's something you planned to do, it is now irrelevant." Shadow Weaver gestured to the slowly dissipating smoke clinging inside the barrier.

Angella opened her mouth but a guffaw fell out. Shadow Weaver looked ridiculous in the fluffy bathrobe Castaspella provided. It was the ugliest garment she'd ever seen and had so many sequins it nearly hurt to look at.

“Here is your dress,” Angella said, gesturing to two guards to put up the changing screen for Shadow Weaver again. The last guard gathered the dirty water and carefully bundled the dirty towels on top of the crystal bowl and left the room. Angella tossed the dress over the top and left the room, keeping her eyes pointed directly in front of her during her exit.

“I’m done.” Shadow Weaver called after a few moments.

When Angella reentered the room she saw the robe that was tossed over the changing screen was in tatters. She held back her smirk at the petty move. The queen decided to make sure that every robe that was given for laundry during Shadow Weaver’s captivity would be pink and fluffier than the last. She would allow the small victories to amuse her at least for a time. The changing screen was back in its position at the edge of the room and the robe remained in its position.

“Angella?” Shadow Weaver inquired.

“Yes?” Angella answered before she could think to correct the way she was addressed.

“Why do you place restraints on yourself? You could be so much more powerful,” Shadow Weaver said, tucking her hair behind her ears.

Angella held up a hand. “Don’t speak your poisonous words of power to me.”

“Adora is literally She-Ra, the Princess of Power and only good has

come from that. You should be pleased. She's grown into a very dedicated rebellion fighter."

"I'm not the one that trained her to be a warrior." Angella accused. "It's despicable what she endured in the Fright Zone."

"It only made her stronger." Shadow Weaver insisted. "Do you want to know what we talked about while you were being dazzled by parlor tricks?"

"Not particularly."

Shadow Weaver barreled on. "We spoke of trust and Adora made me promise to give her the full truth to her questions. I may be many things but I would never be so flippant as to toss away a promise to someone who spared my life."

"Even with something as pure as the truth you will always find a way to taint its intention."

"Yes, I could have spun it into prose and prophecy but Adora did not want that. I gave her the hard facts of her origin. She needs this time to process but Adora will be fine."

"No, thanks to you," Angella said.

"She will be back. She wants answers and she is too clever to not seek my counsel."

"You stay away from Adora! You will not speak to any of the

children. I will triple the guards in every room of the Palace if I have to." Angella vowed, clenching her hand in a fist.

"Stay away from Adora. Stay away from Bow. Stay away from Glimmer." Shadow Weaver mocked. "Perhaps, you should give me a list of those I'm allowed to speak with. I am sure it wouldn't trouble you half as much."

"From now on you will speak directly to me or Castaspella."

"I'm going to get your royal attention during my captivity?" Shadow Weaver's eyes widened in mock surprise. "That is good news."

"Don't read into it." Angella rolled her eyes with a sneer. "We are the only ones that are immune to your scheming."

"Hardly." Shadow Weaver argued, slamming her hand against the magical wall. She had prepared herself for the electricity and gritted her teeth to avoid making a sound. The momentary pain was worth the gasp Angella produced. "The only reason for your alleged immunity is the anger you're letting override the fear you have of me. There is no reason to fear me. I am no longer your enemy. There is a war coming that cares not for our petty squabbles. I am curious if you will hide away behind your Moonstone again when the time comes?" she asked, tilting her head.

Angella fought to keep her face blank. She would not give the other woman the satisfaction of a reaction. "You will remain here until we've decided what to do about the portal." She pivoted and hurried from the room.

“I look forward to your visits,” Shadow Weaver called after her, and then Angella was gone.

Inane prattle filtered through the door and continued down the hallway just moments after Angella left. Shadow Weaver angled her head to the door. Angella must have taken her advice seriously despite what Glimmer thought if the Princess Alliance was being called.

Shadow Weaver listened for any hint of their plan of action only to learn there was nothing of value. The Rebellion was exactly as she suspected, a bunch of little girls playing heroes and a bunch of adults letting them. Despite that fact, they held Hordak’s forces at bay and even went so far as to recapture the sparse territory he’d claimed. Yes, joining the Rebellion was truly the best way to destroy Hordak.

The rhythmic click of Angella’s heeled boots leaving the room served as Shadow Weaver’s wakeup call the next morning. Aromas from her breakfast permeated the small space before Shadow Weaver had properly awakened. Her sleep was not restful last night but it was certainly better. It apparently would take her some time to adjust without the comforting chill of her shadow powers to cocoon her. Truly a dreamless, darkness was Shadow Weaver’s most preferable slumber to anything else. Silent and still with no dreams or memories to haunt her.

“What is the rush, your majesty?” Shadow Weaver asked as she finished her final stretch.

“You’ve been given thirty minutes the same as before.”

Shadow Weaver made a show of placing her tray next to the chair off to the side. If Angella wanted to retrieve it, she would need to enter the spell to reach it. “What would it hurt to give me ten minutes more to eat?”

“Why do you barrage me with endless inane questions?” Angella asked with a sigh.

“You are my only link to the outside world.” Shadow Weaver answered as if the solution should have been obvious.

“Castaspella can deliver your meals from now on if you prefer,” Angella suggested.

“If I wanted to poison myself I would have stayed in the Fright Zone and continued eating cold gruel and ration bars,” Shadow Weaver said. She also wasn’t sure if she could restrain herself from harming Castaspella if she spent more than five minutes in her presence.

“Castaspella is not going to poison you,” Angella said, unable to meet Shadow Weaver’s eyes.

“Yes, and you sound completely confident that she hasn’t at least contemplated it.” Shadow Weaver walked just to the edge of the barrier, nearest Angella. “I’m glad you are here. You said something the other day that perplexed me. You said that I had treated you poorly, but before now I had only been the best friend I’d ever been to anyone.”

“Don’t you dare sit there and pretend you don’t know what I’m talking about.”

“You have me at a complete and utter loss, Angella.”

“That seems to be a reoccurring theme of yours. You just have a selective memory when you hurt me, is that it?” Angella placed a hand to her chest as her face colored with anger. “Later that night after my mother told Norwyn about our engagement, you found me in my room and told me there was no power in love. You told me that I was a foolish girl with a head full of dreams that I wasn’t worth your time.”

“Angella, the only time I spoke to you that night was near the arch. I came to tell you about my feelings and you told me you never wanted to see me again.”

“Don’t lie to me, not about this.” Angella shook her head wildly, her loosely curled hair bouncing. “I was inconsolable. My mother took us back to Empyrean that same night. My mother was able to convince the Empyrean council that my marriage could wait. When I finally returned five years later, your statue was already tarnished. They told me you used mind control on Micah and used the Spell of Obtainment to turn yourself into a demon.”

“Mind control? Is that what they told you?” Shadow Weaver asked in amusement. “I never used mind control on Micah to help me with that spell. He willingly offered his help.”

“Micah was a rock as I mourned you. I didn’t know what had become of you. Whether you had grown mad with power or was starving in some cavern on Beast Island. Finally, I asked my

mother to find you. Imagine my surprise when the reports of the woman called Shadow Weaver in the Fright Zone was you." Angella snapped, jutting an accusatory finger just inside the barrier. "Glimmer was right. You lie about everything."

Shadow Weaver struck, quick as a snake, and grabbed Angella's hand before she could retreat.

Angella's face became thunderous. "Let go of me."

"Not until you listen." Shadow Weaver stated calmly.

The queen parted her lips again to shout for guards or make another demand but before she could succeed, Shadow Weaver pulled Angella off balance. She pulled the winged woman closer and awkwardly spun her so that Angella's back was pressed against the front of Shadow Weaver's body.

Shadow Weaver immediately clamped a hand over Angella's mouth, halting anymore sounds other than muffled yelling that she was sure wouldn't be heard through the loud hum of magical energy. Angella fought Shadow Weaver with every movement, but the sorcerer held firm. Their struggle sent them tripping backward.

Before Shadow Weaver could regret her choice in an attack she felt the solid comfort of the armchair break their fall. Angella kept squirming on Shadow Weaver's lap, muffled words caught behind the vice grip of a slender hand. Careful to mind the delicate wings of Angella's back, Shadow Weaver tightened her hold. The queen was determined to get away but all it was serving to do is bring her feelings to the fore.

“Stop. Moving.” Shadow Weaver whispered harshly. She leaned over panting from the recent exertion. Her breath escaped through the crack in her mask onto the long neck in front of her. “I didn’t perform mind control on Micah and while those are my words, I never said them to you that night.”

She felt Angella still in her arms, shiver and stiffen as the queen realized the position they were in. If anyone were to walk in it would look more intimate than circumstances should allow.

Shadow Weaver took a steadying breath. “In hindsight, my methods were unorthodox, but I needed you to listen to me. Don’t scream,” she said, removing her hand from Angella’s mouth.

Angella huffed with a toss of her head. “I can’t believe you. If you’re trying to convince me to release you, molesting me is not the way to achieve it.”

“I had to stop you from running away and hiding like you always do,” Shadow Weaver said, recognizing just a moment too late those words were the wrong ones to declare aloud.

Angella’s hand came up sending a light beam at the other woman and beating her wings to carry her back towards the door. Shadow Weaver’s hands instinctively cast a shield with her hands, but no magic accompanied her movements. The flash hit her dead on, lifting her from her feet. She struck the other side of the barrier. The electricity greedily ravaged her body before she fell to the floor. Her breath rattled as she weakly lifted her head.

A trio of guards rushed into the room at the commotion. Angella

was once again outside the enchanted circle when they promptly pointed their crescent-shaped spears at Shadow Weaver.

"Your majesty! Is everything okay?" The guard on the left asked.

"I'm fine," Angella said.

Shadow Weaver brushed her hair away from her face, looking at Angella. The guards may have bought the lie because the queen had her back to them, but the sorcerer knew better. Fuschia flamed across Angella's cheeks and her pupils were blown wide with what Shadow Weaver was certain the queen thought she would convince herself was fury.

"Should we fetch the healer?" The same guard questioned.

"No. Leave us," Angella said gruffly.

"If you're sure…"

"That was an order." Angella kept eye contact with Shadow Weaver while the guards hurried away, closing the door once more. Shadow Weaver was slowly getting her breathing under control.

"Never do that again." Angella walked backward to the door, keeping her eyes trained on Shadow Weaver with every step. "Ever."

The door slammed closed and Shadow Weaver's eyes drifted close

in blissful oblivion.

Pain greeted Shadow Weaver as soon as she opened her eyes. The moonlight was too bright and warm for it to be morning. She gingerly sat up, trying to stretch her aching muscles.

Castaspella looked startled as she dropped the tray on the floor. “Sorry,” she said then smirked.

“This is the part where you leave,” Shadow Weaver said, her eyes trained on the foods in front of her. Even spilled across the tray they looked thousands of times better than her prison meals in the Fright Zone. She was correct in her assessment of the moons’ position in the sky. The mess was definitely a midday meal.

“If you’re looking for Angella, don’t bother,” Castaspella said as she paced back and forth. “I’m not her. I don’t buy this frail and broken act.”

“We don’t have to speak,” Shadow Weaver reminded her. Her body ached and she was still drained enough to sleep more. It was obvious a healer had not been summoned to examine her. She had expected Angella’s anger, but her callousness took her by surprise. Maybe she'd finally overstepped her boundary. “Angella managed to complete this task without a word,” she told Castaspella.

“You’ve finally chased her away by talking about Micah.” Castaspella persisted. “That’s what you do, you know. You swallow people up in your darkness until they’re nothing but abused husks of their former selves and then you spit them out.”

Shadow Weaver was confused momentarily as she considered the new information. They did talk about him briefly, but Micah had nothing to do with why Angella was not here today of that she was certain. This could only mean two things. Either, Angella lied about just what their disagreement entailed, or Angella was affected by what happened despite her actions. It was entirely possible with all the Bright Moon's Queen goodness her guilt at being aroused by the enemy was eating her alive and she wasn't ready to face what happened. Ever since the bathing incident and the subsequent conflict thereafter, she was certain Angella began to see her as a woman again instead of just evil incarnate.

Perhaps, it had been too long since someone challenged Angella. There was also a possibility Angella had never been manhandled into submission and it spoke to an obscure desire she was too embarrassed to admit.

Shadow Weaver could certainly tease it out the queen she thought then chuckled under her breath. The laugh slowly got louder until she had fully unnerved the woman in front of her. "Very good, Mistress Mystacor. Did you practice that in the mirror for long?"

Castaspella's face became an unattractive shade of red at being caught out. "Oh, just go jump in a bog." She kicked the tray further into the barrier and turned to leave.

Shadow Weaver remembered Castaspella always tagging along with Micah and Angella. She always pretended she hadn't liked Angella on their outings, but Shadow Weaver knew sibling rivalry when she saw it, however, one sided it was on Castaspella's part. "Do you sometimes think if I never existed you might have had a chance with Angella?" She asked conversationally.

Castaspella's eyes widened and her face became ashen. "What?"

"There's so much envy when you look at me and her in the same room that I'm surprised your eyes don't outshine my own." Shadow Weaver passed her hand under her eye line for emphasis.

"Shut your treacherous mouth." Castaspella stomped to the edge of the barrier.

Shadow Weaver stood just as close, but she carefully avoided touching the spell. "Go ahead. Just one step further. Finish what you start for once. After all, we know Angella likes her women with some follow-through."

Castaspella nostrils flared and she was practically vibrating in place.

"Pathetic," Shadow Weaver tutted. "No wonder she chose Micah over you."

"She chose him over you too." Castaspella pointed out.

"You are so deeply steeped in your sexual jealousy that you don't even see the evidence in front of you," Shadow Weaver said in a slow sing-song. "Maybe you do. That is why you pulled her from the room, isn't it? You saw her concern for me on that first night. You knew then that her feelings were not gone."

Castaspella shook her head. "You're wrong. Angella would never love a vile thing like you," she said desperately.

“She already does,” Shadow Weaver said confidently. “She’ll choose me over you time and again. It must kill you to know that your flimsy little containment spell is not for your protection but mine.”

With a yell, Castaspella threw herself at the barrier. It flared to life, tossing her across the room.

Guards knocked down the door but it was Angella who led the charge inside. “What’s going on here?” she asked.
The guards immediately helped Castaspella from the floor.

“Let me go. She doesn’t deserve to live. I’m gonna kill her. I swear it.” Castaspella babbled as she tried to shake off the two guards’ firm hold and stay upright at the same time.

“What have you done?” Angella shouted to Shadow Weaver then turned her attention back to Castaspella. “Stop it. You're not killing anyone. That’s not the person you are.”

All the fight left Castaspella at once. She saw past Angella’s soothing tones and latched onto the pleading desperation leaking into the older woman’s speech. “I can’t believe she’s right.” Her voice cracked through a sob.

“What’s she talking about? Right about what? What did you say to her?” Angella asked the questions in a single breath.
“There was no harm done. I simply told the truth.” Shadow Weaver answered.

“Your version of the truth is never harmless.” Angella stared at

Shadow Weaver. She turned and dismissed the guards. "Escort Castaspella back to her suite, I'll be there momentarily."

"It's so refreshing to see someone so protective of you." Shadow Weaver murmured as she watched the guards drag Castaspella from the room. She nodded to the sorcerer like an old friend just before she was no longer visible.

Angella opened her mouth and closed it with a shake of her head. The queen exited the room with a slow creak of the door. Shadow Weaver still received her food, but Angella nor Castaspella delivered her meals for the rest of the day nor the next. By the third day, she tried not to let the queen's absence bother her and failed.

Shadow Weaver prided herself on self-control and discipline. She carried herself with the utmost poise and expected those around her to do the same. She had been left to her own devices excluding the silent guard that now brought her meals. The sorcerer found herself missing the productivity in the Horde. There was always something to do. Either there were reports to file, drills to oversee, cadets to intimidate, or deeper magic to access from the Black Garnet. Being a prisoner was a waste of time. The Princess Alliance was still in Bright Moon but no one had asked for her assistance. What was taking them so long to act?

Shadow Weaver held herself still. She would not allow herself to fidget. She felt the effects of Angella's lack of appearance. Angella's presence made the interludes of mind numbing boredom worth it. The queen was the only bright spot of her captivity. Even the brief interactions spent trading barbs quickly became the highlights of her day.

Finally, the sound of purposeful steps and rustling wings approached the door. Her chest felt odd, but she would not allow that traitorous rush of emotion to escape during her weakened magical state. There was no time for such follies. This was just another day.

"My, that is an entrance befitting a queen." Shadow Weaver tempered her voice. She kept it level as possible as Angella stepped inside with her breakfast.

"We've made a decision about Hordak's portal," Angella said.

"It's taken you four days to decide that you were invading the Fright Zone? No, wonder the Horde's forces were easily running circles around you," Shadow Weaver said.

Angella regarded her coolly. "In the Princess Alliance, we work together. We don't bark orders at each other. No one is disposable and everyone gets an equal say in what happens."

"Yes, clearly that's working out well for you," Shadow Weaver said unimpressed.

"The Princess Alliance working together stopped the siege of Bright Moon." Angella countered, standing straighter. "We all shared in that victory. Now, you have been part of the Horde for many, many years and I need information about security and any new weapons the Horde may have been working on?"

"So, this is to be a negotiation? I tell you what I know and you don't starve me." Shadow Weaver nodded to the tray pointedly.

Angella slid the tray to Shadow Weaver. “Do you have anything to contribute or not?”

“I might be willing to impart my knowledge of the Fright Zone but I required something from you.”

“You’re a prisoner.” Angella shook her head.

“Have you captured someone else that can give you a firsthand account of the inner workings of the Horde as well as the landscape of the Fright Zone including any possible defenses? Consider my request, it’s completely harmless I assure you.”

“I somehow doubt that is the case.” Angella looked unconvinced. “What do you want?”

“Entertainment.”

“I think I have one of Glimmer’s old dolls from storage.”

“Cute,” Shadow Weaver said with narrowed eyes. “I prefer something more cerebral. Perhaps, some reading materials.”

“No magic tomes,” Angella said at once.

“No magic tomes,” Shadow Weaver agreed easily. “I would like the thickest book you have on botany.”

Angella stared at her captive unblinking. “What?”

“It’s the subject about-”

“I know what it is!” Angella snapped. “I never understood how you liked flowers. You don’t even like to be dirty.”

“I said I hated sand.” Shadow Weaver clarified, “Flowers are so much more than we give them credit for. Like me. I also like to appreciate beautiful things. I am allowed to have hobbies.”

“I assumed the only hobbies someone like you might have in the Horde would be eating babies and bathing in the blood of your enemies,” Angella said smugly.

Shadow Weaver blinked, eyes wide. “Don’t be silly, that only happens during the winter solstice.” The innocent look completely contradicted the deadpan delivery.

The laugh escaped Angella before she registered she made the sound. She covered her mouth with her hand and glared at the other woman. The mask always hardly gave her any information as to Shadow Weaver’s reaction to her laugh but the eyes seemed to be pleased. “You will get your book.” She grumbled after a few beats.

“You’ll have all the insider knowledge at your disposal, which alone should be worth an entire library.” Shadow Weaver argued.

“One book or no books,” Angella said. “You assumed this was a negotiation. That’s incorrect. The fact you don’t seem to recall is that you are a prisoner. Your very basic needs will be met.

Entertainment should really be your problem to be sought elsewhere.”

Shadow Weaver knew she had no more to gain from this interaction. If she couldn’t do magic the days would grow even longer than the ones before. “I humbly accept my queen,” she said. The midday moon hit the pearl gems from the queen’s jewelry. Shadow Weaver squinted from the sheen that managed to target her sight. “One other thing, I would prefer to be out of direct moonlight.”

“Because you’ll melt during waking hours?” Angella asked with a blank face.

Shadow Weaver cracked an unseen smile at the dig. “I prefer darkness when I sleep and before you make the obvious statement this was before the incident in Mystacor. It would make me more comfortable to be in the shade.”

“You’re a prisoner. It doesn’t come with comfort. My only obligation as your jailor is to keep you alive.”

“To what end? Do you intend to serve me until the end of days?” Shadow Weaver’s voice drawled in a smooth timbre that spoke of dark promises. As long as she held the queen in her orbit there was still hope of making it out of the containment quickly. “Though I would not be opposed.” Shadow Weaver continued on, pleased by the slight blush staining Angella’s cheeks. “You could always post a guard on the balcony if it would alleviate your worries, but even I can’t survive very long without proper sleep.”

Angella’s face grew darker but not from embarrassment. “There’s no balcony in this room.”

“Details.” Shadow Weaver shrugged.

“That brings us back to the task at hand. I will need the best, detailed route inside the Fright Zone with the least amount of resistance, and I will return with your book in a few moments.”

“If you let me out I can show you-”

Angella cut Shadow Weaver off. “No, it would be too big a risk to allow your influence near the other Princesses.”

“I am not your enemy. Hordak is the only one we should be worried about.”

“That still remains to be seen,” Angella said.

Shadow Weaver’s eyes tracked Angella’s movements down the hall as best she could before the door was closed. Luminous ombre locks of pink and purple made her appear as pure and divine as her name suggested. She only wore the simplest of accessories or tear-drop pearls but they were not needed with the eye-catching leotard and leggings combo that hugged all of her delightful curves.

She dismissed the thoughts as soon as she realized what she was doing. Truly it was a ridiculous notion. She was in a powerless position and thus the one that held authority over her seemed more appealing. That was all.

Yes, her words often skirted along the line of indecency with Angella, but it was an act, a ploy to keep the queen off balance.

What was even appealing about Angella? She had grown into a woman that was definitely too shrewd and short-sighted for her tastes. A coward hiding behind her title and guards. She scoffed at herself. It was no use. No matter how much she tried to tamp down her love under scorn and denial, Angella was still the woman that had her heart. She was captive in more ways than one.

In the end, Shadow Weaver should not have been as surprised as she was that it had taken so little effort to convince Glimmer to break her out of the confinement. The Princess was clearly the more proactive between the two monarchs of Bright Moon. She grasped the Princess' outstretched hand and in an instant, the three of them arrived on the highest platform in Bright Moon just under the Moonstone.

Shadow Weaver immediately began writing the spell on the ground. She checked the glyphs and was just about to seal it when she noticed a cluster of vines creeping forward. Bow and Glimmer gasped, thinking they were caught and turned just in time to see Perfuma, Mermista, and Frosta appear.

"What do you think you're doing?" Mermista asked with a flip of her hair.

"Don't try to stop us." Glimmer summoned her staff, shifting into a fighting stance. "This is the only way to save Adora."

"We're not trying to stop you. We wanna come with you," Perfuma said with a grin.

Mermista shrugged her shoulders. “We could do the whole ‘You can’t come with us it’s too risky’ thing.”

“Or you could just accept that we’re coming. Because we are.” Frosta interjected.

Shadow Weaver shook her head. “A larger group will be a disadvantage. I wouldn’t risk it.”

“We’re calling the shots. You’re gonna have to make that thing bigger, Weird Scary Lady.” Mermista pointed at Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver readjusted the spell to include the three other Princesses and a spot for Adora should they be successful. “There. It should safely teleport all of us.”

“What do you mean by should?” Mermista asked.

“Quickly now. We’ve taken too much time as it is,” Shadow Weaver said. If her internal clock was correct it wouldn’t be too long before Angella gathered her evening meal from the kitchen.

With Glimmer’s proximity and the promise of another magical resource, Shadow Weaver had enough confidence to start the incantation. Her magic flowed within her and she released it forward to finish the spell. The lines of the glyph she scribed in the air were sharp and clear. She hollowed out an inclusion for Glimmer to take her hand.

Glimmer sighed and walked forward. The Princess took hold of Shadow Weaver’s wrist and the magical seal was completed. She

glanced around the platform at the display of power. Shadow Weaver saw rather than heard Angella's distressed exclamation, but it was too late. The scenery before them disappeared and they were captured in a haze of magic.

"Glimmer, tell me you did not just teleport us all into the Fright Zone?" Angella demanded as soon as the spell dissipated around them.

"Well, obviously, I can't do that, Mom," Glimmer said, waving her hand at the surrounding décor.

Shadow Weaver held up placating hands. "Angella, I understand you're upset."

"Upset doesn't even begin to cover how furious I am." Angella whirled around, snarling at the sorcerer. "Clearly, you can't be trusted. You will be heavily guarded from now on."

Shadow Weaver pressed her hands together as she floated across the floor with the residual magic buzzing within her. "Glimmer understands the immediate importance of rescuing Adora."

"I hope Glimmer also understands the danger she's placed everyone in, yet again," Angella said, looking at her daughter.

"We have to make it to Hordak's sanctum. You'll have to punish Glimmer later," Shadow Weaver said.

"Don't talk to me about my child." Angella jabbed a finger into Shadow Weaver's collarbone.

Shadow Weaver looked down at the digit and slowly returned her gaze to Angella's face. "Don't you recollect what happened the last time you pointed a finger at me?"

"You wouldn't dare." Angella's eyes narrowed to slits as she twisted her index finger into the brunette's shoulder.

Shadow Weaver stepped forward. "I dare you to deny you enjoyed it."

"Can we address whatever this is later?" Mermista asked, glancing between the women. "We're supposed to be rescuing Adora or whatever."

The door slid open, revealing a lizard woman staring at them in shock.

"We need to go," Shadow Weaver said, grabbing Angella's hand and running through the door.

"Wait. What about Perfuma?" Angella asked. She glanced over her shoulder as the door slid closed.

"She can handle it, mom." Glimmer panted next to her. "This is what we do."

There was a lot less resistance than Shadow Weaver anticipated at Hordak's fortress. The Princesses that accompanied them were off fighting and that would have left her with her intended party

for this mission had the Queen not hitched a ride on the teleportation spell. They reached a hallway with two paths at the end when Catra rounded the corner.

"Shadow Weaver?" Catra scoffed with a sneer. "I heard you were with the enemy but did you seriously think bringing the Queen of Bright Moon would help you win? She looks like she's never fought in her life." She chuckled with a shake of her head.

"There's no sense in trying to fight us. You don't stand a chance." Shadow Weaver warned her former ward. "Join us in this fight or stand aside." She extended her hand then clenched her fist.

Catra smirked just before she moved. She drew the whip and sent it rocketing toward them with a twist of her wrist. Shadow Weaver pulled Glimmer out of the line of fire and Bow rushed forward, interrupting the weapon with a trick arrow before it made contact with Angella.

Catra retracted the weapon and ducked avoiding the arrow aimed for her head. She chanced a glance at the wall behind as she avoided the next projectile; it was covered in sticky goo. She ran and cracked the whip at the archer. The arrow that was still lodged on the tip of her weapon exploded across his torso. Goo now covered Bow as he slid behind Shadow Weaver, Glimmer, and Angella.

"Bow!" Glimmer exclaimed.

"Don't lose focus." Shadow Weaver tightened her grip on Glimmer's hand, preventing her from checking on her fallen friend. "Concentrate!"

Glimmer teleported back and forth across the small corridor. Catra waited for the sparkles that seemed to be materializing slower and slower with each movement. With a crack of her whip, she successfully seized Glimmer's wrist. Angella threw a light beam at Catra before she could pull Glimmer forward. The whip went slack and Catra backflipped away. The queen sent another stream of light just barely missing Catra.

"Angella, stop playing nice or get out of the way," Shadow Weaver said, removing the whip from Glimmer's wrist.

"What are you doing with that?" Angella asked, glancing at Shadow Weaver.

Catra bounded off the wall and propelled herself at Angella with outstretched claws.

Shadow Weaver intervened in Catra's attack and sent a creeping tendril of dark energy to snatch her from the air. "Catra, there's no need for us to be enemies. I can help you. I can offer you a way out," she said as Catra landed in a pained heap.

"So, what? You're on the side of good now? You made me this way, and you get to be a good guy? Thanks, I'll pass." Catra growled at Shadow Weaver. She twitched and started to get up. "Is this all you got? A few days with the Princesses and you're this weak? No wonder you defected."

"It doesn't have to be this way." Shadow Weaver started, pouring more power into her attack. A weak cloud of darkness erupted from the floor causing Catra to float above them.

“You’re going to drain Glimmer. Take the magic from me instead.” Angella insisted, taking Shadow Weaver’s hand quickly.

“Do you know what happened to me after you escaped? Do you even care?” Catra spat, struggling against tightening magical hold. “Of course you don’t care. You couldn’t wait to get away from here, from me. You came back for Adora.” She accused, the tears in her eyes flowed freely.

“Not everything revolves around you, Catra! I came back to stop Hordak. I will make sure he’s destroyed. Don’t make me destroy you too.” Shadow Weaver used the cloud to push in more, suffocating the teenager. “I’ll ask you one last time. Will you join us?”

“Oh, I’m gonna make sure we win.” Catra wheezed with a smirk. “We’re gonna open that portal and then there will be nothing left of you, the Princesses, or this frilly queen.”

Shadow Weaver could not believe what she was hearing! Of all the insolent things Catra has done, she only cared about destroying the world. She understood the threat the full might of the Horde presented, why couldn’t Catra? And for the teenager to think she could harm Angella in the process? How dare she? The sorcerer felt her rage erupt; her intent surged across Catra in a punishing lightning storm.

The indistinct whispers she thought long dead came alive with a roar inside her. She could conquer this obstacle and get herself back to normal. Power was the answer and she needed more. Always more power but this time was different. The source was too pure and wild for her magic to latch on properly.

“Light Spinner, please, don’t.” A frightful Micah shouted in her head unbidden.

“We were just playing.” Catra’s tiny voice joined Micah’s from her memories.

The connection to Angella’s magic faded as Shadow Weaver was unable to hold the link. Angella removed her hand from Shadow Weaver’s. “Stop it, she’s subdued.”

Shadow Weaver immediately ceased her magic. She glanced at Glimmer, the recovered Bow, and back to Catra. “Hordak’s goal is a threat to all of us. You may not see it now, Catra but you soon will when he decides that you also are disposable.”

“I guess you’ll have that in common,” Catra said, grabbing the taser from the floor. She lunged only to find herself restrained by a horned woman.

“No, don’t.” The horned woman pulled Catra backward and they scurried away. “You can’t fight them. They’re too strong.”

Shadow Weaver watched them go in relief. Clearly, her control had waned since her connection to the Black Garnet was cut off. She valiantly tried to ignore the voice that told her she just transferred her feelings to the darker part of herself to Catra. Now was not the time for distractions, Hordak must be stopped.

Glimmer groaned behind her. The Princess looked pale as she leaned against Bow. Shadow Weaver reached out, stopping her movements when Glimmer flinched.

“It was not my intention to take so much from you,” Shadow Weaver said plainly as her hand fell to her side. She looked away. “We need to move. Hordak’s sanctum is not much further.”

“Give us a couple of moments. Glimmer is not feeling well.” Angella argued.

“There is no time to waste.” Shadow Weaver shook her head. “Catra will no doubt be running back to Hordak to tell him of our invasion.”

“Let’s go!” Glimmer said, standing straighter.

“Are you okay to run?” Bow looked at Glimmer in concern. He had not released her.

“I’ll have to be,” Glimmer responded.

Shadow Weaver heard something scuttling behind them but did not bother to look back as their group took off in a run. Hordak’s imp swooped from the ceiling and pulled at Glimmer’s hair. It scratched her and moved again when she batted it away. It circled, diving for another attack that was disrupted by Angella’s flash attack to its face. Bow’s trick arrow bound it with a net, and the imp fell to the floor with a squeal. The door in front of them opened and three bots shuffled forward to block their path. Shadow Weaver assessed the threat ahead of them when Glimmer placed her hand in the older woman’s.

“Glimmer, no. You’re too weak.” Bow pleaded with her.

“Bow’s right. I have plenty of magic,” Angella said, taking Glimmer’s place.

“We can use your magic as a relay instead of a funnel.” Shadow Weaver explained to Angella as their hands reunited.

“How? I’m not a sorcerer.” Angella grunted, feeling the drain on her magic begin immediately.

“Feel my intent and cast with me,” Shadow Weaver said and lifted her hands. They shot lightning at the bots overloading their systems. The bots beeped rapidly and started smoking. “Quickly to the door!”

They made it through the doorway before the bots detonated. A sinister green glow pulsed somewhere in the distance. It got brighter as the surrounding machinery whirred louder.

“This way.” Bow declared, running toward the light.

“Bow!” Adora shouted back. They were definitely close now.

Angella and Shadow Weaver blew the door open, sending twin bolts of magic at Catra. Catra slid away from the lever with a hiss.

Glimmer teleported to Adora and started to untie the ropes. “I’m gonna get you out of here.”

“Why don’t you just teleport me to the sword? Maybe She-Ra can pull it from the portal.” Adora suggested, rotating her wrists.

“I only have one more teleport in me and we need it to get back to Bright Moon,” Glimmer replied.

“We have to get the sword out of the portal before one of them pulls the switch,” Adora said, tugging against the ropes.

“Adora, you have to stop moving,” Glimmer said.

Bow ran in behind the two casters, pulling an arrow from his quiver. He shot as soon as he had Hordak in his sight. The arrow was snapped in two by Hordak’s fist. He snarled and wrenched a large exhaust pipe from the wall, flinging it at the three intruders. Angella and Shadow Weaver halted the projectile’s trajectory with magic and threw it to the side, smashing the wall. The room shuddered as containers exploded around them. Support beams collapsed and Hordak ran to the other side to avoid being crushed. Glancing at the lever and the barricade of debris separating the two halves of the room, Catra stood.

“Catra, please, don’t.” Adora pleaded, yanking at her loosening bonds.

Catra just smirked and tensed her arm but she felt something odd. She looked down when the floor shifted under her feet. A large metal ball burst from the floor, pitching her away from the lever.

“What is that?” Shadow Weaver inquired as the sphere leaped over the room’s wreckage with ease. It was heading straight for them. She and Angella charged their hands, sending bolts of energy at it but there was no effect on its polished metal body.

“Bow, is that the Elemental from your home? What’s it doing here?” Glimmer asked.

The Elemental stopped an inch from Shadow Weaver, uncurling to reveal a towering beetle. It slithered closer, rubbing its head against the masked woman’s outstretched hand with a coo.

“I think it’s decided that Shadow Weaver is its mother,” Bow said, releasing another trick arrow.

“It what?” Angella blinked in confusion.

The Elemental in question squirmed in place and coughed twice then a large shard landed in Shadow Weaver’s hand. The shard glowed and she sensed the power binding her to it as well as the link to Elemental that guarded the piece.

“Hordak!” Adora yelled, bringing their attention back to the problem at hand.

“Don’t let anyone near that lever!” Shadow Weaver ordered the Elemental. It rolled away at once, unbending itself to claw at Hordak. It reared up snapping its mandibles at him.

“We need to get the sword to Adora.” Bow crossed the room with some difficulty. He ran, firing arrow after arrow at Catra as the girl effortlessly dodged each one. His last arrow accidentally bounced off the sword. Sprawling lightning shot across the room.

“Don’t agitate the pedestal.” Shadow Weaver cautioned. “We don’t know what it could do to the portal.”

“I’m trying not to.” Bow argued.

Shadow Weaver glanced at the shard in her hand. She had an innate notice She-Ra’s sword hilt from across the room. In her mind’s eye, she saw the blueprint of what made up the intricate twisting designs surrounding the Runestone of Etheria. The metal all but spoke to her, reacted to her. She released her hold on Angella’s hand and slammed her own forward.

“What are you doing?” Angella asked, trying to regain her grip. “I still have magic. We can beat them.”

“For once, I do not think sorcery will work, but this might.” Shadow Weaver watched as the sword rattled and shook but the platform held it firm. She thought briefly of trying to break the lever, but she held a better connection to the metal in She-Ra’s sword. It was purer than anything else in the room she could sense. She twisted her wrist and beckoned the sword with the close of her fist. It flew from the apparatus to her outstretched hand. She struggled to stay upright. It was too heavy to get across the room quickly.

“No.” Catra gasped as she witnessed what happened.

The ground shook as the primed portal lost its power and disassembled, releasing errant energy throughout the room.

“To me!” Shadow Weaver called the Elemental. She stepped onto its back and it crossed the room headed to Adora. She slid off the Elemental, landing beside Adora and Glimmer who was tugging at the last knot.

“Just put the sword in my hand,” Adora grunted. “She-Ra will do the rest.”

Shadow Weaver placed the sword safely in the blonde’s waiting hands.

“For the honor of Grayskull!”

“We have to go. Now.” Catra yanked at the stunned Hordak. He looked at the crumbling building in dismay and followed her.

Catra and Adora shared one last look before the brunette ran away. Glimmer and Bow whooped, hugging She-Ra. They jumped in their best friend’s arms and she held their combined weight easily, spinning with them all with a laugh.

“We’re so glad you’re okay,” Glimmer said.

“Woo-hoo! Yes! We did it.” Frosta cheered, running forward to join the group hug. Perfuma and Mermista soon appeared embracing their friends.

“Touching as this is, we need to go!” Shadow Weaver called out.

Bow pushed She-Ra toward the spell and took his place beside her. Everyone else formed the circle they used to teleport in. The Elemental rolled over settling next to Shadow Weaver.

“Are we taking this,” Mermista trailed off. “…ball with us?”

Frosta encased her fists in ice and began moving forward.

"Don't attack it," Shadow Weaver said. She eyed the rolling creature and shook her head. "We can't. There's not enough magic to take all of us and it." She placed a hand on its cool metal plating to cease its movement. "Meet us in Bright Moon."

The Elemental unfolded at once, yet again nudging its head against Shadow Weaver's palm. It gently took the Runestone shard from her hand and stomped back to the hole it left in the floor and tunneled underground.

Frosta returned to her place in the circle while Shadow Weaver held out her hand for Glimmer.

"Now," Shadow Weaver said as they held each other by the wrists, the spell springing to life.

Glimmer groaned, the strain on her magic was almost too much. A swirl of magic surrounded the group and suddenly they were back in Bright Moon.

Shadow Weaver watched as the Princesses cheered around her. The Flower Princess, Perfuma, if she remembered correctly grabbed her in a tight hug that squeezed her hands to her sides. The young woman was deceitfully stronger than her frame suggested. Shadow Weaver could do nothing but wait until it was over and begrudgingly admit that she was pleased by the successful rescue. She was extremely thankful to be released as the noise around her died down.

“Mom, I know I’m probably going to be grounded for the rest of my life, but we prevented a portal from destroying Etheria. That’s gotta count for something, right?” Glimmer asked hopefully.

“Seize her!” Castaspella yelled. Five Bright Moon guards marched forward with their spears on Shadow Weaver.

“Stand down,” Angella said calmly.

The guards immediately stood at attention. “Yes, your majesty.”

“Where were you?” Castaspella asked. “The guards said they saw dark magic envelop the Moonstone when you all disappeared. I assumed Shadow Weaver escaped.”

“Shadow Weaver did not escape. Glimmer released her and disobeyed my direct orders,” Angella said as her eyes slid to her daughter.

Glimmer flinched at the glare directed at her. “Okay, I know what I did was wrong, but it was the only way to save Adora. We weren’t going to get another chance.”

“Shadow Weaver still needs to be locked up. When she’s exposed to magic she could use her shadows to mind control us like she did Micah,” Castaspella said emphatically. She tried to tower over the older woman only to discover she was several inches shorter.

Shadow Weaver released a long-suffering sigh. “I never performed mind control on Micah for his assistance. I don’t practice mind control.”

Adora cleared her throat awkwardly.

"…anymore." Shadow Weaver amended.

"Castaspella, you don't have to do that. Shadow Weaver saved us. She's the whole reason that the portal was never opened, in fact, we found out something that might even change the war," Adora said, standing between Castaspella and Shadow Weaver.

"What circumstances?" Castaspella raised an eyebrow, waiting for the explanation.

"It seems I am a Princess." Shadow Weaver informed her.

"Oh sure, you're a Princess and I'm the guardian of the thirteenth moon." Castaspella chortled, bending over in laughter.

The platform vibrated under their feet, startling everyone as a roar sounded below them. The Princesses all moved into fighting positions just as the Elemental came crawling into view. It stood to its full height, clicking its mandibles as it stopped behind Shadow Weaver.

"This is so unfair," Adora whined. "Mara had a dragon, Shadow Weaver gets an Elemental, what do I get?"

"Adora, you have a large magic sword and a talking, flying unicorn." Frosta pointed out.

"Yeah, but how cool would it be to have my own Elemental?" Adora exclaimed and gestured to Shadow Weaver.

Everyone glanced at Shadow Weaver who was subtly trying to pull her collar from the Elemental's mandible. She finally managed to remove it without tears in the fabric and held up a hand in warning as it tried to swoop back in with its gaping maw. The Elemental rubbed its head on her palm and wriggled happily when the woman finally pet it, albeit reluctantly.

"Aww, it cares about you so much!" Bow said, both hands pressed against his face.

"Well, that's just poor judgment." Castaspella scoffed under her breath.

"If it's going to stay, shouldn't it have a name, or are we going to continue to call it 'rolly thing'?" Mermista asked.

Adora looked at Mermista in confusion. "Who's calling it that?"

"I've been calling it that in my head," Mermista replied.

Bow nodded excitedly. "I agree, let's give it a name."

"It is a weapon. Did you name your bow and quiver?" Shadow Weaver asked evenly.

"What if I did?" Bow asked with a challenging eyebrow.

"Oh! How about Cecil?" Perfuma suggested. She created a flower crown of clovers and tossed it onto the Elemental's head.

The Elemental grabbed the ring of flowers from the sky and scarfed it down with a content growl.

"No! Bad, Cecil!" Perfuma wagged a finger at the Elemental.

Shadow Weaver turned to Perfuma. "I'd thank you not to scold my Elemental."

"I think its name should be Nibbler," Bow said with a decisive nod.

"We don't have time for this." Castaspella tried to interject.

"Rustbucket!" Frosta screamed.

While the Princesses bickered amongst themselves, the Elemental moved its beetle and serpentine body across the Moonstone's platform. It inched toward Angella, brushing an inquisitive leg against the opaque feathers closest to the ground.

"Away with you!" Angella said as she pivoted, moving her wings out of harm's way. The Elemental mewled dejectedly. "Don't try that with me just slink back over to your owner." The queen continued, nodding at Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver hummed, watching the exchange in interest. She eyed the Elemental in a new light. "Slinky." The newly named 'Slinky' slithered up to Shadow Weaver awaiting instructions or attention.

"Slinky!" the Princesses and Bow proclaimed. Slinky promptly

rolled on his back and revealed his belly for rubs.

“Aww,” Perfuma said and gave him light scratches along his tummy.

“Are you always this enthusiastic?” Shadow Weaver asked at the display.

“Yeah, Weird, Scary Lady they really are.” Mermista drawled, studying her nails.

“Now, that we once again have order,” Angella proclaimed. “We need to decide what to do about our newest,” she paused on the last word, “...Princess.”

“This can’t be happening!” Castaspella said as she threw her hands into the air. “How? W-what even is this? Of all the people on Etheria, how did you manage to forge an untainted link with a Runestone?”

Distantly, Bow remembered his pocket tingling during Shadow Weaver’s healing from She-Ra. “I think I know what happened.” He revealed and pulled a gem from his pocket. “I found it in one of the studies while doing research on the First Ones’ technology.”

“It looks just like the shard we found at your home,” Adora said, studying it. She squinted and used Bow’s wrist to point the gem towards the Moonstone for more light. “The glyphs carved into it don’t make much sense because I think this is a key of some sort but it confirms that Shadow Weaver’s Princess powers are being able to control metal.”

“It must have reacted to She-Ra’s magic and allowed the bond to Shadow Weaver,” Bow said, handing the Runestone to Shadow Weaver.

“Micah kept it?” Shadow Weaver asked in awe. The familiar weight calling forth a few memories she’d rather keep locked away.

“This was yours?” Castaspella immediately grabbed the shard. “Micah and I would play with it for hours, trying to get it to twitch or roll. Neither of us ever could.” She lamented, placing the Runestone back into Shadow Weaver’s hand. “Now, I know why.”

“I’m grateful you did find it, Bow,” Shadow Weaver said. “However, it’s starting to look more and more like my Runestone is shattered or trapped in a ruin. We have to find it soon.”

“And give you more power?” Glimmer asked.

“It would be more power, yes, but this is necessary for taking down Hordak,” Shadow Weaver said carefully.

“You don’t need more power, Shadow Weaver, you need to learn to control the power you have,” Perfuma said gently.

“You sound just like those fools at Mystacor.” Shadow Weaver said, her eyes squinting in anger. “I have never placed limits on my magic and I don’t intend to start now.”

“Yes, you will. You are not allowed to go anywhere until you have

proven that you deserve to join the Alliance.” Angella stated, gliding back to the castle.

“Queen Angella, wait!” Adora called after her. “Glimmer, could you please?”

“Everyone, grab on,” Glimmer said as she transported the group just inside the main hallway leading to the War Room.

“I can vouch for her.” Adora rushed after Angella.

“Just how will you do that Adora?” Castaspella asked, looking at the blonde. “You’ve proven you can’t be objective. Can you guard her all day, all night, and be She-Ra on top of it?”

Adora looked conflicted like she was trying to figure out a schedule to do just that. “Shadow Weaver can be useful. She must have some good deep inside. Runestones don’t just pick people at random. Her destiny is to be here with us.”

“Adora, have you forgotten what she’s just done to you?” Castaspella asked.

“It did hurt but Shadow Weaver was telling the truth. I’m a First One. Our very first mission was to reunite all the Princesses to fight the Horde,” Adora said and looked at her friends. “Guys, help me out here?”

“I believe everyone deserves a second chance and we need all the Princesses we can find,” Perfuma said with a small smile.

“Thanks, Perfuma,” Adora said in relief.

Bow looked conflicted. “No, Adora. I agree with Queen Angella. You didn’t see her earlier. She tried to kill Catra.”

“Bow, Catra’s tried to kill us multiple times.” Adora pointed out.

“This was different. She used Glimmer like a battery to punish and torture Catra. She almost drained her,” Bow said with a shake of his head. “I know you think there might be good in her but I just can’t see it.”

“There has to be. No one just becomes a Princess if they’re not meant to be,” Adora said. She knew the response sounded hollow to her own ears.

“Adora, it’s okay,” Shadow Weaver said, placing a gentle hand on the younger woman’s shoulder and looked at Angella. “I will submit to the judgment of the Princess Alliance.”

Chapter End Notes

Boom! Big reveal. New Princess on the block. So, what do you think? Do you love it? Hate it? Questioning my sanity?

Thanks to everyone who took the time out to give kudos and reviews! I’m happy to know there’s interest in this. :)

Until next time!

I Never Knew Daylight Could Be So Violent

Chapter Summary

The trial of Shadow Weaver and other adventures.

Chapter Notes

I claim all mistakes as my own. :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shadow Weaver was grateful that the Rebellion hadn't planned to drag out her waiting period before the judgement. In less than two hours from the initial disagreement in the hallway, the new Princess found herself in a chair with a formation of guards to keep her company. She spent her time looking past the high back chairs to study the mural that covered the walls. It was difficult not to feel resentment that she was not present in the pictures with Angella. She could have been the co-ruler of Bright Moon and stopped the Horde years ago. Someone had intervened in her life and when she figured out who it was all the magic in the universe would not save them from her wrath. The double doors opened and Angella led the procession of Princesses and sorcerers into the War Room.

Angella remained standing after all the Princesses had been seated. "We are here today because we are faced with two difficult questions. The first is how far would you go to defeat evil? And the other is who deserves a second chance? You will hear arguments about Shadow Weaver's previous conduct before her arrival in Bright Moon."

The General, Juliet, stood to the right of Angella with a staff in her hand. “Let the records show that Truth Spells are being administered,” she announced.

“There is no need. I will speak the truth.” Shadow Weaver began but she was interrupted by Castaspella.

“Your words have no value to the Princess Alliance. They are traps designed to coax your prey toward a nefarious goal.” Castaspella moved to stand in the center of the two sorcerers that accompanied her. They cast the strongest Truth Spells they could and released them at Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver felt the magic spread through her and settle on her tongue like a foul taste. She always hated Truth Spells. She had no problem speaking honestly, but the lingering effects took hours to wear off and it made her tongue feel like a foreign entity.

Juliet waited until the sorcerers moved away from Shadow Weaver. “Let the record show there will be three test questions to confirm the strength of the Truth Spell.”

“Hey, who’s doing the recording?” Frosta asked with her hand raised.

Angella’s eye twitched as she glanced at the Ice Princess. “Frosta, you volunteered for that role.”

“Oh, I thought I only volunteered to write the test questions,” Frosta said.

“I can transcribe, your majesty,” Perfuma said, pulling a notebook and pen from her compartment in the war table.

“We can also record audio,” Bow said, raising his electronic recorder.

“Thank you Perfuma and Bow.” Angella nodded to each of them. “Let’s continue. Shadow Weaver, are you currently in Bright

Moon?”

Shadow Weaver felt the compulsion working over her mouth as she answered. “Yes.”

“Are you currently standing or sitting?” Angella asked quickly.

“Sitting.”

“What is the most embarrassing thing your parents caught you doing?” Angella asked haltingly and glanced at a silent cackling Frosta. She regretted not for the first time that she had given the Princesses such latitude in how the Alliance would function.

This was an unexpected question for certain. They probably hoped to humiliate her, but the question was not worded in a way that applied to her. Shadow Weaver waited to see if the Truth Spell would compel her to answer or remain inert. “I cannot answer that,” she said after a moment.

“She’s tampered with the Truth Spell?” a guard behind the brunette’s chair gasped.

“How is this possible? Just how powerful is she?” The sorcerer closest to Castaspella mumbled.

Queen Angella cleared her throat for silence. “Why can’t you answer the question, Shadow Weaver?”

“I cannot answer the question, because I don’t have any parents.” Shadow Weaver answered frankly.

Castaspella walked to the center of the room. “Shadow Weaver, you stand accused of the following crimes: Mind control of the late King Micah, the murders of Master Norwyn, and sorcerers, Acqui and Solyn, the kidnapping of Glimmer, Bow, and Adora. Attempted mind erasure of Adora and many indirect war crimes from your time with the Horde that are too numerous to count. Do you deny these charges as they are read to you?”

Shadow Weaver remained still and silent. The standards of Mystacor had significantly fallen. There was entirely too much leeway in the Truth Spells, even with the multiple applications. The spells were not layered to compensate for each other. The sorcerers honestly thought the same spell would strengthen the one before it. If she fought it, she could lie to Beast Island and back without any of them being the wiser.

Etheria, save her from idiots.

On the one hand, she could instruct them on more effective Truth Spells and earn more trust, but on the other, she would be obligated to bare every one of her secrets if the Rebellion asked. That would not do. Some of her life experiences should never see the light of the moons. She would answer to the best of her ability.

Castaspella got tired of waiting for Shadow Weaver's reply. "Well? Do you have anything to say?"

"I am guilty, but not of everything," Shadow Weaver replied calmly. "If I'm going to be tried, at least attempt to get the charges correct."

"And just what is that supposed to mean?" Castaspella asked.

"History is crafted by its victors and thus everything is skewed to reflect a nobler point of view." Shadow Weaver spoke slowly and carefully. "I do not know how many times I have to reiterate, but I did not use mind control to influence Micah. I asked Micah to assist me in using the modified Spell of Obtainment and he agreed."

"More lies!" Castaspella smacked the surface of the War Table. "There's no way Micah would willingly agree to something so evil."

"The Truth Spell is still active." One of the sorcerers pointed out.

"She's subverting it somehow like with the parent question," Castaspella said.

“We will have the order,” Angella said and Juliet slammed her staff to the floor. “Castaspella, do you have confidence in the present sorcerers to cast an effective Truth Spell?”

“Yes, Queen Angella.” Castaspella agreed begrudgingly.

“Has there been a case of anyone resisting three truth spells at once?” Angella asked Castaspella with a raised eyebrow.

Castaspella shook her head with a sharp exhale. “No, Queen Angella.”

“In that case, the answer given by Shadow Weaver will be recorded as fact.” Angella proclaimed and waited for Perfuma to record the exchange. “Do you have any more questions for the accused?”

“Shadow Weaver, why were you using such a dangerous spell with a third-year apprentice as your only second caster?” Castaspella asked.

“I had no other support. Norwyn and his sheep did not think the Horde’s reign was serious enough to involve Mystacor. They didn’t believe the spell would succeed,” Shadow Weaver said with a toss of her head.

“It seems they were correct considering what happened next.” Castaspella scoffed.

“It would have worked!” Shadow Weaver insisted, rising from her chair. A guard pressed her back in her seat down roughly. “Micah stopped casting during the ritual and the spell went awry. The structure failed and the demon bound itself to me.”

“Is that why you betrayed the Sorcerer’s Guild and joined the Horde?” The younger sorcerer from earlier asked.

“I would like to point out that I did not betray the Sorcerer’s Guild. Norwyn attacked me first and I defended myself,” Shadow Weaver replied with a roll of her wrist. “The only direct attack I ever made

on Mystacor was during Adora's visit. I left to find someone that would appreciate the magical knowledge I had to offer."

Mermista groaned out, slouching over the table. "Ugh, what is your point? Because it sounds like you're saying you became evil because you were throwing a tantrum."

Shadow Weaver smoothed her hair back out of her eyes. "Call it what you'd like. It seemed like the best way to prove the Horde was a threat to be taken more seriously."

"How can you use that to justify what you did to help the Horde?" Castaspella paced in front of Shadow Weaver's chair. "You manipulated, tortured, and terrorized children."

"Why don't we ask what we're all thinking?" Adora finally spoke up. "Shadow Weaver, are you sorry for anything that you've done?"

"That is the question, isn't it? Regret. Remorse. The conscience for our choices and consequences." Shadow Weaver inclined her head. "Yes, I have certainly considered this numerous times in the past few weeks."

"Classic Shadow Weaver non-answer." Adora crossed her arms, resisting the urge to pout. "You can just answer yes or no, you know."

"My answer is not simple. From all you've experienced, Adora, you know this world is not boiled down to the hero is good and the villain is bad. Honorable people make seemingly terrible choices for the right reasons while the morally inept make life-saving choices for possibly horrible ones and you could all be there at one point." Shadow Weaver used her hand to emphasize what she was saying.

Perfuma looked up from her notes. "We would never do anything like that."

“You never know what you would do if the odds are stacked against you,” Shadow Weaver stated. “This is a war.”

“Of that, we are well aware,” Angella said softly, glancing at the mural behind her.

Shadow Weaver kept her eyes on Angella. “I apologize for hurting Glimmer.”

Angella’s wings bristled. “Your apology is extremely late.”

“Would it make you happier to hurt me as well?” Shadow Weaver asked.

Angella’s eyebrows raised in question. “It...probably would.”

“And no matter how much you despise my actions you won’t allow yourself to retaliate.” Shadow Weaver shrugged one shoulder. “Why is that?”

“It won’t erase what happened and it’s not what a good person does,” Angella said faintly.

Shadow Weaver held up her index finger. “That is precisely the point that I’m making. You all seem to think this conflict is simply good versus evil.”

“It is good versus evil. What war have you been fighting?” Frosta asked with a frown.

“I want you all to consider this. Each of you is fighting and suddenly you notice a runaway Horde tank is trampling a village. Its path to destruction will end at an orphanage filled with trapped children. You have a split second to divert the tank, but the result will kill a kind, elderly man trying desperately to put out the flames of his home. What do you do?”

“We find a way to save everyone.” Bow answered at once and everyone agreed with a decisive nod.

Shadow Weaver hummed at the predictable answer. “What if I told you the elderly gentleman was working with the Horde to sell the orphans into our army to feed the rest of the village for winter?”

“This is a very specific scenario. Did this really happen?” Glimmer asked, leaning forward.

Shadow Weaver nodded. “Years ago something similar happened.”

“What happened to the village?” Bow asked.

Adora clenched her hand under the table. “And the orphans?”

“The orphans are cadets in the Fright Zone and the village is fine. The runaway tank was faked to discredit the man to his village. His greed got the better of him and he wanted to renegotiate the terms of the Horde’s agreement,” Shadow Weaver said, noting the Princesses’ full attention. It was time for the Princesses to understand how the world worked. The stark dichotomy of right and wrong was a concept that would fail them.

“If allowed in, what would you bring to the Princess Alliance?” Netossa asked.

“Not only can I give you countless secrets of the Horde’s inner workings, but I can also reveal the Fright Zone's weak spots and alternate bases of operations. Use me to be the voice of reason in times of stress. I can be the one to shoulder the tough decisions.” Shadow Weaver suggested and took the time to make eye contact with everyone seated. “You asked how I can justify what I did for the Horde; it was my job. I was the Horde’s Tactical Battle Advisor and you must admit that I did an exceptional job for a time. In addition to that, I know more about Etheria than most people have even forgotten. Armed with that knowledge, I am willing to do all I can to help the Rebellion thwart Hordak and the rest of the Horde. I do not expect you to like me, tolerate me, or trust me for now, but can you truly say that you do not need me?”

“Does anyone in the Princess Alliance have more to add in support or opposition of Shadow Weaver?” Angella asked the room.

“I have something to say.”

Juliet nodded. “The Alliance acknowledges Commander Glimmer for the record.”

“Shadow Weaver is a terrible person. She’s malicious and sarcastic and cutting and has probably never done anything that didn’t directly benefit herself-”

“Glimmer.” Adora hissed.

“... *but* she saved us in the Fright Zone. She could have led us into an ambush or handed the bulk of the Princess Alliance to Hordak, and she didn’t.” Glimmer glanced around the room. “She offered Catra an option of abandoning the Horde before attacking. Shadow Weaver risked her life to fight Catra and Hordak when they tried to open that portal. I do despise her, but she hasn’t given me or any of us a reason not to accept that she now wants to help in the war against the Horde.”

“Glimmer, what about when she tortured Catra when she declined the offer and nearly drained you of your magic?” Bow asked with a frown.

“I alone decided to let Shadow Weaver out of her prison and to transport us to the Fright Zone. Yes, she used my magic, but we didn’t know how much magic it would take to achieve what we did,” Glimmer said and sat back down. “Only Shadow Weaver can answer why she attacked Catra like that.”

“I have heard all the arguments and I’m ready to make my decision.” Angella addressed the room. “Do we all agree that Shadow Weaver’s actions today proved that she is currently acting in the best interests of the Rebellion?”

The Princesses murmured amongst themselves but gave scattered answers in the affirmative.

Bow still appeared indecisive but managed a halfhearted “Yes.” To Angella’s question.

“I can’t believe you’re seriously considering doing this Angella.” Castaspella had a prominent vein throbbing along her forehead.

“The decision has been made, Castaspella. Our major goal was always to reunite the Princess Alliance to defeat the Horde. Shadow Weaver is a Princess and despite her past has given no indication that she will be anything other than helpful. With that in mind, she will work with the Rebellion to atone for her past.” Angella walked around the war table. “Adora, may I borrow the Sword of Protection?”

“Of course, your majesty.” Adora rushed to place the weapon in Queen Angella’s hand.

Angella nodded to the guards and they stepped back, allowing Shadow Weaver to rise from her chair. The former sorcerer kneeled smoothly in front of the queen.

“Shadow Weaver formerly of the Horde, formerly Light Spinner of Mystacor, will you pledge to stand with us against those you once served?” Angella passed the sword from one of Shadow Weaver’s shoulders to the other.

“I do,” Shadow Weaver said with a bowed head.

“Commander Glimmer, Adora, She-Ra Princess of Power, do you vouch for her and take responsibility for her?”

Glimmer nodded as Adora replied. “We do your majesty.”

“The Rebellion and Princess Alliance accept your vow of allegiance, Shadow Weaver, Ferrous Princess.”

There was no fanfare or cheers to welcome Shadow Weaver into the Alliance, just the quiet shuffling movement as the Princesses left the War Room and Castaspella’s sustained sputtering.

“Welcome to the Rebellion,” Spinnerella said quietly as she passed Shadow Weaver. Netossa nodded her head once and remained silent beside her wife.

Perfuma slid a white carnation behind one of Shadow Weaver’s ears. “I look forward to fighting beside you, Ferrous Princess.”

The room slowly emptied, leaving Adora and Angella lingering behind with the new Princess.

“Seriously, Shadow Weaver? That was your best argument? ‘I know I’m evil but you need me?’” Adora asked, throwing her hands up in exasperation.

“One of the first things I learned as an apprentice was to know my audience. My actions spoke louder than any words I could have chosen. As you saw when I corrected the charges, any claim of my innocence would have been met with hostility and would have gotten us nowhere,” Shadow Weaver said.

“If you had a plan, why didn’t you tell me?” Adora asked with a small frown. The unspoken ‘Why didn’t you trust me with the truth?’ lingered in the air like a stench.

Shadow Weaver twirled the hair of Adora’s ponytail in her fingers. “There was no elaborate planning on my part. I simply told the truth, Adora.”

Adora slowly pulled away from Shadow Weaver’s touch. “Thank you,” she said to Angella.

“Don’t thank me yet, this is a substantial undertaking you’ve created for yourself.” Angella shook her head as she eyed Shadow Weaver.

“Will I be placed back in my prison or triple guarded?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“There’s no need,” Angella said calmly. “I trust Commander Glimmer to handle you herself.”

“Oh, yeah,” Glimmer said, appearing in the doorway. She smacked her fist against her hand. “I’m in charge, rookie. Get lots of rest because you’re gonna get a crash course in Princess training.”

Shadow Weaver didn’t like the sound of that at all. Instead of commenting, she returned her attention to Angella. “I assume I’m being given a permanent room?”

“Yes, we have a spare room that would be suitable for your stay. It will be a show of trust if you extend the same,” Angella remarked. She walked out of the War Room.

“I believe an even better show of trust would be if my Runestones were returned to me.” Shadow Weaver suggested, falling into step with Angella.

“Tests are being run to determine that there is no corruption like the Fire Runestone. I’ve seen what power does to you and I’m concerned. You will return to me every time you want to recharge just as Glimmer does.” Angella barely paused as the guards opened and closed the doors for them. “These will be your quarters.”

Shadow Weaver looked around the room and was delighted to see it was nearly identical to her prison. During her boredom, she spent her time mentally assessing the room to fit her needs. She would enjoy making this space her own.

“Do you want to discuss what happened with Catra today?” Angella asked.

“Not particularly.” Shadow Weaver, trailed a finger along with the armoire in the corner of the room.

“Adora seems to have a lot of faith in your ability to change,” Angella told her.

“And you?” Shadow Weaver glanced over her shoulder.

“I wouldn’t have accepted your allegiance if I thought otherwise,” Angella said, walking further into the room. “I have not forgiven your actions, but you have been given a second chance, Shadow Weaver. Use it wisely.”

“I plan to.”

“See that you do.” Angella nodded. “Adora is putting her reputation as a hero on the line for you; take care that you don’t disappoint her again,” she warned.

“While I’m grateful for her support, I cannot guarantee that I will be a paragon of morality.”

“Yes, I know,” Angella said. “As you know, I don’t just have elemental magic from the Moonstone at my disposal. Glimmer and I share the Moonstone’s magic, so I needed to forge a small bond with your magic to allow my Angelic magic to flow through you and prevent Glimmer from being drained further.”

“Do you feel like someone is whispering to you just out of your hearing range or a preternaturally chill surrounding you?” Shadow Weaver asked, turning to assess Angella for signs of dark magic.

“No, thank goodness,” Angella said, shaking her head. “I just saw your magic. It’s a side-effect of the bonding. It’s the darkest I’ve ever seen. It was maroon, desolate, and unquenchably hungry.”

“Maroon?” Shadow Weaver’s eyes widened. “Are you certain?”

“I’m positive,” Angella confirmed. “What does that mean?”

“Perhaps nothing. Its presence has always been darker,” Shadow Weaver said distractedly. “If I had known I would have prepared you for it. My apologies.”

“Is that what it’s like for you?” Angella asked, then lightly fluffed a decorative throw pillow. “You fight that mass of darkness inside you all the time?”

“It’s my burden to bear. I have made my choices,” Shadow Weaver said.

“Speaking of choices, I noticed you never answered the question about remorse.” Angella peered at the other woman.

“There are some things I regret in hindsight.” Shadow Weaver nudged her mask. “Not everything. I’ve done only what I felt was necessary at the time.”

“Including punishing children with magic? Why did you do that to Catra?”

“Catra made the mistake of threatening you. She’s always been an insolent little cur,” Shadow Weaver said nastily.

“You’re Catra’s parent. Hers and Adora’s. You can’t just attack her when you don’t like what she says. You are supposed to be their solace and protection,” Angella said.

“I have only ever tried to protect Catra!” Shadow Weaver hissed. “She was a runt. Skittish and naive with no idea of what it takes to survive. It is not an easy life being a child in the Horde. No one can show weakness there, not even I. I raised them the best way I knew how. Adora flourished and excelled while Catra slacked off, connived, and schemed to get to her current position.”

Angella stared at Shadow Weaver in confusion. “You truly believe that, don’t you? This was your way of caring for them.”

“I could tell you stories about what happened to those children before I arrived that would straighten your hair,” Shadow Weaver threatened. She took a calming breath. She needed to be more careful with her words.

Truth Spells were most effective when your subject was distracted and unaware that they were being interrogated. It also helped if the questions were likely to retrieve an emotional outburst from your subject. As the widow of a powerful sorcerer, Angella would definitely know this. The Truth Spell was weakening but definitely

still active and Shadow Weaver had all but ignored the sensation for her agitated state. Of course, none of that knowledge mattered if the person asking the questions could burrow past your defenses.

Shadow Weaver tapped a sharp nail at a low hanging crystal. “Well done, Angella.” she chuckled darkly.

“You’re not the only one who knows how to seize an opportunity,” Angella revealed, keeping her face impassive.

“You never cease to surprise me.” Shadow Weaver admitted, opening the drawers of the nearby vanity. “You could have just as easily asked me about that night in Mystacor.”

“This was more pertinent. A queen must put their personal feelings aside for the good of their kingdom.”

“Is this your way of admitting there is still something personal between us?” Shadow Weaver asked.

Angella walked back to the door and placed her hand on the doorknob. “I have to make an official report about your status, so you’re not attacked on sight.”

“Of course, Angella. Do not let me keep you.” Shadow Weaver nodded.

Angella paused and turned slowly. “Make no mistake, if I find out this is a ploy to harm anyone in Bright Moon or the Rebellion, I will not hesitate to have you thrown into the darkest cavern I can find for the rest of your days.”

“I am here to help,” Shadow Weaver said.

“So you keep insisting. You need to decide if you’re here for the Rebellion or yourself,” Angella stated and opened the door.

Shadow Weaver sighed and continued exploring her new accommodations. She didn’t turn again until the door closed and

Angella's footsteps were no longer audible.

The Princess Alliance allowed themselves a few days of rest after their victory against Horde. Etheria's smaller rebel factions reported that the Horde was quiet. There were no reports of Horde troops scouting new places and in fact, anyone that saw Horde soldiers observed them leaving the smaller occupied territories. Shadow Weaver knew this was something to be extremely wary about and could do nothing about it. She was left completely to the whims of the Rebellion. It was also imperative that she began training with the Princesses as soon as possible so they could plan the next attack against the Horde. She suspected there would be a Princess Alliance meeting soon, but she did not expect it to interrupt her sleep schedule.

"Emergency Princess meeting!" Glimmer said, tugging a previously slumbering Shadow Weaver from her bed.

"Unhand me." Shadow Weaver twisted her wrist, trying to break Glimmer's hold. "What is going on?"

"As if you don't know," Glimmer responded, placing her hands on her hips. She looked over Shadow Weaver. "You really sleep in your mask?" she asked in surprise.

Shadow Weaver nodded, making sure her mask was properly secured. "I surmised you Bright Mooners had no concept of boundaries," she spoke pointedly.

"You have five minutes to get dressed then I'm teleporting you to the War Council Room with or without clothing," Glimmer said and flashed out.

Shadow Weaver quickly got dressed, glancing ruefully at her teacup. She smoothed down her clothing and had just tamed her hair when Glimmer reappeared right on time.

“Okay, we’re all here,” Glimmer said as they landed in the War Room.

“Good morning, everyone. This is the first official Princess Alliance meeting including Shadow Weaver.” Angella slowly sipped her tea.

Shadow Weaver glanced around the room. “Are we focusing on finding out the Horde’s next move? We stopped the portal from being opened, but we cannot sit idle whilst the Horde regroups.”

“There have been no reports of the Horde for several days now. We dealt a major blow to the Horde and you need to learn to work with us as a Princess,” Adora said, sliding into her chair.

“In the Princess Alliance, we talk to one another and decide as a group what is the best course of action.” Angella placed her teacup on the table and it was immediately removed by a previously unseen servant.

“While you’re debating and setting up committees about how to take votes, the Horde will be plotting and executing. We need to act.” Shadow waved her hands over the holographic mountains of the tables.

“That’s not the Princess way.” Glimmer maintained.

“You run off with spontaneous plans all the time, Glimmer.” Mermista looked up from picking at her nails.

“Okay, sometimes it’s not the Princess way,” Glimmer said.

“Is this really how you conduct all of your Princess Alliance meetings?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“Yeah,” Adora said with a yawn.

“Yup, pretty much.” Glimmer nodded.

“I just sleep.” Mermista leaned back in her chair, propping her feet on the table.

“Just how have you managed to fight off the Horde’s forces?” Shadow Weaver asked in disbelief.

“With the power of friendship,” Perfuma said with a grin.

Bow looked up from his arrows. “Teamwork.”

“Ice Fists!” Frosta said, demonstrating her powers.

“Sea-Ra!” Mermista rocked forward and pumped her fist.

“Mermista, that’s so not a thing.” Adora’s jaw tightened.

“Well, you’ve never let me wield the Sword of Protection, so I guess we’ll never know.” Mermista shrugged.

“Let’s just focus.” Adora covered her face with her hands and sighed. “It’s our first Princess meeting with Shadow Weaver and we need to help her learn how to use her powers.”

Shadow Weaver was still standing. She noticed Frosta had gone back to silently scribbling on a spare piece of parchment. She leaned over and discreetly looked at the drawing. “I’ve never been able to breathe fire, but I suppose I could try if it will help the war,” she said sardonically.

Frosta smacked her hands over the paper, glaring at Shadow Weaver. “Has anyone ever told you it’s rude to peek?”

“Yes,” Shadow Weaver replied.

Perfuma ran a finger down the tiny Venus flytrap. “Oh, I know! We can go over battle tactics again. Bow, do you have the mini-dolls of everyone?”

Bow shook his head and didn’t bother to check his bag. “I haven’t made one of Shadow Weaver yet and for the last time they are

war-table battle figures."

"Perfuma, that didn't work last time. Everyone just came up with powers they didn't have and Bow made eleven cat puns." Adora curled her fists on the table in front of her.

"Okay, we totally pulled off all our ideas and took back the fortress to the pass." Mermista went back to reclining in her chair. "And the plant golem was pretty cool."

Shadow Weaver looked at Bow in question.

"And they were really good puns." Bow argued.

"Catra doesn't make cat puns!" Adora groaned out.

"As someone who has spent extensive time with Catra, I can assure you she hates cat puns." Shadow Weaver picked the chair on the right side of Angella's and sat.

"We included the cat puns because we didn't wanna say she just skulks in the shadows and purrs your name, Adora." Mermista pointed out.

Everyone looked at Adora and nodded their agreement.

"You know what? It doesn't matter because we're not doing the scenarios this time," Adora said with a blush.

"But we never even got to include Shadow Weaver." Perfuma frowned.

"She wasn't even here last time," Adora said slowly. "She was with the Horde."

"Exactly. She didn't get a chance to tell us how she would capture the tower," Frosta said, lowering her voice in the timbre for the Winter's Bane. "Here's how I think it would have happened."

“Alright listen up!” Glimmer stood, slamming her hands on the table. “I’m the Commander of this Rebellion, remember? We’re somehow gonna whip this brooding, evil woman into a Princess worthy of our cause.”

Shadow Weaver’s eyes widened then narrowed. “I do not brood.”

“I’m getting poetic. Don’t interrupt, rookie.” Glimmer pointed at Shadow Weaver.

Bow leaned over. “This sounds an awful lot like your ‘Shadow Weaver is a horrible person’ speech,” he whispered to Glimmer.

“It’s the same inspiration.” Glimmer argued.

“I adore poetry,” Perfuma said, “Who doth know the shadows like our fair maiden.” She paused confused as she scrutinized Shadow Weaver. “…mossy, gray maiden. We-”

“Enough,” Angella said and all talking ceased. “No more scenarios and no more Commander speeches, poetry, or what have you. Find a way to include Shadow Weaver in your fighting without getting off track.”

“Let’s go outside and run through it with a more hands-on approach,” Adora said.

The Princesses relocated to the expanse of grass between the courtyard and the greenhouse. Glimmer teleported to the Bright Moon barracks and returned with two practice staffs.

“We need to see how much physical training you’ll need.” Adora tossed Shadow Weaver a wooden staff.

“We’ll fight without powers. The winner is whoever gets three contact strikes. No maiming.” Adora outlined the ground rules.

“Naturally,” Shadow Weaver agreed. She placed the staff behind her head and stretched her back before widening her stance.

“Go easy on her, Adora!” Glimmer chuckled.

Adora twirled the staff over her wrists in an impressive display as she ran forward. She lifted it over her head with both hands, bringing it down fast. Shadow Weaver stopped her hit with a quick block upward. Adora spun the staff in her hand, pushing forward for a low strike.

Shadow Weaver blocked again. They rocked back on their heels and repositioned. Their staffs met in the middle with a sharp snap. Shadow Weaver turned the staff in her hands and sent a series of strikes against Adora’s, driving her backward. She lunged for a quick thrust and pressed the tip of her staff to Adora’s shoulder, completing the first hit of their match.

Bow and the other Princesses looked stunned.

“I believe that is my point,” Shadow Weaver said, stepping back into a defensive pose.

“How did you do that?” Adora asked in astonishment.

Shadow Weaver moved her hands along the staff. “Is it so difficult to believe? I have overseen countless drills in the Horde.”

“Force Captains always led drills and you always used your magic, even to move.” Adora stammered. She rubbed her shoulder, trying to determine if she imagined the touch.

“You know what?” Glimmer looked thoughtful. “She had no issues keeping up with us in the Fright Zone invasion.”

“Adora, you know better than to make assumptions on your opponent,” Shadow Weaver said. “Or an ally.” She added after a beat.

“Okay, we’re fighting for real now and I’m not going easy on you,” Adora said with a determined scowl.

Adora held the staff parallel to the ground and ran for Shadow Weaver once more. She spun the staff, chasing Shadow Weaver back. She shifted left and their staffs met again in the middle. Adora pushed further, moving the tip of Shadow Weaver’s staff to the ground, trapping it under hers.

Shadow Weaver pulled her staff free and swung, aiming for Adora’s head. The blonde ducked just as she expected. Shadow Weaver quickly turned, dragging the staff along the ground. Adora jumped above the sweeping attack. Adora spun and thrust from her height, tapping Shadow Weaver on the nose of her mask and again on her hip as she landed.

“Two points for Adora!” Glimmer shouted and the Princesses cheered happily.

“I thought you said there would be no maiming?” Shadow Weaver readjusted her mask.

“I barely touched you,” Adora said cheekily. She flexed her arms and waited for Shadow Weaver to strike.

“Score is now two to one in Adora’s favor,” Bow announced.

Shadow Weaver moved suddenly and slammed her Bo staff down. Adora dodged backward and twisted, trying to land her third hit. Shadow Weaver deflected the blow and attempted a quick counter.

Adora sidestepped the attack and stabbed her staff between Shadow Weaver’s wrist and weapon. Adora twisted her staff and moved Shadow Weaver’s arm up into an elbow lock. Adora kicked Shadow Weaver’s staff to the ground and gave her former mentor a final tap with her staff.

“That was good.” Adora helped Shadow Weaver stand. “You’ll need a bit more practice to hone your current skills, but luckily we

won’t need to start from basics with fighting.”

Shadow Weaver and Adora sparred a few more times before Adora’s stomach growled like there was a beast living inside of her.

Adora blushed. “Okay, everyone, that’s a break! Let’s get some snacks...or lunch,” she said absently, rubbing her abdomen.

Shadow Weaver walked to a nearby bench and sat down heavily. A cool breeze blew across the grass, drying the sweat on her neck. She closed her eyes and listened to the birds tweeting merrily as they flew overhead and the rapid buzzing drone of dragonflies dancing above the overgrown flower bed nearby. The nearly inaudible rustle of wings tickled her hearing before the candied flower scent greeted her nose. “Hello, Angella.” She opened her eyes just in time to see the startled look receding from the queen’s face.

Angella handed Shadow Weaver a steaming teacup. “You look like you’ve had quite the workout.”

Shadow Weaver tried not to let her hands shake as she gripped the tea like a lifeline. “Will you be joining us?”

“I’m not much of a fighter.” Angella waved away the offer.

“That’s not true anymore, is it?” Shadow Weaver asked, placing the tea beside her on the bench and extending a hand. “I promise I’ll be gentle.”

Angella’s mouth twitched upwards as she ignored the hand. “I never pictured you as a physical fighter.”

“I’ve overseen enough training drills in the Horde to know how to execute basic fighting techniques.” Shadow Weaver shrugged. She noticed a small white box in Angella’s hands. “Is that for me as well?”

“Our chef made ginger snaps to go with afternoon tea,” Angella handed Shadow Weaver the box without ceremony.

Shadow Weaver opened the pastry box and was immediately greeted with the warm sweet scent of her favorite flavor. Taking a ginger snap from the box, Shadow Weaver slipped it under her mask. The cookie dissolved on her tongue and its spicy molasses taste was delightful. “Delicious.”

Angella nodded then left just as quietly as she came.

“You and the queen, huh?” Huntara asked from behind her.

“Where did you come from?” Shadow Weaver asked, pulling her mask back in place. She was so distracted from the short interaction that she didn’t notice Huntara stomping over to her. She vaguely remembered Huntara from the Horde. The young woman was defiant and crass with excellent leadership skills; she quickly rose to the position of Force Captain. One day she disappeared after a raiding mission and they just never spoke of her again. This wasn’t unusual. Horde soldiers tended to disappear all the time through death or capture.

“Shouldn’t you be skulking back under a rock for your afternoon nap?” Shadow Weaver snarked.

“Everyone looks at you like enemies but Huntara sees you as women. There’s an attraction between you,” Huntara said as her hand crept toward the box of ginger snaps.

“Huntara is hallucinating,” Shadow Weaver said, pinching the reaching hand. Thankfully the other Princesses were still inside and didn’t hear the accusation.

Huntara snorted and smirked at the action. “Just as well. Once you get used to desert grub all these delicate tea cakes give me indigestion.”

“As fascinating as this dialogue about your intestines has been, I have to be elsewhere.” Shadow Weaver gathered her cookies and

tea, walking to the floating greenhouse up ahead.

In the past, Shadow Weaver decided restraint of emotion was best and it didn't help her or Angella ultimately. She had considered briefly that it had been too long to go back to the way they were, except Angella certainly appeared receptive to her flirtation. If Huntara, someone that didn't know either of them, could sense an attraction then it was just a matter of time before the Princesses noticed also. That would be detrimental to her position in the Rebellion. The Princess Alliance and Castaspella, as soon as she shook herself out of her self imposed stupor, would assume Shadow Weaver used Angella to stay out of prison. She decided she would take her cues from Angella about their relationship. She finished her tea and left the greenhouse when she saw the other Princesses walking back to the practice area. There was work to be done.

Shadow Weaver's Princess training continued when no more information surfaced about the Horde's plans or whereabouts. Transitioning to her newly granted elemental magic was similar to learning to cast sorcery all over again. She was reduced to a first-year apprentice. Muscles she had never previously considered were now being stretched and the possibilities on how to use her powers seemed only limited to her imagination.

The training was awkward and gradual. She struggled to be a part of the team with the other Princesses instead of a leader. Some of them tried to be helpful, but it was clearly difficult for them to get too close after her history with the Horde. In short, it was hard work.

Adora wanted to make sure she was ready to accompany her to the Crimson Wastes as soon as possible. Mara's ship was buried and Shadow Weaver's elemental powers would be crucial to unearth the spacecraft if she could connect to its metal hull.

Today Adora, Bow, Glimmer, and Perfuma were trying a different method to test Shadow Weaver's powers and limits by simulating a Horde attack in Plumeria.

"Why can I not bring my Elemental to these training sessions?" Shadow Weaver asked Adora.

"You don't see me bringing Swift Wind everywhere, do you?" Adora responded. "Besides, Slinky won't always be there."

Shadow Weaver hummed. "I am beginning to suspect you are too jealous of my command of such a powerful weapon," she said, tapping Adora's nose.

Adora waited until Shadow Weaver glanced away and stuck her tongue out quickly. "I will be the attacker so keep the damage as minimal as possible and save all of the hostages." She reached for the sword on her back. "For the Honor of Grayskull!" She-Ra was nowhere in sight after the light of her transformation finished.

Glimmer, Bow, and Perfuma nodded to Shadow Weaver and pointed silently for her to move forward. They moved low around the vine houses and straw huts. Shadow Weaver saw the first hostage made of foliage just a few yards away when She-Ra sliced the hut they were crouched behind in half. Glimmer grabbed everyone and teleported to the other side of the village.

"Bow, distract She-Ra." Shadow Weaver requested. Bow sent arrows flying through the air, the wind of the projectiles tugged at the hair on the back of Shadow Weaver's head.

Shadow Weaver ran to the closest trapped villager and safely pulled them to the safe zone with Glimmer's help. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Bow get knocked out. "Glimmer, Bow has fallen."

"I got him." Glimmer flashed away.

"No, you don't." Perfuma restrained She-Ra's arm as she went to damage one of the stationary villagers.

Tossing the sword to her other hand, She-Ra shot magic at Shadow Weaver as she tried to rescue the trapped villager. Shadow Weaver tried to use the metal whip to deflect the hits, but her movements were clumsy. She dropped the whip and called a rusted panel from the ground. Crossing her right forearm in front of her, Shadow Weaver created a shield just as the next magic blast from She-Ra soared forth.

Breaking the vine on her wrist, She-Ra picked Perfuma up with a grunt and tossed her away across the village. Glimmer grabbed Perfuma from the air just in time.

"Just you and me now, Princess," She-Ra boasted with a point of her sword. "Huh-ha haha!"

"What was that?" The 'unconscious' Bow whispered from his place on the ground. "Who told her to ad-lib an evil laugh?"

"Adora, just fight," Glimmer said exasperatedly smacking her forehead. "There's a reason you don't have any lines."

"Fine," She-Ra said shortly and sent several blasts from her sword at Shadow Weaver.

Now essentially all alone, Shadow Weaver saw no other alternative. She couldn't dodge the attacks successfully and dived to the ground, sliding between She-Ra's legs. She rolled on the ground, making a crude longsword with the makeshift shield. The two weapons clanged together. She-Ra's strength drove her to her knees.

Shadow Weaver slid away, she stood and coughed, regaining her breath. "Again." She gasped.

She-Ra charged again but Shadow Weaver was ready. She tugged at the Sword of Protection with her powers, pulling She-Ra off balance. The brunette quickly forged two metal escrima sticks. She used the left one to wind She-Ra and the right one to sweep She-Ra's legs from under her.

“That was pretty good!” She-Ra exclaimed, grabbing the pole from her chest. The blonde flipped backward, kicking Shadow Weaver away from her. “But I’m better.”

“Again!” Shadow Weaver stumbled back, swaying unsteadily on her feet.

“I know that look. You need to recharge,” Glimmer said, standing in front of Shadow Weaver before she could charge again.

Perfuma passed Shadow Weaver a canteen with water. Shadow Weaver waved it away.

“You need to hydrate.” Perfuma looked at her with concern.

“I will worry about hydration later,” Shadow Weaver said, breathing heavily.

“Assessment time, rookie. Right now you’re completely flunking out on Best Friend Squad Princess Boot Camp.” Glimmer crossed her arms in disappointment.

“And why is that?” Shadow Weaver turned tensely.

“You let three Etherians get captured,” Adora said, walking over.

Shadow Weaver steepled her hands. “I can’t believe my score is based on how I rescued fake villagers.”

“Their straw parents are expecting them to come home and you don’t even care!” Bow replied dramatically.

“What are three straw lives versus the rest of Etheria?” Shadow Weaver waved a hand flippantly. “Sometimes these decisions will have to be made. It’s an acceptable loss.”

Glimmer growled in frustration. “You have to stop approaching this like a Horde tactician and more like a Princess.”

“The habits won’t change overnight, Commander Glimmer.” Shadow Weaver spoke sharply, spitting out her title.

“We know but that’s why we’re going to be here to make sure you stick to it. You’ll make new habits with us.” Glimmer held up a light encased fist. “Or else.”

Perfuma cleared her throat with a grin. “I vote we do guided meditation to help Shadow Weaver find her inner peace.”

“That’s a great idea Perfuma!” Glimmer grinned. “I’ll see if my mom is willing to let Shadow Weaver spend some time in Plumeria.”

“That’s enough for the day. Let’s head back,” Adora said. She subtly positioned herself next to Shadow Weaver. The former sorcerer looked like a stiff breeze could knock her over.

The air was filled with rich scents of freshly baked bread and broiled fish. It beckoned Shadow Weaver into the open door of the dining room. Before her was a long table covered with a lace tablecloth. Angella sat at the head of the table, sipping from a long-stemmed wine glass.

“Please tell me that’s not apple juice.” Shadow Weaver settled in a chair in with a groan.

“Rough day?” Angella inquired, pushing a filled glass to Shadow Weaver.

“I know the real reason for the Princess Alliance’s recent victories. All that sparkles and kindness is just an act.” Glimmer and Shadow Weaver’s large personalities butted against each other usually ending in interference from the other Princesses and overexertion from Shadow Weaver. “You are raising a despot.” She bit out.

“Glimmer takes her title of Commander very seriously.” The glass was pressed against Angella’s lips. Her eyes crinkled as she smiled. “You need to catch up to their level of teamwork and comradery not to mention their physical ability.”

Shadow Weaver looked up from her wine glass, turning towards Angella. “And just what do you mean by ‘physical ability’?”

“You are a more mature Princess,” Angella answered carefully.

“Are you implying that I’m too old to keep up with them?” Shadow Weaver demanded, dragging her nails along the table in irritation.

“Be careful of the table cloth.” Angella struck Shadow Weaver’s hand. “You’re youthful in spirit certainly-”

“These are high and mighty words for someone who sits on a throne all day.” Shadow Weaver shot back as she retracted her nails completely.

“I am at the peak of my physical fitness,” Angella said. She quickly handed Shadow Weaver the Runestone shard. “Glimmer said you would need this.”

Shadow Weaver grabbed it, her fingers lightly grazed Angella’s as she pulled it away. Angella lifted her wine glass and finished the beverage in one swallow.

Focusing on the shard, Shadow Weaver felt the Runestone’s magic flow into her. Her hair lifted slightly behind her as her body was outlined in mauve. It faded away just as she returned the Runestone to Angella.

“Your recharging is faster than mine or Glimmer’s.” Angella took the Runestone back. “It’s amazing to witness.”

“How long until I earn the right to keep my Runestone?” Shadow Weaver reclined in her seat, moving a little easier now.

Angella placed the Runestone in an enchanted, velvet-lined box for safekeeping. The queen had the box made once she realized she would endure retching from Slinky to retrieve the Runestone shard every time Shadow Weaver returned to recharge. “It shouldn’t be long now. I’m hearing good things from the Princesses.”

“It’s still tense.” Shadow Weaver admitted, pulling at her collar. She should have taken Perfuma up on her offer of water. She probably wouldn’t be overheating now. “Do not expect me to be sipping hot chocolate in pajamas with them anytime soon.”

“Maybe in another month,” Angella said ominously and observed the other woman with a critical eye. “Those robes can’t be comfortable to run in. How do you intend to fight in this clothing?”

“I will admit, they are particularly restricting. I have never needed to move this fast before. I’ve been doing some designing of my own. It’s past time for a change to my wardrobe.” Shadow Weaver smoothed down her dress. “My powers and Mermista’s are similar. They are both completely reliant on the immediate sources within range. Thankfully, Slinky has been scavenging the Whispering Woods for my materials.”

Angella sat the enchanted box roughly on the table. “You can’t use Bright Moon as a junkyard.”

“It’s all very sustainable. He eats refuse and scrap metal.” Shadow Weaver waved her hand in the direction of the sleeping Elemental in spherical form. He followed the Runestone wherever it was unless summoned elsewhere by Shadow Weaver.

“Just keep him out of my way.”

The last rounds of training took place in Crystal Castle due to the ease in which the environment could be changed. An option that Adora suggested embarrassingly after their fifth training session in Plumeria.

Adora was all business when they arrived in Crystal Castle. “Light Hope, we need a simulated attack. Something that includes speed, strength, problem-solving, combat, and teamwork.”

“Assessing all criteria.” Light Hope appeared behind them. “I believe I have found a suitable option.” Their surroundings dissolved and suddenly they were under attack.

“Rookie, the seventh rule of Princess Battle is Princess Cooperation!” Glimmer shouted as Shadow Weaver nearly cracked Frosta’s ice fists with her polearm. “Be aware of your surroundings.”

“You said that was rule three, twenty, and once it was rule forty-two.” Shadow Weaver grunted, trying to take down the bot in front of them. It shot the weapon from her hands.

“Don’t question the rule book!” Glimmer yelled back.

“Did you finally write the rule book?” Bow asked, sliding past two bots.

Shadow Weaver used her powers to roll the closest bot backward, bowling over the two pursuing them. She forged a nearby wall panel into a broadsword and swiped at the next bot’s legs, taking it down. The tunnel they ran through was collapsing and the Horde was on their tail. Her lungs burned and her muscles ached in protest, but she wouldn’t give up. Not when they are so close to victory.

Bots scurried forth, blocking their path. Mermista sent up a thick wave of water, shorting out the closest bots and halted the first round of plasma beams. Perfuma’s vines appeared, wrapping all the turrets and cannons. The weapons were pulled to face each other as they fired, destroying them all.

Bots scurried over the wreckage, shooting a steady stream of lasers. Frosta raised them to the ceiling with jagged spikes of ice through their hulls. A larger bot clanged down the hall behind them. Shadow Weaver turned and halted its movement. She kept it stalled in place and slowly crushed it.

“End simulation,” Adora said calmly.

“What is it now?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“You just injured your party. You crushed a boss bot in an enclosed space and it’s going to explode sending shrapnel flying in all directions,” Adora said.

“I could have shielded us with the remaining metal.” Shadow Weaver argued.

“As an afterthought, you have to be proactive, Shadow Weaver, not reactive.” Adora shook her head. “You are part of a team now. You are responsible for everyone’s well-being as we are responsible for yours.”

“Princesses work together because we’re stronger together,” Perfuma said with a decisive nod.

“Adora, my sensors indicate that Shadow Weaver was manipulating the environment to form a protective shield for your team.” Light Hope flickered into view.

Shadow Weaver sent her a smug look.

“Oh, well good. Then we’ll try again.” Adora then raised her voice. “Light Hope, run scenario Alpha 421.”

“Simulating.” Light Hope droned out.

The scene changed all around them and there were in a cavern surrounded by bots, Horde soldiers, and cannons. Without warning, the soldiers and bots charged first, hoping to overwhelm

them with sheer numbers. The Princesses stood in a circle together, covering all sides of the battle.

“Hold,” She-Ra said, staring at the advancing army. “Frosta now!”

Icy peaks jutted from the ground tossing the bots and soldiers away from them. Mermista shot up on a tidal wave of water, washing the army back against the rocks. Large vines split the wave and kept the fighters captive while Bow, Frosta, and Glimmer ran ahead. Glimmer sent a barrage of light blasts, disorienting the next wave of soldiers.

The cannons whirred to life, glowing green from their perches. Glimmer held Bow’s shoulder as they teleported behind the cannons. One by one the arrows soared with practiced efficiency. A lime green laser soared through the air with Bow in its sights when She-Ra used her shield to ricochet it to the side of the canyon. The rocks tumbled and slid to the ground, piling one on top of the other until the army could no longer move forward then all was silent.

Everyone’s cheering and celebrating was cut short when the ground shook. With a powerful bang, the rocks exploded to dust, forcing everyone to shield their eyes from the debris and smoke. A tank crept forward. Rolling over the desiccated bots and waterlogged vines.

The Princesses stood still trying to gauge their next move when the tank shot. She-Ra jumped, landing behind the tank, pulling to slow its movement. Her heels dug into the dirt as pieces of its metal frame bent under her hands. Shadow Weaver slammed her hand up and the turret moved with her, missing everyone completely. She forced the metal back. Using all her strength and magic to stop the movement of the tank, her arms shook and she felt sweat beading across her forehead.

Perfuma moved beside her and a cluster of vines lifted the tank, driving it further back. Mermista sent a multitude of waves,

pushing the tank more. She-Ra began to tug with ease, her steps becoming more confident. Frosta pressed her hands to the ground and enveloped the tank in ice.

Shadow Weaver walked forward and clasped her hands together, she brought them down in a hammer blow and waited. A low, squeaky whine sounded and fissures of cracks traveled down the middle of the tank. It split neatly in half and the simulation ended.

"And that's how it's done Princess style," She-Ra said, pumping her fist in the air. Everyone moved forward, patting Shadow Weaver on the back and chatting excitedly.

Glimmer spoke up. "Time for your assessment. You've really worked hard and I want you to know it hasn't gone unnoticed. I think we all agree you've graduated to Princess-In-Training."

After breakfast, the first order of business for Shadow Weaver the next day was to put the finishing touches on her Princess weapons and outfit. She forged and tested throwing knives on a piece of plywood.

"Enter." Shadow Weaver called out at the knock on her door.

"Adora told me you were collecting spare metal for your arsenal. I have some for you," Bow said, stopping at her workbench. He placed a cloth bag on the table. "I designed them when I started to learn archery. They are used to protect your thumb from the friction against the string but the rings always got caught when I was firing rapidly. Building up callouses ended up being my best solution."

Shadow Weaver picked up the bag, the rings inside jingled softly.

“You could still use them as thumb rings. Maybe you could remold it into something more comfortable as an emergency source of metal?”

“I will keep that in mind,” Shadow Weaver said, turning back to her work. “Thank you, Bow.”

“You’re welcome.” He called over his shoulder as he passed Angella.

“I got a report about the strange noises coming from your chambers.” Angella winced, hearing a screech then a ripping noise that battered her hearing and echoed down the halls. “What are you doing?”

“I’m forging,” Shadow Weaver said as she lowered the warped piece of metal to the floor.

“How’s that going? Still part of your secret costume change?” Angella asked when Shadow Weaver offered nothing more.

“You’ll see it soon enough. Since we are heading to the Crimson Waste to retrieve Mara’s ship.”

“I look forward to seeing the finished product,” Angella said, picking up one of the thumb rings on the table. “I need to talk to you about something.” She turned it over in her hands and placed it back down.

Shadow Weaver glanced at her. “I’ll be but a moment,” she said and snapped a metal cuff across her forearm.

Angella looked alarmed. “You won’t need any weapons for this talk.”

“Having my element close at hand is comforting,” Shadow Weaver said.

They walked out into the hall and almost bumped into Castaspella who looked to be closely studying a vase across the hall.

“Yes, that’s not suspicious at all.” Shadow Weaver drawled.

“You’re really going to do this?” Castaspella asked, storming up to Angella.

“Thank you for your continued suggestions, Castaspella. I’m fine,” Angella said.

Castaspella turned to Shadow Weaver. “If you hurt her. I swear I’ll-”

“Yes, yes you’ll use all your magical might.” Shadow Weaver waved a hand like she was shooing away an insect. She moved suddenly and was pleased when Castaspella started at her proximity.

Castaspella moved past the two women with a growl, making sure to hip check Shadow Weaver.

“One day, one of you will have to let me know what this rivalry is about.” Angella huffed, steadying Shadow Weaver. “I know she blames you for Micah, but lately she seems more hateful than before.”

“She’s never going to forgive me for tainting her honorable, big brother.” Shadow Weaver brushed off the worry. “To what was she referring? How will my walking with you harm you in some way?”

“Glimmer wishes to learn magic and requests that you be her instructor.”

“I knew that was a matter of time.” Shadow Weaver nodded. “Glimmer is strong and she has shown an aptitude for magic I have not seen since Micah.”

“That is what I’m afraid of.” Angella sighed, hugging herself. “I don’t want Glimmer to learn magic. I want you to decline if she asks you.”

Shadow Weaver wanted to hold Angella. She clasped her hands together to rein in the craving. “Magic is about intent. If she does not approach it with sinister designs then you have nothing to fear from her learning.”

“Glimmer does not need magic. She is plenty gifted on her own,” Angella said.

“Wouldn’t you feel better knowing that Glimmer is practicing without danger?” Shadow Weaver asked, sitting on one of the stone benches in the courtyard. “The yearning for power can be very addictive. The spark is already there and her curiosity can be perilous. We wouldn’t want her learning from just any magical tome without the proper guidance.”

“Castaspella is a perfectly respectable sorceress.” Angella looked to the castle.

“Castaspella is merely an adequate sorcerer. You know Glimmer is not meant for mediocrity,” Shadow Weaver said calmly. “Adequate magic can be the difference between coming home with a bruised ego or not coming home at all. If you’re worried about my influence, invite Castaspella along. She might just learn something.”

“You will be provided full access to our library and anything you might need to safely instruct Glimmer in magic.” Angella turned, revealing her stern expression. “Glimmer will not learn anything Castaspella does not sign off on. Are we clear?”

Shadow Weaver nodded. “As crystal my queen.”

In addition to the library and magical artifacts that Bright Moon had, Shadow Weaver would also be granted use of the greenhouse as no one had properly tended to it in what looked

like years. With Perfuma's help, it was quickly wrangled back to its former glory and ready to be used as one of the primary magical lesson venues.

Glimmer eagerly teleported into the greenhouse as soon as she was given permission. "Good afternoon, Glimmer." Shadow Weaver greeted. "It seems your aunt does not share your penchant for punctuality."

"I heard that. I do have a kingdom to run as well," Castaspella said as she entered the greenhouse.

"Let us begin. Magic can take many forms, most magic is grey." Shadow Weaver paced slowly around the small space. "Grey magic is magic that is not performed for specifically beneficial reasons. It also does not focus entirely on the intent to harm. It is seen as falling in a range between light and dark magic."

"Glimmer, your magic can be full of light. There is no need to ever resort to dark or grey magic." Castaspella glared at Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver held the sorcerer's gaze. "Magic takes on the intent of the caster. Your magical intentions must be determined and resounding. For example, do you recall what I told Adora about healing?"

Glimmer nodded.

"Intent is what gives magic its inherent power. If you don't mean what you are casting then the spells will fail." Shadow Weaver removed a stack of books from the stool in the corner and handed them to Glimmer. "That will be all for today."

"What?" Glimmer fumbled with the books as she stood. "How can that be all? We haven't done anything."

"Glimmer, you requested to learn magic so you must start where the Mystacor apprentices start," Castaspella said, steadying the pile of books in her niece's arms.

“My level of magic has surpassed the apprentices by years with the invasion of the Fright Zone.” Glimmer argued. “You promised to make me stronger.”

“I have only ever trained the truly gifted. Right now you are unpolished and uninformed. If you want to wield the power you were born with then you will start at the beginning or continue as you always have,” Shadow Weaver said. “Without magic.”

“Magic is not a toy.” Castaspella placed a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “You have to learn it properly or you would be a danger to yourself or others.”

“Why are you here?” Glimmer nudged off the hand and stepped away with a glare. “I asked mom to have Shadow Weaver teach me. All you’ve ever done is hold back your magic.”

“Glimmer,” Castaspella gasped.

Shadow Weaver slashed her nails across the surface of a nearby crystal globe, sending an ear-splitting squeal through the room. “Disrespect will not be tolerated, Glimmer. Not in this space. You will learn at this pace or not at all. Make your choice,” she said.

“I was excited to learn magic and I didn’t think there would be so much reading. I’ve always been the weakest Princess.” Glimmer bowed her head, studying the books laden in her arms. “I’m sorry Aunt Casta,” she said quietly.

Shadow Weaver tilted Glimmer’s face up to look at her. “You are strong, Glimmer, but you will need all your strength for this. Similar to my Princess training, this will not be an easy venture.”

Less than a week after Glimmer’s first magic lesson, Adora declared they would go looking for Mara’s ship, but the day didn’t go as smoothly as they anticipated.

Huntara leaned back in the chair with her feet on the table as she filed her nails. “Is Glitter gonna keep us waiting much longer?”

“The guards said she’ll be here any minute,” Shadow Weaver responded as she walked into the room.

“Hey, it’s a special occasion,” Bow announced. Adora and Huntara looked at him, awaiting an explanation. “It’s Shadow Weaver’s very first Princess mission.” He shot an arrow in the air that exploded and released confetti over them.

“That’s right. My rookie is all grown up.” Glimmer appeared in the room, pretending to wipe a tear. “Unfortunately, I can’t go because I’m still tailing my mom as punishment for releasing Shadow Weaver which is really ironic since Shadow Weaver gets to go with you guys on this mission.” She rambled.

Shadow Weaver was aware of how strained Glimmer’s and Angella’s relationship was after the unplanned Fright Zone invasion. She had taken to tuning out Glimmer’s whining about shadowing Angella while she performed her royal duties.

“It’s okay, Glimmer. You’ll get to go with us next time. Just let your mom cool down,” Bow said, throwing an arm over her shoulder.

“Totally fine. I’m going to prove to my mom that my decisions are better than they appear. I’ve already made an official proposal as Commander and she accepted it,” Glimmer said and teleported away. She returned with Mermista in tow. “So, as part of my anti-Horde strategy, I’m sending you.” She hitched a thumb at Mermista, sipping her soda with disinterest. “Adora, Bow, Shadow Weaver, and Huntara on a mission to retrieve Mara’s ship from the Crimson Waste. Then, Bow will repair it and we’ll have a spaceship. Take that Horde,” she finished, punching the air with a manic grin.

“Uh, Glimmer?” Adora said.

“What?” Glimmer responded.

“The Crimson Waste is a desert and Mermista kind of needs water for her powers to work,” Adora said.

“Right,” Glimmer said, walking back to Mermista. “I’ll be right back.” She added and teleported away again.

“Didn’t you propose going to the Crimson Waste for the spaceship?” Huntara asked the blonde.

“This is important for Glimmer so I sort of let her have the idea,” Adora said, scratching the back of her head.

“Did I hear Glimmer? She’s needed in the defense meeting immediately,” Angella said, coming to stand beside Huntara.

“Whoa, Shadow Weaver!” Adora exclaimed just taking notice of the older woman. “I’m liking the new look.”

Shadow Weaver was still covered head to toe in clothing. A lot of her original dress was still present in her new outfit’s design. The most obvious change was with her floor-length dress. The dress was shortened considerably into an asymmetrical handkerchief skirt for easier movement.

A gleaming ornate belt buckle now housed the smaller shard of her Runestone. Attached to the belt was a right hip holster that appeared to contain a thick cylinder of lead or steel. The accessories included two brass and silver rings on her left thumb and the new armor attached to her reduced right sleeve. The darkened metal on the pauldron was of simple make, its segmented pieces flowed down her arm ending at a fingerless gauntlet. Black tights tucked into equally black mid-calf boots completed the ensemble.

Angella gave Shadow Weaver a penetrating gaze. Her eyes assessed the new outfit. “You look very dashing,” she said neutrally. “As soon as Glimmer returns, remind her that she should have been in the defense meeting ten minutes ago.” The queen continued toward the throne room.

Shadow Weaver nodded her head and turned her attention to the group. “Clearly this mission is off to a grand start.”

“It’s just a small hiccup we’ll be leaving in no time,” Bow said.

“Don’t huff too much Dark One. It will wrinkle your fancy clothes and you won’t be ‘dashing’ anymore.” Huntara smirked, pausing in her filing.

Shadow Weaver flicked her finger, pushing the chair back so Huntara’s legs were removed from the table. Just then Glimmer returned with a less than enthusiastic Perfuma informing them all about her interrupted morning meditation being ruined.

“Now that this whole thing is settled, let us depart at once. Mara’s ship isn’t gonna retrieve itself,” Shadow Weaver said.

“That’s the spirit!” Huntara clapped Shadow Weaver on the back nearly knocking the other woman to the floor.

The two moons overhead were bright and seemed to follow their footsteps through the brittle sands as they made their way towards Mara’s ship. Shadow Weaver glanced over her surroundings. She briefly stayed in one of the uninhabited caves several yards west of their current location after she was exiled from Mystacor. The desert had not changed. The heat was oppressive and dry, the quicksand was unassuming and the plants were strange and dangerous.

Suddenly, a cactus rumbled and exploded, covering Perfuma with cactus juice. Shadow Weaver watched as it splattered along the sand just missing her boots. Huntara moved further up and with just a few words, she and Adora easily goaded each other into a competition. They ran, kicking up sand behind them, shoving roughly in an attempt to make it to the top of the hill.

It took her a couple of beats to realize that she had unconsciously quickened her steps in an attempt to keep up with Huntara and Adora and slowed down. She was still within range to hear Perfuma complaining about her lack of connection to Cacti and her failures as a nature and flower Princess.

“Maybe if you gave cacti a chance you would realize that beneath that prickly surface is a really great friend,” Bow said, trying to encourage her.

“Huh?” Perfuma frowned in confusion.

Bow frowned. “Uh…this cacti thing is about Huntara, right?”

“What? No, I really mean cacti.” Perfuma confirmed.

Shadow Weaver paused not turning around as she spoke, “Perfuma, cacti are like any other plant just more independent. They use the moonlight to feed themselves and provide oxygen. The thorns that you see are their protection from predators that wish to use it as a water source in the desert.”

“Feeling a kinship to the desert plants?” Bow asked, leaning toward Shadow Weaver with a big smile. “Thorny exterior and all?”

Perfuma seemed to not hear them as she continued having her break down. “And now I’m surrounded by cacti. Cacti that hate me.” She sobbed, falling into Shadow Weaver’s arms.

“There, there.” Shadow Weaver patted Perfuma’s back stiffly.

Bow grinned and shot Shadow Weaver a thumbs up.

“How am I going to use them to move the ship?” Perfuma’s words were muffled by Shadow Weaver’s thick collar.

“I don’t think that’s gonna matter anymore,” Bow said, bringing their attention back to him.

Perfuma and Shadow Weaver walked just to the crest of the hill and saw the empty crater than once held the ship.

“I can’t believe the Horde took the ship.” Adora panted as she slumped forward with her hands on her knees.

Huntara snorted and spat into the sand. “It could have been any number of scavengers. You weren’t very discreet when you tried to recruit me last time.”

“Gosh, well I guess we should come back some other time,” Perfuma said, trying to sneak away.

Shadow Weaver stood in front of Perfuma, blocking her exit. “If it is the Horde, they will liberate it of anything valuable. We need to find the ship as fast as possible for it to be of any use to us.”

“I can find it. Huntara is the best tracker in the Crimson Waste.” Huntara kneeled and placed a bit of sand in her mouth. “Rubber and metal. You may be right and the Horde took the ship.”

Shadow Weaver watched as Adora tried to emulate this thug of a woman.

“Oh yeah I definitely taste rubber and...sand,” Adora said, spitting the filthy grit from her mouth. High pitched beeping sounded just as Adora finished wiping her tongue. “What is with the Crimson Waste!? Did you put alarms in the sand?”

“Calm down guys. It’s my pad. I souped it up so Glimmer could check-in.” Bow removed his tracker pad from one of his numerous hidden pockets and switched it on.

Glimmer’s face appeared on the screen. “How goes the mission? Did you get the spaceship back yet?”

“There’s actually been a little bit of a setback,” Bow began.

“Bow, no. Hang up. Turn it off right now,” Adora hissed, making a cutting motion across her neck. “Seriously, stop.”

Bow turned his back, ignoring her movements.

“What’s Adora doing?” Glimmer asked, watching the blonde flail her arms.

“Uh dancing, because the mission is going super! We have to go and do mission stuff now,” Bow announced with an unconvincing grin.

“Glimmer, turn that off, and get back to the meeting.” Angella’s voice sounded out through the static before the device shut off.

“I don’t like lying to Glimmer.” Bow put away the pad.

“We’re not lying.” Adora shook her head. “There’s just no need to worry her. You know how Glimmer hates meetings. If she runs off again without her mother’s approval she’ll be in even more trouble. We can handle this.”

“So, about the ship, we could just follow these.” Bow pointed to the large machinery tracks on the ground, leading away from the crater left by Mara’s ship.

The group walked on as three large carrion birds circled overhead, waiting for a chance at a meal. Their steps brought them closer to bleached bones framing a settlement off the edge of a cliff.

“I thought this is where we were headed,” Huntara said, running forward. She peered below her with a grin. “The Valley of the Lost. It’s a smuggler’s haven and my home.”

They climbed down the steps leading into the bazaar. Each of the stalls was packed in close quarters. In the first part of the marketplace, they were surrounded by general chatter and the encouraging bark of a vendor selling his wares. Sparks flew from a stone grinder as they walked past the discount blacksmith. Further down were shouts and jeers from people watching two bugs fight to the death. Sneaking through the excitement, Huntara grabbed four bundles of cloth and handed them each one so they could hide their faces and clothing. Sketchy deals from the

smugglers to the Horde soldiers were taking place out in the open.

Shadow Weaver kept her head down not wanting to be recognized by the Horde soldiers in the market square. She felt the prickling sensation of someone watching them and discreetly glanced up. High above them on a balcony made of flimsy wood sat a small child. The child made a rude face and she passed. She glared back at the child and continued forward.

Passing through a back alley, they saw the lizard woman and the horned woman that had aligned themselves with Catra. Huntara's face became murderous as she snarled. The warrior started forward and Adora caught her arm.

"No," Adora whispered and pulled Huntara back out of sight. "Shh, Catra's goons are here," she said to the rest of the group.

"They're not her goons. They are my goons. I just never got a chance to fire them. I'll fix that now," Huntara stated, limbering up for a fight.

"I'm so glad I am here to take part in your poor managerial skills." Shadow Weaver whispered.

"There's a sense of honor," Huntara said, cracking her knuckles. "Even among thieves."

"I think it's best to avoid confrontation," Perfuma suggested quietly.

Huntara raised an eyebrow. "You afraid to fight, Flower Girl?"

"No, Perfuma's right. There's sure to be others. We'll be outnumbered." Adora tried to reason with the Crimson Waste native.

"I don't like not fighting," Huntara grunted out.

"I hadn't noticed." Shadow Weaver remarked.

“I understand you want payback, but finding the ship is our mission.” Adora reminded her.

The heavy footfalls of boots thundered towards them.

“Hide,” Bow said quickly.

The group scurried behind a broken wall as quickly as possible.

“They went this way. Over here.” The Horde soldiers grunted, running past them.

“The Valley is crawling with Horde soldiers and we still don’t know where the ship is.” Bow peeked from behind the wall.

“This is still my home and I know who can help.” Huntara stood.

Perfuma leaned forward, whispering to Adora. “Are you sure we can trust her contact? Everyone in the Crimson Waste seems to come off a little back stabby.” She glanced at Huntara. “No offense.”

“You scared?” Huntara turned with a smirk. “Good, because we’re here.”

“Is that a ‘no’ on the trust question?” Bow asked as they walked up to a dusty booth with a tattered curtain at the end of the winding alley.

“Ugh, who would buy this junk?” Huntara called out.

“Fools, just like you.” A heavyset woman opened the curtain. She had a straightened mane of hair surrounding her grizzled face. Her stern visage included an eye patch and a robotic prosthetic arm. “You shouldn’t be here.” She grumbled out. “It’s not safe. Hurry.” She moved away from the door and allowed them inside.

Shadow Weaver looked across the dingy hovel. It was packed with filthy castoffs from floor to ceiling. She got the impression that the one clear spot on the floor with the dust-covered area rug was probably where this woman slept.

Huntara had apparently found something more alarming by the appearance of the abode. "Grox, what's going on? Where's the gang?"

"Hiding. The Waste has been infested with Horde Scum since you left. Can't turn around without them interfering with business." Grox cleared her sinuses and expectorated.

Shadow Weaver stepped back as Perfuma dodged the spit with a disgusted gasp. Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed as she shuffled quietly forward. Adora stopped her with a small shake of her head.

"Things haven't been easy." Grox continued as she gave Huntara a rough one-armed hug. "You're a real sight for sore eyes."

"You too. Grox, I need your help." Huntara's voice softened. "We're looking for a ship."

"And I got just the thing to help." Grox rifled through a pile of rubbish. A Horde vest fell to the floor near Bow's feet.

"Aha!" Grox stood again with a large horn in tow. "Now, before I do this, Huntara. I need you to remember one thing. One thing you forgot that's important. This is the Crimson Waste. Trust no one." She brought the horn to her lips and let out a loud bugle. "I've got the Rebel intruders!"

Huntara had Grox in the air by her shirt in seconds. "You sold us out!?"

"Look at you." Grox laughed, sneering down her nose at Huntara. "The Huntara I knew would have seen this coming. You've gone soft."

Rapid steps moved closer to their location. “They’re in there. Come on.” A Horde soldier shouted from outside.

“Leave her. We have to go.” Adora tugged on Huntara’s arm.

“I’ll be back,” Huntara vowed with a growl, tightening her grip.

“Run along now. That’s what you’re good at.” Grox wheezed with a smirk.

Huntara dropped Grox and ran through the back door. They burst from the hovel and ran too fast for the Horde soldiers to react. Shadow Weaver zeroed in on Grox and rolled her wrist before she was out of range. She sensed the exact moment the prosthetic arm bent backward. She smiled in satisfaction and pretended not to know why there was a sudden crack of bone or agonizing scream as she ran behind the others. Their path was cut off by Catra’s goons. They held pipes in their hands as they attempted to brandish them menacingly.

“Looks like there’s no way to avoid a fight now Princess.” Huntara removed the retractable spear from her back with a twirl.

“For the honor of Grayskull!" She-Ra pointed to the small cactus growing against the building. “Perfuma, make a wall so they can’t surround us.” She ran forward, deflecting the pipe from the lizard woman.

Huntara blocked the next blow from the horned woman. Bow kept an arrow notched but was unable to fire due to the tight space.

“Allow me,” Shadow Weaver said, moving forward. She wound the pipes around their wrists and tossed the two goons into a shack across the path.

Shadow Weaver pulled the thick of lead into a short fighting staff. The group turned around to face the soldiers pursuing them. The Horde soldiers hesitated when they saw Shadow Weaver. She-Ra lunged, catching one in the solar plexus. The blonde heard the rush of air and intercepted the taser headed for her.

“Really now you shouldn’t play with those,” Shadow Weaver said. “Someone could get hurt.” She used her powers to crush the instrument, causing it to misfire in the second soldier’s hand. They went down with a yell as electricity traveled up their arm.

The first soldier recovered from the body blow and the third rushed them. She saw more troops headed their way when a yelp alerted her that Perfuma was once again unsuccessful in controlling cacti. The girl was now covered in cactus needles.

“More Horde soldiers are coming. We’re being boxed in.” Huntara glanced at both exits and grabbed Perfuma by the arm. “This way.”

She-Ra sliced down some barrels, slowing down their attackers.

Diving behind some wooden crates, they all breathed a sigh of relief when the soldiers passed without incident. Loud beeps sounded from Bow in the tiny space. He jumped and fumbled with the datapad.

“Ugh, I’m finally on break from Etheria’s most boring meeting.” Glimmer’s voice came out of the tiny speaker entirely too loud.

“Shh!” Adora held a finger to her mouth.

“Can’t talk. We’re being chased through a smuggler’s den.” Bow hissed at rapid speed.

“Quiet that thing,” Huntara grunted.

Shadow Weaver clenched her hand, resisting the urge to snatch the tracker pad from him and destroy it. “They will be on us in seconds. Shut it off.”

“Oh! I’ll be there as soon as I can.” Glimmer’s eyes lit up with excitement.

“Glimmer, don’t you dare,” Angella said in the background. “Glimmer!” It was too late. Glimmer disappeared from view and

the pad's screen went dark.

"Perfuma, what happened to you back there?" Adora asked her friend.

"I hate cacti." Perfuma groaned out. "There I said it. I love and honor all things except cacti. I hate spitting and the Crimson Waste. It is *full* of negative energy."

Huntara picked at a thread on her shorts. "It wasn't always like this. Used to be a criminal could carve out a decent life in the desert."

"Well, it's terrible now." Perfuma sniffled.

"I know." Huntara put her head in her hands and shook it.

Perfuma went to copy the action but encountered cactus needles. "Ouch."

"Hold still." Shadow Weaver scooted closer to Perfuma. She used her nails as tweezers and efficiently removed the thorns from Perfuma's skin. "If you ever figure out how to control cacti you can use this attack. It seems most effective," she said after the last thorn was removed.

"You want me to use thorns as projectiles?" Perfuma asked with wide eyes.

"You have to use everything you have at your disposal," Shadow Weaver said.

"We can't wait on Glimmer. We have to get to Mara's ship now before the Horde decides to move it again." Adora stood, glancing around for more Horde soldiers.

"We can find it with this." Bow held up a Horde Force Captain badge.

"What would we do with that?" Huntara asked.

“All Horde badges have trackers in them.” Shadow Weaver revealed. “Very astute, Bow.”

“Exactly, that’s how they were able to find Catra when we...detained her,” Bow pried the cover off using a screwdriver and plugged up his handheld to the badge. He pressed a series of buttons and a signal zeroed in on a cluster of Horde soldiers from the map on the screen. “There’s our ship,” he reported with a grin.

While She-Ra and Bow took care of the Horde forces at the top of the canyon, Huntara and Shadow Weaver tried their best to encourage Perfuma to lift the ship from the bottom.

“Okay, remember.” Huntara hummed in a wordless mantra.

Perfuma closed her eyes and hummed along, trying to meditate past her pessimism. “It’s no use.” she sighed, slumping her shoulders.

“Listen to me,” Shadow Weaver grasped Perfuma’s shoulder. “You are nature personified and you can command these plants. Extend your power and find the link to these cacti. It’s there within you and within them.”

Perfuma nodded. “You’re right.” She opened her hands and reached out beyond the normal blockade. She felt something new.

Shadow Weaver felt the younger woman’s elemental magic thrum beneath her skin. She released Perfuma before her sorcery decided to leech off the connection. “Now, Perfuma. Focus.”

“We’re underground!” Perfuma gasped excitedly.

“You’re just realizing that now?” Huntara asked.

“Yes, and you know what else is underground? Roots!” Perfuma used her hands to beckon the roots from the ground and moved onto the ones from the sides of the cliff. The huge, crawling roots began to break away the foundation of the canyon, falling onto the ship. Perfuma struggled to keep the ship lifted with the extra weight.

Shadow Weaver fixated on pulling more elemental magic from the shard in her belt and linked to the ship’s metal hull. She held her hands up and pushed the ship higher.

The stalled ship moved higher as Shadow Weaver and Perfuma used their elements to raise it from the pit. Above them, She-Ra and Catra ran back and forth across the scaffolding trading blows. Distantly, Shadow Weaver found it odd that Catra wasn’t more talkative and seemed to ignore her presence. Her concentration was broken when more rocks fell from the walls of the canyon.

Redoubling her efforts, Shadow Weaver poured more magic in holding the ship, but she didn’t have the strength. “I can’t hold it much more.” She grunted as her arms began to shake. “We need She-Ra.”

“We need a little help here!” Huntara called up to She-Ra.

A golden aura surrounded She-Ra as she powered up to destroy the rocks on the ship. Shadow Weaver glowed a light pink and she reconnected to the steel of the aircraft. She prepared to assist Perfuma in lifting the ship once more, gathering her renewed strength, but everything came to a halt. Sprawling roots twisted into a dais, elevating the ship high above the canyon. Huntara and Perfuma ran up the scaffolding to celebrate with Bow and Adora while Shadow Weaver moved at a more sedate pace.

“Get yer ass over here, Dark Princess,” Huntara called, pulling Shadow Weaver close with a rough bicep around her neck.

“This was a victory for all of us,” Adora said, holding out her hand with a small smile.

Shadow Weaver clasped it firmly, shaking it twice.

Perfuma grabbed Shadow Weaver in another bone-crushing hug as soon as Huntara released her. “Thank you for helping me,” she said.

“You are welcome.” Shadow Weaver awkwardly patted the top of Perfuma’s head. “I’d like to discuss the hugging.”

“What is there to discuss?” Perfuma pulled back but didn’t yet release her fellow Princess. “Friends hug. Especially new friends.”

“We’re friends now are we?” Shadow Weaver inquired.

Perfuma nodded eagerly. “Of course.”

“As friends are we not duty-bound to do each other favors?” Shadow Weaver asked lightly.

“Celebratory hugs are non-negotiable.” Perfuma looked at Shadow Weaver with a decisive stare.

“You may as well give it up, Shadow Weaver. Perfuma’s friendship and hugs are powerful tools in her arsenal,” Adora said through an amused chuckle.

Just then Glimmer shimmered into view. She held up her fists, glancing around the towering scaffolding. “Aw, you guys didn’t even save any bad guys for me?”

“It wasn’t all that exciting,” Shadow Weaver said.

“At least I got to see something of my rookie’s first Princess mission,” Glimmer said.

“I think she’s more than ready,” Adora said with a smile.

Angella knocked on Shadow Weaver's doorframe. "Congratulations on your first successful Princess mission. Mara's ship was retrieved and we gained an ally in Huntara."

"If I never see the Crimson Wastes again it will be too soon." Shadow Weaver groused, turning her boot over out her window. The sand was carried away on the wind.

"I'd nearly forgotten how much you hate sand," Angella said with a small smile, walking into the room.

"It serves no purpose." Was Shadow Weaver's reply. "Are you waiting for something in particular from me?"

Angella said nothing and continued to wait.

"I broke that woman's arm because she double-crossed us." Shadow Weaver admitted evenly.

"When you go rogue and use more force than necessary, how can we trust you on recon missions or supply runs?" Angella asked with a sigh.

"I do what the other Princesses cannot or will not." Shadow Weaver defended passionately. "I'm the necessary Dark Princess. My purpose is to act so they don't sully their conscience."

Angella's face remained blank. "Don't martyr yourself for your anger issues."

"I broke that woman's arm today because she alerted our position to the Horde and placed everyone in danger," Shadow Weaver said. "And for nearly spitting on us."

Angella clutched her mouth in disgust. "How barbaric."

"Quite," Shadow Weaver agreed.

"Despite your unconventional methods, today was a great success," Angella said. "Next time don't stray off course."

Chapter End Notes

I kind of agonized over this chapter and decided it was time to post before I changed it too much. ^_^ Hope you enjoyed!

Edit: Big thank you to everyone that takes the time to review or drop me a kudos!!

Until next time.

No Light, No Light in Your Bright Blue Eyes

Chapter Summary

Schemes, spells, and hiStory happen here ;)

Chapter Notes

Archive: Don’t copy to another site without permission

Spoilers: I’m picking and choosing what canon plotlines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, “Light Spinner” will be pretty spoilery.

Disclaimer: She-Ra and the Princesses of Power belong to DreamWorks and the wonderful Noelle Stevenson. Any and all other brand names that might appear here belong to their respective owners. I do not make any money on this story. Please don’t sue; you only stand to gain an extremely mismanaged pile of finances for your efforts.

Author’s Note: This is inspired by fan art, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine’s song “No Light, No Light” along with Five Finger Death Punch’s “Wrong Side of Heaven.” My brain couldn’t leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Welcome readers! I’m still shocked at the number of people joining my completely indulgent romp through a kinda sliding doors alternate universe. Let’s get to it!

After all the team bonding that happened with the other Princesses, Shadow Weaver could not help feeling like she was slowly being edged back out to the fringe of the group. It was extremely subtle at first and it took her a disconcerting amount of time before she recognized what was happening. The Horde was embarrassing the Rebellion at every turn. They were being thwarted with the knowledge that could only come from directly inside the Rebellion or from someone that suddenly had been bestowed the gift of foresight. The worst part was the Rebellion's realization that each major loss stemmed from a plan developed by the newest Princess, Shadow Weaver. No one had outright excluded her from attending Princess Alliance meetings, but she was often regarded with thinly veiled suspicion and mistrust.

Shadow Weaver felt like she was trying to navigate a field of traps with a blindfold and the sentiment didn't lessen at the Alliance meeting later that day. As she walked into the room, all the lively conversations ceased and most of the other Princesses avoided her eyes.

"Shadow Weaver, it's good to see you." Perfuma pulled out the chair next to her with a blinding smile, deciding to step forward as Shadow Weaver's ally.

"Uh, am I too late for the meeting?" Flutterina asked with wide, innocent eyes, walking behind Shadow Weaver.

"This meeting is for Princesses only," Shadow Weaver said, blocking the doorway. She wished very much to close the door in Flutterina's face. Flutterina had been scurrying underfoot as soon as she arrived. She claimed to idolize She-Ra and the other Princesses of the Rebellion. Her reverent proclamations always rang hollow to Shadow Weaver's ears. Flutterina was hiding something and if Shadow Weaver had a fortune to leverage, she would risk it all to uncover the elf's secret.

"I know you're still upset about our recent losses. That's no reason to take it out on Flutterina," Angella said with a raised eyebrow. "Let her pass."

Shadow Weaver observed the looks being cast her way. She remained silent and stepped aside.

“Oh, wow I get to be an honorary Princess.” Flutterina skipped inside the room, humming happily as she brushed past Shadow Weaver.

Once everyone was seated, Adora started the meeting. “So, everyone knows we retrieved Mara’s ship thanks to the assistance of Bow, Huntara, Perfuma, and Shadow Weaver in the Crimson Waste a few weeks ago, but it’s still too badly damaged to understand the message from Mara about a First One’s weapon.”

“All we do know is the Horde has been collecting way more First Ones’ technology than before. Every site we've been able to find intact has been missing vital communication components,” Bow reported, looking up from his tracker pad. “I’m doing everything I can to restore Mara’s ship.”

“Thanks, Bow.” Adora nodded. “General?”

“We’ve received our third report this week of Horde transports located deep in the Whispering Woods,” Juliet pointed to a marker on the holographic war table. “They are avoiding most of our surveillance teams. From their pattern, we determined they are transporting a lot of cargo to some unknown location.”

“We need to stop the next transport and figure out what they are up to.” Shadow Weaver suggested.

“The last time we followed one of your plans, we barely made it out,” Mermista said, drumming her black fingernails along the table.

“I’m sure Shadow Weaver is trying her best,” Flutterina chirped. “She’s not willingly leading you into ambushes.” She swung her legs cheerfully.

Shadow Weaver glared. “I’m certainly not.”

Adora cleared her throat awkwardly and pressed a button on the table. The image changed to a different map. “Some of the mountain colonies are reporting Horde’s presence nearby, so we’re gonna go clear the trade routes for them.”

Shadow Weaver waved her hand over the War Table. “If we are traveling to the mountain colonies then we can easily capture one of the Horde’s bases. It will contain information on their current projects as well as any possible plans they hope to complete in the future. With this victory, we can regain our advantage and keep the Horde from progressing further.”

“We’ll get to it if we can. Reopening the trade routes and any needed rescues are the primary goals.” Adora pointed across the three-dimensional image. “I think Bow, Glimmer, and Frosta should take the mountain pass while I, Perfuma, Mermista, and Shadow Weaver take the basin with the farm.”

“This sounds like a wonderful plan.” Angella nodded, looking around the table. “Are there any objections?”

“None here.” Bow shook his head.

“Let’s go!” Frosta said, vaulting over the table.

Shadow Weaver stayed behind as the Princesses filed out of the room. She was not willing to deal with the furtive glances any longer. She watched as Flutterina pulled Adora aside and decided not to leave the room just yet. It was astounding how often people forgot how keen her sense of hearing was.

“Hey, Adora,” Flutterina whispered to the blonde. “Do you think we should even trust Shadow Weaver’s information? Mermista had a pretty good point back there and Shadow Weaver did use to be your enemy.”

“Shadow Weaver is a Princess. She’s been trying her best to help the Rebellion,” Adora replied.

“If you’re concerned about my loyalty, perhaps you should stay here.” Shadow Weaver spun to face Flutterina. She enjoyed the guilty jump of both girls when they realized she was still in the room.

“I can help. I face Horde soldiers and bots the same as you,” Flutterina protested.

Shadow Weaver stared at the girl intently. “So, I’ve heard. I’m curious as to how you have learned such skills?”

“I had to find some way to survive after the war took my family.” Flutterina looked down. “But I’ll never be a hero like She-Ra or the other Princesses,” she said softly as her lip trembled.

Adora kneeled beside the younger girl, looking into her eyes. “Flutterina, the war with the Horde has cost all of Etheria so much. The fact that you’re here trying to prevent other families from experiencing the same loss makes you an even bigger hero than any of the Princesses combined.”

“Thanks, Adora,” Flutterina said, throwing her arms around Adora in a hug.

“Why don’t you find the chefs and tell them to ready an ice cream party for when we get back?” Adora suggested.

Barely two steps into the basin Adora, Perfuma, Mermista, and Shadow Weaver were under fire by a line of horde tanks.

“This path was supposed to have a few Horde soldiers and two tanks. Where did all this come from?” Adora asked as they ran behind the closest farmhouse.

Adora held the Sword of Protection high in the air. “For the honor of Graysku-.” A bot shuffled around the corner and shot the sword out of her hand. “Whoops, I got it,” she said and rolled out the way of the next shot.

“Who did the reconnaissance?” Shadow Weaver used her powers to hurl the closest bots stalking toward them away.

“For the honor of Grayskull.” She-Ra leaned around the corner and batted a blast back to the cannon. “The General got a report directly from the farmers that live here.”

“No one’s been here to care for this land in a while,” Perfuma said, eyeing the dried and brittle tomatoes plants.

The group ducked simultaneously as one of the plasma blasts tore through the house, leaving a smoldering wall too close for comfort.

“We cannot sit stationary for much longer,” Shadow Weaver said.

“I’ll draw the cannon fire away while you guys destroy as many of them as you can.” She-Ra bounded through the wrecked house. She shot light from her sword to the cannons and waited for them to shoot back. The cannons moved aside and two boss bots moved forward with charged lasers.

“Adora!” Shadow Weaver called out. She spread her arms and peeled the metal away from the nearby cannon, encasing the first boss bot in a constricting shell. The attack from the first boss bot took out itself and the now weakened cannon. The second bot finished charging its EMP attack that sent them all sprawled across the ground.

Mermista recovered first and raised herself on a cyclone of water, sweeping up the cannons and bots she threw them across the basin.

Perfuma flattened them all under plants as the machinery landed. “We have to retreat.”

“We need to get to the mountain pass immediately. The others may be dealing with a worse force,” She-Ra said.

“Mermista, Perfuma! Where are you guys?” Frosta asked, sliding along an ice bridge.

“Frosta, over here,” She-Ra called out.

“What happened?” Glimmer asked after she teleported in with Bow.

Mermista released the wave she was surfing across. “The Horde was waiting for us.”

“Same here. They overwhelmed us. We barely made it out,” Bow explained.

“How’d we lose this time?” Perfuma asked, looking at the destruction.

“We’ll do better next time guys. At least we got out with everyone,” She-Ra said, leaning on her sword.

Bow’s tracker pad chimed and he quickly answered it. “Hello?”

“She-Ra, come in.”

“What is it, General?” She-Ra came to stand next to Bow.

“We just got word that there is a new weapon being relocated less than one hundred yards from your location,” Juliet said, typing on the screen. “I’m sending you the last signal ping.”

“That’s really close to us, Adora,” Glimmer looked at the coordinates. “We could capture the new weapon.”

Bow scratched his chin. “It’s too close. How did they plan an ambush and get around us in that amount of time?”

“If we are going to interrupt that transport we need to get there in a hurry.” Shadow Weaver glanced toward the mountain range

surrounding them.

“Fine,” Mermista said, blowing a few strands of hair from her face. “But how are we going to get there? Glimmer can’t teleport us all there and back us up.”

Spinnerella and Netossa arrived and in a funnel cloud. “We heard you guys could use some help,” Netossa said.

“Everyone be careful. The new weapon in this truck is sure to be powerful,” She-Ra warned as they ducked behind the nearby trees.

Spinnerella stood quickly and capsized the truck with a small funnel cloud as soon as it passed in front of their cover. She-Ra hopped on the truck and threw the driver from the vehicle before it stopped sliding across the ground. As the Horde soldier tried to scramble to his feet, he was trussed up by Perfuma. Shadow Weaver tore the doors off the back of the truck.

“Knowing Entrapta this new weapon is going to be big, scary, and deadly.” Bow walked forward to see an empty truck. “Or it’s invisible. Genius,” he gasped.

She-Ra walked inside, swung her sword in the air, and shrugged.

“Or it could be empty.” Bow amended.

“I don’t understand.” Adora frowned with a shake of her head.

Clanking and whirring echoed from the forest. Dozens of bots surrounded them.

“Another trap,” Netossa said, backing up.

“Shadow Weaver, take out as many as you can. Everyone else, cover her and fan out.” She-Ra ordered as she sliced the first bot in half.

“We could try one of my new spells.” Glimmer drew a complicated rune in the air. A cloud of pink sparkles flew forward, wiping out half of the closest bots. It left behind a smoldering patch of singed trees.

“That’s too much force, Glimmer. Turn down the magic.” She-Ra shook her head, punching a bot far across the field. “Shadow Weaver is the most effective against the Horde weapons. Just focus on keeping the bots further away while we fight them.”

“The point of my magic lessons is so I can be just as effective. I can help if you just let me.” Glimmer encased a handful of bots in a shimmering pink cloud of magic. She smashed them on top of the next round of bots creeping from the forest.

“Glimmer, you can’t just unveil untested spells in the middle of a battle,” Bow shot two arrows over his shoulder.

“Shadow Weaver thinks my power is impressive,” Glimmer said, sending another blast to the side.

She-Ra cut another bot in half. “Even Shadow Weaver would agree you have to practice before-”

“Shadow Weaver would like to remind you of the battle currently taking place,” The older woman said, swiping her hands across the air. She spun the new wave of bots so their lasers could target each other. Spinnerella used a gust of wind to push them away before they exploded.

“We need cover.” Netossa tied up a couple of bots and flung them back into the Whispering Woods where they landed with a crash.

Frosta sent continuous ice shards at her group of bots. “They just keep coming,” she said.

“Almost out of arrows!” Bow used his quiver to crack the lenses of an advancing bot. He spun, kicking another one before falling back.

Shadow Weaver placed her hands on the side of the truck and manipulated it into a large shield for the Princesses. She kept most of the bots at bay by sending shrapnel made from the remaining metal of the truck at the Horde bots. Once the final Princess was behind the shield, she groaned heavily, feeling the telltale signs of her elemental hold waning.

“I’ve got this,” Glimmer said, moving her hands to create a magical barrier.

“Glimmer.” She-Ra grabbed her by the collar and pulled her down, breaking Glimmer’s concentration as a bot’s laser soared past them.

Clenching her fists, Shadow Weaver stood again and walked calmly around the battered shield.

“Don’t do anything crazy.” Adora grabbed her arm.

“There is no choice. We can’t retreat with this many still active. Just fall back when I give the signal.” Shadow Weaver pulled the last reserve of magic from the shard on her belt and extended her senses as far as they would go. The bots lit up in her mind like targets on radar. She pushed both fists forward forcing all the metal in her reach to vibrate in place. The bots beeped rapidly and mercifully stopped moving. The shockwave from the multiple explosive blasts threw her backward. She slid across the grass and banged her head against the mutilated truck’s rear axle.

“Is everyone okay? The reports didn’t sound good.” Angella ducked into the tent with the General.

“There was another ambush,” Shadow Weaver said groggily, prodding the bandage across her the back of her head with a wince.

“So, uh, Shadow Weaver, just a quick note for the next time. Flying through the air is not a signal,” Mermista said.

“We’re fine,” Bow said just as his trick arrow exploded and covered him with sticky, green sap. “Okay, we could stand to be a little better.” he wiped his face, smearing more of the mess.

“The Horde is always two steps ahead. There has to be some explanation for these setbacks.” Glimmer pondered aloud.

Flutterina rushed through the curtain and clutched her cheeks. “Oh golly! Are you guys okay?”

“Hey, Flutterina. We’ll be fine after some rest.” Adora put the goo covered pillow down with a tired smile. “This won’t defeat us.”

“That’s right because you’re the Rebellion! Who cares if you received incorrect information about a Horde base?” Flutterina asked.

Shadow Weaver peered at the pink-haired girl through squinted eyes. “What are you suggesting, Flutterina?”

“It’s just that,” Flutterina said, then looked away, worrying her bottom lip. “No, forget it. It’s not my place.”

“You’re correct, it is not your place,” Shadow Weaver snapped.

Glimmer glared at Shadow Weaver and walked to the young girl. “What is it Flutterina?” She asked gently.

Flutterina looked at Shadow Weaver with fearful eyes. “Nothing, nothing. I shouldn’t say.”

Swift Wind sliced open the tent with his horn and pranced in. “Good news, I double backed and followed a Horde convoy and

the trucks were definitely coming from a mountain range south of Bright Moon."

"Then that's where the new base will most likely be located." Adora nodded as she stood. "Your majesty, with your permission I'd like to go back out and find the base and any new weapons the Horde might have created."

"I'd hate to send you all back out to be hurt." Angella looked at Bow and the weary Princesses.

"Your majesty, I believe we would be successful with a smaller party. That way the Princesses could get in and out before the Horde knows you're there," Juliet said.

"Well, I know I'm in." Netossa flexed her bicep.

"Darling, your arm." Spinnerella pointed to the bandage.

"Nuh-uh." Netossa shook her head. "I'm not gonna let you win this one. I got more bots than you."

"There's no prize on the line," Spinnerella said with an annoyed sigh.

Adora walked to Swift Wind. "Can we take this back to the war table? We have a new plan to discuss."

Flutterina, Bow, and the Princesses trailed behind Adora out of the tent.

"Shadow Weaver, I need to speak to you for a moment," Angella said as the former sorcerer was about to pass her. "Give us a moment." The queen nodded to Juliet. She stood in front of the tent's ruined entrance. "How are you?"

"I'm fine," Shadow Weaver said testily.

"You're not fine," Angella responded. "In case you haven't noticed, your head is bandaged. The reports said you blew yourself up.

You nearly put everyone in danger with that stunt. What were you thinking?”

“I was thinking about covering our exit so that we may retreat. I was also thinking She-Ra could heal me as before,” Shadow Weaver said, shifting to leave.

Angella's eyes hardened and she didn’t move from her position. “I don’t think you should accompany the Princesses in the next plan.” She informed Shadow Weaver.

“Is that an order?” Shadow Weaver challenged.

“If it comes to that,” Angella said curtly.

“Angella, what is going on?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“A suggestion was made that you might be the cause of the ambushes.”

“You are saying I was accused of being a spy,” Shadow Weaver growled. “By whom?” she asked. She already had her suspicions. There was unfortunately nothing she could prove at the moment.

Angella ignored the question. “I have to treat this allegation seriously. You will not be returning to the field effective immediately. You will also have guards accompanying you until such time as the claims have been proven to be true or false and we will decide what to do with you.”

“Why did you acknowledge me as a Princess if I’m no different than a prisoner conscripted to battle for you?” Shadow Weaver spat. One of Bow’s discarded broken metal arrow pieces shot across the tent. She snatched it from the air and took a calming breath. “Have I not proven myself?”

“It could have been a plot to lull us into trusting you,” Angella said icily. She gestured behind her. “These guards will escort you back to the palace.”

“I am not the villain here, Angella. I am not spying on the Rebellion. You don’t believe these accusations, do you?” Shadow Weaver pleaded and peered deeply into the other woman’s eyes.

Angella’s gaze faltered. “Your queen has spoken,” she said and left the tent.

“Angella.” Shadow Weaver stepped forward and two Bright Moon spears slammed down, halting her movements. She spread her arms, pushing the guard’s spears away. “Angella, wait.”

Juliet faced Shadow Weaver, resting her hand on the hilt of her sword. “The queen has made her decision.”

“I’m not talking to you, General,” Shadow Weaver said. Muttering from the rebel factions and Bright Moon villagers started around her. She knew she was making a spectacle of herself and she didn’t care at this moment. She was putting forth actual effort with the Rebellion and to be accused of being a spy was completely unfounded. She didn’t fault Angella for doing what needed to be done, but she should still be allowed to make a defense for herself.

The guards caught up with Shadow Weaver and grabbed both of her arms. While she could easily break their hold again, it wouldn’t help her case. She watched Angella continue to walk away from her. An ache reminiscent of the night at Mystacor’s arch throbbed in her chest.

The guards escorted Shadow Weaver swiftly to her room and shut the door. Her renewed captivity was not like when she first arrived in Bright Moon. There was no trace of magic or a containment spell to greet her. She supposed it would be similar to staying in an inn she could never voluntarily leave for the foreseeable future.

Slinky unfurled his body and moved carefully across the room to Shadow Weaver's side. Shadow Weaver gave him a gentle scratch under his chin.

"Any visitors in my absence?" Shadow Weaver asked the Elemental. Slinky tossed his head in the negative. "Very good." she praised. Frantic steps echoed down the hallway. She opened her door just as Juliet passed by. "General, what is going on?" She asked.

"It's none of your concern, Shadow Weaver." Juliet sneered, continuing down the hall. The General nodded to the guards and the door was slammed shut.

Shadow Weaver knew the Rebellion didn't trust her. She had expected it in the beginning. If she was in their position she would have been apprehensive as well as she'd only recently defected from the Horde. On the surface, it seemed like she had the most to gain from the Horde's recent victories. No one seemed to take into account that she had no means or time to communicate to the Horde between their increased rescue missions and supply runs. All that was being accomplished by their suspicions was keeping her from assisting the Rebellion toward victory. The Dark Princess hated being sidelined.

“Shadow Weaver, there you are.” Glimmer appeared in her room.

Shadow Weaver turned around slowly. “What has happened?”

“Bow. He was hurt really badly,” Glimmer whispered. “The Horde’s new weapon is deadly. She-Ra healed him, but he still needs time to recover.” She explained, frowning at Shadow Weaver. “Why weren’t you in the greenhouse?”

“Nevermind that.” Shadow Weaver griped. “What are you planning?”

“You said Catra betrayed you, right? That means she’s in your old position. All we need to do to defeat the Horde is to think like her. You know everything about her. How is she staying two steps ahead?” Glimmer asked.

“Take us to my greenhouse,” Shadow Weaver said, placing a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “The best solution is the simplest one. You don’t need to think as Catra does.” she continued as they landed.

Shadow Weaver walked to her Font of Focus at the center of the greenhouse and crushed flowers growing along the side between her hands. She dropped the petals into the water, watching as its surface became a dark, blank pool of potential. After she poured the crushed Lunar Lenses into Glimmer’s hand, she waited for her

apprentice to imbue it with her magic. It took only a few moments for the lenses to glow brightly. Glimmer glanced at Shadow Weaver. At the brunette's nod, Glimmer let the dust fall into the Font of Focus.

"Show me what you remember about location spells," Shadow Weaver said sedately.

"Focus and remember what I'm searching for," Glimmer said, swirling her index finger over the surface. The glyph formed across the water, gleaming brightly. The water rippled and showed them a Horde base in the Whispering Woods. "A secret base." She gasped as the images changed to multiple angles across the base of operations. "That's how the Horde is always two steps ahead."

"Hold the connection." Shadow Weaver leaned forward and squinted when she saw a flash of familiar pink on Catra's tracker pad screen. The image wobbled out of focus and returned to its neutral liquid state.

"What did you see?" Glimmer asked.

"Nothing useful as of yet," Shadow Weaver responded.

"What are we going to do?" Glimmer glanced at Shadow Weaver. "Adora is walking into another ambush. If the Horde is tracking She-Ra this may be our only chance to stop Catra."

“Who said the Horde was tracking She-Ra?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“The General suggested it.”

“Interesting,” Shadow Weaver said. Unless someone else joined the Horde with sorcery knowledge or skills it was highly unlikely the Horde could be tracking She-Ra. She nearly had the full picture of what was happening around them. There was certainly a spy in Bright Moon helping Catra launch ambushes and capture territory. Adora’s newly devised plan was already being executed and as far as the spy knew everyone was in the dark about the Horde’s new base. She and Glimmer had an opportunity to stop more losses and destroy the Horde’s latest weaponry.

Shadow Weaver turned to Glimmer. “I need you to retrieve my Runestone shard.”

Glimmer and Shadow Weaver arrived in the bushes just outside the Horde base. Glimmer immediately sent two light flashes, knocking out the duo of soldiers standing idly by the door. A third ran forth and was quickly taken out by another blast before they got too close.

“Catra must still be inside,” Glimmer said to Shadow Weaver with a determined frown.

“Distract Catra. I’ll destroy the Horde weapons,” Shadow Weaver said. She walked forward, brushing away the shaggy moss curtain of the entrance while Glimmer rushed forward. The cavernous Horde base was filled with transport vehicles and tall shipping containers. Catra was just ahead talking with two Horde soldiers.

“What are you doing here?” Catra asked in confusion.

“Defeating you!” Glimmer shouted, sending a concentrated stream of light at Catra.

“Oh, it’s you.” Catra dodged out of the way.

“Who else would I be?” Glimmer asked. She shot her hands to the floor, chasing Catra around the base with her magic.

The soldier beside Catra barely had a chance to gasp before he was knocked out by the magic attack. The other soldier ran away but was quickly cuffed to the wall by Shadow Weaver. She held up a finger, shushing the soldier. She concentrated and used the transport vehicles as pendulums to crush the shipping containers on the other side of the Horde base.

An explosion from the fuel tanks behind her sparked a hungry inferno that soon consumed the support structures around the base. Shadow Weaver saw Catra running to the control panel. The teen hit a button to reveal the newest bot design. It burrowed into Horde's floor with a large drill and remained still.

"You have to decide, Sparkles. Do you wanna defeat me or take out the bot?" Catra taunted, running to the exit.

"You can handle Catra," Glimmer said to Shadow Weaver. "I'm gonna take the pulse bot out of here." she teleported the bot just as it released a high pitched ascending tone. The pulse exploded across the sky high above the Whispering Woods, sending a faint resonance through the atmosphere.

A flaming crossbeam fell from the ceiling hurtling towards Catra. Catra put her hands over her head and dived forward, trying to avoid the collision of the bar. Shadow Weaver moved her arm, halting its movement.

Catra opened her eyes and stared at Shadow Weaver in suspicion. "You saved me? What are you up to?"

"I can still release it if you wish." Shadow Weaver reminded her, letting the metal rapidly drop a few inches and paused it again just before it reached Catra.

Catra rolled out of the way with a snarl. “I owe you for your prison break.”

“As I recall you begged me to figure out a way for me to stay around.” Shadow Weaver floated the metal clear of Catra. She spread her arms casually. “You’re welcome.”

“Don’t try and tell me you did this for me. You left me and went running to Adora.” Catra slashed her hand through the air. “It's obvious she’s your favorite. You’ve never done anything for me.”

“Octavia,” Shadow Weaver said slowly.

“What about Force Captain Dumb Face?” Catra asked.

“Attempting to break your nose were not her only plans for you.” Shadow Weaver batted another flaming metal structure to the other side of the base. “I convinced her to rethink her priorities.”

Catra scoffed. “So? You saved me once out of the thousands of times you hurt me. I could have handled her,” she growled, elongating her claws. “I don’t need your help. I’ve never needed your help.”

“Yes, you were clearly just about to avoid being flattened of your own accord,” Shadow Weaver said sarcastically.

“Why are you just standing here? We need to go before everything collapses.” Glimmer coughed, waving her hands after she returned. “Where’s Catra?”

Unsurprisingly, Catra was already outside. Shadow Weaver watched as the teen disappeared into the trees before Glimmer looked in the direction of Catra's departure.

“She escaped,” Shadow Weaver said dully. She felt the tingle of teleportation along her skin and shrugged off Glimmer’s hold. “Go assist Adora.”

“What about you?” Glimmer asked in surprise.

“I will return to Bright Moon,” Shadow Weaver replied and turned away. She glanced over her shoulder. “Glimmer, there is no shame in restraint.”

“Ugh, you sound like Adora. We defeated the Horde today. I can handle it,” Glimmer said and disappeared.

Shadow Weaver turned on her heel and walked briskly from the Horde base as the interior was engulfed in flames. Her eyes drifted back to the path Catra took. She rubbed her thumb over the small semi-circle of scar tissue on her right wrist. It was one of the few scars on her body that wasn’t the result of the Spell of

Obtainment. How interesting that Catra bit the exact spot Adora gripped as a baby. That attack set the tone for their future interactions. She wanted to dispose of Catra that very moment and she would have were it not for Adora stumbling over on her tiny legs to peer into the filthy box someone left outside her door. Catra and Adora were devoted to each other ever since that moment.

Her musing was disrupted by the scent of smelted iron and rubber. It invaded the air on the tails of the blistering heat. The smoke burned Shadow Weaver's nostrils and made her eyes itch. She forced a support beam to bang against the top of the cave, causing a rock slide. The boulders landed at the entrance, stifling the fire. Thick plumes of smoke billowed around every spare crevice, swirling into the sky.

She retreated into the Whispering Woods and called to Slinky from their link. It would be best if she returned to the castle as soon as possible. Being missing from her room during this latest conflict would not make the Rebellion confident in her loyalties.

It always baffled people that Shadow Weaver enjoyed gardening. She was composed and secretive so they could never fathom her wanting to get on her hands and knees, toiling through the dirt. It certainly surprised Angella after her impassioned abhorrence for the beach and all things sandy. As far as Shadow Weaver was concerned, gardening was a more fulfilling activity than languishing along the coastline.

Shadow Weaver had always appreciated the art of horticulture and personal gardening. Quite simply gardening allowed her a

chance to connect to a powerful life cycle. It gave her a chance to grow nourishment or medicine. It converted a plot of land into a vibrant landscape that accepted her efforts and never judged.

Humming a wordless song, Shadow Weaver stepped carefully through the Whispering Woods. The day was overcast and more dreary than usual. The air around Shadow Weaver was still but not fresh and calm like an upcoming rainstorm. She hurried along to finish her task and return to Bright Moon before she was missed.

Beside a young tree, she spotted four plants about waist high. The flowers formed loose pale purple and white, pyramid-shaped spikes. She slipped on her gardening gloves and readied her shears. With a practiced hand, the plant clippings were added to the growing cache she kept tightly sealed in a jar. She placed the jar, gloves, and shears in a canvas bag on her hip and stood.

"And just what do you think you're doing?" Angella asked as she landed beside Shadow Weaver.

"Your majesty," Shadow Weaver greeted conversationally. "What brings you to the Whispering Woods on this fine day?"

"Don't play coy. What are you doing outside of Bright Moon without your guards?" Angella demanded.

"You mean the three women completely inept of stealth? I left them behind."

"It's your guard detail. You don't get to leave them behind," Angella said with a glare.

"I came to the Whispering Woods to collect Dictamnus and poison sumac, neither of those plants you would have access to in Bright Moon." Shadow Weaver turned and saw something that struck her as odd. A little dot of what looked like a couple of flecks of pollen floating down like snowflakes. It rapidly became a cluster that covered the ground and discolored the grass with a sizzle.

A spore landed on the top ridge of Angella's left wing and she cried out. The spore was quickly burning away a layer of feathers. Shadow Weaver immediately pulled Angella under the cover of a nearby tree. The leaves above them quickly disintegrated as the pods made contact.

"It's a spore storm. We need to find shelter," Shadow Weaver said, flattening her gauntlet into a makeshift covering as they hurried through the Whispering Woods. She heard the metal burning away just seconds before spores scorch themselves down her forearm.

They arrived at a small hut built directly into a low, sloping hill. Several overlapping tree roots and branches made up its outside wall.

"What is this place?" Angella looked at the broom propped next to the door. "Who would be living in the Whispering Woods?"

"I don't know, but we have to get inside. Let us see if they are feeling welcoming." Shadow Weaver grunted as another spore burned through her clothing and singed her hand. She drew them closer to the dwelling, feeling the comforting buzz of a magical blockade brushing against her skin. "We should be safe here," she declared, dropping the charred steel to the ground.

"Someone must be home." Angella nodded to the smoke pouring out of the small chimney on the hut's roof.

"Indeed." Shadow Weaver agreed and glanced around her. The spores were falling rapidly now and made an unnatural pattern around the barrier. She brushed away the large taro leaves that shielded the dingy cloth door.

A strange, short woman with a mop of gray hair threw back the curtain door. "Hello, dearies! Come in, come in. You're just in time to help Madame Razz prepare supper," she said with a near toothless grin.

"You were expecting us?" Angella asked in surprise.

“Of course, Angella.” Madame Razz looked from the queen to Shadow Weaver. “Oh, little Bea it’s so nice to see you again. It has been a while since I’ve spoken to the Under People, but I know they still like their hand pies,” she said, ushering the women inside. “Now where has he gone to now?” She muttered to herself as moths fluttered around her head. “Broom! Where are you?” she called.

“My name is Shadow Weaver and your broom is just outside the door,” the Princess informed the woman.

“Ah, lazy Broom,” Madame Razz flapped a hand in the air. The broom came through the curtain and into her grip.

“She has magic.” Angella gasped.

“Of course, Madame Razz has magic. Magic is everywhere,” The older woman said, pulling an area rug off a low stone bench. “Come, come. You can rest here.”

Shadow Weaver gently propped Angella against her shoulder on the inside wall of the surprisingly roomy cabin. The queen’s face was twisted in pain as she fought to stay upright. Shadow Weaver reached into the canvas bag, looking for one of the healing potions she brewed.

“I have just the thing,” Madame Razz said and shuffled around the room, dumping random ingredients into a cracked pottery bowl. The last thing she grabbed was a large metal mixing spoon. Her hands moved with purpose, beating the mixture into a paste. “Here you are, little Bea. This will make your love all better.” She sat the bowl on the table near Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver’s eyes widened at the word ‘love.’ “We’re not-”

“We haven’t-” Angella began then hissed in pain.

Shadow Weaver was conflicted. She detected ancient magic from Madame Razz and though something about the crone made her want to trust her, she wouldn’t risk harming Angella. She stared at

the paste warily before dipping a finger into the bowl. She applied a little to the burn on the back of her hand. An icy, itching sensation spread across the injury, leaving behind unblemished skin.

“Turn around so I can apply this,” Shadow Weaver said to Angella.

“What is it?” Angella asked, breathing sharply through her nose.

“It is a very powerful healing poultice.” Shadow Weaver held the bowl up.

“Just give it to me,” Angella said as her wings fluttered in irritation, causing her to flinch. “I can do it.”

“It is far more likely you will injure yourself further trying that,” Shadow Weaver said soothingly. “We can’t let these burns fester. I'll be as gentle as possible.”

“Fine. Be quick about it.” Angella conceded and slowly extended her wing.

Shadow Weaver took her time applying the poultice to the reddened patches interspersed across the downy, translucent wings. She watched in relief as Angella’s wings and brow relaxed. "How does that feel?"

"Infinitely better," Angella said with a relieved smile.

“Come along, food will help both of you heal and we have much to do.” Madame Razz appeared at Shadow Weaver’s side. She pulled the taller woman to a pit where hot coals glowed sedately. She handed Shadow Weaver a knife and small container of mushrooms, a bundle of spinach, and some wild onions. “We need this and this. Chop, chop.” The crone threw an apron over Shadow Weaver’s head that looked to be a patchwork of oven mitts sewn together.

Shadow Weaver decided it would be easier to monitor what goes into their food if she was the one preparing the meal. She put on the apron and diced the vegetables in front of her. Despite Madame Razz's eccentric way of storing her food items, there were soon hand pies crimped and ready to be baked.

Shadow Weaver returned to Angella and removed the apron. "Now, why have you braved the Whispering Woods looking for me? Surely, it wasn't only because I abandoned the guards?"

Angella's previous irritation returned. "Using Adora, Spinnerella, and Netossa as bait was not part of our plan to unearth the Horde spy."

"I didn't see another option. The timing was crucial and we could not allow the spy to give Catra any new information," Shadow Weaver said, inspecting her arm for any serious burns.

"Have you gotten any closer to identifying the spy?" Angella asked.

"Someone is working very hard with Catra to keep us at each other's throats and the Horde several steps ahead." Shadow Weaver waved her hand calmly. "Do you not consider it strange that a lone Elberon villager was able to save Adora, Swift Wind, Glimmer, and Bow from a Horde ambush?"

"Flutterina is a very brave girl." Angella squinted suspiciously. "Are you suggesting she is a spy?"

"Angella, who is more likely to lower the guard of the Princess Alliance? Mean, old Shadow Weaver or a cutesy little forest elf?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"You may have a point," Angella admitted. "What if you're wrong?"

"I doubt I am wrong. There are too many coincidences surrounding Flutterina's arrival. Our plans only started failing in the missions after we retrieved Mara's ship." Shadow Weaver

pointed out. “If I am incorrect then you have my permission to find that eternal pit.”

“I don’t like all this subterfuge.” Angella tugged at the frayed edges of her ruined gloves.

“I know you don’t.” Shadow Weaver tapped her fingers on the stone table. “This is the best way, Angella. Flutterina or whoever they are has been targeting all of our insecurities. She is trying to sow dissent and chaos into the Rebellion and this is the only way to stop her.”

“How can you be so sure that’s what she is doing?” Angella asked.

Shadow Weaver slowly slid her hands into her lap. “It is what I would have done.”

They fell into an uneasy silence. The only outside noise was from the buzz of magic protecting the hut.

“I know this was only the second time you’ve encountered Catra since the Fright Zone invasion. What happened?” Angella asked softly.

“I didn’t harm Catra if that is what you’re asking,” Shadow Weaver said defensively. “I let Glimmer take the lead in battle. When the building began to burn, Catra was nearly trapped under and I stopped it.”

Angella looked down. “And that’s all?”

Shadow Weaver placed a hand flat on the table in front of her. “We exchanged words and she fled. That is all,” she confirmed.

The interaction had gone better than she expected. She and Catra hadn’t fought and their verbal altercation was barely worth mentioning. For once she had no desire to retaliate for her impudence. Angella and the Rebellion expected her to do what was right as a Princess. She was content to know that she could

do so without oversight and even despite being outwardly seen as the spy.

There was a snort in the air, causing Shadow Weaver to glance over at their hostess. She saw that Madame Razz was leaning against her broom in a deep slumber. Suddenly, the crone snapped her fingers, and the flames behind her were snuffed out. She quickly used a spatula to move the hand pies onto a plate and brought them over to Shadow Weaver and Angella.

"They smell incredible. Thank you, Madame Razz," Angella said with a smile.

"You're welcome, dearie." Madame Razz looked expectantly at Shadow Weaver and cleared her throat.

Shadow Weaver looked at the older woman in confusion.

"Hats off at the table." Madame Razz smacked Shadow Weaver with her broom.

"I'm not wearing a hat." Shadow Weaver glared at Angella who was giggling at the scene.

"Oh yes, Madame Razz sees now." She adjusted her glasses and squinted. "You did not mean to call to the darkness in the beginning did you, Little Bea? You only wished to fight it."

Shadow Weaver pressed her mask harder against her face. "I am not removing my mask."

"I already see you, dearie. You have your father's eyes," Madame Razz replied as she moved suddenly to the back of the cabin, digging through an assortment of mismatched boots. "I'll fetch drinks before Loo-Kee takes them all."

Angella squeezed her hand softly. "Shadow Weaver, you should eat. We don't know how long the storm may last." Her fingers on her other hand trailed along the edge of the mask.

“Don’t.” Shadow Weaver’s hands stopped her movement with a firm grip. “The Spell of Obtainment left its mark in exchange for my power,” she said.

“I know,” Angella said quietly.

“I don’t want you to see me like this. Even my eyes are not the same.” Shadow Weaver warned. She felt Angella start to pull away the mask then stop.

“I know,” Angella repeated. “The time I had my mother confirm your identity was not the only time I looked in on you,” she revealed, removing her hand from Shadow Weaver’s mask.

“You saw them?” Shadow Weaver exhaled faintly.

Angella inclined her head. “I am not afraid,” she said, pushing the plate closer to Shadow Weaver. “Try and have something to eat.”

“Listen to your Angella, Little Bea. She’ll show you what’s what.” Madame Razz came back and left two bottles of chilled fruit juice on the table.

“Eat.” Angella insisted.

Shadow Weaver’s hunger outweighed her discomfort and she finally broke away a small piece from a hand pie. She titled the mask away from her face just enough to slip the bite in her mouth. It was only after the flaky crust and tasty filling washed across her tongue that she realized just how hungry she truly was. She pinched away a few more bites of the pie and focused solely on her food instead of the light illuminating the dwelling. Every time she moved her mask, she felt like there were thousands of glances on her movements.

“My name is Shadow Weaver. Why do you insist on calling me, Little Bea?” Shadow Weaver asked Madame Razz once she’d finished her meal.

“Madame Razz knows who you are. Oh, goodness me. You don’t know your history? You’ve connected with your magic, but no understanding of why you wield it.” Madame Razz tutted with a shake of her head. “Just like Mara.”

“You knew Mara?” Angella asked.

“She was just like Little Bea. Powerful but lost. A lot like Adora.” Madame Razz peered at Shadow Weaver. “I can see you within her.”

“In which do you see me?” Shadow Weaver asked with a tilt of her head.

Madame Razz slapped Shadow Weaver with her broom. “Bah, pay attention.” She walked away, sweeping the floor.

Angella laughed softly.

“I am glad you’re enjoying yourself at my expense,” Shadow Weaver remarked.

“We wouldn’t even be here if you’d stayed in Bright Moon.” Angella pointed out, brushing the crumbs from her gloves. “I don’t know why you needed more plants. You still have free reign of the greenhouse and the garden on the second floor.”

“Since I have copious amounts of free time during my artificial imprisonment and because you have also suspended Glimmer’s magic lessons. I’ve been honing my skill in potions.”

“What could you possibly need poison sumac for?” Angella asked.

“It’s an experimental combustible I am working on.” Shadow Weaver answered simply.

“Just be careful,” Angella said as she looked through the gap of the curtain. She no longer saw any falling spores. Some of the moons were becoming less visible in the sky and the moonlight was dimming, signifying the rapidly approaching night.

“It’s safe to go home now, dearies,” Madame Razz said, not so subtly pushing them towards the door. “Take care.” They heard her just inside fussing about solicitors bothering an old woman.

“How long do you think she’s been out here alone?” Angella asked, watching as the final spores along the grass disappeared into steam.

“If she knew Mara, it’s safe to say Madame Razz has been alive over a millennia.” Shadow Weaver glanced back at the hut. “I would love to decipher the knowledge that’s trapped in that scattered brain.”

“What are we going to do about Flutterina?” Angella asked, ducking under a tree branch.

“I’ll handle it tomorrow at the next Princess meeting.”

Angella looked concerned. “We should arrest her as soon as we get back to the castle. I don’t like leaving her free, knowing she is spying and reporting back to the Horde.”

“It would be best if we kept the element of surprise. We finally have the upper hand,” Shadow Weaver said.

“We all know how much you enjoy that,” Angella said dryly.

“Careful with that wit,” Shadow Weaver said, holding her hands up in mock surrender.

“If you successfully thwart the Horde spy, I’ll have your Runestone shard returned to you tomorrow evening.” Angella offered.

“Keep it as an emergency power source,” Shadow Weaver said. “However, with your permission, I’d like to finally look for the rest of my Runestone. I have talked to Bow and he said his fathers found it and Slinky on a research mission. I’d like to travel with them and see if I can find the entire Runestone. I will be no good to the Rebellion if I am still recharging once a week.”

“We'll revisit after we catch the spy,” Angella saw the Moonstone glowing through the last thicket of trees. They were almost back at Bright Moon. “Thank goodness.”

“Are you tiring of my presence already, your majesty?” Shadow Weaver teased.

“I actually had a nice time this evening. The dire situation notwithstanding,” Angella said, coming closer to Shadow Weaver. She grabbed her hand and pulled it close to her chest. “Thank you,” she whispered.

Shadow Weaver drew in a sharp breath at the unexpected touch. The smell of gardenias that always seemed to cling to Angella invaded Shadow Weaver’s senses. She didn’t know what she was being thanked for. Was it gratitude for revealing the real spy or making sure Angella was safe during the spore storm? She decided it didn't matter and focused on the warmth radiating from her right hand.

Angella slowly released Shadow Weaver’s hand and turned gracefully. “Try not to give the guards too much trouble when they discover you outside the castle.” She opened her healed wings and ascended into the sky on a path back to the palace.

“Your majesty, sorry to interrupt your meeting. Shadow Weaver has been adamant that she speaks to the Princess Alliance.”

Angella sat up straighter in her chair. “She is no longer allowed to interact with the Princess Alliance until we have proof that she is or is not the Horde spy.”

“Your majesty, she insisted and there is a matter of the Elemental,” The guard said apprehensively.

Angella peered at her guard. "If you cannot handle one former sorcerer-"

"No one needs to *handle* me," Shadow Weaver said, riding into the war room on Slinky's back. "I am not the Horde spy and I can prove it." It was clear the other Princesses would not believe that their new friend was a Horde spy unless they saw the evidence. She had Angella's support to reveal the spy and she would do it the best way she knew how.

Shadow Weaver's eyes met the elf's across the table. Flutterina let the saccharine façade slip and a split second flash of malice had shown through her gaze.

Those eyes.

Shadow Weaver remembered those eyes staring at her from a balcony in the Crimson Waste. They probably felt confident their conniving had sealed her fate. Whoever this person was wanted her to know it was them. They wanted her to feel like she had no options. Drastic action had to be taken.

Shadow Weaver pulled Flutterina's chair tight against the war table before anyone registered the movement. Flutterina was now trapped. No one expected her powers to be fully charged. The Dark Princess fashioned a metal cuff and used it to attach Flutterina to the chair by her neck.

"Help! She's going to kill me." Flutterina cried, trying to pull the collar away.

There was a brilliant glow in the air and Shadow Weaver knew that She-Ra would be standing before her soon.

"Let her go, Shadow Weaver," She-Ra said, towering over her.

Slinky started to growl threateningly and Shadow Weaver urged him to return to her room. Bow was aiming an arrow with no doubt deadly precision. All of the Princesses stood with their

elements at the ready and every guard in the room pointed their spears at her.

“I present to you, your spy.” Shadow Weaver declared. “Flutterina is an impostor.”

Flutterina gaped in shock. “Don’t listen to her. She’s evil and crazy.”

“I know very well when someone is trying to fabricate discord.” Shadow Weaver tightened the cuff around the young girl’s neck until Flutterina’s face became a horrid shade of magenta. “I know it is difficult to trust me due to my history, but I assure you I am not the one spying on the Rebellion.”

“Look at her eyes,” Angella gasped as Flutterina’s eyes flashed between pink and dark green scleras with slitted pupils.

“What is she?” Mermista asked.

“What is your name?” Shadow Weaver demanded, rushing to the chair which held the spy hostage.

“Alright, alright.” Flutterina gurgled out as her body lengthened into a reptilian being with a slender build. “The gold isn’t even worth this treatment.”

“You’re a shapeshifter.” She-Ra gasped out, lowering her sword.

“Call me Double Trouble,” they said weakly, gasping out then going still.

“You’re not gonna execute them, are you?” Bow asked when Shadow Weaver didn't attempt to remove the restrictive collar.

“No, that would be too good for them,” Shadow Weaver said, staring at the limp body in front of her. Double Trouble’s chest rose and fell with their soft breathing. She would need to release them if she wanted to keep them alive.

“Perfuma, restrain them, please. Frosta, immobilize them until we can create a new containment spell.” Angella requested. “She-Ra, please bring them to the Bright Moon prison.”

“I see you still enjoy your dramatics,” Angella remarked to Shadow Weaver once they reconvened back in the war room.

Glimmer looked at Angella in surprise. “Mom, you knew?”

Angella nodded. “Shadow Weaver approached me after the Rebellion’s second failed mission in Thaymor about the possibility of there being a Horde spy in Bright Moon.”

Shadow Weaver pressed a button on the war table and zoomed in on Thaymor. “The Horde knew exactly where we’d be and knew exactly how many bots would be too large of a force for us to handle.”

“How did you know she wasn’t just trying to accuse someone else of being the spy?” Frosta asked.

“I was hesitant to believe her, but she started predicting the Horde’s pattern and exit strategies,” Angella admitted. “I made arrangements for both contingencies. I am pleased to know Shadow Weaver is still loyal to the Rebellion.”

“Why didn’t you tell the rest of us?” Glimmer asked.

“The fewer people that knew, the better. We couldn’t risk anyone alerting the spy that we were onto them. The spy seemed to be able to extract information from several methods at once and we didn't know how to restrict that,” Shadow Weaver said, resting her hands on the edge of the table. “The only person I told after Angella was Adora.”

“Adora!?” The Princesses asked.

“I’m sorry guys. I hated keeping it from you. It was so hard. I had to act like everything was normal,” Adora said, clutching her head. “Shadow Weaver even gave me secret acting lessons.” She turned to Shadow Weaver. “Please, please don't ask me to do that ever again,” she pleaded.

“I think I speak for everyone when I say we owe Shadow Weaver an apology,” Bow said and paused. “Okay, that felt way weirder out loud.”

“Yeah, we all thought you were definitely the spy,” Frosta said.

“I knew she couldn’t be the spy,” Mermista said, slouching into her chair. “In the Mer-mystery novels, the most obvious choice is never the perpetrator.”

“Mermista, why didn’t you say anything?” Adora asked annoyedly.

“We didn’t have any other suspects to compare to Shadow Weaver, so I left it alone,” Mermista said with an eye roll. “It always works out in the novels.”

“You mean everything always works out in the *murder* mystery novels?” Glimmer asked.

“Thank you, everyone. Next time, forget your preconceived notions about me and trust that I have the Rebellion’s best interests at heart,” Shadow Weaver said, waving her hand over the War Table. “We mustn’t waste time. We have to assume the Horde knows everything we’ve been planning up to this point. We cannot pursue Dryl later today.”

“If the Horde knows we’ll be there, shouldn’t we go to keep them from thinking Double Trouble was captured?” Bow suggested and tapped the map, making horde symbols appear in battle formation next to Dryl.

“That could work if we knew what the Horde’s plan was,” Adora said.

“Is there any way we can revive Double Trouble in time to ask?” Angella asked Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver kept her eyes on the map of Dryl. “I doubt they are going to talk to us.”

“After you choked them until they passed out, you mean?” Mermista added.

“I needed to subdue them quickly,” Shadow Weaver said as she tried to plot the Princesses across the simulated map of Dryl.

Glimmer’s eyes lit up. “There’s a new rune I've been wanting to try.”

Angella shook her head. “No, Glimmer. You are to use your magic from the Moonstone and nothing more.”

“Double Trouble might talk if we send Shadow Weaver in to talk to them,” Mermista said. “They already know she used to be with the Horde. If we send her in, they’ll be so scared of her that we’ll find out the Horde’s plan in no time.”

“That’s actually a really good idea, Mermista,” Adora said.

“I just know the last person I would wanna see is the person that just held me against a chair until I passed out,” Mermista replied.

“We don't have to do that. Shadow Weaver could try to befriend them and earn their trust,” Perfuma suggested.

“Perfuma, that’s gonna take too long. Let me go in,” Frosta said, forming ice fists with sharp spikes along the knuckles. “I can handle this.”

“I agree with Mermista’s plan. I will use my reputation and extract the answers we seek with an aggressive approach.” Shadow

Weaver curled her hand in the air to emphasize her claws.

“Are you gonna hurt them?” Frosta asked excitedly.

“Not too badly. I won’t even be leaving permanent marks,” Shadow Weaver said over her shoulder as she walked from the room.

“I knew you’d come to visit me sooner or later. My performance was so good you couldn’t stay away,” Double Trouble said. “I bet you want to know what I did to make them turn on you.”

“Not at all,” Shadow Weaver said calmly.

“Oh, honey. You can play it cool, but I’ve seen you all with your guard down, even you. Although,” Double Trouble morphed into Angella. “I’m sure if I’d tried harder I could have seen more of you.” They winked with Angella’s face. “Oh, my Dark Princess this ache in my heart longs only for you.” They continued with a perverse grin and dark green sclera flashing through the disguise.

Shadow Weaver didn’t react. They craved an audience and attention. “For a mimic, you’re not very observant of your surroundings. We are alone. I'm here because they know I can do what they won’t.” She told them as she entered the confinement spell.

Double Trouble’s eyes widened as they went back to their original form. “You wouldn’t. You’re a Princess now.”

“We both know I have no qualms about hurting you.” Shadow Weaver threatened, as her metal cuff extended over her fist like a bayonet. She began tracing the blade over Double Trouble’s left eyebrow. “How about I fix it so you will be the most unique copy of whomever you choose to be?”

“There’s really no need to get physical again. The only allegiance I have is to gold,” Double Trouble said, flinching away from the blade.

“I will return. Try to stay pretty until then,” Shadow Weaver said, trailing the knife across Double Trouble’s face.

“What did they say?” Angella asked once she closed the door.

“They said their only allegiances are to gold. I only had to threaten physical violence,” Shadow Weaver said.

“That seems too easy.” Angella frowned.

“Not a bit,” Shadow Weaver said, walking away. “I helped Glimmer put a Truth Spell on the containment. It works best when the other person is not focused on the sensation of the Truth Spell as I’m sure you recall,” she pointed out.

“Do you really think we should pay them?” Angella asked, falling into step.

“That depends on the information,” Shadow Weaver said.

Bow, Angella, and the Princesses all crowded into the Bright Moon Prison to see what Double Trouble had to say in a matter of moments.

“Oh wow, a captive audience for little ol’ me,” Double Trouble said with an elegant bow. “You really shouldn’t have.”

Shadow Weaver held a leather pouch and shook it so that the coins inside jingled teasingly. “We have your gold. Now talk.”

Double Trouble's ears twitched. “That sounds a little light, but you did manage to catch me. I suppose I could give you a discount on my normal rate,” they said with a shrug. “The Horde has been planning a massive attack for some time now. I just had to stall until they could get underway. The Horde have their sights set on

Salineas. Once they control the oceans, then they can control Etheria."

Shadow Weaver glanced at Mermista. She had never seen the girl look so stricken. She watched as Mermista twisted her braid between her hands unable to speak.

"That will never happen. We won't let it," Glimmer said with a determined shake of her head. "We know the Horde's plan now and we can stop them."

"Stop them? It's already done." Double Trouble smirked as they continued. "When I didn't check-in, Catra knew the timetable had been moved up. Dryl has been abandoned as all the Horde's forces were moved to Salineas. You're too late but, hey, at least you got your little dust bowl Dryl back."

"No, that's not true. You're lying again," Glimmer said. She grabbed Mermista, Adora, and Bow before teleporting away.

Perfuma looked at Shadow Weaver and Angella. "This can't be true, right?"

"Is the spell still active?" Angella asked.

Shadow Weaver nodded, gripping the leather pouch in her hands.

"What is taking them so long?" Frosta asked.

"It's gone." Mermista sobbed, clinging to Bow as they reappeared.

"We've lost Salineas," Glimmer confirmed.

"Such a shame this could have all been avoided if you'd all had just a little more faith in your fellow Princess," Double Trouble said with a large grin.

Glimmer's face flushed with anger. "If anyone is to blame it's you!"

Double Trouble rested their head on their hand. “Don’t get testy, love. You need to keep your head as Commander. Who knows how many more lives you could lose?”

Glimmer yelled, running forward.

“Stop.” Shadow Weaver, stood in front of Glimmer. “This is exactly what they want. Remember if you attack the prison it may release them.”

Adora’s face became grim. “We can fix this. We’ll get Salineas back.”

“Yes, we will,” Angella said. “The Horde has dealt the Rebellion a substantial loss, but we will not be defeated. We will rise stronger than ever but we have one more task to complete before we do so. Shadow Weaver, on behalf of the Rebellion I’d like to once again extend our sincerest apologies and dismiss your guard detail. I also grant you leave to go find your Runestone. May you find all the answers you seek.”

“Thank you, your majesty,” Shadow Weaver said.

The wind whipped Shadow Weaver’s hair around her head as she stood on Slinky’s back. The Elemental set out in search of her Runestone. His mandibles clicked rhythmically as he investigated the Whispering Woods. He circled through the trees faster and faster until he finally stopped at their final destination.

“No luck, huh?” Bow asked as Slinky came to a stop in front of the Library.

Shadow Weaver slid down Slinky’s back and landed on the grass. “It would appear not.” She tapped the Elemental’s shell and sent a command through their link to return to Bright Moon.

“Well, we better go inside. My dads can direct us to their dig site,” Bow said with a nervous laugh. He stiffly glanced at the Library.

“Bow, what’s going on?” Adora asked.

“George may not react well to Shadow Weaver,” Bow said as Glimmer teleported them inside.

“You know in everyday society people can just use a door.” Shadow Weaver pointed out once they landed inside the Library.

“Bow, what a surprise!” Two men ran and embraced Bow, lifting him off the ground.

“Hey, George. Hey, Lance.” Adora waved.

“Adora. Glimmer. Get in here.” George held out his arm.

Shadow Weaver noticed how uncomfortable Adora and Glimmer looked pressed close together during the hug. Glimmer’s aggression in the field caused Adora to hover protectively and try to curb her magic usage. She also suspected their friendship was even more strained by the recent loss of Salineas. Bow valiantly tried to grin through the tension as he clutched at both girls like a lifeline. Once the hug was over, Shadow Weaver took a few moments to study Bow’s fathers. Lance was tall and slim with long dreadlocks. George was shorter and had a more reserved smile. His hair was close-cropped with a touch of gray at his temples and a neat handlebar mustache. She could easily see their features reflected in Bow.

“Lance, George, this is Shadow Weaver.” Bow introduced.

“Shadow Weaver, a pleasure.” Lance gave her hand a vigorous shake.

George peered at the woman. “Why is that name so familiar?”

“Well…” Bow said, scratching the back of his head.

“Did you say, Shadow Weaver?” George asked, shifting subtly into a fighting stance. “What is going on?”

“She’s good now. I mean not *good* really,” Adora said, waving her hands quickly. “She’s working on it. She’s a Princess now. We came because that Runestone shard you found with the Elemental is Shadow Weaver’s.”

“I would like to know where you found it,” Shadow Weaver said as she walked through the foyer of displays. “This is impressive. I’ve never seen such a comprehensive collection of First Ones’ writing and artifacts.”

“Why thank you! Would you like some tea or snacks?” Lance asked, rushing to the kitchen.

Shadow Weaver shook her head. “I would prefer if we started the expedition as quickly as possible.”

“Shadow Weaver, don’t be rude,” Adora said quietly. “They are the only ones that know the possible location of your Runestone.”

“I still don’t understand how Slinky wasn’t able to track back to his original location,” Glimmer said, sitting on the couch nearest the fireplace.

“It could be a security measure installed by the First Ones if it ever got into the wrong hands,” Bow said as he sat beside her.

Adora ducked her head with a nervous smile. “He also could have been damaged. We kind of hit him a lot when I first activated him.”

“Can you control the Elemental? Tell me everything,” Lance said, balancing a pen in his mouth over the tray laden with sandwiches and tea.

“Honey, put the tray down first, and then it will be easier to take notes,” George said through an affectionate sigh.

“Nevermind the tray. I must know more. We’ll leave at once,” Lance declared, sliding the tray on the table quickly. “Best research squad!”

“What are you hoping to find?” Adora asked, trying to keep up with Shadow Weaver’s quick pace back through the Whispering Woods.

“I’m hoping to find a full Runestone and not bits and pieces of shards such as this one.” Shadow Weaver gestured to her belt buckle.

“At least your Runestone is portable like She-Ra’s,” Glimmer said from her other side. “You don’t have to worry about going all the way back to a home base to recharge like me or Perfuma.”

“I have already considered the advantage of its portable size, but I still need to recharge once a week with the larger Runestone shard,” Shadow Weaver said. She realized they were in a part of the Whispering Woods that didn’t look remotely familiar.

“Here it is,” George said, pointing to the markers they put around the dig site. “This is where we found the shard and the Elemental.”

“Okay, everyone spread out. Slinky had to come from somewhere,” Adora said, walking along the path of ground markers.

There was a small rumble beneath their feet and suddenly Lance was nowhere to be seen. His screams were swallowed by the sounds of crumbling stone and cracking wood.

“Lance! Are you okay?” Bow kneeled by the hole that was now in the dirt.

“I’m fine,” Lance called up to them. “A gigantic tree broke my fall.”

“Can you see anything?” George asked his husband.

“It looks like the tree grew up from beneath a waterfall. It also looks like some sort of stone structure beneath that. I’m gonna see if I can get closer.” Lance informed them.

“Don’t move. We’re coming down to you,” Adora said.

“Uh...guys,” Bow said as the ground rumbled again and disappeared from below their feet.

The group fell through the dirt and the first three layers of reaching branches. Shadow Weaver found herself tangled in vines.

Glimmer quickly teleported from branch to branch carefully bringing everyone in front of the stone entrance under the ancient tree. “Is everyone okay?” She asked.

“A little worse for wear but otherwise unharmed,” Shadow Weaver answered, dusting off her clothing. Her eyes tracked the details of the great cavern there were in. Bright rays of moonlight peeked through the ancient tree’s canopy. Just under the tree’s massive roots held a stone entrance.

Adora squinted. “There’s First Ones’ language inscribed on the door.”

“What’s it say, Adora?” Bow asked

“It says the Kingdom of Aldehaim.” Adora’s voice echoed across the cavern. The door glowed and a scanner moved across the doorway.

“An underground kingdom!” Lance and George exclaimed together.

“How did they stay hidden for so long?” Glimmer asked.

Shadow Weaver studied the architecture of the stone door. Besides the First Ones' sigil over the arch, there were also geometric etchings that ran down the rest of the stone frame beyond the patches of thick moss. "Most if not all of Etheria was built on ancient First Ones' technology and structures. This could have been one of the first kingdoms ever established on Etheria."

"I could not have said it better myself," George said, looking at Shadow Weaver impressed.

"Bow, where have you been keeping this lovely woman?" Lance asked.

"Remember we told you-" Bow started.

"Right, right Team Evil but she's good now," Lance said, waving a hand. "I insist you come over sometime so we can compare notes."

"I don't know if we're going to have time for tea with the war going on, honey," George said.

"How do you feel about ginger tea?" Shadow Weaver asked, relishing the look of uncomfortable shock on Bow's face.

"We don't have it often, but it's one of my favorites," Lance said with a genuine smile.

"Did Shadow Weaver just become friends with your dads?" Adora whispered sideways to Bow.

"Am I dreaming?" Bow asked, shaking his head to clear it. "Ouch! Thanks, Glimmer," he said, rubbing his arm.

"Got you covered." Glimmer pinched her fingers together in the air with a grin.

"Well, first things first. We have to get through that door," Adora said, pulling the Sword of Protection free of her arm.

“Adora, wait!” Shadow Weaver reached out for the blonde.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” She-Ra leaped for the door. A click sounded under her feet from a pressure plate.

A booming mechanical voice sounded around them. “Identify yourselves.”

“She-Ra,” she said confidently.

“She-Ra is not an acceptable response. Identify yourselves or you will be dealt with by lethal force.” The voice threatened and the group heard the sound of lasers charging.

Shadow Weaver pushed Adora off the pressure plate and warped a nearby dirty piece of metal into a shield, but the laser blast never came. She peeked from behind the shield and saw that the sentries were now motionless.

A scanner passed over her body, apparently having recognized the change in weight upon it. It changed and swept horizontally, focusing on her ears. “Inhabitant detected. Please reveal your eyes for identification.”

“What?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“Please reveal your eyes for identification.” The electronic voice repeated.

“There has to be another way,” Shadow Weaver said as the scanner light blinked.

“Please reveal your eyes for identification.”

“I know you don’t remove your mask for anything but this is your quest and it’s required, Shadow Weaver.” She-Ra placed a hand on her shoulder.

Shadow Weaver shook her head. “The Spell of Obtainment changed my eyes. It won’t work.”

“We have to try. We don’t know what kind of fail-safe they had. The tech inside could engulf everything in flames or seal this entrance away forever,” Bow said.

“Everyone stands behind me,” Shadow Weaver said haughtily. She slid her mask off carefully holding it just under her eyes. She was scanned from head to toe then on its second pass it locked on her eyes.

“Identification complete. Welcome, Runechilde, daughter of Beatrix.” The entrance released a series of chirps and the stone door lowered into the ground.

“Beatrix? Is that your mother’s name?” Glimmer asked.

“I know nothing of my past, however, I do recall parents are how you generally get sons and daughters.” Shadow Weaver replaced the mask and walked ahead.

Luminescent grass and weeds glowed under their feet with every step through the small hallway. Their light revealed the decorations across the walls. Shadow Weaver looked at the broken mosaics on the inside walls. The people all resembled the way she looked before the Spell of Obtainment.

“This is fascinating,” George said as Lance scribbled notes at a rapid pace.

The floor sloped downward, taking them deeper underground. At the bottom, they finally reached a bridge that separated them from a settlement up ahead. Jagged fixtures of amethyst jutted from buildings at random angles, illuminating the city in a violet glow.

“Wow,” Glimmer said.

“This is where you grew up?” Adora asked.

“For as long as I can remember, I have lived in Mystacor,” Shadow Weaver said, looking for anything that could be familiar.

Bow used a small pair of binoculars that popped out of one of his arrows. “There was a major battle here between Aldehaim and the Horde.” Just at the end of the bridge, he saw ripples in the otherwise still water. He zoomed in with the binoculars but there was no longer anything visible. “We need to be careful there may be something else in here with us.”

“Good thing I’m still powered up,” She-Ra said, waving the Sword of Protection. “Let’s go.”

The construction of Aldehaim was largely a cluster of smooth stone buildings stacked on top of each other on either side of a murky canal. Most of the houses and buildings had signs of destruction from the grand battle that raged in the kingdom so they were shocked when they finally reached a building that looked untouched. It was a large lecture hall with rows upon rows of desks placed in the semicircle around a holographic projector. In each desk was a small skeleton slumped over their datapads.

“What did they do? Why would anyone do this?” Glimmer asked faintly. She pressed her hand tight against her mouth.

“Krull gas,” Shadow Weaver answered quietly as she leaned over the desk closest to her.

“How do you know?” George asked.

“It leaves a film when the bodies release their final breath.” Shadow Weaver pointed to the chalky black dust on the desk.

“Shadow Weaver, please, tell me you’ve never done this.” She-Ra pleaded.

“No, thankfully the ingredients the Horde needed to produce this were long extinct by the time I joined them,” Shadow Weaver

said.

Bow walked to the projector and removed the datapad. He blew away the dust. “I’ll see what I can find out from this, maybe it will give us the location of your Runestone,” he said not long after the awkward silence descended.

“Has anyone else noticed that every picture and body we’ve seen that isn’t the Horde has some sort of face-covering from the nose down?” Glimmer wondered aloud.

“According to the lessons I’m reading through, it is against Aldehaim culture for anyone to show their full face to someone who’s not your direct family or betrothed,” Bow said, studying the beeping datapad.

“You hear that, Shadow Weaver? You might have a date waiting out there for you.” She-Ra tried to joke.

“It is far more likely they are in here with the rest of the corpses,” Shadow Weaver said, walking faster. “Let’s continue.”

“I think I’ve found it,” Bow announced. “It says during every tenth lunar cycle they pay homage to the Runechilde of their generation with a grand festival and ceremony. This festival was held in the town square which is just up ahead.”

The town square was coated in water and putrid sticky foam that clung just to the edge of the center mosaic. It crisscrossed the stone in random patterns.

“Ugh, what is that smell?” Glimmer held her nose.

A reverberating growl came out of the shadows near the town hall. The source of the sound crept into the light, revealing its iridescent red body. It towered over the group with a grimace, its enormous crescent-shaped mouth filled with sharp, translucent teeth. On its forehead held a thin protrusion with a glowing orb on the end in front of its three reflective eyes. With a roar, eight tentacles moved its slimy body towards them at breakneck speed.

“How do we get past this thing?” Lance asked, clutching George’s hand.

“That’s one mean looking Elemental.” Glimmer yelped, charging up a magic attack.

“It is a Guardian, not an Elemental.” Shadow Weaver clarified as she scrutinized the Guardian for weaknesses. “First Ones only activated them as a last resort. They are lethal and unstoppable.”

“We’re gonna have to stop this one.” She-Ra charged forward, sliding under a reaching tentacle and slashed. The sword bounced off its armored skin. A tentacle picked She-Ra up and threw her across the courtyard.

Bow pulled arrows and started hastily firing at the Guardian. “Glimmer, take my dads out of here.”

“What?” Lance asked aghast.

“Bow, you can’t seriously think we’re gonna leave you here to fight an unstoppable creature?" George demanded, trying to shrug off Glimmer’s grip.

“He’s only showing concern. Do not argue. We cannot fight this monstrosity and defend you as well.” Shadow Weaver created a spiked war hammer and slammed it into a tentacle sliding toward her. A light glinted out of the corner of her eye. She turned her attention toward it as it waved around calmly. It was so bright and pretty. All she knew is that she needed to get closer to it. She walked forward and her grip slackened on the weapon.

Glimmer reappeared and sent a concentrated magical blast into the Guardian’s face. The Guardian flinched then roared in anger, breaking the trance Shadow Weaver was in. “What the heck are you doing?”

Shadow Weaver shook her head free of the lingering haze. “The light on its forehead is a lure with some kind of enchantment. Don’t look directly at it.”

“How do you expect us to fight this thing from our peripheral?” She-Ra sniped back. She decided to use brute strength to beat the Guardian back on the defensive. “Bow, take out the lure.”

Bow sent a volley of arrows at the hypnotic light hanging from its forehead but the beast whipped it around too fast to track. With a wide sweep of its two front tentacles, it lobbed them all backward.

“This is impossible. This thing is huge and fast and doesn’t have any vulnerabilities that I see,” Glimmer said, breathing hard.

“We can try to take out its eyes.” Bow suggested.

“I have an idea but She-Ra will need to toss me close to its mouth," Shadow Weaver said, hefting her war hammer on her shoulder.

“Hold on. What idea?” Glimmer asked quickly.

“You want me to what?” She-Ra gaped at her. “Are you nuts?”

The Guardian began hacking and spit a ball of mucus across the area. It splattered against a column and splashed around them, filling the air with a fetid odor of brine and sulfur.

“So, gross.” She-Ra pivoted out of the way of the phlegm.

“Don’t let it touch you. We don’t know what that substance does,” Shadow Weaver said, ducking behind the closest column.

Glimmer teleported behind cover. “Oh, is that all?”

Shadow Weaver turned her Warhammer into a large, sharp shark-toothed serrated dagger. “There’s no time. Throw me now.” She shouted to She-Ra.

“Don’t die,” She-Ra said, grabbing the back of Shadow Weaver’s clothes and hurled her at the Guardian.

The Guardian's mouth opened, a gurgling sounding from the back of its throat. Shadow Weaver soared through the air and grabbed the angler, pulling it downward with her into the Guardian's mouth. She grabbed one of its spiky teeth and ducked her head. Yellow blood exploded around her as the creature let out a deafening shriek. It thrashed around and she lost the grip on the spindly tooth. She used the dagger to stop her descent. The blade found purchase on its slippery throat. The light glided past her, falling into the darkness that was probably its stomach.

She used the dagger to climb back up and saw the outside purple glow through a thin layer of its skin. It was still moving with purpose. Changing the dagger to a sword, she gripped it and thrust it outward with one strong shove. The skin finally gave way and she hacked her way out of the Guardian, slipping out in a waterfall of blood and entrails. With a final squeal, the Guardian collapsed and its body was finally still.

"Shadow Weaver, that was awesome!" Glimmer shouted. "I would give you a high five or something but you reek and I don't want to touch you."

"When I saw you fall in the Guardian's mouth I thought you were insane. Was that the plan you didn't want to tell us about?" Bow asked.

Shadow Weaver shook her hands free of the clinging blood. "Not entirely. I was hoping to come back out of its mouth."

"You know if you had told me what you were trying to do, Bow could have achieved that with an exploding arrow in its mouth," She-Ra said with a grin.

"It's dead, is it not?" Shadow Weaver huffed.

Bow removed an arrow from his quiver and sprayed Shadow Weaver with a canister of water.

"Why is this an arrow that you still deemed necessary?" Shadow Weaver sputtered, wiping the water away from the eyeholes of

her mask.

“If I didn’t have this arrow, you’d be walking around in Guardian’s guts, so you’re welcome.” Bow twirled the arrow through his fingers and stored it back into the quiver.

“Thank you,” Shadow Weaver drawled, squeezing out the ends of her hair. She managed to make the words of gratitude sound as if they were somehow more painful than being swallowed.

They started to walk back to the center of the courtyard when the Guardian’s body vibrated and moved.

“It can’t be still alive,” Shadow Weaver said as she and She-Ra held their swords at the ready.

“No, it’s a trap door. Look!” Bow said, pointing to the mosaic of the lunar phases in the middle of the town square.

A mechanism squeaked and churned along, raising a large platform that resembled a ring where the Runestone sat in a yellow gold claw place setting upon the dais. The candy pink Runestone was slightly larger than the Font she used for her morning ritual. It was rough and cracked, several tool marks marred its surface. Shards of varying sizes littered the stone surrounding the pedestal.

“The fools! It’s been damaged extensively. The Horde probably tried to remove it before the Guardian was activated.” Shadow Weaver picked up one of the shards from the floor. It was smaller than the housing on her mask. She would make sure it was secured.

Resting her hands against the Runestone, Shadow Weaver allowed her Princess magic to access it. With a gleam and a twinkle, the shards lifted around her like the Lunar Lenses at Mystacor. The main Runestone glowed, sending beams of light bouncing off each shard and finally connecting with Shadow Weaver. Her hair flowed behind her in an unseen wind as a dark

pink aura outlined her body. A rush of energy entered her body and she felt her powers fully recharge.

“Do you think it can be moved?” She-Ra asked, stepping forward. She powered down.

Shadow Weaver shook her head. “Not without damaging it further. We need to find a way to protect it so the Horde can never try to possess it again.”

“Look, just along the outside of your Runestone is its name. The Blush Sapphire.” Adora read.

“I thought sapphires were blue?” Glimmer asked with a confused frown.

Shadow Weaver gestured to the Runestone in front of them. “Apparently not.”

“The Blush Princess doesn’t fit,” Bow said, glancing over Shadow Weaver.

“Huntara was right. Shadow Weaver is the Dark Princess,” Adora said.

“That sounds like a novel, *Shadow Weaver: Dark Princess Chronicles* ,” Bow said with a dramatic growl.

The platform started to move again, sliding down into the courtyard as if it was never there.

“For now, it looks like you’ll have this trap door to protect and hide your Runestone,” Glimmer said, looking around.

“Glimmer, can you get us out of here?” Bow asked.

“No problem.” Glimmer reached out, pulling everyone closer.

“Not yet,” Shadow Weaver said. “This may be my only chance to find out more about my past.”

“Bow, can you find us another exit?” Adora asked.

Bow tapped the datapad, bringing up a map of Aldehaim. “We’ll need to head further in. I hope there really is another way out because the Guardian trashed the bridge by tossing pillars when it tried to get away after swallowing Shadow Weaver.”

Not far from the town square, they came onto a modest stone cottage with the name ‘Beatrix’ across the door frame.

Adora stepped closer to the door, brushing away the dust. “Daughter of Beatrix, that’s what the door called you. This must have been your home.”

“Maybe I’ll find more answers for what happened here inside,” Shadow Weaver said, opening the door.

The house was in shambles. Overturned chairs, broken bookshelves, and shattered knick-knacks littered the floor. Most of the skeletons inside had older versions of Horde armor. The two with brass armor embroidered with a filigree of laurel leaves and vines lie in the middle of the chaos, reaching for each other across the room.

The group carefully stepped over the bodies, making their way through the cottage. Eventually, they reached the final room. It had a dusty carved door with toys and smiley faces along its border. In the middle was a hand-painted wooden plaque with eight blank spaces. On the floor in front of the door, were two corpses with swords through their chests. It appeared at the last moment both combatants landed fatal blows. The one pressed against the door had identical armor to the two other bodies in the living room. Adora opened the door and the group discovered the space was mostly untouched by the rest of the house’s destruction.

Glimmer, Adora, and Bow spread out looking for more clues about the Blush Sapphire or the battle while Shadow Weaver stood into the doorway and studied the pictures around the nursery. One picture had a man and woman in what looked to be decorative formal robes one would wear for a wedding. The man was tall and had short-cropped sandy brown hair. He had light grey skin and the same piercing green gaze as she once had, but his eyes were rounder and kind. The woman beside him had darker grey skin with her jet black hair in a tight French braid. Her light blue eyes twinkled with a sternness Shadow Weaver had seen on herself many times. With their collective features, she knew this couple had to be her parents.

Shadow Weaver's eyes darted to another photograph with the two adults in more casual clothing as they held a sleeping newborn between them proudly while a boy in his late teens sent a playful wink toward the camera. She tore her eyes away from the picture and walked further into the room.

Shadow Weaver headed for a crib against the back wall. It looked too pristine to be an accident. She began to reach out for the mobile.

"Aww, this is too cute. Shadow Weaver, is this you?" Adora asked, looking at the picture of a baby girl trying to put a foot in her mouth through a satin face mask. The baby was clearly the woman in front of them. Her hair was similar to voluminous raven locks Shadow Weaver currently had.

"Adora is right. Your hair is bigger than you are. Oh wow, your eyes are so green," Glimmer gasped, leaning over to see the image.

"Look at her wittle hands." Bow cooed at the picture.

"I'm keeping this." Adora declared, hugging the photograph to her chest.

“Absolutely, not. These are my belongings,” Shadow Weaver said, reaching for the picture.

“Take one of the other ones. This one is so mine,” Adora said, dodging the swipe aimed at her.

Shadow Weaver decided to let it go for now. She could always get the picture back later when Adora least expected it. Stepping around the teenagers, she continued to the crib and touched the mobile. The wind chimes jingled softly. The bottom panel of the crib slid open, exposing a damaged hologram projector.

“Bow, could you please?” Shadow Weaver handed it off to the archer.

“It doesn’t look too bad. Let me see what’s wrong,” Bow said and grabbed one of his arrows. The arrowhead fell off, revealing a screwdriver and he went to work. He muttered to himself for a few moments. “That should do it.”

The hologram flashed and a figure hurriedly came into view. The helm they wore was tight-fitting, a high polished brass helmet with bladed crests on top. The wear of battle marked the gleaming metal with harsh cuts along its surface. They pulled off the helm and underneath was a khaki silk neck gaiter. With a hesitant hand, they touched the fabric covering their mouth and pulled the cloth away exposing their face.

“Hello, Little One. I’m your mommy, Beatrix.” The woman smiled, revealing a fanged grin. “You lived in Aldehaim with me, your father, Ustard, and your older brother, Bewli. So much has happened my sweet daughter. I may not have much time and I hope you never have to witness this recording, but I’m not sure if our forces are strong enough to hold them off forever.”

Beatrix took a deep breath before continuing. “Scorporous in the Fright Zone has accepted an alien calling himself Lord Hordak into their community. We cast him out of our society on Elder Zid’s suggestion. Elder Zid told us he foresaw an upcoming war sparked

by this man. He also said you are the last Rune baby in Aldehaim. Elder Zid has never been wrong before and I have made arrangements to send you to Mystacor. Master Norwyn is an old friend. He will raise you and keep you safe. I wish there was more time. I wish that I could have seen your first steps. I wish I could have seen your bond reawaken Aldehaim's Runestone. I wish Ustard and I could have stood beside you when you married."

"Maybe in another lifetime," Beatrix said wistfully. Her eyes darted to the pictures around the room. "I am sending journals and a chest of holochips with Norwyn so he can show you its contents when you come of age. If I fail and you are seeing this then we are long gone and I'm sorry. I know you are going to be a great person someday. You have your father's eyes and already have his inquisitive mind and I hope-no. I know you were bestowed my courage. Never stop questioning my daughter. Join the Princesses and make your mark upon this world. Stop Hordak."

There was a crash and the sound of fighting in the background.

"Beatrix!" A pained cry happened off-camera.

"Ustard." Beatrix's eyes teared up and she wiped her eyes. "It is against custom to refer to you as your name before the naming ceremony but I want you to know that you are loved. You are strong and your name is-"

Here Beatrix's image glanced to the side, her eyes wide then her gaze narrowed with determination. She pressed an unseen button, pulling the gaiter back into place. She stood and drew her sword. The hologram's point of view was jostled as it seemed to lower into darkness. "You bastards will pay for every inch!" was the last thing heard from Beatrix and the hologram ended.

"Shadow Weaver, your mom was a freaking warrior," Glimmer declared with a grin.

Shadow Weaver didn't respond. Her hands tensed, sharp nails piercing the palms of her hands through her gloves. The metal in

the room lifted off the ground while she stood trembling in place.

Adora looked at her with wide eyes. “Shadow Weaver?”

“Norwyn!” Shadow Weaver’s spine chilling yell echoed off the walls. “How could he keep this from me!?” A silver picture framed slammed against the door.

“She’s gonna destroy the room if we don’t get her to calm down. What can we do?” Adora asked Glimmer and Bow.

“Hey, it’s okay.” Bow approached Shadow Weaver with his hands out. “Norwyn’s not here. He’s gone.”

“I’ve always known I was bound for something greater!” Shadow Weaver screamed, swiping the projector to the floor. She clawed the wooden posts of her crib. “I’ve always known,” she said desperately, falling to her knees.

“Guys, can you give us a minute?” Adora asked, looking at Bow and Glimmer.

Glimmer nodded silently and teleported away with Bow in tow.

“Do you wanna talk about what just happened?” Adora kneeled beside Shadow Weaver. At the shake of the older woman’s head, Adora scooted closer. “Do you remember the oath you made to me when you were imprisoned?”

“Yes, I do.” Shadow Weaver sighed and stood. “Norwyn was my mentor, Adora. He raised me and tutored me in magic. He was also my harshest critic. He kept finding ways to keep me from exploring Etheria, from learning more magic, and now I found out he kept an entire portion of my life from me.” The metal rattled once more around the room.

“Where have I heard that before?” Adora snarked.

“The irony is not lost on me I assure you. My reaction was poor and for that, I apologize.” Shadow Weaver held Adora’s hand.

“Your apology means nothing to me unless you plan to continue to make up for it. I’ve seen your effort. I’m trying to believe that you’re doing what you're doing for unselfish reasons.” Adora glanced at her. “Or less selfish reasons but I can’t have you ready to charge off when you’re upset. We have enough of that as it is with Glimmer. So, don’t apologize,” she said with a serious expression then smiled. “Do better.”

“I will try,” Shadow Weaver responded.

“Good, we’ll take what we can carry now. I’m sure Glimmer or Angella can convince Castaspella to send the journals from your mom to Bright Moon,” Adora said.

Chapter End Notes

So just a little random useless trivia for you. I woke up out of a dream and there lingering in my subconscious was Aldehaim. It was one of the first full scenes I wrote. It's really not that different from my first draft of it. Also, I really couldn't pass up the chance to imagine baby Shadow Weaver/Light Spinner.

Thank you, thank you to all the people that take the time to review and kudos. I always enjoy reading the reviews and learning more about your interpretation of the story.

Until next time. ;)

You’re My Head, You’re My Heart

Chapter Summary

The aftermath of Aldehaim and new beginnings.

Chapter Notes

Archive: Don’t copy to another site without permission

Spoilers: I’m picking and choosing what canon plotlines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, “Light Spinner” will be pretty spoilery.

Disclaimer: She-Ra and the Princesses of Power belong to DreamWorks and the wonderful Noelle Stevenson. Any and all other brand names that might appear here belong to their respective owners. I do not make any money on this story. Please don’t sue; you only stand to gain an extremely mismanaged pile of finances for your efforts.

Author’s Note: This is inspired by fan art, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine’s song “No Light, No Light” along with Five Finger Death Punch’s “Wrong Side of Heaven.” My brain couldn’t leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

All errors I claim as my own.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

I’m back. *cracks knuckles* This is the longest chapter of the story. Get your snacks, get comfortable, and let's get to reading!

Chapter 5: You're My Head, You're My Heart

The usually cheery and enlightened sky of Bright Moon was grey and stormy. The moonlight was nearly nonexistent tonight, leaving Shadow Weaver in an eerie silence nearly void of light. The guards' nod in greeting was ignored as she passed. Lightning flashed in the distance as she continued to walk silently to her room. In just a few moments this entire ordeal could finally be behind her.

Shadow Weaver pushed her door open, trudging inside the room. She removed her outer clothing cautiously. She went through the motions of placing all her armor and gadgets on her workbench. Flipping a switch on the electric kettle, she re-heated the ginger tea that was leftover from this morning. Once it was hot, she poured it into the teacup, spooned in a hefty amount of sugar, and stirred it until the granules disappeared. It would likely still be bitter from sitting all day.

After perching herself on the edge of her bed, the brunette stared into the teacup. The comforting scent of the curling steam calmed her as she held it in her hands. How had the day turned out so disastrous? It had been a simple plan when they began the task. She would seek out her Runestone and unleash her full elemental magic potential. Never did she expect to find her origins or her family. The ending result left her with more questions than she was comfortable with and she truly hated being ignorant.

Breathing deep of her tea again, Shadow Weaver sat a little straighter as she felt a tug at her torso. Placing her cup on the side table, she lifted her undershirt and gently prodded at a bruise along her ribs. She must have been hit harder by the Guardian than she thought. The largest downside to coming down off adrenaline was the pain from any lingering injuries you don't notice in the heat of battle. Beyond the slight pain throbbing along her ribs, Shadow Weaver felt numb from betrayal.

Even from the grave Norwyn still exercised his wretched hold on her life. Norwyn should be grateful his death was a quick one. Shadow Weaver was certain if he was still alive she would have cleaved him in two.

She allowed her shirt to fall back over her skin and pulled up her sleeve. Staring at the demon scars along her forearm, she wished not for the first time that she could reach for her shadows. She needed that quiet vacuous space of nothingness that used to give her solace. Ever since she connected to Angella's magic, her link to darkness was getting harder and harder to grasp. Though she loathed to admit it, darkness was her vice and her enemy. She would not allow it to use her again.

She stifled a yawn and glanced out the window. It was so late that the hours were quickly approaching morning. She doubted sleep would have come easily to her. Rest certainly didn't sound more appealing than her waking hours at the moment. Invoking Norwyn's memory would undoubtedly bring all her past deeds to haunt her in her dreams, spitting venom and judgement from their many pallid faces. She reached out her hand, distractedly trying to find her teacup. Picking it up with a clatter she quickly stilled the drinkware and steeled her nerves.

"Shadow Weaver, is that you? Are you okay?" Angella knocked quickly.

Shadow Weaver moved to the door, barely cracked it, and replied with a swift. "I'm fine." She started to close it when Angella stopped the motion by placing her hand against it.

"You couldn't sleep?" Angella asked, sliding her hand to brush against Shadow Weaver's comfortingly.

"It appears I'm not the only one." Shadow Weaver removed her hand from the tempting touch.

Angella's eyes rounded with concern. "May I come in?"

“You are the queen after all.” Shadow Weaver shrugged one shoulder.

“You still have the right to privacy.” Angella pointed out, waiting patiently.

Shadow Weaver stepped away from the door, silently allowing her entry.

“I hope you understand what it took to retrieve this,” Angella said, pointing to the crate filled with journals, holo chips, and the few personal effects from Aldehaim. “I thought Castaspella would combust when I told her why we needed to access Master Norwyn’s old quarters.” She joked.

“I will have to write up a commendation for you,” Shadow Weaver said flatly. She busied herself with straightening the items at her work table.

“What happened at Aldehaim? No one has seen you since you came back from finding your Runestone.” Angella placed a hand on Shadow Weaver’s back.

Shadow Weaver finally faced Angella. She methodically removed the hologram from the box and played Beatrix’s message for Angella.

“You look so much like your mother,” Angella said once the Shadow Weaver paused the holographic message.

“Not anymore.” Shadow Weaver clenched her hands to avoid reaching for her mask.

Angella sighed. “It sounds like your parents did what they thought was best.”

“Everyone assumed I was just the power-hungry mentor turned traitor of Mystacor. I found out unsurprisingly Norwyn was a bigger prick than I even suspected.” Shadow Weaver ran a hand over the paused image of her mother. Her fingers went through

the projection and she sighed. She bent over and grabbed a discarded journal. It was the only one in the box that wasn't from her mother. "You should read this." She handed it to Angella.

Angella's eyes tracked along the page. Her brow became more and more furrowed as she reached the end. "It was Norwyn that night?"

"When Nigella announced our engagement, he knew he wouldn't be able to control me anymore. I'm glad he is dead." Shadow Weaver snatched the journal back and tossed it against the wall. "My only regret is that I didn't make him suffer. He has taken everything from me."

"I'm definitely not Norwyn's biggest fan right now either, but please try not to lash out," Angella admitted softly.

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath. "I wonder if I had been raised as Beatrix and Ustard intended, would it all be different? My parents entrusted Norwyn to reveal my true nature when I came of age and he decided I wasn't worthy. Norwyn was always my biggest detractor. He was constantly telling me to embrace my limits and forget about aiming for higher goals. He decided what my destiny should be."

"Norwyn was never truly successful in his endeavor. Your magic still spoke to your shard and you could move it." Angella pointed out, rubbing soothing circles across the other woman's back. "Can you honestly say that the person you were then would have worked with anyone else or would you have charged ahead believing you were the stronger, fastest Princess because you had both elemental power and sorcery at your disposal?"

"You might be right." Shadow Weaver peered at Angella over her shoulder. "Light Spinner was not ready to accept the responsibility it takes to be a Princess," she said, watching the birds take flight against the predawn sky. "I believe Shadow Weaver is."

“I know she is,” Angella replied with a soft smile. “Would you like to do something to commemorate your family’s lives?”

“Why would I want to do that?” Shadow Weaver tensed. “They gave away their right to be in my life. They could have left Aldehaim instead of leaving their baby’s life in the hands of that...” she released a frustrated huff.

“I know you didn’t know Ustard, Beatrix, or Bewli. That doesn’t mean you don’t want to mourn what could have been.” Angella ignored her tone. “Your family chose to give you what they assumed would be a better life. They chose to stay behind and defend their home. Something I’m sure you know all too well.”

“Maybe in time,” Shadow Weaver said, scooting the crate further away from her. “For now I just want to focus on the future.”

“If you’re sure?” Angella rested a hand on Shadow Weaver’s shoulder.

“I am. Speaking of the future, Angella, I’ve been thinking should we Princesses fail,” Shadow Weaver began.

“You won’t. I have hope that we will see the end to this war.” Angella insisted.

“ *If* we do. Then you will be Bright Moon’s last line of defense. We all need to hone our skills.”

Angella crossed her arms. “I seem to recall that I handled myself quite well during your imprisonment.”

“I was completely without magic or defenses at the time. You might be our best warrior if all that was required was to have the Horde lie down and not move or attack.” Shadow Weaver remarked with an unimpressed shake of her head. “This fight belongs to us all. All of Etheria. When the time comes, you must also act.”

“You must think it’s such an easy request you’re making.” Angella looked away. “Do you want to know a secret? I despised you, you know, that first night of your captivity.”

“Really? I had not noticed.” Shadow Weaver intoned. She still got sharp pains in her chest when she remembered the angry rasp of the word ‘monster’ from Angella’s lips.

“Can you quit speaking for once and listen?” Angella asked annoyedly. “You were a stranger to me. You were this broken and weak woman spitting venom despite her apparent mortal danger. You stuck to your convictions and when it was all over the only thing you cared about was surviving. It always stuck with me.” She smiled and shook her head. “You were right. I am a coward. I’ve always been the queen that stays behind to hide behind the Moonstone. Micah was the brave one. And Glimmer…so much like her father. Once again I stayed behind, letting her make the hard choices, letting her be brave for me. I kept lying to myself, told myself that I was being responsible, but I was just scared. When Glimmer accused me of being paralyzed with fear, all my anger came back at you. I blamed you for putting that rift in our relationship then I saw it was just me and my fear again. It wasn’t until we were running through the Fright Zone that I realized what I was capable of even though I mostly got in the way.” She chuckled softly.

Shadow Weaver was silent for a few moments after Angella finished being so open with her. “Angella, you have more courage than you know. We ultimately thwarted Hordak’s portal with your assistance. Never discount your efforts in that.”

Angella flushed at the compliment. “I can’t see myself going on any regular missions anytime soon, but I am ready to be more active in the Rebellion.”

“That is marvelous news. I look forward to fighting alongside you,” Shadow Weaver said.

Angella studied Shadow Weaver intently. “I suppose you did get your wish answered all these years later. You have unlocked your potential.”

“I wished I had the bravery to admit my feelings that night before it was too late,” Shadow Weaver said earnestly. “I was blinded by power again. Time got away from me while I was busy making plans about how I’d rule Bright Moon and defeat the Horde. When I finally came to the realization, you were gone.”

“I’d like to get some things clear. One, *I* was always going to rule Bright Moon and two, you are still bad at wishes,” Angella said lightly. “You once wanted more power when you were the most accomplished sorcerer in ages and now you want more courage as the newest Princess of the Rebellion.”

“ *We* would have ruled Bright Moon,” Shadow Weaver countered. “I needed different courage to face you. You who were so brave to open her heart to me. I was the coward when it counted and it cost us both so much. I will not allow someone else to dictate my destiny any longer.” She walked closer to the queen.

“What does that mean?” Angella asked quietly.

Shadow Weaver gently tugged off her mask. Double slitted pupils dilated in response to the change in light. Beyond the scars, Angella saw the woman she fell in love with years ago. Her thumb traced over Shadow Weaver’s lip scar and leaned forward. She peppered kisses across the marks tracking down the Dark Princess’ forehead and jaw.

Angella cupped Shadow Weaver’s cheeks, brushing her nose against the one in front of her. “You’re still beautiful.”

Shadow Weaver’s breath hitched and her eyes shimmered with unshed tears. She tilted her head, brushing her lips against Angella’s. When their lips touched it transported her to a simpler time before the conflict and before the Spell of Obtainment. They

were once again just two young women enjoying their first kiss on the beach.

Shadow Weaver slowly ended the kiss. She brushed her fingers through the ends of Angella's hair. "We have lost so much time, Angella."

"Yes, we have." Angella agreed. "We can make up for it."

"We certainly will," Shadow Weaver said. "It would be my greatest wish to court you again."

"If that is truly your greatest wish, who am I to disappoint?" Angella laughed softly. "I accept," she said, placing a small kiss on the corner of Shadow Weaver's mouth.

"You have no idea how much this means to me." Shadow Weaver admitted.

"Probably as much as it means to me," Angella replied with a small smile.

Shadow Weaver held Angella's hands. "There's much to discuss about our courtship and how it affects everything."

"We'll get to that but for now I don't want to see you again until you're well rested," Angella said, nudging Shadow Weaver toward her bed. She walked back to the door, looking lovingly at the woman. There was shuffling in the hallway behind her as she started to pull the door shut.

"Queen Angella, good morning. I'm glad I found you. You have to see this picture of baby Shadow Weaver." Adora announced gleefully.

"Oh my, she is adorable!" Angella said with delight.

"Let me see her again," Bow begged.

Shadow Weaver stumbled to her bed and collapsed onto it. Her final thought as she drifted off to sleep was a vow that she would get that damnable picture back if it was the last thing she does.

Between the constant requests for rescues and humanitarian aid from all across Etheria, the Princesses were quickly running out of steam. The stress was evident on the Alliance and it wouldn't be long before everything finally reached its boiling point. Salineas was still lost and the Rebellion was no closer to regaining any of the lands that were seized by the Horde. Mermista, mourning the loss of her kingdom, had not moved from her guest room's bathtub in weeks. Refugees from all surrounding Salineas territories came to Bright Moon in droves.

Bow, Glimmer, and Adora had left that morning for Liquadine, an archipelago a few miles just outside Salineas' Sea Gate. The Best Friend Squad reported that they arrived early enough that they were likely to drive away the Horde forces before any occupation could occur. Perfuma volunteered to use her powers to secure the Whispering Woods while Frosta refortified her own kingdom.

The only people left in Bright Moon to answer Sea Hawk's distress call were Spinnerella, Netossa, Shadow Weaver, and Angella, who to the surprise of everyone, decided she would be a part of the rescue effort for Sea Elf village. Spinnerella transported them in a funnel cloud to the nearest port to meet Sea Hawk.

Shadow Weaver tried to steady herself as they landed. "I think I prefer Glimmer's method of travel."

"You get used to it," Netossa said with a grin.

"Ahoy! Welcome to the *Dragon's Daughter V* or was it *VI* ?" Sea Hawk frowned with a scratch of his chin. "No matter. There's no time to waste," he said once they made their way up the

gangplank. “Weigh the anchor!” He declared. “Let’s set sail to adventure!”

Shadow Weaver paused and looked at Angella then back to Sea Hawk. “Who are you addressing?”

Sea Hawk swung on loose rigging and landed near the anchor. He pulled his cutlass from his belt and slammed the pommel down on the automatic pulley. The anchor rose from the water back to its position on the ship. “Now then,” the pirate said, replacing his cutlass into its scabbard. “The queen is exempt but the rest of you will have to earn your keep as my honorary crew.” He returned to the helm and began to steer the ship to open water.

“Treat this as any other mission please, Sea Hawk.” Angella smiled. “I’m happy to help any way I can.”

“I’m not. Where is your actual crew?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“My crew is on a perilous adventure!” Sea Hawk twirled the end of his mustache with a wink.

“No one wanted to sail with you because you keep setting your ships on fire, did they?” Spinnerella asked.

“Were you gonna tell us that we’d be serving as your crew on top of rescuing the Sea Elves?” Netossa gestured at the four of them.

“Not to worry. I can cover all the basics of a pirate crew’s duties in a shanty.” Sea Hawk suggested. He drew in a deep breath.

“Do not sing,” Shadow Weaver said sharply.

“But I must! Surely Mermista must have told you about my shanties.” Sea Hawk held his right hand in the air and kept steering with his left. “Shanties so wondrous they soothe the most vicious of sea beasts with its melodies.”

“If you start singing. I will not be responsible for my actions.” Shadow Weaver threatened slowly.

Sea Hawk laughed uproariously. His face fell when he glanced at her again and she didn't join in his laughter. He cleared his throat. “My first crew of Princesses was more fun.” He grumbled.

“Land ho!” Angella cried suddenly. She turned to Shadow Weaver, grinning proudly.

“You look as though you were waiting all your life to say that,” Shadow Weaver said casually.

“That was not an invitation for comments, thank you,” Angella replied, raising her chin.

“I beg your pardon, your majesty. Continue with your nautical fallacies,” Shadow Weaver said teasingly.

Angella squinted her eyes silently as they approached from the south of Sea Elf village out of the view from the Horde. Just over a tall ridge, Shadow Weaver could see Hordak as fired at random locations over Sea Elf Village with his blaster.

“I need to get over there,” Shadow Weaver said, not taking her eyes off Hordak.

“Spinnerella and Netossa get all the Sea Elves evacuated. Sea Hawk, stay on the ship and I better not see any fires,” Angella said sternly.

“But your majesty. I can anchor the boat here and accompany you on land. You can’t stop the call to adventure!” Sea Hawk crowed with a mighty pose.

“I’m going for Hordak,” Shadow Weaver saw his crimson teeth bared as he grinned maniacally.

“No, it’s too risky for you to go alone,” Angella said, hovering above Shadow Weaver. “We are going to Hordak. We’ll distract him while they get the villagers out safely.” She grabbed Shadow Weaver under her arms and flew the short distance to Hordak.

“Enough of this,” Shadow Weaver said as she landed to the ground behind Hordak. She immediately dove out of the way of the hand cannon’s laser, watching as it exploded some coral behind her head.

Hordak paused in his firing with a smirk and turned completely. “If it isn’t the magician. I’ve heard some interesting reports lately. Do you think new clothes and basic self-defense gives you an edge? How can you hope to defeat me?”

“Allow me to demonstrate,” Shadow Weaver said as she ran forward.

Hordak charged his laser blaster and fired. At the last second his arm jerked, firing directly into the air. “What’s wrong with this piece of junk?”

Shadow Weaver jumped on a bot and used its body to launch her in the air. She manifested a sword as she came down, aiming for Hordak’s face.

Hordak blocked the move with his blaster. He swung his left arm, trying to bat Shadow Weaver away but his arm stopped short. He grunted, face twisted with effort as his arm refused to move. The armor against his arm pressed down, returning the weapon to his side. Armored plating around his ribs compressed, making it difficult to breathe. His ribs creaked with the pressure hard enough to bruise though not enough to shatter.

“I thought the soldiers’ reports were madness. The great Shadow Weaver, a pathetic Princess.” Hordak sneered. “My, my fate does have an odd sense of humor.”

“You will not win, Hordak,” Shadow Weaver said, returning the sword to the metal at her hip.

“Is that so?” Hordak asked mockingly. “Etheria is all but conquered. Catra has done more in a few weeks than you have in your entire career as my Tactical Advisor. You taught her too well.”

“Then I’ll give you courtesy she will not. I will let you see the knife before it guts you.” The darkened gauntlet sharpened to a point. “You should have just killed me.” Shadow Weaver spat.

A booming crash shook the ground. Terrified screams sounded in the distance and Shadow Weaver hesitated just inches from Hordak’s face.

Hordak smirked. “Such a shame to finally have all that power and be neutered. Bound by a little moral code. Will you kill me or save them? Tick tock, Princess.” His boisterous laugh at her dilemma turned to a wheezing shout as his right ribs cracked.

Shadow Weaver returned her gauntlet to its original state. She used Hordak’s armor to lift him high in the air and then quickly slammed him to the ground. “That’s for Aldehaim.” Prying off a bot’s shell, she used it to skate across the sand toward the screams.

Hordak scrambled to his feet with a growl. He charged the blaster, aiming for Shadow Weaver’s back. A large orb of light struck him the face and again in the knee. He stumbled back and blinked his eyes, trying to reorient himself. Holding the charge on his blaster, he squinted through the pain and saw Angella flying above him. The queen glared down at him, holding two more orbs of energy.

“Well now, this is a surprise. Look who’s out in the moonlight.” Hordak shot his blaster at Angella.

Angella dove, flying directly for the blast. It was a direct hit on the queen and filled the space with smoke and the smell of crackling ozone. Hordak’s eyes looked around for any sign of the queen’s body when he was suddenly airborne. The smoke was parted by Angella’s wings to reveal a shimmering light shield encasing her body. Hordak soared through the air with a yell and hit the water on the other side of Sea Elf village.

As soon as Shadow Weaver made it over the hill, she saw Sea Hawk being tossed around by the energy shots from a tank.

Ducking under his form, she continued and grabbed the cowering Sea Elves. Placing herself in the tank's line of fire, she started to bend the barrel toward the sky.

A plume of dazzling smoke erupted from the middle and the tank exploded. "Hang on." Glimmer appeared behind them and they were back on Sea Hawk's ship.

"Okay, that was everyone left. Ugh, where's Sea Hawk?" Glimmer asked and flashed out of sight. She returned with the bruised man and dropped him on the deck.

"Glimmer, where did you come from?" Angella smoothly landed on the deck of the ship. "Where's Bow and Adora?"

"Mom?" Glimmer asked, staring at Angella. " *You* came on a rescue mission?"

"We all have to do our part to defeat the Horde," Angella said lightly as though it was an everyday occurrence.

Shadow Weaver stared at Hordak from the ship's stern. His dripping form climbed back up the cliffs overlooking the remnants of Sea Elf Village. Behind her, she heard the sobs of the Sea Elves and turned her head away from their failure.

"You dropped Hordak in the sea. How wicked of you," Shadow Weaver remarked as Angella stepped closer. "It is not what I would have done but effective nonetheless."

"Very effective since you softened him a bit for me," Angella said, patting Shadow Weaver on the shoulder. "I know you wanted to defeat Hordak. You made the right decision to save the villagers."

"I certainly hope so," Shadow Weaver replied.

Adora slammed the double doors to the War Room open. She and Bow were covered in seaweed and oily silt as they marched through the door. “Thanks so much for helping us out back there, Glimmer.”

“Well, I figured since you had such a positive outlook on everything you could handle a little walk from Liquadine on your own,” Glimmer said from her position at the war table.

“Now, Adora, I’m sure Glimmer had a perfectly good reason why she teleported away in the middle of the battle,” Bow said, glancing at his best friend.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “I created a tracking spell that alerted me when Hordak resurfaced and he did today at Sea Elf Village, so that’s where I went. Our battle was already lost.”

“We probably wouldn’t have lost if someone had stayed to help us,” Adora grumbled under her breath.

Bow threw his arms around Adora’s shoulders. “That’s okay, let’s just agree to check in with each other before we go off to fight Horde leadership alone.”

“When did you do a tracking spell?” Angella demanded, walking over to her daughter. “Glimmer, I gave a direct order that you are not to use any magic besides your elemental powers. You have become too aggressive.”

“Mom, the magic is helping.” Glimmer argued. “I got the rest of the villagers out and saved Shadow Weaver’s life today.”

Shadow Weaver barked out a derisive laugh. “You hardly saved me, Commander. I was handling the tank before you arrived.”

“Right, cowering in front of a tank must be a new Princess fighting move I missed in our combat training.” Glimmer countered with a mockingly sweet smile. “My mistake.”

Bow raised his voice. “Alright, let’s look at the positives. We did save Sea Elf Village and no lives were lost in Liquadine today,” he said with an uneasy grin as he took in all the haggard faces staring back at him.

“Thank you, Bow.” Angella nodded, keeping a critical eye on her daughter. “Swift Wind?”

Swift Wind straightened his back and saluted with one of his wings. “Yes, your majesty?”

“You just got back from scouting the Southern Coast, is there anything new you can tell us?” Angella skimmed through the newest stack of progress reports in front of her.

“It’s on fire,” Swift Wind said with boisterous candor. “Lots and lots of fire.”

Angella kept her face blank. “Thank you, Swift Wind.”

“No problem.” The unicorn sank into a small bow.

Bow tried again to boost morale. “I know it’s been tough since we lost Salineas, but we’re picking up the pieces.”

“It’s been more than just ‘tough’, Bow. We failed Mermista,” Glimmer said, pointing to the Water Princess’ empty chair.

“Has she still not come out of her room?” Angella asked.

“No, and we need to do better. We will take back Salineas and take back all of Etheria. No matter what it cost,” Glimmer said, slamming her hands against the War Table. “No matter what the Horde throws at us.”

“Glimmer, those are some very serious words.” Bow eyeing her with concern and not a little fear.

“This *is* serious. This is real. We’re going on mission after mission every day and it doesn’t matter. We have achieved nothing,”

Glimmer said, clenching her fists.

“That’s not true. We’ve restarted the Princess Alliance and united all the kingdoms under your insistence Commander Glimmer,” Angella said.

“And it’s not enough. We sit here and vote and plan while the Horde beats us at every turn. I’m not gonna do it anymore. I’m not gonna sit here talking and reporting all day. This is when our people need us the most. I need to figure out how to stop the Horde anyway I can,” Glimmer said and walked out.

“We’re dismissed,” Angella said quickly, following her daughter out of the room. “Glimmer! Glimmer, come back here. Glimmer, do not walk away from me.”

“So, clearly we’re not gonna get anything done today.” Adora groused as she stomped out. “If anyone needs me I’ll be checking on Mermista.”

With the meeting dismissed, Shadow Weaver retreated to her room. She sat on her chaise lounge slowly with a sigh. Angella appeared in her doorway. “Did you catch up with, Glimmer?” she asked her partner.

“No, she teleported to her room before I could reach her and she’s refusing to answer the door.” Angella smoothed her hands down her clothing. “I don’t know why she’s acting as if she alone will be able to defeat the Horde.”

“I’m afraid I may be to blame for Glimmer’s behavior,” Shadow Weaver said. “I thought she would be able to handle her innate talents.”

“This is exactly what I was afraid of. She’s so impulsive. I don't know how to reach her.” Angella sighed. “What if she can’t be reached?”

“Glimmer’s heart rules her decisions. I have no doubt she will realize her folly in time, Angella. I will talk to her. Who else besides me would know just how far one could fall in their pursuit of power,” Shadow Weaver answered. “Ultimately, tensions are high as we are all stressed and tired.”

“Including you?” Angella asked with a penetrating gaze.

“I am not used to mediocrity and failure, though I will manage,” Shadow Weaver said dismissively. “Do you have any pressing matters to attend to?”

“Nothing at the moment,” Angella said softly. “What did you have planned?”

“We haven’t been able to properly spend time together since the beginning of our courtship. I want to be alone with you, unfortunately I cannot think of anyplace on Etheria where we could achieve this,” Shadow Weaver replied, glancing out her window.

“I know somewhere we can go and it’s completely secluded,” Angella said, pulling a crystal near the armoire. The bottom drawer opened wide and revealed a hidden door and stairs. “In every room, there are false crystals. If there was ever an emergency, everyone in the Palace could get out using multiple escape routes.”

The steps led down to a gilded doorway that opened into a large, lustrous purple cavern. Various sized pearls embedded into the walls cast twinkling light upon the room. An aqua quartz crystal stalactite hung from the very center of the room, glowing brightly.

Angella swept her arm in the air. “Welcome to the Chamber of Queens. This location is passed down from Bright Moon’s monarch

to monarch."

An enormous serpent fell from the ceiling and reared up. It opened its mouth to reveal razor-sharp teeth and a triple forked tongue. Angella held up a calm hand. She let out a series of trilling, guttural chirps and the guardian immediately became docile.

"I see," Shadow Weaver said, watching the scene. "This is why you're not impressed with Slinky."

"I also don't feel the need to flaunt my Elemental everywhere I go." Angella sniffed, petting the Bright Moon Guardian. "Isn't that right, Scerio?" she grinned at Shadow Weaver over her shoulder.

Scerio moved its cobalt eye to Shadow Weaver and flicked its tongue, scenting the air around her. Its pointed, armored plates along the top and sides of its head flared and shook as it assessed her. He slithered closer and with a curious hiss. The plates lowered as Scerio released a hissed imitation of Angella's earlier speech.

"You taught it to speak?" Shadow Weaver's eyes widened.

"It's only one word in Empish. It means friend," Angella responded as Scerio nudged them affectionately and slithered back up the wall. "You have a way with animals."

"Is there some reason they shouldn't adore me?" Shadow Weaver asked, looking through the chamber.

"Not at all." Angella grinned. She looked up the stairs to the altar. "I can't tell you anything more about the Chamber of Queens. It's shrouded in secrecy for the monarchs that command the Moonstone." She walked ahead to another side door.

In the hallway was a gallery of the previous Bright Moon rulers. The media ranged from woven tapestries to painted portraits to holograms and finally, an intricate mosaic similar to the picture that was in the war room was on the end. Below Angella's portrait

was a spot for two magical staffs. There was only one long, bright purple staff on the display stand. It had a pearl crescent moon on the top and the middle held one of the small signature Bright Moon crystals.

“Is this your fighting staff?” Shadow Weaver asked, running her fingers along its surface.

“Micah made it for me. He was certain that one day we would both charge into battle together and finally defeat the Horde,” Angella said.

“I feel like anything I try to say would be inadequate.” Shadow Weaver cupped Angella’s cheek in her right hand. “I am sorry, Angella. Truly.”

“Thank you.” Angella leaned into the touch. “Come along. I just thought of something we could do together.”

They walked to the next room and Angella gestured to a brass globe in the corner of the room. It had numerous multicolored circles all over its surface. “I found this projector down here many years ago,” she said, pressing the top.

“Stars.” Shadow Weaver gasped, craning her neck to see the simulated night sky all around them.

“I figured you’ve never seen them.” Angella smiled at the look of wonder in her partner’s eyes.

“I have never had the pleasure.” Shadow Weaver walked slowly around the room, taking in every star pattern.

“What do you know about constellations?” Angella asked, pushing the globe toward the wall.

“Constellations are cosmic formations that appear in the night sky. They typically represent a mythical being, animals, or inanimate objects. I also know because of stars the First One’s climate was different than ours,” Shadow Weaver recited easily.

“That is absolutely correct,” Angella said lovingly. “We are going to stargaze together.” She pulled off her cape and flapped it in the air to smooth it out. Angella placed the cape on the ground and descended to the floor, pressing her back against the cave wall. She opened her arms, reaching out to Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver stepped gingerly onto the cape. She settled onto it and reclined into Angella. Angella’s arms surrounded her and she relaxed into her embrace with a happy sigh.

Angella rested her chin on Shadow Weaver’s shoulder. “Do you know any of the stories attached to the stars?”

“No, do you?”

“I know a few,” Angella revealed softly. “My mother was quite fond of the fables attached to the stars.”

“And how is Nigella?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“You may ask her yourself if you invoke her name during the evening’s first shine of twilight.”

“No, thank you,” Shadow Weaver said, suppressing a shiver at coming face to face with the Queen of Empyrean after all these years.

“Are you...afraid of my mother?” Angella asked amusedly.

“I am not afraid. I am cautious,” Shadow Weaver said quickly. “There is a vast difference.”

“You are.” Angella sing-songed into Shadow Weaver’s ear.

Shadow Weaver crossed her arms. “You are mistaken.”

“I can call her here now if you like.” Angella teased.

“There is no need. I have nothing I wish to say.”

“If you say so.” Angella brushed her hand over Shadow Weaver’s long fingers. She poked at one talon. “Are these permanent?”

Shadow Weaver chuckled and held up her hand. The nails retracted and completely shrank down until she had short, trimmed onyx fingernails.

“Why would you keep them so long or sharp?” Angella asked, reaching for her hand again.

“I’ve gotten used to them over the years and it goes with my image,” Shadow Weaver replied cheekily.

“Of course.” Angella looked at her fondly then sighed. “I hate to say it.” She reached over to shut off the star projector. “We’ve been gone long enough.”

“This was a magical experience, Angella. Thank you for sharing it with me,” Shadow Weaver said. She assisted Angella with reattaching her cape once they were both standing.

Angella held Shadow Weaver’s hand once again. “Maybe next time we can venture out of the castle.”

“I will work on some way to make that happen.” Shadow Weaver vowed.

Shadow Weaver decided to use her rare moments of free time to check on the remedies and potions in her greenhouse. She was trying to give her tasks all the attention they were due even though she was filled with anticipation of seeing Angella later. Thankfully, Shadow Weaver found all of her ingredients exactly where she left them. She had arranged them in preparation for her return to the greenhouse but one could never be too careful. Her hands moved of their own accord as she prepared the

ingredients for her pain and health potions. After the pain potions were all poured into their glass flasks, she took a trowel to dig up her explosive potions from flower pots filled with muddy soil.

Scrutinizing each flask against the bright moonlight, she consulted her notes to determine which had the desired texture. She found the dictamnus jar and removed it from the bucket of water with great care. The line she etched on the side of the jar indicated no one had tampered with the potions or the results.

“I need your help,” Glimmer said, landing inside the greenhouse.

“I see.” After double checking her notations, Shadow Weaver procured three flowers from the jar in front of her and began brewing her newest experiment. “How can I be of assistance?” She asked.

“Before I released you, you said you could make me more powerful but I need more,” Glimmer said, walking closer. “I need to get stronger.”

“Glimmer, you are already one of the most powerful beings on Etheria.” Shadow Weaver shaved flints into the dictamnus liquid. “Your power will continue to grow every day. All you need to do now is refine it.”

“There had to be more for me to learn. I know Mom listens to you. She believed you about the spy,” Glimmer said, stopping at the work table. “Convince her to let me have magic lessons again. They were helping. I was helping.”

“It is eerie,” Shadow Weaver said.

“What is?” Glimmer asked.

“I was once where you are. Hungry for purpose and motivated by the violent invasion ravaging Etheria. It was why I started to look into modifying the Spell of Obtainment. I do not say this often.” Shadow Weaver turned to face the teen. She placed a gentle hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “I have made a terrible error. I should not

have goaded you into this journey. Do not let this consume you, Glimmer. Losing Salineas was not your fault."

"I'm not you." Glimmer brushed Shadow Weaver's hand away from her shoulder. "I can handle my power. My magic is full of light, not darkness."

"Light or dark all power corrupts in the end if you are not careful. It took me a long time to learn that."

"I just want to save everyone," Glimmer said.

"You informed me numerous times that Princesses work together. Remember that you are not alone in trying to save Etheria."

"Okay," Glimmer said softly and teleported away.

"You missed afternoon tea," Angella said, her heeled boots stopped just to the right of a kneeling Shadow Weaver.

"Hello, Angella," Shadow Weaver said cordially. "I had not realized how much time had passed. We said we would meet after supper once everyone had gone to bed."

"I have been thinking," Angella said. "If you are amicable, I'd like to see you in my rooms tonight."

Shadow Weaver stood and regarded her partner. "Are we no longer going to take our time?"

"With this war, I'm not sure we can continue to take our time. The Alliance's morale is at an all-time low and the Horde is gaining more territory than we can recapture," Angella held Shadow Weaver's hands. "My proposal is about intimacy. I find myself wanting to spend any spare moment with you. If that evolves into coupling then we will explore it together."

"A proposition and a proposal all rolled into one. When should I expect my dowry?" Shadow Weaver asked.

“Tease if you want but you better be at my door after dinner,” Angella said, flicking her index finger under Shadow Weaver’s chin playfully.

“Is that a threat? If I don’t show up, will you punish me?” Shadow Weaver asked coyly.

“I’m sure I can have that arranged. I am queen after all,” Angella said with a wicked smile.

Night could not come soon enough for Shadow Weaver. Her anxiety and anticipation did not return until she was in front of Angella’s door. She glanced at both sides to make sure there was no one in the immediate vicinity to see her enter and placed two sharp raps against the double doors.

“Enter.” She heard Angella call through the door.

When Shadow Weaver opened the door, she didn’t see Angella right away. Once she got further into the royal suite she spotted Angella at the vanity, brushing her hair. Her ever present white gloves were absent.

“How could you have been so sure it was me?” Shadow Weaver asked, closing the door behind her.

“I told the guards I’m not to be disturbed unless there’s a dire emergency,” Angella explained, spinning to the side as she began to apply scented oil to her legs. "I doubt I would get such a polite knock during an emergency."

Shadow Weaver’s eyes widened as she saw the other woman’s attire. The thin, powder pink robe fell just to the tops of Angella’s thighs and teased at the outline of the figure beneath it.

“Is that so?” Shadow Weaver replied absently as she finally pulled her eyes from the sash tie at Angella’s waist. She desperately wanted to pull the simple knot and reveal the expanse of skin to her hungry gaze.

Angella stood and noticed Shadow Weaver hadn’t moved since she stepped into the room. She followed Shadow Weaver’s stare. “Is it too much?” the queen asked nervously.

“You look otherworldly,” Shadow Weaver responded honestly.

“Thank you,” Angella said as a shy grin tugged at her lips. “I prepared a mineral bath with the enchanted salts from Mystacor. I want you to be relaxed and pain-free tonight. At least for a little while,” she said with a wink, pulling Shadow Weaver along to the large bathroom.

“Someone is bold tonight,” Shadow Weaver said, rubbing her thumb over the soft hand in hers. “Are you trying to seduce me, Angella?”

“Says the woman that flirts as often as she breathes.”

Shadow Weaver tugged to bring Angella into her arms. “Your reactions are so intriguing. You still make it too easy for me.”

“And you just like vexing me. Go on, into the bath. There is a robe and clean underclothes provided for you when you’re done.” Angella pushed Shadow Weaver gently into the bathroom and pulled the door closed behind her.

Shadow Weaver quickly got undressed and placed her mask on top of the clean towels by the sink. She stepped into the large claw foot tub filled to the brim with bubbles. Taking a deep breath, she allowed herself to sink under the water. When her lungs finally began to burn, she emerged from the water and grabbed the hand towel and soap provided. As she washed, it felt like she was scrubbing her body clean of the day’s stress. Once her washing was done, she got dressed in the new underclothes left for her. She was grateful not to see a pink eyesore left for her.

She grabbed the midnight blue floor-length silk nightgown hanging from the door and redonned her mask before returning to the bedroom.

In the middle of the floor, Angella sat on an oversized floor pillow serenely waiting for Shadow Weaver. “Come join me,” She gazed at the brunette from under her eyelashes and patted the space beside her. “I’ll massage your back.”

“That sounds wonderful but I would much rather pamper you. I did request to court you after all,” Shadow Weaver said. “I have yet to provide a date or gift for you.”

“It’s not a competition,” Angella rose on her knees and held out her hand to Shadow Weaver.

“I have not allowed anyone to look upon my body since the Spell.”

Angella raised an eyebrow. “I’m not just anyone and I’m aware of what the Spell of Obtainment did to you.”

The full extent of the situation came at Shadow Weaver all at once. She and Angella were alone and barring an immediate emergency they would be together in this room unless she left. Angella had stated that tonight was about intimacy. All Shadow Weaver could think about was how long it had been since someone had touched her. She would be lucky if she didn’t peak with the first touch of Angella’s hands. Her partner was proposing a massage to relax her and it sounded like the most decadent form of torment to Shadow Weaver.

“No one has ever seen the full extent. There is a difference between being aware of scars and seeing the all damage.” Shadow Weaver tried to stall.

“Robe off.” Angella narrowed her eyes seemingly catching on to what Shadow Weaver was doing and pointed to the cushion beneath her. “Lie down.”

Shadow Weaver followed the instruction and sank to her knees and laid on the edge of the soft cotton pillow. She felt the delicate double lines of gold foil inlayed in its fabric against her hands as she tried to find a comfortable spot. The brunette could feel herself tensing even more as she felt Angella's movement towards her.

"You'll need to come closer than that," Angella said with a chuckle.

Shadow Weaver scooted just a bit closer and waited. All possible thoughts escaped her head as Angella's soft hands pressed firmly against her skin. When Angella's hands tripped across the base of Shadow Weaver's spine, she inhaled sharply.

"I'm sorry." Angella removed her hands at once. "Did I hurt you? Is the pressure too much?"

"No," Shadow Weaver croaked out. She took a breath, cleared her throat, and continued, "No, I'd like it a bit rougher."

"Are you sure?" Angella asked, sliding a finger along with the tangled assortment of scars along Shadow Weaver's back. "I would think these would be sensitive."

"They are." Shadow Weaver squirmed, beginning to feel a persistent pulse between her legs. With any luck, she could convince Angella that she was ticklish and that would be the end of it.

Angella's hands pressed down on Shadow Weaver's hips. "Stay still."

"How can I?" Shadow Weaver ground out.

"I'm just trying to help," Angella said soothingly. "Do you want me to stop?"

"No."

“Then let me help,” Angella said, and then Shadow Weaver felt a warm weight on the back of her thighs.

“What are you doing?” Shadow Weaver started to get up.

“Keeping you in place. Now stop moving.” Angella insisted, running her hands up Shadow Weaver’s sides. “For once just let someone help you.” The queen’s hands brushed the outline of her breasts and this time a moan did escape Shadow Weaver’s mouth.

Angella pressed herself against the brunette’s back. “We don’t have to do anything you’re not comfortable with.” Her lips brushed against the pointed ears of her partner’s. “Stay here tonight. The bed is more than big enough for both of us.”

Shadow Weaver bit down on her lip to stop the mewl that nearly sprang forth. Her ears were very sensitive. She had never before allowed anybody, including any of her lovers near them. She tilted her head and flicked her ear away from the warm breath and plump lips. “It is also suspended from the ceiling.” She pointed out.

“I can help with that.” Angella rose onto her feet, opened her wings, and held out her hands. She scooped Shadow Weaver up in a Princess carry as the brunette stood. With little difficulty, she flew up to her bed and deposited Shadow Weaver on the surface.

Shadow Weaver melted in the plush linens of Angella’s bed. “Mm.”

“Are you okay?” Angella asked with a chuckle.

“This is the softest bed I’ve ever laid in,” Shadow Weaver said, stretching her hands over her head.

Angella slipped under the soft blanket and pulled Shadow Weaver closer. “Do you remember our first kiss?” she asked.

“How could I forget? You dragged me to that wretched beach again, insisting that we needed to see how it looked under the moonlight at night.”

“You’re still annoyed about that?”

“There was sand in my shoes for days.”

“You’re ruining a perfectly good moment, you know.”

Shadow Weaver took off her mask and turned. She took hold of Angella's chin with her forefinger and thumb. "We can make a new one," she suggested.

Shadow Weaver had been craving this moment since the first kiss they shared when they resumed dating. She imagined it numerous times before that and was overwhelmed by the longing of finally kissing Angella again. They met in the middle, the brushing of their lips was a slow and unhurried dance.

Angella pulled her closer, running her hands across the back of Shadow Weaver’s shoulders and disappearing into the thick head of hair. Shadow Weaver’s tongue brushed teasingly against Angella’s lips, coaxing them open. She savored the taste of the faint sweetness from the wine the queen drank earlier at dinner. Sharp teeth nipped Angella’s bottom lip and she moaned into Shadow Weaver’s mouth.

Shadow Weaver pressed herself forward and flipped them over so she was straddling Angella. The brunette kissed her partner in earnest, settling her weight between her legs. Angella shivered as Shadow Weaver’s hand brushed the inside of her open robe.

“That is the real reason you wore this robe, isn’t it? Easy access.” Shadow Weaver drawled, grinding against Angella teasingly. She delighted in the blush it produced across Angella’s face and the gasp that burst forth.

Immediately following was a quick flash of panic in Angella’s eyes as Shadow Weaver started to dip her hand lower. Shadow Weaver

rolled to the side of her partner. “I think it would best not to rush into anything we might regret,” she panted.

“I never thought to ask. Are you not interested in sexual contact?” Angella asked.

“You ask after what just occurred?” Shadow Weaver laughed quietly and shook her head. “I desire you and desperately want to be intimate. I’m not ready just yet and I suspect you aren’t as well.”

“I thought I might want to,” Angella said, running a hand through her hair.

“Whenever you are ready I will be right here.” Shadow Weaver gave her a sweet, chaste kiss. “We’ll return to your original plan. We will do what feels natural and comfortable.”

“You are so wise,” Angella said lightly as she trailed her index finger across the ridge of Shadow Weaver’s nose and smiled when it scrunched at the tickling touch.

Shadow Weaver stopped the finger and nipped it playfully. “Let’s get some sleep.”

All Shadow Weaver really knew when she awakened the next morning was that it was too early. It was too early and her body was thrumming with desire. Angella was draped over her left side and held her in a tight embrace. Shadow Weaver’s face was buried in the queen’s neck while their legs were tangled together. The ombré haired woman’s breath tickled over the pointed ridge of her ear with every exhale. The brunette fought the urge to rock against the thigh wedged between her own.

Shadow Weaver groped the edge of the bed, hoping to put some distance between herself and Angella when she suddenly remembered she was not on the ground, but in the air. Until Angella woke up or rolled over, she was stuck pinned beneath the other woman. Angella shifted in her sleep with a mumble, brushing her lips across Shadow Weaver's ear. The older woman valiantly fought the groan clawing its way out of her throat but it was no use. The sound escaped and vibrated right against Angella's neck.

Angella instantly roused, looking down at Shadow Weaver. "What's wrong?"

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes and tried to slow her breathing. She angled her head away from Angella. "Nothing is wrong," she said tightly.

"Why won't you look at me?" Angella whispered. "Do you regret last night?"

Shadow Weaver snapped her head back to look at her partner at the hurt tone in Angella's voice. "Not at all, Angella. I-"

"Then what is wrong?" Angella repeated. "Please tell me."

"It is my ears," Shadow Weaver said slowly.

"Yes?"

"You brushed them in your sleep."

"Did I hurt you? I suspected they were sensitive."

"No, you did not hurt me," Shadow Weaver said. She didn't elaborate further and just continued to look deeply into Angella's eyes with an arched eyebrow.

What the older woman was trying to convey suddenly dawned on Angella. She moved her hands slowly, giving Shadow Weaver

ample time to pull away. She trailed her fingers up and down the pointed helix. “I like your ears.”

“I might have noticed.” Came the strained response.

“So I was correct.” Angella nipped the ear lobe and sucked it into her mouth. “Your ears are very sensitive.”

Shadow Weaver began panting under her breath. She shifted restlessly. “Angella.” She breathed.

Angella was intoxicated by the effect she was having on her normally stoic partner. She pulled away and returned her fingers, tracing the delicate shape of the older woman’s ear. Their breath mingled as Angella began to close the distance between them. Angella pressed her lips to Shadow Weaver’s and squeezed her breast gently. Shadow Weaver inhaled sharply feeling the warmth rush through her veins at the touch. Shadow Weaver pushed weakly then more insistently until she was straddling Angella.

Angella broke the kiss. “Why must you be on top?” she whispered.

“Why do you let me?” Shadow Weaver purred.

The brunette used her weight to press her partner against the bed. Shadow Weaver placed scattered kisses down Angella’s jaw and the column of her neck. When the older woman reached the base of Angella's neck she sucked at the soft skin and nipped at random intervals. The ombré haired woman moaned softly. She tightened her hold, keeping Shadow Weaver’s mouth on her neck and arched into the warm body above her.

Glimmer teleported onto her mother’s bed. “Mom, I’m sorry it’s so early. I wanted to ask you about some missing boo- what the fuck!?”

“Glimmer, language,” Angella said, grabbing her discarded robe from the bed.

“Don’t language me right now. You’re in bed with Shadow Weaver.” Glimmer screamed.

“Would you hand me my mask?” Shadow Weaver’s words were muffled against Angella’s shoulder as she waited for the item to be passed to her. She glanced at Angella. “You were supposed to tell her,” she said, covering her body with the blanket.

“Of course I did. I told her when…” Angella began then trailed off. “Oh, dear.”

“What? What were you supposed to tell me?” Glimmer demanded.

“You have to calm down, Glimmer,” Shadow Weaver said, affixing the mask.

“No, no way. You don’t get to tell me to calm down when I find you in bed with my mother.” Glimmer shook her head with a sneer. “Is this the real reason why we stopped magic lessons? You decided to go for someone that held more power?”

“I would never use Angella that way,” Shadow Weaver protested.

“Glimmer, Shadow Weaver and I are dating,” Angella confessed quickly.

“Oh, okay,” Glimmer said and promptly fainted.

“Glimmer,” Angella exclaimed, reaching for her daughter.

“What’s all the commotion? Who’s being attacked?” She-Ra and Bow burst through the door. “What’s wrong with Glimmer? Shadow Weaver, why are you in bed with the queen?”

“Glimmer had a shock and fainted,” Shadow Weaver said simply.

Glimmer groaned and sat up. “Guys, you’ll never believe the crazy dream I just had,” she said, shaking her head. “My mom told me she was dating Shadow Weaver.”

She-Ra opened and closed her mouth several times. Then finally she let loose a scoff followed by a series of high pitched sputters as she pointed between Angella and Shadow Weaver.

“Are you going to say words or continue with your bird calls?” Shadow Weaver sighed. She and Angella landed gently on the floor.

“I’m stunned. What do you expect?” She-Ra asked.

“Stunned people are generally silent,” Shadow Weaver said, still clutching the blanket to her body.

Bow folded his weapon and attached it to his back. “I wondered when this would happen.”

Adora powered down. “Bow, you knew?”

“I only had suspicions. There was nothing concrete until today.” Bow couldn’t help glancing at the mark on Angella’s neck.

Angella immediately moved her hair over her shoulder to cover the mark from view.

Glimmer teleported to the floor. “Why didn’t you say anything?” she asked, looking at her best friend.

“Glimmer, what was I supposed to say?” Bow asked. “‘Hey guys, you ever noticed how Shadow Weaver has a crush on the Queen?’ That wouldn’t have gone over well.”

“How did you even suspect anything when Shadow Weaver wears a mask?” Adora asked.

“Body language." Bow shrugged like it was obvious. “Whenever Shadow Weaver is in the room with Angella she always shifts towards the queen just a bit like she’s ready to defend any threats.”

“Aww,” Adora said, glancing at Shadow Weaver.

“Fine. Whatever. Are you going to continue dating Shadow Weaver, mom?” Glimmer asked. “What about dad?”

“My love for Shadow Weaver does not negate my love for Micah. Your father will always have a place in my heart, Glimmer,” Angella said.

“Love? You *love* her? You actually love Shadow Weaver?” Glimmer sputtered.

Angella smiled softly at the woman beside her. “Yes, Glimmer I-”

“You brought her into our life!” Glimmer bared her teeth as she turned to Adora. “Oh, I need to know if Shadow Weaver must have some good deep, deep down inside her,” she paraphrased. “What a load of bull. She would have been better off dead.”

“Glimmer!” Angella shouted.

“Glimmer, what?” Bow asked.

“Take that back,” Adora said with a gasp.

“Why do you keep defending her? She abused you and Catra,” Glimmer said, pointing to Shadow Weaver.

“I remember what Shadow Weaver did to us and that’s between me and her,” Adora said. “All she’s been doing recently is help us.”

“She’s been helping herself to my mother. I told you evil people don’t change.” Glimmer hissed.

Shadow Weaver tried to keep as much dignity as she could be wrapped in a fluffy coral comforter. “Glimmer, whatever your misgivings about me I assure you that I would never willingly hurt your mother and I’m not trying to replace Micah.”

“I wouldn’t be surprised if that wasn’t your plan all along considering you probably killed him.” Glimmer shot back.

“You are completely out of line and out of control,” Angella shouted. “Apologize right now.”

“I will never apologize to her,” Glimmer sneered.

“Apologize or go to your room,” Angella said. “I will be there to speak to you shortly.”

“No.” Glimmer shook her head, standing her ground.

Angella was taken aback. “What did you just say?”

“I said no. I’m not going to my room,” Glimmer said slowly.

“It wasn’t a request,” Angella said, standing closer to her daughter. “I’m the queen and I can make you if I have to.”

“Glimmer, what is wrong with you?” Bow asked, resting a hand on her shoulder.

“I’m sick of talking,” Glimmer said, moving Bow’s hand away. “All anyone wants to do lately is talk. What does it fix? Nothing. Nothing changes.”

“Hey,” Bow said softly, shushing Glimmer and pulled her into a hug. “What is really the issue here?”

“We’re going to mission after mission and no one will admit that She-Ra’s not the savior we thought she was. All she’s done since she's come into our lives is made things worse,” Glimmer said.

“I’m doing my best, Glimmer. We are trying to fix this but you don’t want anyone’s help. You just keep rushing off,” Adora said.

“Your best isn’t good enough! We keep failing and no one is on my side, not even my mother.” Glimmer waved a hand in Angella’s general direction. “Why can’t you just trust me?”

“Because you stopped including me in your decisions!” Adora shouted. “You, me, and Bow were always a team. We were the

Best Friends Squad and now I don't know what we are." Her arms dropped to her sides.

Glimmer's voice became eerily calm. "If that's how you feel, then we aren't friends."

"Glimmer!" Bow reached out for Glimmer as she teleported away. "Adora!" He ran after the blonde as she stormed away.

Angella had the Bright Moon guards searching every inch of the Palace for the rest of the day and could not find any traces of Glimmer. Shadow Weaver and Spinnerella traveled to Plumeria, Dryl, the Frost Kingdom, and the refugee camps with no success. It seemed as though Glimmer had well and truly vanished until they finally got word that she was in Mystacor and didn't wish to see her mother.

Shadow Weaver walked across the grass through the courtyard of Bright Moon. She passed Slinky's spherical form rocking sedately on the grass. His metal coating glittered in the softness of the afternoon moonlight. Tapping two fingers against his shell, she invited the Elemental to walk with her.

Slinky nudged her roughly, nearly pitching her off her feet. "Not now." Shadow Weaver warned.

The Elemental persisted and rolled quickly to Shadow Weaver who caught him. Her heels skidded along the dirt.

"What are you doing?" Adora asked as she jogged up to the odd scene.

"I'm performing strength and reactionary exercises," Shadow Weaver said, pushing her arms straight. Slinky shot up into the air

and sailed over the Whispering Woods. He landed nearby with a crash and emerged from the trees with a mechanical chirp.

Adora looked at Shadow Weaver as if trying to solve First Ones' sigils for the first time. "You're playing with him," she said as her mouth curled into a soft smile that didn't reach her eyes.

"Adora, you are looking more pensive than usual." Shadow Weaver left a series of taps along Slinky's shell. The elemental rolled away into a shaded patch near the gazebo. "I take it Glimmer has refused to see you as well?"

"This isn't about Glimmer." Adora frowned with a scoff. "I came to you because I need your help."

"Of course, Adora. How can I be of assistance?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"Bow is heading to Mara's ship for repairs and I'm going to speak with Madame Razz," Adora explained.

"She would be good to consult," Shadow Weaver agreed.

"Madame Razz knows all about magic and She-Ra and I think she was even here when Mara was still around. I need to understand what the Heart of Etheria Project is." Adora paused, blinking. "Wait. You know who Madame Razz is?"

"Yes, Angella and I were trapped in the Whispering Woods during the spore storm and we came upon her cottage," Shadow Weaver said.

"Oh that's great news," Adora said with relief, relaxing her features. "Because I can never find her when I'm looking for her only when I need her."

Madame Razz's cottage was much the same as the last time Shadow Weaver visited but it seemed to be filled with more oddities along the walls and somehow the stone furniture had been relocated.

"Oh, Mara, dearie. You should have told me we were gonna have more company," Madame Razz said, not turning around as she rustled through her hut. She knocked over objects and grabbed a wicker basket from the floor.

"Razz, what are you looking for?" Adora asked.

"Ingredients for the pie we are making with Swift Wind and Little Bea!" Madame Razz shouted. She tossed three decorative fans over her shoulder.

"Little Bea?" Adora asked, looking at Shadow Weaver.

"Do not ask," Shadow Weaver said.

Adora jumped as a wicker basket and two cloth dolls were shoved in her arms. "Why are you talking about Swift Wind? He's not even here."

"Hey, Adora," Swift Wind said cheerfully then squinted. "Shadow Weaver."

"Steed," Shadow Weaver said.

Madame Razz finally turned and regarded Shadow Weaver closely. "Ah, You are finally found now. Princess of the Under People. The Kingdom of Algernon."

"That's Aldehaim, Razz," Adora said as a straw sun hat landed on her head.

"Don't correct me, Mara. It's not nice to correct an old woman. Razz knows the truth better than anyone." She spilled out some flour and what looked like rice across her counter. Using her rolling pin, she began to mash it together.

Adora tossed her head, trying to dislodge the hat. “Swift Wind what are you even doing here?”

“I always come to see Madame Razz. You have to check up on old ladies living alone in the woods. Have a heart, Adora,” Swift Wind said with a disapproving shake of his head.

“Madame Razz, we have come to consult you about the Heart of Etheria project.” Shadow Weaver called out to the crone.

“Now we must have sugar!” Madame Razz suddenly declared as she shoved pie crust into a cracked Horde helmet.

“What do you need sugar for?” Adora asked.

Madame Razz swatted Adora with the broom. “The pie, Mara. You can’t have a proper pie without sugar.” She dumped another armload of items with Shadow Weaver and walked out of the hut with a second wicker basket.

“So, apparently we’re making a pie,” Adora said, dropping everything on the floor as soon as Madame Razz was out of sight.

“She does seem to be quite fond of them.” Shadow Weaver put her armload on the nearby cluttered counter and followed Madame Razz’s path through the Whispering Woods.

“Adora, I don’t think Razz can help this time,” Swift Wind said. He ducked under low branches and hopped over roots.

They watched as Madame Razz yelled into the trees at the mysterious Loo-Kee neither of them saw.

“Do you want to try other avenues?” Shadow Weaver tilted her head at Adora in question.

“Look Swifty, Shadow Weaver, I know Madame Razz doesn’t look like much but she’s always been there when I needed her. I promise you she knows something. Even if she doesn’t know she knows. I have a plan.” Adora glanced at the older woman.

“Was your plan to lose her? Because you lost her,” Swift Wind stated, looking at the space Madame Razz used to occupy.

“Oh shoot.” Adora squinted through the trees “Razz? Razz!”

“I saw her. She headed this way looking for sugar.” Shadow Weaver pointed behind her.

They ran to catch up with the woman and found her just ahead in a clearing. It was an ancient First Ones’ ruin with a statue holding a sword that appeared to be the Sword of Protection. The Whispering Woods had taken back the stone, vines covered its surface as they approached it.

Adora looked at the destroyed statue noticing the deep marks along its surface. “These were made from a sword. Mara’s sword. She was here.”

“Wow, she must have been really crazy,” Swift Wind remarked as he witnessed the destruction of the statue.

“This is not madness. Mara did this in anger and desperation.” Shadow Weaver ran a hand down one deep groove.

“Why? What did she find out that made her want to do this?” Adora pulled the vines away to reveal the statue’s face staring up at her.

“Oh good, you found the sugar. Now we need berries.” Madame Razz grabbed the box and scurried around picking berries.

Adora saw a piece of crystal glinting next to a box of sugar. She picked it up, turning it over in her hands.

“Adora, keep up and help an old woman pick berries.” Madame Razz turned with her basket, wagging a finger at Shadow Weaver. “No sneaking berries.”

“This was left deliberately. Why was it there?” Adora showed Madame Razz the crystal once she had caught up to the older

woman.

“Oh, that’s from Mara. She wants to speak to you.” Madame Razz nodded to herself as if to reassure her mind of the answer.

Adora gently gripped Madame Razz’s shoulder. “But she can’t. Mara has been gone for a thousand years.”

Madame Razz paused then shook her head, disturbing the moths about. “That’s not right. Mara promised we’d make a pie together today.”

Adora smoothed her features trying a different approach. “Razz, why is today the day we need to make the pie?”

“Keep up, Adora. It’s an important day.” Madame Razz bopped her with the broom.

“What is important about today? Shadow Weaver asked.

“Today...” Madame Razz hesitated in her berry picking. “Today is the day I must-duck!” She moved to avoid something unseen.

Adora drew her sword.

“Adora, wait. I think she’s having another memory,” Shadow Weaver said quickly.

“She’s remembering talking to Mara again.” Adora realized and began to listen in.

“The sword does not make you She-Ra. You are She-Ra. There’s no magic that can change that because you can’t control magic. Magic just is.” Madame Razz was looking at an unseen recipient to her dialogue but her magnified eyes were boring through Shadow Weaver as she spoke. “Your people made the sword for She-Ra but she has always been here.”

“What people?” Adora asked once Madame Razz finished speaking. “Are you talking about the First Ones?”

“First Ones, of course, dearie.” Madame Razz snacked on a handful of berries.

Shadow Weaver plucked a couple of berries from the closest bush and placed it in the wicker basket. “Madame Razz, you said Mara wanted to speak to Adora. Does it have something to do about the Heart of Etheria?”

Madame Razz smiled and patted Shadow Weaver’s hand. “Yes, Mara wanted to warn Adora that she was in grave danger.”

“Mara, was here before with you wasn’t she?” Adora asked.

“Oh, Mara you were never supposed to succeed. You gave your all and Razz could do nothing to stop it or save you. Mara or Adora, it always ends up the same.” Madame Razz bowed her head as her tears flowed down her face.

Adora turned Madame Razz around, holding her shoulders. “It doesn’t have to end up like that Razz. Help me, Adora. I’m here now.”

“Oh, yes. Razz can help but we need to hurry.” Madame Razz looked up at the sky. “It’s almost time.”

Adora beamed and leaned against Swift Wind. “See, I told you there was a method to Razz’s brilliance.”

“It’s almost time to put the pie in,” Madame Razz said, running away like something was chasing her back to her cottage.

“What!?” Adora exclaimed.

“There’s no time left!” Razz yelled back from her concealed location in the Whispering Woods.

“Madame Razz is rather spry for a woman having lived for over a millennia,” Shadow Weaver commented.

“It’s getting late. Maybe if we help her finish the pie we can unlock the rest of her memories.” Adora hopped on Swift Wind’s back.

When they finally got back to the hut, Madame Razz was placing the pie on near fire to cook. Shadow Weaver watched the older woman as she swept. It was an exercise in futility however as all she did was use her broom to move the pile of mess from one side of the cottage to the other.

“You are still wondering if Madame Razz is a batty old woman, yes?” She paused in her sweeping. The broom stood by itself as she walked forward. “Something has changed or shifted maybe. I try hard to think and everything gets all muddled.” She waved her hands and counted on her fingers. “Mara, Adora, the present, future, and the past.”

Adora yawned as her lids drooped down over her eyes.

Shadow Weaver kneeled next to Adora. “Sleep,” she said softly.

“I can’t. There’s so much I need answers for,” Adora said through another yawn.

“The timer will go off when the pie is done and we can resume our task,” Shadow Weaver said, smoothing Adora’s hair down as she began to hum a lullaby she made up when Adora was particularly fussy as an infant. Adora was asleep in moments. Shadow Weaver leaned back against the slumbering Swift Wind and closed her eyes.

“You have a decision to make.” Madame Razz’s voice came from directly beside Shadow Weaver.

The pleasant smell of cinnamon, assorted wild berries, and a toasted, buttery crust in the air teased Shadow Weaver awake before she registered the words that were spoken above her. “What decision?”

“You know even when you do not know or wish to know.” Madame Razz responded simply.

“And what is it I’m supposed to not know?” Shadow Weaver asked. Try as she might her sleep-addled mind was unable to follow any of the conversation.

“Heroes take many forms but we all move towards one goal,” Madame Razz said calmly. “You had it taken from you once. Don’t do yourself a disservice this time.” The timer rang nearly echoing in the small hut.

Before Shadow Weaver could react, Madame Razz was off and running again. “Adora, wake up.” She shook the blonde’s shoulder.

Adora sat up, watching as the curtain to the hut draped close. “Swift Wind, come on.”

Swift Wind awakened with a toss of his mane. “What? Where are we going?”

“The pie is done,” Adora said. She stood and walked out.

Shadow Weaver glanced at Adora and noted the blonde looked as though her world had been shattered yet again. When she placed the crystal key into its slot on the control panel she couldn’t have known what to expect about Mara’s message. No one could have predicted this revelation. The Heart of Etheria Project was created by the First Ones’ to destroy their enemies. Etheria itself was a

weapon. Light Hope was a corrupted computer program that brought Adora through the portal, not Hordak. No matter how shocking the truths were, Shadow Weaver wasn't completely surprised that this was the case.

Adora wiped her eyes on her sleeve. "Mara gave her life to save everyone."

"She was brave, my Mara," Madame Razz said, placing the pie on the captain's chair. "There you go Mara, dearie." Without another word, she walked out of the ship and into the night.

"I'll make sure she gets home safe," Swift Wind said quietly trotting after Madame Razz.

"Adora, we have to destroy this," Bow said.

"Perhaps the First Ones were foolish to store all that raw magical energy in the planet's core, but it's still magic. We can use it if we could figure out how to tap into it," Shadow Weaver said.

Bow pressed the heels of his hands against his eyes. "I can't believe you. You want to try to harness something that could destroy a planet," he said angrily.

"Part of me is not even shocked," Adora said dully. She had her arms crossed. "Are you surprised?" she asked Bow.

"It was merely a suggestion." Shadow Weaver shrugged.

"If you were truly watching then you know there may be no way this could be helpful, Shadow Weaver." Adora sighed. "If and only if everyone agrees am I willing to consider alternatives." She retrieved the crystal key from the ship's control panel. "Can you stand with me if our only choice is to destroy it? If our only choice is to destroy all the magic in the core of Etheria. Can you trust me?" she held out her hand to Shadow Weaver.

Adora unknowingly placed her in a position unlike any she had ever been a part of. Everything in her wanted to fight to save the

limitless power just under their feet. Shadow Weaver was certain they could never truly annihilate the magic. 'Magic just is' Madame Razz had said. Etheria would take care of itself and magic would continue to exist even if it survived in another form. Try as Shadow Weaver might, she could never control all the magic in Etheria. It was an easy choice to make.

"Yes, I will stand with you." Shadow Weaver slowly grabbed Adora's hand.

"Thank you," Adora said genuinely. "Let's get back to Bright Moon and tell everyone what we found out."

"So we fixed the recording from Mara's ship and found out what the Heart of Etheria is," Adora said and began to summarize their adventure in the Whispering Woods.

"I hope you don't plan on having a Princess Alliance meeting without me," Glimmer said, coming into the room.

"How long have you been in Bright Moon? Do you have any idea how worried I've been about you?" Angella asked, rushing forward to hug Glimmer.

"I'm sure you had plenty of comfort." Glimmer teleported away from the embrace and glared at Shadow Weaver. "I have news that we should all hear."

"Excuse me, young lady you storm off and I have to hear from Castaspella about your whereabouts and you think you can just march in here and interrupt this meeting?" Angella was near yelling as her wings opened behind her. "Explain yourself now."

"There's no time for explanations," Glimmer said, turning her back on her mother. "Double Trouble told me they know what the

Horde is doing with the communication components. Hordak is trying to send a message to Horde Prime so he can invade us with his armada."

"He must be coming for the Heart of Etheria." Shadow Weaver surmised, ignoring the jab. "We can't allow him to access it."

"That brings me to this," Adora said, calling up a simulation for the Heart of Etheria. "In the center of the planet is all the stored magic of Etheria." The planet glowed, shaking and growing until it burst into holographic shards all around them.

Perfuma gasped. "That's really gonna happen to Etheria? To us?"

"Tell me that's not true," Angella said with a stricken look on her face.

"It's true. That's what will happen if the Heart is ever activated and used." Shadow Weaver confirmed.

"The Heart of Etheria nearly destroyed everyone in Mara's time. It can't be allowed to go off," Bow said grimly.

Mermista groaned, rolling her eyes skywards. "Why?"

"How can we stop it?" Angella asked, her eyes pleaded with Shadow Weaver to have a solution.

"You said this is all of Etheria's magic through the centuries?" Glimmer asked with a smile. "What if there was a way to restore it? We could use it to defeat the Horde."

Adora balled her hands into fists as she started speaking as calmly as she could. "Glimmer, you heard Bow. This is a massive superweapon. There is no way to restore the magic or channel it without it going off. We have to disable it."

"You don't know that," Glimmer said, turning to the woman beside her. "Shadow Weaver, you know we're running out of options. Every day the Horde claims more territory." Her hand waved over

the War room table. It showed a map of all the recently claimed territory. “You all know trying to tap into the Heart of Etheria is the right thing, the smart thing. So, I say we get Light Hope to tell us how it works and we can get our power back.”

“Am I your ally now?” Shadow Weaver inquired acerbically.

“Light Hope can’t be trusted. All she wants to do is set the weapon off. Why aren’t you getting that? Even Shadow Weaver knows it’s dangerous and she’s a power-hungry sorceress turned power-hungry Princess.” Adora paused, turning to Shadow Weaver. “No offense.”

Shadow Weaver held up her index finger, lowered it, and waved her hand dismissively.

“If she was thinking clearly, she would agree that we should use the Heart of Etheria,” Glimmer said. “If you three had already made up your mind on your little Best Friend Quest, why did you even call this meeting?”

“I am capable of making my own decisions,” Shadow Weaver said though her objections went unheard.

“Are you even listening!?” Adora yelled.

“Clearly we’re getting nowhere right now.” Angella stood. “Let’s take a five minute break to think about our stance on the Heart of Etheria.”

“I second that,” Bow said.

Perfuma and Frosta walked out of the War room quietly.

“Madame Razz is home safe and sound but you know not sound of mind.” Swift Wind stated as he arrived.

Mermista walked to the other side of the table with Adora, replaying the planet’s simulation over and over.

Shadow Weaver wondered if she had enough time to get some ginger tea when a steaming mug was placed in front of her. She looked at Angella gratefully. “Thank you.”

“I figured running through the Whispering Woods didn't provide you with a lot of opportunities for tea so I had the chefs fetch some,” Angella said, she squeezed her hand softly.

Glimmer’s shoulders grew tense as she turned away. Shadow Weaver left the room and ducked into a dark corner so she could take a few reverent sips before the meeting was called back into order.

Bow was standing beside Glimmer silently. He reached for her hand. “I know we’ve lost a lot but-”

“That’s an understatement,” Glimmer said, yanking her hand away. “We’ve nearly lost everything to the Horde. This magic is the only thing that can help us save everyone.”

Perfuma conjured a flower into her hands. She debated on using the Heart with each pluck of the petals.

Frosta had gotten sleepy, her head lulled, hitting the table and jolting her awake. “Is there any way we can continue this in the morning like the actual morning when we’ve all gotten some sleep? Not that I’m sleepy or anything.”

“Let’s decide right now,” Mermista said, turning off the simulation. “I would do anything to save my kingdom, so I say let’s do it.”

Glimmer nodded decisively. “Thank you, Mermista. Finally, someone who understands what we’re up against.”

“Bow and Adora said it was dangerous. What if we set it off in the process? Uh, just come back to me,” Perfuma said now tearing the flower petals off at an alarming rate.

Frosta rubbed her eyes, trying to stay awake.

“How come I still don’t have a chair even though the new person does?” Swift Wind asked.

“Oh no, I’m sitting on Emily.” Scorpia pointed out with a smile.

“Swift Wind now is not the time to whine...about chairs.” Adora’s eyes widened when she saw Scorpia sitting at the War Table.

Everyone sat stunned as they tried to decide if they were delirious from lack of sleep or if they really had another security breach.

“Scorpia, how nice of you to join us.” Shadow Weaver moved closer to Angella, turning the lead on her hip into a spear, its blade glinting in the light. “Why are you here?”

“Hey everybody. How are you?” Scorpia waved. “Gosh, I’m so sorry about popping in unannounced, but I didn’t wanna interrupt. You all seemed super busy, so I snuck past the guards and was waiting for you to notice me.”

“Horde Soldier!” Frosta yelled, leaping upon the table.

“For the honor of Grayskull,” Adora said quickly.

“Wait a minute,” Angella called out. Bow and the Princesses chased Scorpia out into the gardens. She glanced at Shadow Weaver, the only remaining person in the room with her. “You said the Bright Moon force field doesn’t allow anyone in if they wish harm right?”

“That is correct. I can’t imagine why Scorpia might be here,” Shadow Weaver said and followed the other Princesses outside. She heaved a relieved sigh when she discovered her flower beds and greenhouse remained untouched.

She-Ra was just in the middle of a mighty sword swing when Scorpia finally revealed she was there to seek help for Entrapta. Perfuma began to move sluggishly from her place on the ground. Shadow Weaver summoned hidden cabling and began to bind Scorpia.

“Uh, so weird request. My shell is sensitive and brittle. Can you use something else to tie me up?” Scorpia asked with a pleading smile. “Thanks so much.”

“Perfuma, are you well enough to make some vines?” Angella asked as she steadied the Flower Princess.

“Yeah, I’m almost back to my old self,” Perfuma slurred out. Vines grew from the ground and wound themselves around Scorpia and pulled her arms tight to her sides.

“Again, I am so, so sorry about the whole stinging thing. It happens when I’m startled,” Scorpia said sincerely.

Perfuma’s eyes softened and she made a flower to go with vines binding Scorpia. She gently wrapped the bot, Emily, as well and rolled it next to Scorpia with a smile. Shadow Weaver watched the scene curiously.

Glimmer stepped forward with a frown. “All right, Horde soldier, why are you here?”

“I have a far more serious question. How does everyone keep getting in here?” Angella asked shrilly.

Scorpia’s attention immediately drifted to Shadow Weaver once more.

“Your security is laughable, Angella. Your guards only patrol the inside of the palace and the magical shield is subjective.” Shadow Weaver reminded the Queen. “It’s apparently weaker than I thought because Double Trouble was allowed to pass through it several times.”

“I’m sorry, is there something in the newest batch of ration bars that’s making everyone defect?” Adora asked Scorpia. “I wouldn’t be surprised if Lonnie showed up next.”

Glimmer cleared her throat loudly. “Are you listening to us?” she asked Scorpia.

“Uh, sorry no. It’s just that it’s Shadow Weaver and in Bright Moon.” Scorpia laughed in disbelief.

Emily beeped next to her.

“Thanks, Emily. Of course, Shadow Weaver is here. She’s the newest Princess of the Rebellion. Now everything about Catra’s behavior makes so much sense.” Scorpia groaned. “And now I’ve left this is gonna mess her up.”

“Can we get back to the topic at hand?” Angella asked quickly. “Scorpia, you said you needed our help to save Entrapta. How do you know she’s in trouble?”

Scorpia peered at the queen. “Wow, your majesty, uh ma’am. Can I just say you are very pretty up close? I’d thought you’d have fangs and glowing red eyes like the posters Shadow Weaver designed in the Fright Zone.”

“I forgot about those,” Adora said mostly to herself.

Bow leaned over and whispered loudly. “Is that why you were afraid of Queen Angella when you first got to Bright Moon?”

“Would you care to explain that?” Angella asked Shadow Weaver.

“Scorpia said Entrapta’s situation was dire,” Shadow Weaver said, looking at Scorpia expectantly.

“The thing is you all seem really good at friendship and I kinda need it to save Entrapta,” Scorpia said, craning her neck to look at all the Princesses.

“You’re here to learn how to be a good friend?” Perfuma asked, her eyes glittered with sudden adoration.

“Yes, exactly.” Scorpia nodded excitedly. “I thought I was being a good friend to Catra but it turned out she wasn’t being a good friend to me. I also have no idea what friendship is and now that Shadow Weaver’s a Princess so, I figured anything was possible

and that's why I came here to get help because the truth is Entrapta was my only real friend."

Emily beeped again and managed to sound affronted.

"And Emily," Scorpia added.

Perfuma cooed at the story.

"Say things that make sense." Mermista pleaded.

"Entrapta wanted to warn Hordak about the whole portal weirdness thing and Catra sent her to Beast Island before she could and I..." Scorpia sighed, dropping her head in shame. "I let her."

Adora gasped. "Beast Island? With the blood beetles? And the trees with razor blades instead of leaves, that's real?" she clutched her face in shock. "I thought those were legends the Horde told us to keep us in line."

"Oh yes, Beast Island is very real but it's much worse than that." Shadow Weaver confirmed.

"It's worst? Oh, what have I done?" Scorpia cried out in anguish.

"If we want to safely deactivate the Heart of Etheria, Entrapta is our best bet," Bow said with a contemplative look.

"We still have to figure out what we're doing about the Heart of Etheria," Glimmer protested.

"There's nothing to figure out, Glimmer," Adora said, crossing her arms. "Mara said not to trust Light Hope. She also said that she had become corrupted and the Heart of Etheria project was a bad thing. She loved Light Hope and gave her life to stop the Heart from being activated. We need Entrapta." The blonde protested before turning to the queen. "Your majesty, please, we must go to Beast Island."

Angella nodded once. “Shadow Weaver knows the most about Beast Island and she will accompany you. With the Horde moving forward the rest of you will focus on evacuation missions,” she said to the rest of the Princesses.

“You’re letting them go? Mom, have you ever heard of anyone coming back from Beast Island? This is a terrible idea and we don’t have time to wait for them to get back.” Glimmer grunted, grabbing her hair in frustration. “Entrapta has a habit of exploding anything she gets her hands on. Are we sure you want to let her near it? Let’s just go to Light Hope and ask her about the Heart.”

“Glimmer, you do want to rescue Entrapta, don’t you?” Bow asked with a puzzled frown.

“I do want to save people but it’s too much of a risk to place the Princess Alliance in danger for one Princess that betrayed us. So, I say we shouldn’t rush off on this rescue mission.” Glimmer threw her hands up.

“Okay, but there’s one flaw in your argument,” Mermista said, pointing at Shadow Weaver as she enunciated. “Former Second in Command of the Horde standing right there.”

“As the Commander of the Rebellion, I say we don’t have time to run off on a ridiculous rescue mission,” Glimmer said.

“You may be Commander but I am still Queen and I have made my decision,” Angella said, her voice hard as a diamond. “Shadow Weaver knows everything there is to know about Etheria’s magic. The only person that would know more than her is Madame Razz. Shadow Weaver and Entrapta will collaborate on research for the Heart. If they say there’s a way to tap into its magic safely, we’ll use what we can to defeat the Horde. If they say no then that’s it, Glimmer we deactivate or destroy it.”

“Madame who?” Glimmer asked in confusion.

Angella turned to the other Princesses. “Frosta and Perfuma escort Scorpia to the prison in the South tower and we’ll all get

some rest. We have a busy day ahead."

Shadow Weaver watched with narrowed eyes as Bow and Adora whispered frantically to each other. "Does this spare room have more or fewer cushions than my prison had?" She asked Angella as the garden emptied.

"I didn't remove any cushions this time," Angella said with a grin. "Are you okay? Do you want to talk about what happened on Mara's ship?"

"I just want to relax with you." Shadow Weaver admitted softly.

"Come along then," Angella said, grabbing her hand. "There's been so many changes for Glimmer this past year. Do you think she will ever forgive me?"

"There is nothing to forgive, Angella. This was perhaps the wrong time for Glimmer to find out about our courtship on top of all the stress of the war, but Glimmer will come around. She loves you."

"I don't want to lose anyone else."

"We're going to save Entrapta and make sure that doesn't happen," Shadow Weaver assured her partner.

"How deadly is Beast Island?"

"Angella…"

"Tell me."

"It is a death sentence from which no one has ever returned," Shadow Weaver said bluntly.

"I forbid you to go." Angella tried to pull her hand out of Shadow Weaver's tightening hold. "I'm ending this right now. We'll find another way."

"Angella, you know we have to go."

“You better come back to me.”

“I promise.”

“If you die, I’ll kill you myself.”

“If anyone could figure out that conundrum, I’m confident it would be you,” Shadow Weaver said as they arrived at the royal suite.

“I wish not to be disturbed unless there’s an emergency,” Angella said sternly to the guards standing outside her room.

“Yes, your majesty.” The guards stood at attention.

“I’m going to take a quick bath,” Shadow Weaver said once they were inside the room.

As soon as she finished, she found the blue robe from her previous stay and exited the bathroom. Angella gave her a kiss and went to take her own bath. Shadow Weaver removed her mask and waited for Angella to return. Steam wafted out of the side door just before Angella made her entrance. She came to Shadow Weaver, holding her hands out expectedly. Shadow Weaver stepped into her arms and then they were airborne before landing on the bed together. The Moonstone cast a radiant glow across the room. Shadow Weaver moved a possessive arm across Angella’s hip and pulled her back against her. The moss gray hand began trailing up and down Angella’s side.

“I’m not hurting your wings, am I?” Shadow Weaver asked.

The queen released a pleased hum. “No, I’m enjoying this very much.”

Shadow Weaver’s lips traveled every inch of Angella’s neck she could reach. The ombré haired woman began to squirm against Shadow Weaver. She bucked and squeezed her thighs together, trying to ease the slight ache.

“Patience my queen,” Shadow Weaver said, nipping to punctuate her statement.

“More.” Angella hissed softly at the sting of the sharp teeth against her skin and bared her neck further with a whimper.

“Are you certain?” Shadow Weaver asked just as softly. She would have loved nothing more than to ravish Angella and express her love. With the stress of her upcoming mission, she didn’t want her partner to feel pressured in her panic for her safety. “We will have time when I return.”

“I have made up my mind. I don’t want to spend another night wondering what it would feel like with you in my arms.” Angella pulled Shadow Weaver’s hand from her hip and placed a kiss on her palm.

Shadow Weaver rumbled happily and placed a harder bite at the slope of Angella’s neck. She felt the tickling touch of the queen’s wings shuddering against her. Shadow Weaver slowly pulled the robe away from Angella’s shoulders and placed open mouth kisses over the newly revealed skin. Her hand disappeared under the short hem of Angella’s robe. The brunette brushed up the soft, trembling skin of Angella’s abdomen and was disappointed to find the tied sash stopped her from getting further.

The Dark Princess rose onto her knees, placing pressure on Angella’s hip to have the queen move to her back. Shadow Weaver straddled Angella’s thigh and pulled the sash apart. The robe slid down Angella’s chest, revealing flushed light purple skin. The older woman was delighted to discover her partner wasn’t wearing anything underneath. Shadow Weaver leaned forward kissing and licking down the middle of Angella’s chest. Shadow Weaver’s hand caressed down Angella’s curves as her dark hair brushed teasingly across Angella’s chest.

“You can be rougher with me.” Angella grabbed a fistful of Shadow Weaver’s hair and pulled her up for a deep kiss.

Their lips mashed together violently. Angella moved as if she was trying to ruin Shadow Weaver's mouth. The brunette fervently pushed back with her mouth open, tongue pushing past Angella's lips to the wet space ahead.

Shadow Weaver slid her hands under Angella, scratching down her back. The queen broke the kiss and arched, putting her hardened nipples on display. Shadow Weaver bent her head taking a nub in her mouth greedily.

Angella immediately pushed her chest forward, trying to get more of the sensation. Shadow Weaver removed her mouth and dragged her nails over the wet nipple as she moved to its twin. She let the puckered skin slide across her lips teasingly before opening her mouth to flick at the nipple with her tongue.

Angella clutched Shadow Weaver's head against her chest. The queen's legs opened enough that Shadow Weaver slid forward with a groan. The heat that was emanating from Angella was almost too much to bear. Shadow Weaver's own passion soared through her veins. It had been so very long since she had taken a lover. Sex like everything else had been about power, holding her lover's completion in her hands. She rocked her hips forward desperately, trying to feel closer to the queen. At this moment all she wanted was to surrender.

Angella's breathing was beginning to get shorter and her hips jogged to meet her partner's. The brunette pulled herself away from chasing her own pleasure and retraced the path down Angella's body, avoiding the apex of her thighs in favor of mouthing the rounded fullness of the queen's upper thighs.

Shadow Weaver inched closer, brushing a kiss at the top of Angella's mound and nuzzling the neat pink tuft of hair above Angella's center. The older woman enjoyed the musky smell of her arousal. At the first lap of that wicked tongue across Angella's soaked slit, the queen's hips bucked to meet the brunette's lips like she was hooked up to a live wire.

Shadow Weaver laid an arm across Angella's hips, restraining her as she nudged her lips apart with a seeking tongue. Shadow Weaver moaned at the tangy saltiness of Angella. The Dark Princess knew she would never be able to sate her appetite for Angella. Shadow Weaver continued to explore Angella's center with wide, slow strokes, taking note of the spots that had Angella trembling and moaning. Shadow Weaver brushed her lips over her clit and Angella gasped out her name, sinking her hands into dark locks.

Shadow Weaver focused on that sensitive bundle of nerves, quickly finding a rhythm to match Angella's bucking hips.

"I need-" Angella's breath hitched.

"Tell me," Shadow Weaver barely lifted her head from her task.

"Inside, please." Angella all but sobbed.

Shadow Weaver spread Angella wider so she could slip her two fingers just inside Angella's entrance and nearly came herself when she felt her partner's muscles clench down around her long fingers. Shadow Weaver pressed further inside and curled her fingers, searching.

Angella's hips snapped up and her hand tightened in Shadow Weaver's hair pushing the brunette's head firmly against her. Angella's hips undulated over and over, using Shadow Weaver as a tool for her pleasure.

The older woman felt light headed from the lack of oxygen but didn't dare falter in matching Angella's thrusts. The grasp on her fingers was too tight to move any longer. She reveled in being used by Angella. The brunette could do nothing but hang on until the queen's passion was spent.

Angella came with a hoarse cry and all but collapsed against the bed. Shadow Weaver took a deep breath and lapped up the juices seeping from her partner. She was careful to avoid Angella's

oversensitive clit. Shadow Weaver climbed back beside Angella, caressing her hair through the aftershocks.

Shadow Weaver brushed the hair away from Angella's sleeping face. "I love you," she whispered and extricated herself as quickly as she could.

Shadow Weaver allowed her legs to dangle off the edge of the bed and held her hand out. Three coins leaped into her palm. She enlarged them and flattened them, slowly using them as stairs out the bed. Once she reached the floor she paused, listening for any sounds coming from above her. Hearing nothing she grabbed her clothing and dressed with nearly inhuman speed. Rushing through the castle, she only paused long enough to grab her canvas bag from her room. She uncorked the stopper of a jar with blue liquid and ran to the south tower. She arrived just as she heard Swift Wind mockingly mention something about a dream.

"We need to leave like an hour ago. Shadow Weaver is gonna go ballistic when she realizes we ditched her," Adora said quickly.

"Adora," Frosta said, trying to get the blonde's attention. She noticed Shadow Weaver coming around the corner.

"She'll look at me with those narrowed eyes through her mask which I know is a dissatisfied look and I can just hear her now." Adora groaned out.

"Adora, come on," Bow said. He attempted to discreetly tell his friend with his eyes that she would stop speaking.

"You can spare yourself the imagery because you are not 'ditching' me as you say," Shadow Weaver said directly from behind Adora.

Adora nearly leaped a foot in the air as she turned. “Shadow Weaver! How long have you been there?”

“Adora, she heard everything.” Swift Wind told her.

“Right, thanks for the heads up guys.” Adora glared at Bow and Frosta.

“We tried to warn you, Adora.” Frosta yawned. “I’m going back to bed. Be safe.”

“I raised you and I know what your resolve face looks like. You want to save Entrapta as soon as possible and I’m gonna help,” Shadow Weaver explained.

“Queen Angella can’t be happy about this,” Adora said, walking to Swift Wind.

“She will be less happy about the world ending,” Shadow Weaver responded. “Let us depart.”

They quickly flew away on Swift Wind to Mara’s ship. After a few mishaps with getting the ship to fly they were jetting to Beast Island just as the morning moonlight dawned around them. Shadow Weaver spent her time checking and rechecking her armor and supplies.

“Are you sure about this Adora? Like one hundred percent sure?” Swift Wind asked Adora as he nervously clopped back and forth in front of the captain’s chair.

“Not at all but we have to try. This is our only option for disabling the Heart of Etheria,” Adora peered through the glass, trying to spot land through the fluffy clouds in the sky and thick fog rising from the ocean.

“I feel like we should have reached Beast Island by now, right?” Swift Wind asked.

“Swifty, we have to trust that the ship knows where it’s going.” Adora glanced at the older woman sitting with her back against the captain’s chair. “You’ve been quiet, Shadow Weaver.”

“I’ve just been preparing,” Shadow Weaver said. She waved her hand over the steel and separated the cylinder into two pieces. The first she turned into a machete. Micro serrations followed a quarter down the blade’s straight spine. There were voids in the middle of the weapon making it light for fast attacks.

“What kind of trouble do you expect on the island?” Swift Wind asked the former sorcerer.

“Whatever trouble there is I am not allowing it to get too close,” Shadow Weaver said and carefully wrapped the handle in a length of leather cord. “It was a dumping ground for First Ones. I was almost sent there after my imprisonment in the Fright Zone. Hordak said he crashed landed there before he arrived on Etheria’s mainland however I am not sure how true that is.”

Bow shook his head and muttered to himself. “Glimmer will be fine once we return with Entrapta, she’ll see that it was the right thing to do.”

“Uh, Bow that thing behind you that’s blinking.” Adora pointed to the flashing red planet floating in the front of the ship. “Should it be blinking?”

“Hey, I’m sensing something coming from the island and it’s not good.” Swift Wind whinnied and he tossed his head. “At all.”

The ship suddenly dove, heading straight for Beast Island.

“Okay, let’s not panic.” Bow looked over the panel in confusion. “Nope, nope. Totally time to panic,” he said, grabbing Adora and Swift Wind close.

Shadow Weaver focused on keeping a tight rein of the backpack full of volatile potions and the razor sharp machete from sliding across the lurching ship.

They swooped then gently landed on the seawater without trouble. “Destination reached.” the ship announced, opening the gangplank. The water was barely up to their calves as they waded across to land.

“There’s a skiff up ahead.” Shadow Weaver pointed, readjusting the strap of her canvas bag on her shoulder.

Swift Wind sniffed around the vehicle, startling when a long-tailed insect scuttled across the metal. “Uh, that’s not normal.” He used his nose to tip the bit of metal over to reveal Entrapta’s mask.

“She’s definitely here. We might still have time to save her,” Adora said excitedly.

Shadow Weaver used the skiff to add more armor to her person. “Stick close.” She looked at the overgrown vines of the island and cautiously made her way inside.

Adora chattered behind her about the various razor sharp animals that resided on Beast Island while she observed the ruins embedded into the soil surrounding them.

“You were right,” Bow said, glancing at Shadow Weaver. “This entire island is all First Ones’ tech but it’s corroded and falling apart.”

They headed deeper in and almost walked right into a large bug-like creature. It looked to be ensnared in glowing vines.

“Don’t move,” Bow warned with a whisper. “Maybe it won’t see us.”

The creature stirred with a roar and plodded towards them.

Adora pulled the sword from her wrist. “For the honor of Grayskull!” She shouted.

The Sword of Protection sparked and she didn’t transform. She retreated further into the trees behind them. Bow notched a trick arrow. It discharged some energy and penetrated the beast’s foreleg. The bug pried it off and snapped the arrow in two, tossing it away.

“Aim for its eyes.” Shadow Weaver ran forward and slashed her sword over the spindly hands. The limbs fell to the dirt as the creature writhed in pain. She dove to the side to avoid its larger limbs.

Bow sent arrows into the eyes of the monster. They hit their mark now that it could no longer defend itself. It reared back with a shriek and stumbled backward, deciding that trying to eat them was too big of a hassle. Shadow Weaver sighed in relief and lowered her weapon.

“Adora, what’s going on? Why can’t you transform into She-Ra?” Bow asked.

“I don’t know. Maybe Beast Island has some sort of interference surrounding it,” Adora said honestly.

“Did you feel anything different when you reached for the sword?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“No,” Adora said immediately then paused. “I don’t know. I was focused on fighting the monster but then I just couldn’t.”

“We need to keep moving,” Bow said, hearing chattering and shuffling from the trees around them.

They walked ahead, passing through the strange and alien forest. They saw a small hovel further ahead. When they got closer they saw the entrance had a petrified, shoeless foot sticking out of it. The sickeningly sweet smell of rot lingered in the air around them.

Shadow Weaver directed her weapon to the small structure. "It looks like a serviceable enough dwelling. That must have been where Hordak stayed."

"Do you think that's Entrapta?" Adora asked, looking at the limb.

"The skin looks almost calcified, I don't think Entrapta has been here that long." Shadow Weaver pointed out.

"Well, nothing here on Beast Island has been normal. Who knows what it does to people? We should check right?" Adora asked. "Just in case."

"One of us should check," Bow said, staring apprehensively at the foot.

"Right," Swift Wind agreed.

"I will check," Shadow Weaver said after neither teenager moved. She entered the small dwelling, her sword proceeding her entrance. The body was cloaked and much too tall to be the Princess they were searching for. "It's not Entrapta."

She slowly flipped the body over with her sword and stumbled back as a strangled cry escaped her mouth. The face was gaunt and pulled tight over his prominent bones but his face was unmistakable. Pale features caked with dirt were framed with tangled black hair. Only tattered pants served as the rest of his clothing with a large Bright Moon talisman around his neck.

Adora rushed forward. "Shadow Weaver, what is it? Who is it?"

"M-micah." Shadow Weaver choked out.

"I thought the Horde killed him after capture? You sent him to Beast Island?" Adora accused.

"*I* didn't do anything. I did not know," Shadow Weaver said unable to look away from Micah's body.

“How could you not know?” Adora demanded.

“Hordak didn’t clear every bit of his decision making with me.” Shadow Weaver snapped. “I assumed he died on the battlefield like everyone else.”

“We have to do something. We can’t just leave him here,” Adora said, looking away from the corpse. “We could give him a proper burial on Bright Moon.”

“Adora, we don’t know what lies ahead. We’ll have to leave him for now,” Bow said regretfully.

“I’ll come back for you,” Shadow Weaver vowed. She kneeled and brushed his hair away from his face. Micah deserved so much more than to be defeated by this trash heap. She would crush Hordak’s skull in her hands the next time she saw him. She felt lower than the toxic sediment she was currently treading across. Her stomach sank. She had no idea how she was going to tell Angella the news.

“Hey, there’s that signal again,” Swift Wind announced and shook his head. “Seriously no one else hears it?”

Adora and Bow shook their heads.

“I am starting to hear a buzzing just out of my range of hearing,” Shadow Weaver admitted. “It’s getting louder the longer we stay.”

High pitch chittering sounded around them. Up ahead there was an odd-shaped tree. A small creature scooted forward, scrubbing its tiny paws against its cheeks.

“Aww, this one is kinda cute,” Bow said, moving toward it.

“Bow, wait.” Shadow Weaver warned.

The animal looked up and bared its mouth full of fangs. The trees behind them moved and dozens of eyes looked down on them.

“Pookas,” Shadow Weaver said, backing up.

The Pooka leaped for Bow’s face. Bow threw the Pooka and it landed on Swift Wind, spooking the horse who took off deep into the forest.

“Swift Wind. Come back,” Adora called, running after him.

Shadow Weaver grabbed Bow by the collar and followed Adora’s path. They heard the squeaking growls of the herd pursuing them. Stumbling to a stop, Shadow Weaver dropped her blade as the signal blared in her ears. “They led us into an ambush,” she said, falling to her knees.

Adora used her sword to cut away the vines creeping around Swift Wind.

“We failed, Adora. Glimmer was right. No one comes back from Beast Island,” Bow said with a low voice. His eyes were lidded as he slowly kneeled.

“No, don’t give up. We need to keep going. Shadow Weaver, help Bow.” Adora tried to hack away the bindings but they caught her wrist and began to tug the sword from her hands. “You’re one of the strongest people I know. Fight back. Do it for Angella,” Adora said.

Shadow Weaver reached out for Bow, pulling weakly. “Strong? I couldn’t even save Micah. Angella deserves so much better than me,” she said and let go of Bow. The tendrils moved across her body, pulling her flat against the ground.

“Guys, get up. Come on. I can’t do this alone.” Adora dropped her head. “I can’t do this.” Flashes of her friendship with Glimmer and Bow went through her mind. The final image she saw was of Mara’s teary hologram. ‘Adora, you will be so much more powerful than they ever planned.’ She opened her eyes. “For the honor of Grayskull!”

She-Ra turned the sword to the ground and burned away the sneaking plants. Everyone stood, blinking rapidly as if they were waking from a dream. The Pookas gnashed their teeth in excitement and started running down the trees toward them. They immediately stopped and retreated, scampering back into the forest.

"Woohoo! We did it," Swift Wind said, kicking his back legs.

Shadow Weaver retrieved her sword from the ground. "Not likely. They are desperate for food if they are leaving it is because there's something greater and more fearsome coming."

"Have I mentioned that I hate this island?" Swift Wind asked.

A bellowing, crooning roar rumbled the ground as the new creature opened its mouth. "Princesses, I saved you," Entrapta exclaimed.

"Okay, seriously why does everyone get an Elemental but me?" Adora asked.

In the cramped space of the Elemental's control panel, Entrapta caught them up on what she had been doing on Beast Island so far. "You smell different." She suddenly leaned over to Shadow Weaver, sniffing. "Like a Princess!"

"Entrapta, we're looking for a weapon," Adora said.

"The Heart of Etheria, why didn't you say so. I know exactly where we need to go!" Entrapta pushed the controls and the Elemental powered forth until they reached a rundown tower.

"Are you sure this is where we need to be?" Swift Wind asked nervously as they approached the bridge warily. "The signal is

strongest right here."

"Oh, that? Don't worry it's much better inside," Entrapta said.

"Inside what?" Bow asked, staring at the tall structure. "I don't see a door."

Entrapta disappeared under a curtain of moss with a squeal. She came back out and parted the foliage. "Tada," she said

"A First Ones' temple." Adora marveled at the structure.

"Uh-huh. The First Ones was dumping its secrets and retrofitting Etheria and now I know why. They were trying to weaponize Etheria." Entrapta revealed as she brought up the information on the ancient First Ones' computer. "They built the sword to control She-Ra."

"I remember Madame Razz saying something about that," Adora admitted, thinking back. "Entrapta, how can I shut off the weapon? How do I stop it?"

Entrapta shook her head excitedly. "Once it's activated you have to use the weapon. You don't get a choice."

"We should be fine though, right?" Bow pointed at the screen. "There's still one Runestone not activated."

"That's the Black Garnet," Shadow Weaver said as the display zoomed in on the remaining Runestone.

"Bow, you don't think Glimmer would bring Scorpia back to the Fright Zone, right?" Adora asked her best friend.

"I don't know, Glimmer hasn't seemed like herself lately. There's no way she would know that Scorpia is the last piece." Bow asked, looking at Adora. "Like no way, right?"

"We can't take that chance. We need to get back to Bright Moon," Shadow Weaver said, turning for the exit.

The floating screens dimmed one by one and flickered out.

“That’s not good,” Swift Wind said.

The plants spilled across the computer and up the walkway, reaching for them.

“Have a good journey. Thanks for coming,” Entrapta said, turning back to the computer.

“Entrapta, we are not leaving you here,” Adora shouted, moving to the younger girl.

“I want to stay. This place is pure information. Everything that happened with the Princesses and Hordak was too confusing. Data makes sense, not people.” Entrapta turned. Her eyes were gray and devoid of emotion.

Swift Wind, Bow, and Shadow Weaver fought off the creeping vegetation, trying to pull them under.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” She-Ra cut the vines holding Entrapta and ran outside with her fellow Princess in tow, but the Pookas were waiting on them.

Swift Wind kicked and stomped any Pooka getting too close. A cluster of them tried to take down She-Ra and she turned the sword into an ornate fighting staff, beating them back as they tried to go for the prone Entrapta. Bow shot arrows but the nimble creatures dodged just as quickly as he could fire.

The Pookas surged as one and pulled the sword from Shadow Weaver’s hands. They tried to bite her, looking for any uncovered or vulnerable skin. Shadow Weaver clawed the closest Pookas and reached into the previously forgotten canvas bag. She had a plan that required one of her experimental potions. With wild animals, it’s about posturing after all. It was a gamble but they needed to make their way off of Beast Island no matter what. She was determined to keep her promise to Angella.

Recalling the sword, Shadow Weaver broke it down into small projectiles. “Everyone duck,” she shouted, sending a spray of sharpened metal spikes over their heads. The Pookas retreated a bit and kept a wary eye on the Dark Princess.

Shadow Weaver pulled at her tiny reserve of sorcery magic, making her hair flutter around her head. She held her hands out to her side so she would appear as large as possible. She lengthened her claws with a guttural growl in a challenge to the Pookas.

A cluster of them charged for Shadow Weaver. She waited until they were too close to dodge and threw a glass bottle filled with green liquid. The viscous liquid hissed and bubbled as it burned across their coats. The creatures yelped, retreating into the forest. One of the larger Pookas pawed the ground, licking its chops. It ran and leaped at her from the side. She threw another potion and it hit right on target. Another wave of Pookas tried to edge forward.

“Stay back unless you want to end up like the rest,” Shadow Weaver threatened, holding up yet another glass bottle.

She-Ra gaped in disbelief. “Shadow Weaver, are you seriously trying to intimidate them right now?”

“No, Adora, look.” Swift Wind pointed with his horn.

The creatures that paced in front of them stopped advancing. She-Ra ran over to Shadow Weaver, swinging her staff at the Pookas in warning as Bow dragged Entrapta along in retreat.

Shadow Weaver mimed a throw anytime the Pookas moved closer. “All creatures understand pain.” She explained to the group.

The Pookas backed up growling and gnashing their teeth but refused to attack.

“Tell me you have a lot more of those,” She-Ra whispered.

“I only had two. This is an energy potion,” Shadow Weaver said back quietly.

She-Ra glanced up and realized the liquid was blue and not green like the others the older woman had thrown.

“What’s the plan?” Bow asked, “I’m almost out of trick arrows.”

“And I am almost drained of my magic.” Shadow Weaver revealed. “This standoff won’t hold forever. Pretty soon one of them will get bold enough to attack.”

A large snake beast slithered forward and roared. The Pookas abandoned them in favor of fleeing the bigger predator. The serpent slammed its body against the bridge, crumbling it and sending everyone falling to the forest floor. She-Ra charged the snake, pushing it back with a punch. The serpent shook off the blow and shot forward once more. Shadow Weaver threw wave after wave of shrapnel at the snake looming over them. Further away she could hear Bow trying to break Entrapta out of her stupor so they could retreat.

“There’s more monsters coming. A lot more.” A panicked Swift Wind shouted.

Two more snake beasts arrived with vicious looking spider companions.

“We need to get back to the ship as soon as possible,” Shadow Weaver said as the hold on the metal around her was slipping.

“The ship that’s it.” She-Ra crushed the closest spider under her shoe. “Entrapta we flew here in a First Ones’ ship and if you come with us you get to see it.”

Vibrant life sprang back into Entrapta’s eyes at once. “Ship!? You have a working First Ones’ spacecraft?”

Bow looked at Entrapta. “None of that friend’s speech got through to you?”

“Well, no but thank you for trying.” Entrapta placed and her fingers to her mouth and a shrill whistle pierced the air. The Elemental that transported them through Beast Island tumbled to the ground, stopping the snake beast. “You get ‘em, girl! I’ll come back for you I promise,” she said as they sprinted to the ship.

Adora, Bow, Shadow Weaver, Entrapta, and Swift Wind ran as fast as they could into the throne room.

“You’re back! Oh, thank goodness!” Angella rushed down the steps to embrace Shadow Weaver. “You are in so much trouble once this is all over,” she whispered to her partner.

“I kept my promise.” Shadow Weaver squeezed the ombré haired woman tightly. “Angella, where are Glimmer and Scorpia?” She asked as the hug ended.

“Glimmer went to talk to Scorpia nearly an hour ago,” Angella answered in confusion.

A Bright Moon Guard rushed into the throne room. “Your majesty Princess Glimmer is gone and Double Trouble has escaped their prison.”

“I can’t believe she lied to me again.” Angella’s nostrils flared as she stomped her foot. “Her children’s children will be grounded by the time I’m through with her.”

“We have to stop her,” Bow said, looking at Adora.

“Stop her, what’s going on?” Angella asked.

“Glimmer might be trying to activate the Heart of Etheria,” Adora told the queen.

“That will destroy us all. Glimmer would never do something so foolish,” Angella said faintly.

“I’ll go to the Fright Zone at once,” Shadow Weaver said, moving to the window. She concentrated and sent a mental message to Slinky from her perch.

Angella reached out for Shadow Weaver. “Surely you need to recharge.”

“We don’t have time. I have to get to Glimmer,” Shadow Weaver said as Slinky scuttled towards her. She leaped from the window onto his back.

Chapter End Notes

So, yeah again this turned out to be my longest chapter. I thought about chopping it up several times. I couldn't really find a place that I felt comfortable stopping except the very very end scene which starts my next chapter. Also, as a FYI if you haven't noticed I update my tags for warnings, etc.

I'm always excited when I get my notifications about kudos and reviews. Y'all make my day! Thanks 🤓

Until next time!

You Can't Choose What Stays and What Fades Away

Chapter Summary

Does she make it in time?

Chapter Notes

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Spoilers: I’m picking and choosing what canon plotlines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, “Light Spinner” will be pretty spoilery.

Disclaimer: She-Ra and the Princesses of Power belong to DreamWorks and the wonderful Noelle Stevenson. Any and all other brand names that might appear here belong to their respective owners. I do not make any money on this story. Please don’t sue; you only stand to gain an extremely mismanaged pile of finances for your efforts.

Author’s Note: This is inspired by fan art, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine’s song “No Light, No Light” along with Five Finger Death Punch’s “Wrong Side of Heaven.” My brain couldn’t leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

All errors I claim as my own.

New chapter! Love writing this one. Let’s get to it. Hope you enjoy. :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 6: You Can't Choose What Stays and What Fades Away

“Your majesty, you requested to see me?” Juliet asked as she stepped into the throne room.

“Yes, I need everyone on high alert. Go to the armory and grab any necessary weapons needed to defend Bright Moon. Send word to Castaspella and let her know we will need Mystacor’s aid.” Angella informed the General.

“At once.” Juliet bowed and turned to leave. She paused and looked back at the queen. “Begging your pardon. What force should we prepare for?”

Angella glanced at the Moonstone. “I wish I knew,” she replied honestly. “Just make sure everyone is prepared, please.”

“Yes, your majesty.” The General took her leave.

Angella fought the urge to pace in front of her throne as she wrung her hands together in indecision. She hoped Shadow Weaver would reach Glimmer in time. With the aggressiveness of the Horde, she didn’t feel it was a sound decision to leave Bright Moon and the Moonstone completely unprotected even though all her maternal instincts screamed at her to follow her partner’s path. A bubble gum glow outlined her entire body and a dose of adrenaline flew through her veins. She felt more energetic than she ever had before.

“Glimmer,” she said softly, looking in the direction of the Fright Zone.

Angella immediately soared from the castle. Her wings were beating with purpose through the air. She’d nearly lost Glimmer before. She would not do it again. She paused next to the Moonstone and conjured the most brilliant distress beacon she had ever cast. With the extra magic thrumming under her skin, the Whispering Woods passed by in a blur and she was already in the Fright Zone. It was a sad wasteland of patchwork sheet metal and rickety structures. Her skin itched as the entire climate seemed to change around her. She pushed harder. Glimmer was here somewhere.

First Ones’ sigils erupted across her skin and fatigue enveloped her, making her slowly descend. There was no time for weakness and no time for fear. Angella fell to her knees with a shout and panted through the agony. She let the pain drive her. She was not the only one connected to the Moonstone. If she was feeling this then so was Glimmer. Magic spilled out of her body, stretching for the sky in a vaporous stream of rainbow. “No,” she gasped out.

Lightning crashed and sparked around Etheria while magic peeled the sky away like a curtain.

“The stars,” Angella said. She focused and drew her mind towards the heavens. She stood on shaking legs and tapped into her Angelic magics.

The First Ones’ sigils burned against her skin as she tried to hold the connection of both the celestials and the Moonstone in her body. Another set of wings burst from her back and she was airborne once more, rocketing to the Horde’s base. Her eyes zeroed on a Runestone that had similar markings as she had and she flew towards it. “Glimmer!”

“Mom!” Glimmer shouted back.

Hordak stepped forward with a club.

“Glimmer, watch out!” Angella shouted, charging a light beam. An exploding arrow intercepted Hordak. She was nearly there. She nosedived towards the ground.

“Glimmer, hang on. I’m coming down,” Bow said, sliding down a rope with his bow. A green glow shot down to the floor as he started his descent.

Angella didn’t hesitate as she flew directly into the glow and tossed a light sphere into the recovered Hordak’s face, stunning him. She turned and pushed Glimmer out of the circle in the confusion.

“Horde Prime, he’s here,” Hordak said in awe and fainted.

Glimmer landed roughly on her side. “Mom, w-what are you doing?”

Angella saw Shadow Weaver in the distance, gripping Slinky for dear life. She smiled sadly at Glimmer. “I’m choosing to be brave. Take care of each other,” she said before she disappeared.

Angella’s body felt like she was traveling through a frigid tube winding through space and time. She felt as though her limbs were simultaneously made of lead and air. When she finally hit the ground, she was happy to feel something solid beneath her. She opened her eyes and sat up, cradling her head in her hands.

Taking several calming breaths, she looked around her. Above her was an expansive ceiling with rows upon rows of lime green lights that seemed to stretch on forever. Angella tried to stand on her legs but they would not cooperate with the command from her brain. She gave her wings a couple of experimental flaps but even they would not move her. She finally managed to wobble to her knees and stayed still. Hordak appeared to have the same issues as he gingerly stood up from the floor beside her.

“Is that you, Little Brother?” An emotionless voice asked from the darkness. The throne rotated to show her Horde Prime. His sharp smile was pompous and smug as the two additional toxic green eyes that adorned the left side of his face squinted their assessment of his captives.

The lights came on slowly and Angella saw that what she thought was additional lighting turned out to all be clones of the alien before her. Hordak and Prime Horde argued amongst themselves while Angella got her bearings. Horde Prime’s bionic hair moved without warning, penetrating deep into the base of Hordak’s neck. After his unnerving scream, the only thing left was another blank chartreuse glow.

Angella flinched when Horde Prime’s four beady eyes turned to her. His slow, methodical steps echoed across the mostly empty platform. She tried once more to will her legs to work before the creature reached her.

“I apologize for my brother. His actions are an embarrassment. I only wish to bring peace.” Horde Prime helped Angella stand with a surprisingly tender grip.

“Your version of peace is quite different from mine,” Angella said, snatching her hand away.

“If that’s how you choose to repay my kindness then I’ll have to purge this world. Starting with you,” Horde Prime responded, grabbing Angella’s face. His sterling silver finger talon dug into her cheek as she struggled against the tight grip.

“I wouldn’t do that if I was you,” Catra called out from behind a large piece of rubble. “Etheria is some kind of ancient weapon. A really, really big one and the queen here is connected to one of the keys that activates it.” She walked until she stood beside Angella.

“A weapon?” Horde Prime looked thoughtful. “Yes, that would explain the energy readings.”

“If you want to know how to use it then you need me,” Catra said, pressing a hand to her chest.

“Very well.” Horde Prime released Angella’s face. He trailed his finger armor down her jaw and left a stinging scratch beneath her chin. “Take heed your majesty for Etheria will be the crowning jewel to my empire as I bring peace throughout the universe.”

“If you think the Princesses are going to just let you take over, then you’re sadly mistaken,” Angella spat at Horde Prime.

“You must be tired from your long trip. Rest your majesty. We will talk later,” Horde Prime said evenly.

Something hit Angella from behind and all she knew was darkness.

Angella awakened on a large bed in a simple, windowless room of stark white. Walking past the pale, curved chair with tapered legs, she approached the translucent green force field that served as the door to what she assumed would be her prison. With one apprehensive finger, Angella reached out and touched it. Nothing happened. No spirals or pain, just bits of alien circuitry that revealed itself under her fingertip. She slammed her hands against its unforgiving surface. She tried to form light or sparks to attack the barrier and wasn’t surprised when the magic didn’t arise. She couldn’t feel the Moonstone at all. Horde Prime’s ship felt like it was leagues away from Etheria.

She took a breath to focus herself and let out a low trilling, creaky whistle to test the levels of her Angelic magics. The same circuitry shimmered across the door but it still did not respond to her spell. Pressing her face to the solid surface she turned her head back and forth, straining to see anything of her surroundings outside

her cell. Just at the far end of the hall, she thought she could see a figure watching from the darkness.

“Hello?” Angella called out. “I know someone is there. How long do you plan on keeping me here?” she shouted when no one responded.

The queen retreated to the bed and sat heavily. She wondered if anyone responded to her distress beacon. The Rebellion would come for her and defeat Horde Prime. He was a tyrant who liked to wrap himself in a mockery of peace and harmony. She would try her best to give them any information she could to help. While her faith in the Rebellion and the Princess Alliance was absolute, she still hoped everyone was safe and unharmed back on Etheria.

There was no indication of how long she’d been there. The hallway was dark and desolate with no visible windows. She wanted to pace or try to break apart the chair as a possible weapon but she needed to conserve her energy. She wasn’t sure how long her rescue would take.

A moving shadow cast itself across the floor. “Pretty fancy accommodations, your majesty? Well, for a prison anyways.”

“Catra.” Angella acknowledged with a wary gaze. “Bright Moon’s prison is much better than this one.”

“I find it really hard to believe that Bright Moon even has prisons.” Catra studied her nails.

Angella crossed her arms and leveled a glare at her. “Bright Moon is not all tea cakes and slumber parties.”

“That’s obvious from the sparkles in your hair and the fancy pink clothing,” Catra said with a chuckle. “You don’t have to pretend

anymore. You're alone on this ship."

"I'm not the only one. What do you hope to gain by aligning yourself with Horde Prime, Catra?"

Catra shrugged casually. "The Horde is still the Horde even in space. As long as I stay useful to Horde Prime I'll be safe. I'll just work my way up the ranks like I did before."

"You can't really believe that. Catra, you saw what happened to Hordak. He doesn't even value his own clones. Once you anger him you're liable to be reeducated like the rest."

"Don't pretend you know anything about me," Catra said, slamming a hand to the door.

Angella's eyes widened as two clones appeared from nowhere.

Their eyes stared at nothing as they spoke as one. "Horde Prime has requested your presence at dinner as his honored guests." They glanced at Catra as if noticing her for the first time. "Both of you."

The door flickered and disappeared, allowing Angella to pass. The clones stood beside her, blocking her from going anyway but forward. Just as they reached a closed door, it slid open automatically. The clones hurried into the room and filled the table with food, some unlike any she had ever seen. The identical figures sliced the large brick of aspic into pieces carefully setting a plate of it in front of her and Catra.

"Thank you for attending." Horde Prime greeted them from the head of his table.

Angella stared at Horde Prime with every ounce of hatred she felt.

"Are you not finding everything enjoyable?" Horde Prime asked in mock surprise. "I strive to treat my guests well."

Angella looked at the aspic, debating internally on whether or not the food might be safe to eat. It was not likely to be poisoned since Horde Prime was not yet sure about her full role in the Heart of Etheria. She decided it was best to keep up her strength and took a small bite.

"I hope you find the dish to your liking, your majesty, especially this one. It came from a distant world light-years away from here. A little planet much like Etheria." Horde Prime lifted his wine glass with a smirk. "It is a delicacy that is extremely rare as that world no longer exists."

The spoonful settled heavily on her taste buds and Angella remembered a planet in an early memory in her travels with her siblings. A proud and gentle race of bipedal reptiles that actually practiced the peace and hospitality Horde Prime claimed he was offering. She dropped her spoon in disgust and tried to swallow the bite past the lump in her throat.

"Seconds?" Horde Prime offered.

"I've had quite enough," Angella said, glaring at Horde Prime.

"Are you sure? Let us move on," Horde Prime said, snapping his fingers. "Dinner is nothing without entertainment. Speaking of Etheria, you must miss it terribly." The tall screen behind him was filled with images of the Princesses, sorcerers, Bow, Swift Wind, and Slinky fighting on Etheria. They looked exhausted but they were all still fighting.

"Every Rebellion finds a leader to rally behind," Horde Prime continued. "A shining beacon of hope to follow. And here's your beacon." The screen zoomed in on the blonde running. "Adora."

Catra's hand gripped the table, the metal screeching in protest under her claws.

"She-Ra." Horde Prime sneered. "A nuisance that needs to be eradicated so that peace can be created on Etheria."

The Horde Prime bots pushed in, surrounding Adora on the full screen. Their laser eyes glowed as they charged and their sharp arms sliced the air. Shadow Weaver dived forward, placing herself between the battle bots attack. She parried and yanked two Horde Prime bots' heads off with her powers. She fought like a woman possessed and took down another before one of the bots got in a lucky strike. Ruby droplets spilled between Shadow Weaver's fingers as she went down on one knee.

"You can't hurt her! None of them. The Princesses are all connected to the Heart of Etheria and She-Ra is the key to using it. If you kill any of them or me it will be useless," Angella said with trembling wings.

"Very well," Horde Prime said and the Prime bots stopped, freezing into place. He waved his hand and the screen darkened. "This has been most illuminating, Angella."

Angella's gaze became flinty. "I am to be addressed as your majesty or Queen of Bright Moon."

"Of course. I look forward to our future conversations. For now, please enjoy dinner." Horde Prime cracked open the steaming shell in front of him and ate its contents with a composed hand.

Angella stared at her new plate of food, eating it mechanically. Horde Prime thought he could prey on her emotions. All he showed her was that the Princess Alliance hadn't given up. They were still fighting with everything they had. She needed to do what she could to get home to Glimmer, Shadow Weaver, Castaspella, and all the Princesses that had become her family. She promised to take a mental note of the path they took on the way back to her cell. She knew they would come for her.

From what she had seen of Horde Prime, he was a symbiotic entity. He gained his knowledge through his clones or hosts. The hive mind allowed him to 'see all and know all.' She would not be able to survive alone. Glancing at Catra, she saw the conflicting emotions across the teen's face and knew she wouldn't have to. It

wasn’t until she got back to her bed and started to drift off that she realized that there were no sightings of She-Ra in the projections. Her rescue may take longer than she anticipated.

Before her breakfast arrived the next morning, Angella had determined there were only twelve steps from one end of her cell to the other lengthwise and only five steps width wise. Angella had new sympathy for Shadow Weaver’s time in captivity. The uncertainty was vexing. Horde Prime was aware he couldn’t kill her though it didn’t rule out the possibility she might still be experimented on, tortured, or worse.

The only person not connected to the hive mind she had interacted with thus far was Catra and it was all she could do not to clutch to the fragile girl like a lifeline. She wanted to add attempting to heal the relationship between Shadow Weaver and Catra to her long list of mental goals despite knowing that was an exercise in futility. Nothing could repair that broken bond without significant work, specifically from Shadow Weaver’s side.

Angella paused in her what felt like her hundredth trip across the small space when she felt a prickling of awareness across her neck. “I know you’re watching me, Catra.” She guessed. She was unsurprised when Catra chose to remain silent. She pressed her ear against the door of the cell, listening to a clone yell at Catra about knowing her place with Horde Prime. His shouts trailed off with a choke and the sound of bones rearranging.

“Little Sister, why do you disobey my orders? The queen is not to be disturbed.” Horde Prime’s voice sounded just outside the door.

“Horde Prime, is that you?” Catra asked.

“Horde Prime knows all, little sister. Horde Prime sees all and this part of the ship is off-limits to you. Now, run along.” He finished

speaking through the clone. The harsh sound of bone cracking transpired once more as the prison door disappeared.

A clone gripped Angella's shoulder and steered her away from Catra. As they traveled, Angella was once more frustrated to discover the ship still had no identifying details. Every hallway looked exactly like the one before it. The clone stopped in front of a solid door and walked away.

"Thank you for joining me," Horde Prime said pleasantly, opening the door with a flourish.

"You say that like I had a choice in the matter." Angella bit out.

"I thought you might enjoy a diversion from pacing your cell." Horde Prime pressed a guiding hand on her lower back. The room was filled with mounted heads and jars of preserved lifeforms. On the back wall held several weapons and a glass orb floating above the floor. "Do you like them? They are treasures from my past conquests, the last visages of their worlds," he said with a content lilt to his voice.

"Worlds that you destroyed." Angella clarified.

"I do not relish destruction but sometimes the fields must be razed so that life can be born anew," Horde Prime said as they stopped at the end of the room. "This is my most prized token. It is from the first world I conquered and it was very precious to its people."

Horde Prime removed the floating glass, handing it to Angella. "You know I'm looking for She-Ra and despite the information you so willingly gave up last night you seem reluctant to help me further. I only want to use the Heart of Etheria for peace."

"Peace?" Angella asked in disbelief. "If you activate the Heart there will be no one left."

"Exactly. No war and no suffering. A brand new universe where we can all begin again. But perhaps you need a bit more incentive

for your decision.” Horde Prime snapped his fingers.

The screen behind them showed snapshots of Shadow Weaver, Glimmer, and Castaspella fighting side by side. Angella looked over their weary faces. She fought to keep her face neutral but her watery eyes betrayed her.

“Ah, there’s the emotion. You have a decent façade in place but you cannot mask love.” Horde Prime spewed the last word out like it left a rancid film in his mouth. “Your majesty, there is no need for hostility. My brother’s memories are clear.” He stepped behind her and held her shoulders. “This is not you. You are not the courageous queen you’re trying to be. This is yet another role you’re failing at.”

“I’m not failing anything,” Angella said, squeezing the glass between her hands.

“Is that so? You were losing nearly all of Etheria to my little brother. You can’t control your daughter, Glimmer. You couldn’t even save the one you love.” Horde Prime waved his hand at the screen. The screen flashed and a slow-moving camera swooped over the chaotic wilderness of Beast Island. The image magnified over and over until a clear image was presented. “Recognize him?” he asked.

The air around her felt hot as she stared at his lifeless eyes. “Micah,” Angella breathed. She held the globe tight against her abdomen to stave off the sudden cramps. “What kind of cruel illusion is this?”

“Did your Shadow Weaver tell you she was nearly sent to Beast Island? Did she inform you that’s where Micah was?”

Angella closed her eyes and shook her head violently. “No, no she would not have kept that from me.”

“Are you certain?” Horde Prime turned her roughly and smiled as she opened her eyes. “I’ve always been fascinated by how fragile

emotions are. You accused me of illusions. You know in your heart that this is real and true."

"She wouldn't have kept this from me," Angella repeated with trembling lips.

"But you're not certain, are you? There's still a part of you that doesn't trust her. A part of you waiting for her to disappoint and betray you again. After all, she was with my brother many, many years. How can she change?"

Angella steeled her nerves and glanced at the image of Micah again. After the initial shock, she was able to notice the subtleties around his body. Someone had smoothed back his matted hair and arranged his hands peacefully. It could only have been Shadow Weaver. Whatever her reasoning they would talk it through. She wouldn't give Horde Prime the satisfaction of winning this round.

"You think knowing all and seeing all is power. You're wrong. No matter how much you mock my emotions, love will still be the strongest force in all the universe. You don't understand it and you can't wield it so you try to fill that void with cruelty and clones. I have faith in Shadow Weaver and I'll believe her over you any day. It's really sad that you will never experience anything other than this mindless droning from planet to planet. You're pathetic." Angella continued to stare forward.

The screen went back to Etheria and zeroed in on Glimmer, Shadow Weaver, and Castaspella. "Do you miss them? Wouldn't you like to be reunited with them under my good graces? What would they say if they were in your position?" Horde Prime asked.

"They would want me to tell you that you're not gonna win this fight," Angella said immediately.

Horde Prime tutted and clenched a fist into Angella's hair, pulling her close to him. "You could be at peace. No worries, no fear, nor anger. All you have to do is surrender to Horde Prime."

“I will relish every moment Shadow Weaver spends on your broken body,” Angella grunted, smashing the glass orb to the floor.

“Very well.” Horde Prime pushed Angella roughly toward the door. “Please escort the Queen back to her quarters.” Two clones gripped her arms and marched her from the room.

Back at her cell, another clone stood motionless with a tray of lunch. The clone left the tray on the chair and left her cell. She stared blankly at the meal until the steam no longer flowed across the plate and the bubbles from the drink were no longer present. A small blip sounded from the door to her left.

“I’m not interested in any more of your invitations,” Angella said testily, glancing at the door. “Catra, what are you doing here? Horde Prime forbade you from visiting me.”

“If you don’t want the company,” Catra said with a frown as she started to walk away.

Angella walked to the entrance. “It’s not about what I want, Catra. You need to keep yourself safe.”

“They won’t notice if I’m here for just a bit,” Catra said, looking away.

Angella decided not to push further, knowing instinctively that Catra was looking for company for herself.

“Have you eaten?” Catra rubbed her stomach absently.

“I don’t know what I’m eating. I’ve traveled to many worlds and some of this is unrecognizable as food,” Angella said.

“I thought it was just me,” Catra said with a small smile. She pressed her back to the opposite side of the door and sat on the floor. Angella and Catra remained silent, lost in their contemplations.

"Back again today? Why do you keep returning?" Angella asked in the form of greeting when Catra appeared.

"Tired of me already, your majesty?" Catra asked mockingly.

"I don't want you to get hurt," Angella said. "Horde Prime ordered you not to speak to me."

"I'm bored and it was either watch planets get bombed or come here. At least you're a nicer sight." Catra grumbled and hugged herself.

"You're bored too?"

"A little." Catra shrugged. "The clones do everything. I can't walk two steps without them breathing down my neck." She suppressed a shiver. "It's creepy."

Angella nodded solemnly. "I never thought I'd miss budget and defense meetings."

"What would you be doing if you were back on Etheria right now?"

Angella shook her head. "Besides, grounding Glimmer within an inch of her life?"

"Sparkles better watch out." Catra chuckled.

"I don't know. Besides being Glimmer's mother I've been running Bright Moon and leading the Rebellion. It's been so long since I've had any free time," Angella replied wistfully.

Catra descended to the floor, wrapping her arms around her knees. "Did you know Shadow Weaver has pictures of you?" she

asked.

“I’ve already heard about the propaganda posters she made of me looking like some bloodthirsty creature,” Angella replied haughtily.

“No, not those,” Catra smirked. “She has a sketchbook filled with lots of pages of your portrait.” She glanced at Angella with a raised eyebrow. “You’re not surprised? Or disgusted?”

“Shadow Weaver never told you about her past, did she?” Angella asked.

“Between the insults, violent magic, and basic training, it never came up.” Catra snarked out. “I remember rumors about her starting at Mystacor. What was her name? Tiny Dancer?”

“Light Spinner.” Angella laughed. She told Catra about the story of how she and Light Spinner met. “You remind me a little of her actually,” she said once she finished her tale.

“I’m nothing like her.” Catra’s hair frizzled across her head. “All Shadow Weaver does is use people. She used me to escape and she didn’t even care what happened to me.”

“You are your own person, Catra. No one is denying that, however there are some similarities between you.” Angella turned to face Catra as she continued. “Brass and proud. Fiercely protective. I’d even wager you’re secretly sweet.” she couldn’t help adding.

“No, I’m not.” Catra retorted quickly and ducked her head, hiding her face. “I’m nothing like that.”

Angella didn’t comment on the blush she saw on Catra’s face. The queen had a few more words to describe the other similarities between Catra and Shadow Weaver. They were both instinctively defensive, secretive, and so very fragile. She didn’t want to push the younger woman too far with her observations and decided to move on. “I wasn’t surprised Shadow Weaver convinced herself you could handle it. That you were tougher than Adora.”

“She cares about Adora more than me. She always has.” Catra’s ears drooped close against her head.

“I believe she loves you both equally,” Angella said, keeping her voice soft and soothing.

Catra huffed out a bitter chuckle. “Shadow Weaver is incapable of love. She was cruel to me every moment of my life. You saw how she tried to kill me before we activated the portal. She treats me like garbage. Nothing I’ve done was ever good enough.”

“I don’t condone anything Shadow Weaver has done to you, Catra.” Angella turned fully and rested her hand against the opaque door. “A million good deeds will never make up for how she’s treated you. She is working on changing just like you. I see that you’re conflicted about Horde Prime.”

Catra rose to her feet slowly, keeping her back facing Angella. “I’m a Force Captain and I will complete my goal,” she said dully.

“Their goals and yours don’t align anymore, Catra.” Angella stood, trying to plead with the younger woman. “You know the Princesses will come for me. I can get you out of here if you want. You can help us win.”

“Shut up.” Catra brandished her claws and slashed the air. “You’re just trying to use me too.” she leaped away from the door.

“Catra what use would I have from lying to you? You don’t have the power to get me out of here, Horde Prime does. They’ll come for me. Just tell me if you want to leave with us.” Angella called after her.

Catra offered no greeting as she walked into Angella’s prison cell the next day. “An old First Ones’ ship left Etheria’s atmosphere a

few days ago and Horde Prime can't track it. What do you know about it?"

Angella quickly choked back a gasp. Her hand twitched as her mind registered the information. It was nearly time. The Rebellion was coming for her and she would be free to help them defeat Horde Prime.

"Adora is on that ship, isn't she?" Catra asked after watching Angella's reaction.

"Catra, promise me you won't tell him. You know he will hurt Adora if he catches her." Angella beseeched, grabbing Catra's hand.

"I don't have to do anything. Adora is coming to save you. I just have to let it happen," Catra said quietly and glanced at the clone waiting outside the solid room door.

"That's your solution? Horde Prime is not going to reward you for that behavior." Angella gently brought Catra's attention back to her. "What about you? What will you do after?"

"I've always found a way out." Catra took her hand back.

"We have a way out, Catra." Angella insisted. She stepped closer and whispered quickly. "Escape with me. Come with us. You don't even have to join the Rebellion. I just don't want you to believe you have to stay and survive on this ship with Horde Prime."

"I'm fine. I don't need anyone else. Relying on other people will always let you down. Adora left then Shadow Weaver and Scorpia. I am destined to be alone." Catra stepped away from Angella and demanded to be released.

The door flashed away and reemerged. Angella sat heavily on the bed. "Oh, Catra. No, you're not," she said to the empty room.

Angella picked up the chair leg she managed to break off and waited for her newest visitor when she heard shouting and crashing from outside her cell.

“I’m coming in,” Catra called out.

Angella looked down at the unconscious clone underneath Catra’s feet with confusion. “What are you doing?”

“We don’t have any time if you’re gonna be rescued. Just come with me.” Catra held out her hand.

“Where are we going? What’s your plan?” Angella grasped it and they sprinted away.

They met three clones at an intersection of the corridor. “Little Sister, why is our guest outside of her quarters?”

“She wanted some fresh air. Didn’t you, your majesty?” Catra leaped, throwing the guard off balance.

Angella hit the clone closest to her in the stomach. Her next attack was halted by the second. Catra attacked the clone and slid him across the floor.

“Hit them in the neck that should bring them down,” Catra said, stabbing her claws into the nape of the clone’s neck.

Angella used both hands to slam the green circle that ringed it and the clone immediately fell to the ground.

“Not bad for an Evil Queen,” Catra said, giving Angella an impressed look. The alarms started blaring overhead. “Let’s go,” she said, running at top speed.

They slid into a room and Catra pulled Angella towards a large window. A force field immediately went up around Angella. “What are you doing?” she asked, pushing her hands on the barrier.

“Getting you out of here,” Catra said, typing rapidly on the keyboard in front of her. Simultaneously, all the doors surrounding them sealed the room shut.

“Catra, you don’t have to save me. The Rebellion can get us both out of here.” Angella tried to reason with her.

“I’m saving Adora. Horde Prime has a plan to capture her and make her use the Heart of Etheria.” Catra explained as she paused in her typing. “Even if I sent her a message to stay away, you know she would still come for you. That’s just how she is.” She sighed. Loud banging sounded from the doors and the clones began to claw their way inside.

“I’m assuming this only works if someone is out there to type the coordinates. What about you, Catra? You don’t deserve to be left behind,” Angella said.

“Yes, I do. All I do is hurt, people. There’s no one left in the universe that cares about me.”

“That’s not true. I care about you.”

“That’s only because you haven’t given me a reason to screw up yet.” Catra smiled ruefully.

“Shadow Weaver and Adora both care for you deeply.”

“They left me the very first chance they got, but it’s okay. I’m gonna do something good for once in my life.” Catra pressed a few more buttons. “Hey, Adora,” she called out.

“Catra?” Adora’s confused and apprehensive voice was heard.

“Don’t sound so happy to hear from me,” Catra said sardonically, typing faster. “I’m sending Angella to you.”

Shadow Weaver’s voice boomed across the speakers immediately. “Angella’s with you? What have you done, Catra?”

“Don’t take that tone with her. She’s done nothing to me,” Angella yelled back.

“Angella.” Shadow Weaver breathed.

“I’m here, my love,” Angella reassured her.

“Yeah, don’t get all sappy. There isn’t time. I can’t send her to your exact location but I can get her to your quadrant. You have to be there to catch her,” Catra said. Clones burst through the door behind her.

“Catch her? Wait, what? I don’t understand. Catra, what’s going on?” Adora blurted out in a rush.

“Just listen.” Catra punched a clone reaching for her. “Get to the coordinates I sent you.” She kicked another away. Three clones grabbed her by the arms, slamming her against the wall. Catra struggled to break the hold as the other two got up from the floor. “Adora, I know I screwed up a lot but I’m sorry. About everything,” She screamed and lunged for the control panel.

“Catra!” Angella watched helplessly as the clones overpowered Catra and pinned her to the floor. The green light buzzed past her at a speedy pace and she blinked out of sight.

Chapter End Notes

> Angella and her sacrifices...I’m still not over it damn it! 😭 I didn’t plan to have the shortest chapter come after the

longest but life's funny that way. 😅 I'm editing the next chapter so it shouldn't be too long before I post again.

As always thanks for the reviews and kudos. Also thank you to anyone that's still reading and to any newbies welcome to my sliding doors adventure.

Until next time!

Heaven Help Me, I Need to Make It Right

Chapter Summary

The incredible adventures of lesbians in space.

Chapter Notes

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Spoilers: I’m picking and choosing what canon plotlines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, “Light Spinner” will be pretty spoilery.

Disclaimer: She-Ra and the Princesses of Power belong to DreamWorks and the wonderful Noelle Stevenson. Any and all other brand names that might appear here belong to their respective owners. I do not make any money on this story. Please don’t sue; you only stand to gain an extremely mismanaged pile of finances for your efforts.

Author’s Note: This is inspired by fan art, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine’s song “No Light, No Light” along with Five Finger Death Punch’s “Wrong Side of Heaven.” My brain couldn’t leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

All mistakes I claim as my own.

Hello there, it's been awhile. For some reason I had a complete block with this chapter. Nothing I wrote seemed to work in my head. I walked away from it for a week and slowly came back to it by listening to the playlist I made. I'm happy with it and I hope you like it too.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 7: Heaven Help Me, I Need to Make It Right

As soon as Catra's transmission ended, Adora, Bow, and Shadow Weaver quickly got into spacesuits as Entrapta sent them hurtling towards the coordinates. They waited in silence and stood at the edge of the airlock, looking for any sign of Angella's arrival.

"There she is!" Adora pointed at the tiny bottle green twinkle against the dark emptiness of space.

"I have her." Shadow Weaver backed up a few paces and took a running leap. She kept her hands at her sides for speed though it didn't matter. As soon as she left the ship, it was as if her travel slowed to a listless pace.The mass of light that she hoped would be Angella was almost fully formed and she was still too far away. She could do nothing except ride the momentum carrying her forward and hope she would make it in time.

When Angella finally popped into existence, Shadow Weaver reached out. She grabbed her partner by the hand and pulled her into a tight embrace. Shadow Weaver's world narrowed to the woman in her arms. She barely registered their backward motion until the sounds of Adora and Bow grunting with effort reached her ears. The glowing, sickly aura surrounding Angella was almost gone when the two women fell to the floor of the airlock. Bow slammed his hand against the button to close the doors and the sucking pressure of space ceased.

Angella groaned and opened her eyes with a gasp. “Am I dreaming?”

Shadow Weaver carefully took off her helmet. “Do I normally appear in your dreams, my Queen?” She drawled, her voice tight.

“It is you.” Angella chuckled softly. The queen held Shadow Weaver’s hand in a near bruising grip. She looked around the airlock they were squatting in. “Where’s Glimmer?”

“She’s safe.” Shadow Weaver assured her, rubbing a thumb over Angella’s hand. “She’s on Etheria leading the Princesses in the fight against Horde Prime’s forces.”

“Horde Prime,” Angella said quickly. “He has a hive mind that allows him to see everything through his clones and droids.”

“Adora found a magic door deep in the Whispering Woods that Horde Prime can’t access. We promise Glimmer is fine.” Bow took out his tracker pad and hit a button.

“I’m up. I’m up!” Glimmer appeared on the screen with two glowing fists. “Bow, what’s goin’ on?” she asked, rubbing her eyes free of sleep. “Did you make it?”

Angella didn’t fight the tears gathering in the corner of her eyes. “Glimmer.”

“Mom, I’m so sorry about everything. This is all my fault. When I realized I might not see you again, I didn’t know what to do. I’ve been so stupid.” Glimmer sobbed into the camera.

“None of that matters now. I love you so much,” Angella said soothingly.

Glimmer sniffled and wiped her eyes. “I love you too, mom.”

The ship jerked to a stop without warning. The lights went off and dim emergency lighting came on leaving the room in an odd red glow.

“I’ll check on Entrapta,” Bow said.

“We have to go, Glimmer,” Angella said regrettably. “I’ll do everything I can to be with you as soon as possible.”

“Before you go, can I speak to Shadow Weaver?” Glimmer requested.

Shadow Weaver took the pad, looking at the screen curiously.

“Hey.” Glimmer nodded. “Thank you for bringing Mom back.”

“You’re quite welcome. I was not returning without her,” Shadow Weaver replied.

“See you soon,” Glimmer said and ended the call.

Shadow Weaver hugged Angella tightly. “I do not know what I would do if I’d lost you again,” she whispered.

“Thanks to Catra, you don’t have to,” Angella responded.

“I still don’t understand what happened,” Adora said, scratching her head. “Did Catra say why she did it?”

“She said she did it for you, Adora. She said she knew you would come for me no matter what warning she sent,” Angella said.

“Did Horde Prime do anything to you?” Shadow Weaver pulled back and checked Angella over.

“Just a lot of talking.” Angella smoothed an absent hand under her chin.

“Whatever Catra’s motivation. I’m glad she did it because I…,” Shadow Weaver swallowed. What was wrong with her? She had said it once. Just a few days ago she had expressed her love for Angella. She supposed it had been easier when Angella was asleep and wasn’t looking at her with those doe eyes of lilac. How

pathetic that she couldn't manage to say three words during waking hours? She straightened her back and tried again. "I-"

"It's okay. I understand," Angella said, reaching for her mask. "Just show me."

Shadow Weaver's eyes widened. "Angella, what are you doing?"

Angella leaned in closer. "Take off that mask and kiss me," she demanded playfully.

Shadow Weaver glanced at Adora pointedly. "We can do so later."

Angella spread her wings to cover them from view. Shadow Weaver finally complied and removed her mask. They clutched at each other while their lips met in a desperate kiss.

Adora stared at the wall and tried to pretend she wasn't there.

"Hi!" Entrapta showed up on a large holographic screen behind them.

"Oh thank Eternia," Adora sighed out in relief. Out of the corner of her eye, Queen Angella's wings lowered and Shadow Weaver was back in her mask. "Entrapta, what's going on?"

"One sec." Entrapta waved her hair. "Darla, say hi."

"Hello," A computerized voice said off-screen.

Entrapta looked back and forth as if she was waiting on something. "Oh, Queen Angella. Darla is the ship."

"Entrapta, focus. Why have we stopped?" Adora asked.

"We're out of fuel and practically running on empty," Bow said, showing the fuel gauge in the red.

"The good news is that Darla found a planet nearby with the fuel crystals we need to get back to Etheria," Entrapta said.

Darla dive bombed towards the planet suddenly and all but crash landed on the planet's surface.

Adora, Shadow Weaver, Angella, and Bow prepared to brave the new planet's elements once the ship came to its abrupt halt. Monitors beeped and flashed in the background as Entrapta stared at them perched upon her hair.

"We need the thulite crystals in order to make it back to Etheria," Entrapta said, nudging them towards the door with both hands and both ponytails.

"Entrapta, don't you think we need spacesuits for this mission?" Adora asked, holding both sides of the doorframe.

"No need. The planet is at least ninety eight percent similar to Etheria," Entrapta announced.

"And the other two percent?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Entrapta blinked. "There's nothing to worry about. We can breathe and there's no enemies on site so no need to suit up."

"That's good because Queen Angella doesn't have a suit yet." Bow pointed out.

"I will get working on the spacesuit after I get the old fuel crystals out of Darla's system." Entrapta used her hair to press the button for the gangplank. "They're so old, I'm shocked they lasted so long. They practically fused to her system."

"You'll be able to retrieve them, right?" Angella asked.

"Of course, but poor Darla." Entrapta hugged the doorway. "It must be so painful for her."

“I do not feel pain,” Darla replied.

“Okay! Darla and I are going to spend some quality time together,” Entrapta grabbed some tools and wiggled her eyebrows at them just before the door slammed shut.

“Is it just me or was that just a little…?” Bow trailed off.

Adora shook her head and walked away. “Let’s just leave that where it is.” She kicked the dry dirt. “Darla’s sensors picked up fuel crystals. I don’t see how there could be anything on this planet.”

“What’s that structure in the distance?” Angella raised a hand above her eyebrows, peering past the dust clouds.

“That is a spire,” Shadow Weaver explained to Angella. “It is the first part of Horde Prime’s invasion.”

“There’s numerous ones all over Etheria right now, but we’re not gonna let anything else happen. We’re gonna get the crystals and defeat Horde Prime,” Adora said confidently.

Bow studied his tracker pad. “My pad states there are crystals beneath the planet’s surface so we are on the right path.” He double-tapped a button on the pad and flipped his screen for them to see. “Thulite are bright pink crystals. That’s what they look like.”

“There’s no other color besides tarnished gray as far as the eye can see,” Angella said.

Bow held up the tracker pad, trying to receive the best frequency. Seemingly satisfied with the results he received, he pointed west. “We need to go this way.”

Wind whistled by them as they walked, stirring more soil into the air in lazy swirls. The ground shook and rumbled. A large crack appeared in the arid soil, taking them all by surprise.

“Careful.” Shadow Weaver pushed the archer to the ground as he nearly stepped into a deep crevice.

“Thanks,” Bow said, checking to see if his tracker pad was damaged.

Another fissure crept across the ground, taking Adora under before anyone could react. They heard the blonde tumble down and finally reach the bottom with a grunt.

“Adora!” Angella shouted.

“Adora, are you hurt?” Shadow Weaver called down.

“I’m okay and I found the crystals,” Adora said happily. “No, wait.” She groaned a moment later. “None of them are the pink ones we need.”

“Of course not. That would have been too easy for a two-thirds Best Friend Squad quest,” Bow said with a small laugh.

“There is a light further through I’m gonna check it out,” Adora said.

“Adora, stay away from that light,” Angella said.

“Don’t go into the light!” Bow screamed in a panic.

“It’s not that kind of light. I’m perfectly fine,” Adora said as she disappeared from view.

“The tracker’s reading on the crystals state we’re really close now. We’ll need to follow Adora.” Bow put the pad away and climbed into the hole.

Angella glided down and waited patiently for Shadow Weaver. “Come down quickly. I can catch you if I need to.”

“I wonder what use these crystals might have.” Shadow Weaver wondered as she slid down the crystalline crater. She looked at

the abundance of cobalt crystals that twinkled merrily around them.

“You could probably chip away some samples to take with you,” Angella suggested, walking in the direction of Bow and Adora’s path.

“That would be unwise. We don’t know what kind of chemical these stones are,” Shadow Weaver said, ducking under a jutting crystal.

“The sensors found something living,” Bow said over his shoulder.

“Could there be survivors living on this planet?” Angella asked.

“There’s only one way to find out.” Bow hurried his pace. “There you are, Adora. Are you okay?”

“Hey, guys. These are the Star Siblings.” Adora waved at the three strangers behind her.

“Thank goodness we found you,” Angella said.

“Oh wow, an Angelic being,” Jewelstar said with a gasp. The three siblings kneeled at once while the bird whistled in greeting.

“You may rise.” Angella waved her hand dismissively. “This is hardly a formal occasion.”

“This is Queen Angella of Bright Moon, head of the Rebellion, Bow, my best friend, and Shadow Weaver, a Princess of the Rebellion and the woman that raised me.” Adora introduced them to the Star Siblings.

“She’s your mother?” Starla asked with a smile.

“Not exactly. She took me in as a baby and raised me but she was my commanding officer for most of it.” Adora elaborated. She scratched her arm. “Uh, it’s complicated.”

“Is your entire life this complicated?” Tallstar asked in disbelief.

“Kinda,” Adora admitted sheepishly.

The crystals along the ceiling trembled with another quake that shook the planet.

Angella looked startled. “What is going on?”

“Horde Prime must have made this planet’s structure unstable when he mined it for its resources and left it a husk.” Shadow Weaver guessed.

“The Star Siblings are looking for the thulite too. I think we should work together. They know where the crystals are and we can help retrieve them.” Adora suggested, pointing a thumb over her shoulder.

“The thulite is across this chasm further in. It was just a simple risky jump before but now it’s widened.” Jewelstar stood, appraising the group in front of him. “With an Angelic being though, she could fly across and get them in no time,” he said, rubbing his chin.

“Hello!” Entrapta exclaimed, walking into the small camp.

“Are there any more of you?” Tallstar asked, gathering the Star Siblings rations in her arms.

“Several!” Entrapta answered matter of factly. “But not on this planet.”

Tallstar tried to hide their provisions behind a large stone. “And do you all eat like you’ve never encountered food?”

“Just Adora,” Everyone but Entrapta said.

“Oh, wow guys. Thanks a bunch.” Adora rubbed the back of her neck with a light blush. “I apologize again for eating all your food.”

“Adora, you ate all of their food?” Bow eyebrows lifted in shock.

“Not everything. Just the ration we had set aside for the day,” Starla clarified while Tallstar huffed beside her. “We’ll get more,” she said to her sister.

“We have plenty of rations on our ship. Once we get the fuel crystals, I insist you take what you need.” Angella told the Star Siblings.

“Adora, I came as fast as I could to warn you. This planet is prone to sporadic seismic activity,” Entrapta said, shoving her datapad in the blonde’s face.

“Yeah we uh figured that out from the random holes we fell in,” Adora said with a nod.

“Darla and I figured out how to predict the tremors before they happen. Based on the pattern we won’t have long before a really big one hits. We will need to get to the thulite now rather than later.” Entrapta urged.

“Okay, let’s hurry,” Jewelstar said, walking further into the cave.

“It’s amazing how close they are,” Angella remarked with a soft smile.

“Tragedy of being on the run from a terror like Horde Prime and having no one else will do that.” Shadow Weaver watched as the siblings bantered amongst themselves. “They are very resilient.”

“There’s the thulite just up ahead.” Jewelstar pointed as they ducked through another opening.

“My readings indicate there may very well be another quake soon. Very soon,” Entrapta said nervously.

Adora looked around and noticed a crystal that stood taller than the others. “Your majesty, fly to the thulite as fast as you can. We’re gonna push this one over to make a bridge,” she explained.

Angella took flight, sailing across the chasm with ease.

“Okay, everyone let’s do this all together,” Adora said, bracing against the crystal.

The ground began to vibrate as Entrapta counted down and they pushed. With the last great tremble, the crystal was dislodged just barely touching both ends of the canyon to make a bridge. The quaking stopped for only a moment before the cave shook again.

“We need to provide assistance to Angella,” Shadow Weaver said, running over the bridge as fast as her legs could take her.

Crystals fell from the ceiling and shattered around them like glass. Jewelstar pulled Starla back just before she was crushed.

“That’s our only way out!” Tallstar shouted, running back to the small exit behind them. She and Adora tried to hold the exit open with their bare hands.

“The really big one is coming!” Entrapta warned.

“This bridge won’t hold.” Jewelstar crashed his sickle into the large crystal, pulling as hard as he could.

Bow ran behind Jewelstar and loosed arrow after arrow at the crystals, keeping Jewelstar safe. Starla and Glory shattered the crystals falling toward them with efficiency. Shadow Weaver created a mace to club the falling crystals while trying to keep an eye on Angella.

Angella was already climbing towards the rose-tinted crystals when her grip slipped. The tremors shook stalactites from the ceiling. They were falling too fast to dodge. One plummeted from above with deadly accuracy, crushing Angella's set of wings on the right. She screamed as the hollow bone fractured under the weight. The ground made a fault, lifting the thulite cave and Angella out of reach.

"Angella, your wings. Come back down." Shadow Weaver held out her hands. "I'll catch you."

"No, I can still climb. We need the thulite or we'll be stranded here as the planet breaks apart." Angella quickly reached and pulled herself into the opening ahead of her.

"Be careful." Shadow Weaver watched helplessly as Angella ascended out of sight with two limp wings trailing behind her. "Bow, get back across the cavern before it's too late."

"What about you?" Bow asked.

"I am not leaving without Angella." Shadow Weaver vowed.

Bow nodded and tied a rope arrow around Jewelstar's sickle. He shot the arrow into another nearby crystal to keep it held in place. He and the other two Jewel siblings ran back across the bridge.

"She-Ra." Shadow Weaver gasped as the rainbow light gleamed across the cavern. She turned to see Angella sliding down to her. She caught the other woman and ran back to the bridge.

"No!" Angella said, reaching for the fraying rope.

Shadow Weaver's fingers just missed the broken piece as it gave way to the great weight of the crystalline bridge. They could only watch as their only way across disappeared to the abyss below.

"Take these." Angella tore off her cape and handed Shadow Weaver the bundle of thulite. "We'll need both hands."

Shadow Weaver accepted the thulite and tucked it into her shirt and tightened her belt to make sure nothing would fall out. “We’ll need both hands for what?”

“I heal fast. I can get us across.” Angella tried to move her right wings. They were still stiff, but she could probably hold them straight for a short time. Chances were the women wouldn’t be in the air for very long.

“You can’t fly like this.” Shadow Weaver shook her head.

“I can,” Angella nodded. “They are still wings. We could glide across and get you close enough to pull us over with your metal.”

“That will not work,” Shadow Weaver said. Her eyes darted back and forth across the cavern, trying to find another solution for them to get across. The rest of her sentences blended as they left her mouth. “I didn’t get a chance to recharge when we left Etheria. I’m nearly out of magic again. I don’t know how strong the cable will be.”

“Breathe.” Angella used a hand and made Shadow Weaver look into her eyes. “You can do it. I know you can.”

The Dark Princess nodded decisively in return.

“Shadow Weaver!” Bow shouted. He shot an arrow from a protruding crystal above them. The rope was painfully short but would give them just enough length to reach the very edge of the chasm.

Shadow Weaver frantically made a long thin cable from her gauntlet and mace. She morphed hooks from the thumb rings. “Ready?”

“No, but let’s do it anyway,” Angella said quietly. They ran to the end of the cliff hand in hand. She extended her wings and immediately cried out in pain.

Her wings shuddered, trying in vain to hold their combined weight. They barely made it off the cliff before they were falling. Shadow Weaver shot the cable as far as it would go and it snagged against Bow's rope. The hooks skated across its surface and the cable grew slack as the crystal broke. They felt like they were falling in earnest now and Shadow Weaver was never more relieved than when the ground dug into her palm. She elongated her sharp nails and they nearly broke from the force she used to dig into the dirt. Bow, Adora, Entrapta, and the Star Siblings all grabbed Shadow Weaver's sleeve, collar, and any other clothing that would aid them in pulling up her and Angella.

Shadow Weaver felt the thulite points against her diaphragm as she clutched at Angella's fingers. The silk glove was slipping through her grip. "No," she said. She felt a tug and she noticed Angella removing her glove. "What are you doing?"

"Giving you something to hold onto," Angella said, twisting the glove around her palm she used her still healing wings to lessen the weight Shadow Weaver was trying to hold. The queen landed on the very edge of the cliff and helped to pull Shadow Weaver the final inches until they were both on solid ground again.

"I hope you got enough thulite because we have to get off this planet in approximately twenty minutes and counting," Entrapta announced, showing the group a rapidly disappearing countdown.

Everyone ducked through the crystal archway and hurried to the surface.

Shadow Weaver was in a darkened corner out of the way of the front door with her backpack. She was confident she was hidden unless anyone was looking for her outright. She had a small jar of

healing potion and a length of gauze next to her on the floor. Peeling her shirt away agonizingly slow, she grimaced as it caught on her slightly wet skin. Angella had stopped just before getting on the ship and explained that she would use the celestial power of the stars to recharge and heal. She encouraged Shadow Weaver to take care of any injuries she may have endured during their short-lived flight.

“What are you doing to yourself?” Angella asked affectionately.

“I’m trying not to reopen my wounds,” Shadow Weaver said with a tiny hiss.

Angella quickly lifted Shadow Weaver’s camisole. “How bad are you hurt?” Her face fell. “These are not wounds. You have some small abrasions that your shirt has been irritating.” She dipped a cotton ball into the bottle of healing potion that sat on the floor beside them. She used it to gently dab at the scratches across Shadow Weaver’s soft stomach.

“Careful,” Shadow Weaver said as the medicine was absorbed into the cuts.

“You’re a worse patient than Glimmer.” Angella blew air onto her skin, encouraging the homebrewed antiseptic to dry quickly.

“I risked my skin to get the thulite to safety. You could be kinder.” Shadow Weaver peeled back her fingerless gloves and rubbed a hefty amount into the scratches in her palm.

“My hero,” Angella said as flatly as she could as she packed away Shadow Weaver’s potions and trash.

“Don’t you forget it.” Shadow Weaver readjusted her shirt and stood as Adora came back into the cockpit.

“The Star siblings are going to start their own rebellion when they go to the next outpost,” Adora said.

“That’s great, Adora. Maybe if we can get enough planets rebelling Horde Prime would be spread too thin to focus on Etheria and we can get more time to defeat him,” Bow said.

Adora nodded, staring at the wall.

Bow looked at his friend when she didn’t answer. “Adora, are you okay?”

“I’ve been thinking. I know she’s fought us every chance she got and she’s with the Horde and hurt us time and time again but-” Adora sighed and shook her head. “No, forget it. It’s gonna sound crazy and so, so dangerous.”

“Adora, look at me.” Angella placed her hands on the blonde’s shoulder. “You want to go back and save Catra, don’t you?”

“Yes,” Adora said softly and lowered her head.

“I understand, Adora,” Angella said, hugging her. “I wouldn’t wish Horde Prime’s presence on anyone. Catra was very heroic when she risked her life to save me.”

Emboldened by Angella’s support of her suggestion, Adora turned to the rest of the ship. “Who knows where we’d be if Catra hadn’t saved you. I know he’s done something horrible to her. I don’t want to leave her there. I have to try.”

“It is crazy but so is everything we’ve ever done.” Bow nodded. “I’m with you, Adora.”

“We’ve only just refueled. We barely have a functioning spacecraft and you want to risk that to go after Catra?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“Yes!” Adora frowned. “How are the odds any different when we were gonna save Angella?”

“Our odds are not the issue.” Shadow Weaver said and paused. Her knee jerk reaction would be to say Catra’s not on their side,

but that was no longer the case with her recent actions. Catra spent time with Horde Prime and was well aware of how Horde Prime would react to her rebellion. She defied him and saved Angella despite knowing that. Shadow Weaver was in Catra's debt. Against all odds, she returned Angella to her. "Adora," she began again.

"I know you care about Catra. Even if it's way, way deep down inside. You should tell her." Adora suggested. "Maybe it will convince her to join us."

"There is nothing I can say to Catra that would penetrate that obnoxious mane of hair," Shadow Weaver said sharply then sighed. She didn't like this mission Adora suggested but it was no use. She was already outvoted. If she didn't agree to rescue Catra, Adora would find a way to complete it without her or dig her heels in, refusing to do anything else until Catra was included in their plans. She'd done it numerous times when she was younger. "If we are going to retrieve her from Horde Prime, we will need a solid plan." she finally acquiesced.

"We'll need to sneak past the clones without being seen then," Adora said.

"Catra discovered a weak spot on the back of their necks. If you are cornered and have no other way out, strike there hard and fast." Angella revealed.

"I did think of a plan but it first involves Entrapta making everyone space suits," Adora said.

"During our quality time, I had Darla come up with some schematics for new spacesuits." Entrapta walked across the room on her hair to press a button and display the suits.

Bow groaned. "Can you please stop calling what you do with Darla quality time?"

"Bow, leave it alone," Adora warned.

“It is our quality time,” Entrapta said, turning from the display. “What would you call it?”

“Repairs,” Bow said.

Entrapta scratched her head with one ponytail. “That seems just as odd.”

“Entrapta, I don’t think you realize what you’re implying by using the phrase ‘quality time’ that way.” Bow tried to explain to her.

“This is a vehicle we use in space. It is not a date to Princess Prom,” Shadow Weaver stated plainly.

“Oh,” Entrapta elongated the word. “Darla’s more than just a spaceship to me.” She wiggled her eyebrows again.

“Is she doing this to mess with us?” Bow whispered to Adora. “Part of her has to know what she’s saying.”

“Bow, some things are just not meant for us to understand. The ship is flying and we have functioning space suits,” Angella said, stopping the archer’s protest.

“Yes, functioning.” Entrapta echoed.

“You need to get in the cargo hold underneath the landing gear while I pretend to surrender to Horde Prime. After they search the ship, Entrapta and Bow will go to the server room to find out all you can about Horde Prime,” Adora said, outlining her plan. “Queen Angella and Shadow Weaver will search the ship and find out where they are keeping Catra.”

Entrapta, Bow, Angella, and Shadow Weaver fell out of the cargo hold just as the Prime Horde clones walked out of the hangar with

Adora in restraints.

“Spacesuit testing a success,” Entrapta said into her digital recorder.

“I thought you said they were ready?” Bow asked.

“No, the queen said they were functioning to which I agreed.” Entrapta pointed to Angella with her hair. “The bright side is that we survived the ship’s velocity with zero loss of life.”

“That was an option?” Angella squawked.

“Blowing up because of Entrapta’s tinkering is always an option,” Shadow Weaver said, removing her helmet.

“Adora, we’re in,” Bow said into his earpiece.

“Okay, stick to the plan and everyone assumes radio silence unless it’s mission critical,” Adora answered.

Angella and Shadow Weaver walked through the silent corridors. They passed what seemed to be endless polished archways with a neon green glow highlighting the architecture.

“I hope I can manage to navigate us back to the cell. It’s a complex labyrinth. I tried to count the steps and turns. Unfortunately, they brought me a different way each time I was out of my cell.” Angella studied her shaking hands. “I don’t think anyone can successfully travel these halls without being connected to the hive mind.”

“We’re nearly at the server room.” Bow informed them.

Shadow Weaver clasped Angella’s trembling hands in her own. “Horde Prime will pay for ever laying a finger on you.”

“I told him as much.” Angella grinned at Shadow Weaver. “He didn’t seem to be concerned.”

“I’ll teach him the definition of fear.” Shadow Weaver boasted with a kiss to Angella’s forehead through her mask.

Angella shifted suddenly and tried to tug at the back of her suit.

“What is it?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“It’s tight and pinching.” Angella rolled her shoulders. “The new wings are taking some getting used to.”

“I’ve been meaning to ask. What purpose do they serve?”

“I’m going to get stronger and my next life cycle can begin. That’s all I can tell you,” Angella said with a wink.

“Hmm, I’ll get it out of you in some way.” Shadow Weaver promised, leaning closer to the queen. “Unfortunately, we will have to wait until we are back on the ship before Entrapta can adjust the suit. I hope it does not cause you too much discomfort.”

“This is it,” Angella said, sliding her hand down the green barrier. The room was empty. “Catra’s not in the cell.” She told the group.

“Where else would he take her?” Shadow Weaver asked. She pressed the earpiece against her ear. “Entrapta, Bow, do you copy?” Only static answered her call.

“I can’t hear you over my earpiece either. I can only hear the static and you talking next to me,” Angella told her.

An alarm blared overhead and the sound of marching footsteps got closer. “Something is wrong. We have to find the others,” Shadow Weaver said.

“I think I might remember this hallway. They know we’re here so we may as well leave an impression,” Angella said, running the

opposite direction. Shadow Weaver quickly followed.

They reached a solid set of double doors. Angella yanked it open to reveal Horde Prime's menagerie.

"Is this some sort of pathetic trophy room?" Shadow Weaver asked, eyeing a severed head on the wall.

"These are the things he took from each planet he conquered," Angella explained, walking with determined steps to the back wall.

"Aren't you glad for all that single stick practice?" Shadow Weaver looked at the small arsenal mounted in front of them.

"Like you didn't use that as an excuse to straddle me."

"I don't need an excuse now," Shadow Weaver said, lifting a double-bladed polearm from its mount. "Choose your weapon."

Angella grabbed the staff with a sharp piece of quartz mounted to one end. "Remember to aim for the back of the neck."

Three clones entered the room.

"Send this through your hive mind." Shadow Weaver lifted the polearm and slashed the first clone's neck.

The body froze in place. Lime-green blood streamed down the incision. The clones' eyes remained expressionless as it fell to the floor. The two other clones looked startled and Angella struck, clubbing the first one on the face while Shadow Weaver slammed the side of her blade to the back of the second clone's neck.

"We have to find the server room," Angella said, stepping over the bodies.

"If Entrapta is there we just need to wait for an explosion." Shadow Weaver took off in a jog.

They quickly found a group of four Horde Prime clones trying to flood an open door. Beyond the clamoring mass of white and neon, they could hear the sounds of Bow's and Entrapta's bickering. Shadow Weaver rushed forward and lowered her shoulder. She used the polearm to bowl over the clones while Angella speared each of them in the nape of the neck. Shadow Weaver kicked the clone away from Bow and stabbed him to the floor, twisting the blade in its neck. A stream of green splattered across her boots.

"Entrapta, I don't know what you're trying to accomplish but we need to leave," Angella said as she helped Bow off the floor.

"I'm so close. I just need a few more minutes and I can figure out the network," Entrapta said. Her fingers flew frantically across the keyboard.

"Brother, thank you for taking care of the interlopers impeding Horde Prime's will," A clone said with a smile.

Shadow Weaver turned her weapon to the clone with mussed hair. "What is this?"

"That's Wrong Hordak. We accidentally disconnected him from the hive mind. He's harmless for the most part," Bow explained.

"I suppose Entrapta wants to keep him around?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Bow shrugged. "We broke him."

Shadow Weaver eyed the clone a few moments more. "Fine, he can come. We might be able to get information from him." She lowered her weapon.

"We don't have time to hack Horde Prime properly, but we can still slow him down," Angella said, using her spear to pierce the server interface. Sparks shot from the spear and sent crackling electricity traveling up the spire antenna.

“Entrapta, we are leaving.” Shadow Weaver grabbed Entrapta and ran out of the room.

Multiple explosions boomed behind them as they ran as fast as they could toward the general direction of the hangar. Six Horde Prime clones blocked their path. Sliding to a stop, they backed up only to discover seven more clones bringing up the rear.

“How are we getting out of here? There’s far too many to fight,” Angella said.

“We might have had a chance if someone had not thrown their spear into a computer,” Shadow Weaver said, looking at Angella.

“You weren’t complaining at the time.” Angella shot back.

“I can get us out but you have to promise not to get mad that I maybe...probably one hundred percent completely disregarded your instructions not to tinker with the ship.” Entrapta fidgeted with the tips of her fingers.

“Entrapta, if you get us out of here you can tinker with the ship all you want from now on.” Bow vowed.

“Alright!” Entrapta cheered then whistled. “Hey, Darla.” Darla crashed through the hallway, scattering the clones that were inching closer. “Good girl.” the tech Princess praised, rushing up the gangplank with Wrong Hordak in tow.

“We can’t leave without Adora. She must have found Catra by now,” Shadow Weaver said to Angella.

A brilliant light appeared from their right in a radiant shower of rainbow. The flash cleared and there She-Ra stood resolute and strong, carrying a limp Catra in her arms. Shadow Weaver studied the new transformation proudly. Adora’s innate First Ones’ magic had altered the appearance to look closer to her true self. She looked more mature and certainly more powerful than anything she had ever encountered before.

Masked eyes dropped to Catra again and Shadow Weaver's jaw clenched. Her chest felt tight as she tried to swallow past the tension in her throat. "What did he do to her?" she growled, her hair began lifting around her head.

"Take her and I'll take care of them." Adora handed Catra to Shadow Weaver and turned to the advancing clones.

Shadow Weaver ran up the gangplank, her eyes never leaving Catra. She looked so small and innocent. Her face was pale and her breaths were thready and uneven.

"I know you can hang on, Catra. She-Ra is just outside." Laying Catra across her lap, Shadow Weaver propped herself against the captain's chair. "You're a survivor. You've never stopped fighting a day in your life. You survived me at my worst and won. A few days with Horde Prime is nothing compared to that." She cradled Catra's head against her chest. "I'm sorry, Catra." She whispered.

Entrapta was at the control panel trying to find some way to get them airborne. Darla was running diagnostics on her systems. From the numerous flashes and alerts, it didn't sound like they would be flying away anytime soon. She-Ra walked into the ship and rested her hand on the control panel. The beeping and chimes ceased at once. The ship glowed in the pure light of She-Ra's power and they flew out the side of Horde Prime's fortress.

"Come on, Catra." She-Ra kneeled next to Shadow Weaver and took Catra in her arms. She hugged Catra gently. "You can wake up now. We're going home." She promised and let her magic flow forth.

Catra gasped and coughed weakly. "Hey, Adora."

"Hey, Catra," Adora said softly.

"Adora?"

"Yeah?"

“Was I having a dream or did Shadow Weaver apologize to me?” Catra asked with a confused frown.

Adora let out a watery chuckle. “Why don’t you ask her yourself?”

Shadow Weaver stood smoothly to her feet, avoiding the curious eyes boring into her. “He should not have cut your hair.” She managed.

Angella’s eyes narrowed as she glanced at her partner. She looked pointedly at Catra and back to Shadow Weaver.

“Welcome back.” Shadow Weaver intoned after a few more silent moments and gracefully left the room.

“One would think once you’re in space it would be more peaceful. It’s just nonstop adventures as on Etheria,” Shadow Weaver said as she settled into bed later that night.

“Imagine that. Do you need time to rest?” Angella asked lightly. The corner of her mouth quirked in a smirk.

“No, I do not. I was more worried about you,” Shadow Weaver said as she dug through her backpack, looking for one of her mother’s journals. “You’ve suffered a rather traumatic experience.”

“Of course, darling,” Angella said innocently.

“Do not start with that again.” Shadow Weaver accused lightly, glancing from her book.

“Don’t pout. I’ve always enjoyed your maturity. You know that,” Angella said, tugging a brush through her hair.

“I do not pout.” Shadow Weaver returned to her reading.

“Too bad. If you did it might distract me from what happened in the cockpit earlier,” Angella remarked.

“I do not know what you mean,” Shadow Weaver stated, staring intently at the pages before her. The tangible weight of the conversation was sudden, their playful mood most certainly forgotten.

“You’re really going to try that?”

“I did not know what to say.”

“ *You* didn’t know what to say?” Angella asked incredulously. “You could have tried something genuine. You’re never at a loss for words,” she said, placing her brush down.

“I have spent so long trying to show the Horde that Catra and Adora were nothing more to me than admirable top cadets that I’ve forgotten how to do anything else.” Shadow Weaver admitted.

“Oh, my darling,” Angella said softly, turning to give her partner her full attention. “That is the largest load of rubbish you have ever said to me. Tell Catra the truth.”

“It’s not that simple.” Shadow Weaver shook her head.

“It can be. Just as you’ve shown me what your feelings are, you can show Catra. You can show Adora. When you’re ready, you can finally tell them.”

“Adora doesn’t need me any longer. She hasn’t needed me for a very long time,” Shadow Weaver said.

“Just because Adora grew up and became more independent doesn’t mean she doesn’t need you. They both need you. A better you. The you I know you can be.” Angella sat on the bed.

“Thank you. Your belief in me makes everything easier.” Finally placing her book down, Shadow Weaver reached out for Angella’s

hand. She lifted it and pressed a gentle kiss to her partner's palm. "I need to tell you about Beast Island."

"You found Micah there," Angella said quietly.

Shadow Weaver nodded. "How did you know?"

"Horde Prime." Angella took a shaky breath. "He tried to weaken my resolve to join him."

"He had to know that wouldn't work," Shadow Weaver said. "To come after your family means to bring out the warrior in you."

"All he knew about me was whatever knowledge he absorbed from Hordak's brain," Angella said, smoothing her other hand across the bed.

"I wanted to tell you about Micah sooner. There just hasn't been any time," Shadow Weaver said regrettably.

"Did you know about his treatment?" Angella asked.

"No, I did not. I never would have done that to you," Shadow Weaver responded. She applied a quick reassuring squeeze to the hand still snug in her own. "Hordak sent Micah to Beast Island. He didn't consult with me about his treatment."

"How did you not know?" Angella stood and started pacing in the corner of the room.

"Angella, I wasn't certain." Shadow Weaver placed the journal on the side table.

Angella halted her steps. "You must have suspected it. From what I've seen, Hordak sends all of his prisoners to Beast Island."

"There were only rumors he was captured. He wasn't in any of the cells when I went to check. I assumed the cadets were lying or misheard," Shadow Weaver said.

Angella came back to the bed. “I need to know what else you saw and everything that happened on Beast Island.” She reached out and pulled Shadow Weaver’s hand to rest against her heart. The queen sighed. “I need to know if Micah suffered and what his possible last thoughts were.”

Shadow Weaver steeled her resolve and prepared herself to hurt her partner. “I do not know what befell Micah. I can only tell you what it was like for us.” she proceeded to tell Angella the full unfiltered story of the Beast Island events.

Angella patiently listened until Shadow Weaver’s tale was done. She sniffled, staring over the brunette's shoulder to the opposite wall of the room.

“Angella?” Shadow inquired softly. “Is there anything I can do?”

The Dark Princess felt inadequate as the question left her lips. There weren’t enough apologies she could offer Angella and of course there was nothing to be done. The brunette watched as the queen’s eyes fluttered causing tears of grief to drip from her eyes. After the few moments dragged on the younger woman shook her head in the negative.

“Don’t shut me out. Is there anything you want to do?” Shadow Weaver begged. “Yell at me. Hurt me. Please, Ella. Please.”

A strained whimper escaped Angella’s throat. “Micah…”

Shadow Weaver quickly pulled Angella into her arms. She held her partner until her sobbing cries morphed back into silent tears. Eventually, Angella’s breaths deepened and Shadow Weaver was happy to hold the ombré haired woman throughout the night. All the brunette could do was try to offer comfort and she felt that wasn’t enough. There was nothing she could do that would alter Micah’s fate.

Shadow Weaver was not surprised to wake up alone. She wasn't sure how long it had been since Angella left her side but her partner's clothing and boots were already missing from their shared room. The other woman no doubt wanted some space and solace to process Micah's possible final moments as she mourned Micah all over again.

Trying to shake the thoughts from her head, Shadow Weaver focused on completing her morning stretches. She got dressed and headed to the kitchen. On the way, she found Angella looking fondly into Catra's room.

"How did you sleep?" Shadow Weaver asked softly.

Angella had dark circles under her puffy, red-rimmed eyes. "I'll be fine. I'm still a bit drained." Her voice was slightly hoarse. "I'm glad they're asleep this time," she said.

Shadow Weaver peered into the room. Adora was asleep on the floor next to Catra's cot. "Adora needs to be at peak performance in case She-Ra is needed. She's not any closer to figuring out her transformation and is not willing to learn."

"Where is the Sword of Protection? Can we reclaim it?" Angella asked.

"It's shattered. Adora had to destroy it to stop the Heart of Etheria from being weaponized by Light Hope. Everything we thought we knew about the First Ones is false. They made the Sword to control She-Ra and use her."

"If I've learned nothing else from all of this, it's that nothing is ever the way it truly seems," Angella said wearily.

"Indeed." Shadow Weaver sighed with a shake of her head. "I was afraid of this happening."

"What's that?" Angella asked.

"Catra becoming a distraction," Shadow Weaver said.

“Catra is not Adora’s distraction. She’s her anchor.” Angella countered.

“Her only focus right now should be on trying to find her connection to She-Ra’s magic.”

“You and I both know this is one and the same.” Angella nodded her head towards the room. “Saving Catra seemed to be her focus point when she finally transformed into She-Ra again.” She kept her eyes on the sleeping girls. “Have you spoken to Catra since she was healed?”

“You know I haven’t,” Shadow Weaver replied.

“You need to talk to her. Surely you can relate to her conflicting feelings about switching sides.” Angella urged her partner.

Shadow Weaver hummed noncommittally and looked at her former wards. Adora began weakly punching the air around her before she settled down. Catra’s tail flicked lazily curling around her. Catra’s arm dangled off the side of the cot and Adora’s hand rested just inches away on the floor. Even in their sleep, they reached for each other.

She knew Adora was destined for greatness when she felt the power within her. The blonde was supposed to be the greatest Force Captain the Horde had ever seen. Shadow Weaver had plans for Adora that never came to fruition. Plans that were completely derailed the second Adora found the Sword of Protection. She supposed the argument could be made that her plans were foiled much earlier. If ever there was such a thing as love at first sight it was when Catra and Adora locked eyes as toddlers. She tried to sever their connection at every chance she was allowed. The demon presence used to make it easier to fight the truths she’d always known. Catra was always going to be a distraction for Adora. Catra was always going to be Adora’s weakness just as Angella was hers.

Shadow Weaver turned away from the doorway. “Would you like some tea?”

Angella pressed the panel to close the door. “I’ll take that to mean you admitting I’m right,” she said, placing her hand in Shadow Weaver’s.

“Good morning, brothers!” Wrong Hordak greeted them as soon as they reached the kitchen. Spring green liquid was dripping from the corner of his mouth.

Angella flinched and backed up into Shadow Weaver.

“It’s okay.” Shadow Weaver wrapped her arms around Angella to steady her. “Wrong Hordak, get out.”

Wrong Hordak wiped his face free of amniotic fluid with a confused frown. “I never meant to scare a fellow exalted brother. I will leave at once.”

Shadow Weaver started searching through the cabinets. “Do you believe we will find any tea in here other than instant tea capsules?” she asked after retrieving the box she was looking for.

“I’m afraid not,” Angella responded regretfully. “It can’t be that bad. A little sugar and cream could make it palatable.”

Shadow Weaver heated the water and dropped one of the instant tea tablets. “I’m going to drink as much ginger tea as I can when I get back to Etheria.”

“I’ll make sure.” Angella easily agreed. “You’re grumpier than usual without your morning ritual.”

“You make it better,” Shadow Weaver said, removing her mask. She gave Angella a sweet kiss.

“We have a little more time before anyone comes in here,” Angella told her as she moved the mask out of reach and placed it on her

face. “How do you breathe with this on? Do you never feel claustrophobic?”

“It’s a necessity of which I have become accustomed.” Shadow Weaver sipped from her mug with a grimace. With a practiced hand, she poured a hefty amount of sugar and a splash of cream. “I understand that last night was particularly trying. I would not be surprised if you were having second thoughts about our relationship.” She stated as casually as she could.

“We are fine,” Angella assured her. “I’m still processing what we spoke about last night and I would like to revisit this topic after we save the world.”

“I’ll be here when you need me.” Shadow Weaver sipped from her tea. It was a better mouthful although it paled in comparison to any fresh tea. “I want to do a memorial service for Micah. He deserved more than what that coward Hordak did.” she slid her finger along the rim of the mug. “He deserved better than what I did.”

“Thank you,” Angella said, reaching for her hand. “I’d like that very much.”

In the distance, they heard Entrapta chatting away with Wrong Hordak and a loud crash.

Shadow Weaver accepted her mask back from Angella. “It’s time to start the day.”

“Adora, you’re awake. Good. We really should discuss She-Ra,” Shadow Weaver said as the blonde approached.

“Catra’s fine by the way,” Adora said in greeting.

“I know,” Shadow Weaver said. “You’ve been attached to her side ever since you healed her. I’m sure you would have mentioned any changes in her recovery.”

“What Shadow Weaver is trying to say is we are glad Catra is doing well,” Angella said diplomatically.

“You need to start learning how to access She-Ra at will.” Shadow Weaver persisted.

“How did you do that without the sword?” Bow asked.

“I don’t know,” Adora replied honestly. “I just felt like she was always there inside me trying to get out.”

“What’s important is that She-Ra was there when your friends needed you.” Bow grinned. “Well, friends, ally, and one person who threw me off a cliff.” He amended and returned his attention to piloting the ship as it jerked.

“Be that as it may we don’t have the luxury of this wait and see attitude.” Shadow Weaver’s voice climbed.

“It’s been a long few days in space and I’m sure we’ll be relieved when we are finally home,” Angella said.

“Darla’s speed is only at about thirty percent. It’s gonna take us a while to get there.” Entrapta reported from her place somewhere inside the ship’s circuitry.

“Hopefully Entrapta can fix Darla soon. We need to beat Horde Prime back to Etheria,” Bow said.

“Well, now how about I cook us a meal to celebrate our victorious escape from Horde Prime?” Angella asked the group.

“Uh…” Bow looked intently at the holographic map in front of him.

Shadow Weaver faced Angella. “Only if your cooking has improved significantly since Mystacor.”

“I’m gonna go check on Catra,” Adora said, leaving suddenly.

“Adora.” Shadow Weaver tried to reach out but Angella stopped her.

“Let her go. You and I have a meal to cook,” Angella said as she poked Shadow Weaver playfully. “Also, I’ll have you know that I’ve perfected my gingerbread.” She smiled proudly.

“Have you added more earrings to it or less?” Shadow Weaver teased.

“What do you care? I know you all hate me!” Catra shouted from her room.

“I never hated you.” Adora shot back immediately.

“What are you looking at?” Catra demanded as she caught sight of Shadow Weaver looking into the cracked door.

“Right now is obviously not the time for you to speak,” Angella said as she quickly pulled Shadow Weaver past the door and into the kitchen. “Let’s let them work through it.”

“Queen Angella, can I talk to you for a minute?” Adora asked abruptly.

“Of course, Adora,” Angella said, following the blonde from the room.

Shadow Weaver continued going through the rations trying to find something recognizable that they could use. She was determined to give Adora her privacy. She heard the blonde’s hissed yelling and Angella soothing tones.

“Darla’s sensors picked up Horde ships on our tail,” Bow announced, prompting them to rush back to the cockpit.

“We need to lose them,” Adora said.

“Well, we could go into this asteroid field,” Entrapta suggested with a manic grin. “But I was forbidden from changing the course.”

“Our speed is barely over a quarter of its capabilities.” Shadow Weaver pointed out.

“The ship is falling apart,” Bow argued.

“Well we don’t have any other ideas so I guess we’re heading for the asteroids,” Adora said.

Bow typed in the new coordinates and acknowledged Darla’s warning. Phantom steering gloves appeared over both of his hands. “Okay, we’re in. They shouldn’t be able to find us,” he said.

The ship rocked as laser rockets collided with Darla. Shadow Weaver pulled the ship back to a straightened position, working with Bow to even out the ship’s path. Entrapta revealed there were more ships incoming.

“They shouldn’t be able to see us among the asteroids, what’s going on?” Angella asked.

“Horde Prime can’t track Darla,” Entrapta said, typing on her datapad. “Something else is giving off a trace signal.”

“The chip,” Shadow Weaver realized. “Is it deactivated?” she asked Adora.

“No, we didn’t have time before and Catra doesn’t want Entrapta to look at it,” Adora explained as they jerked from another hit.

Shadow Weaver pointed to the hall leading to the sleeping quarters. “It no longer matters what Catra wants. Her presence is endangering the lives of everyone aboard this ship.”

“I’m handling it,” Adora growled, tugging Entrapta along with her.

Bow looked panicked as they left. “Entrapta still has to fix Darla’s shields.”

“You’re just gonna have to not hit anything,” Adora said over her shoulder as the door closed.

“I can use my remaining elemental magic to give us a burst of speed but it will take all of my concentration.” Shadow Weaver suggested.

“Is there anything I can do to help?” Angella asked.

“You will need to be Bow’s eyes so he can avoid the asteroids,” Shadow Weaver said.

Shadow Weaver stood at the control panel and stretched her senses. It took longer than normal for the metal in the hull of the ship to connect with her. There was a stillness that overtook her like the calm before a storm and then she forced the spacecraft to move. Darla rocketed forward past the lazily floating asteroids.

“It’s not working. They are still gaining on us.” Bow shouted from his seat.

“One moment.” Shadow Weaver’s hair fluffed across her head as she opened her hands out at her sides and held the ship aloft.

“We’re not moving at all now. This is the opposite of what I wanted,” Bow was all but shrieking now.

The ship dove just narrowly brushing past a large asteroid. The Horde ships blasted it and it broke apart sending smaller ones clanging against Darla’s hull.

Shadow Weaver anticipated the drain on her magic but she didn’t know it would happen so quickly. “I can’t hold it much longer. You’ll have to take over,” she said to Angella and released her hold on Darla. The drop in speed was significantly lowered.

“Bow, veer left. Up, down. Go up,” Angella said quickly.

Shadow Weaver noticed a kaleidoscopic streak of energy hopping over the asteroid field.

“Is that She-Ra?” Angella asked, following her gaze.

“Go, right,” Shadow Weaver said suddenly. “It seems she figured out how to transform once more.”

They watched as She-Ra dispatched the Horde ships and cleared a path through the asteroids.

“Bow, you can continue. I am confident Adora did not leave anyone to pursue us.” Shadow Weaver told the archer.

“I left Wrong Hordak in the kitchen before all this started. I know what will be perfect for dinner,” Angella said, kissing Shadow Weaver’s cheek.

As soon as Angella was out of sight, Shadow Weaver leaned heavily against the control panel.

“Are you okay?” Bow asked after a few moments when she didn’t move.

“I am,” Shadow Weaver said.

“Right, normal perfectly okay people nearly slump on the floor to relax after carrying a ship through space,” Bow remarked disbelievingly.

“I just need to rest and I haven’t eaten yet,” Shadow Weaver explained. She lied about how much elemental magic she had stored and was forced to use her reserved magic. She would be drained for a time until they got back to her Runestone.

“The chip removal was a success,” Entrapta announced as she came back. “I’ll get back to fixing Darla,” she said and disappeared into the alcove full of wires.

The door whooshed open again and Shadow Weaver stood cautiously. Adora came into the room and rested on her back on the floor, silently staring at the ceiling.

“Darla’s shields and autopilot are back online. All she needs is a system reboot and she’ll be fully functional once more.” Entrapta reported, hanging out of the panel upside down.

Bow released the controls and laid opposite Adora with his arms resting on his abdomen. Angella and Wrong Hordak entered the room with trays filled with steamed buns.

“This looks delicious,” Bow said, sitting up.

“I admit I’m not that great a cook but I know a few recipes. This is just something I used to make with Glimmer when she was younger.” Angella lowered the tray to the floor. Her eyes turned sad as her shoulders drooped. “We haven’t done anything together in a long time.”

Shadow Weaver came over and trailed a hand down Angella’s face and she relaxed onto the floor next to her. “Entrapta fixed the shields and autopilot. You will see Glimmer soon.”

Bow picked up a bun and bit into it. “These are really good.”

“How did you make the dehydrated protein slaw taste like this?” Adora asked, shoveling another steamed bun passed her lips.

“I wonder if these can be made in smaller sizes.” Entrapta studied a bun and placed her helmet back on, scanning it.

Wrong Hordak quietly ate his food with a small smile.

“Thank you.” Angella moved closer to Shadow Weaver and took her chin. “I have some set aside for you in the kitchen. I didn’t want you to miss out. With the way Adora is putting them away you just might,” she whispered with a chuckle.

Catra came in and paused upon seeing Shadow Weaver. The group looked at Catra and she sat on the floor outside the circle, hugging her knees to her chest. Angella looked at Shadow Weaver and nodded. The Dark Princess scooted over, making room for the younger woman. Angella handed Catra one of the buns once the teen slid into the space. Catra peeked across the small space to Adora. Adora smiled at Catra, her bulging cheeks full of food. Nibbling on her meal, Catra shook her head affectionately.

"So, I admit driving through asteroids was kinda cool. Especially with my copilot today." Bow grinned at Angella. "Glimmer would have loved it," he said softly. Everyone paused in their eating. A more solemn mood settled across them.

"Glimmer should have checked in by now," Angella said, glancing at the datapad near the captain's chair.

Adora bowed her head, looking away. "Catra said Horde Prime was trying to take over Etheria by chipping them."

Angella looked stricken and tightened her fingers in her lap. "Everyone?"

"In one of her last flashes from the hive mind, she saw Frosta, Castaspella, Glimmer, Spinnerella, and Netossa in Elberon fighting off the villagers," Adora said.

"We have to get back, now." Angella began to stand.

"Castaspella was with them, Angella. She wouldn't let anything happen to Glimmer," Shadow Weaver said, reaching behind Catra to grip her partner's hand.

A sudden beeping sounded and Entrapta shrieked happily. "A signal. That means we're in range. Patching us through to the Rebellion's communication channel."

Everyone rushed forward and huddled over the small screen.

“Adora?” Perfuma inquired. She kept sending furtive glances over her shoulder.

Adora frowned as she looked at the flower Princess. “Perfuma?” she asked.

“Perfuma, what’s happened? Have you heard from Glimmer?” Angella asked frantically.

“No, we split up. There isn’t much time left. I needed to tell you that you can’t come back. Horde Prime knows you’re coming. He’s set up a blockade around the planet. We lost them. We lost them all. I’m so sorry.” Perfuma ran away from something off-screen and the transmission ended abruptly.

The cockpit was filled with silence as everyone stared at the datapad’s blank screen in shock. They were each trying to comprehend the desperate message they received from Perfuma. They yearned to return home and defeat Horde Prime and now it appeared as though they wouldn’t even be able to enter Etheria’s atmosphere.

“What do we do now?” Bow asked softly as he placed the datapad down.

Adora had a determined set to her jaw. “We have to get back to Etheria.”

“You heard her. Horde Prime is waiting on you,” Catra said with an annoyed frown.

“We’re not leaving them to be controlled by him,” Angella said.

“Catra, when you were with Horde Prime, do you remember anything about any weaknesses he might have?” Adora asked.

“No, before the mind control all he talked about was knowing everything and seeing everything,” Catra said with an annoyed flick of her ears. “Why would he tell me about weaknesses?”

Wrong Hordak walked up behind Catra, startling her. “Little Brother is right. We do not discuss Horde Prime’s weakness,” he informed them.

“That means he has one.” Adora nodded.

Wrong Hordak’s face twitched. “No, we do not discuss any weakness of Horde Prime because there are none. Horde Prime is all powerful.”

“Nothing in the data bank about weaknesses,” Entrapta said, typing on Darla’s control panel.

“There’s nothing weak about Horde Prime. He knows all and sees all. We do not speak of Krytis.” Wrong Hordak blurted out.

“What is Krytis?” Shadow Weaver asked triumphantly.

“Doing a search on Krytis,” Entrapa said. Darla’s alarm sounded and an obscured planet popped up on the display in red. “It looks like it’s locked and only an administrator can access it.”

Adora walked forward. “Darla, show us.”

“Looks like it’s only a short distance from here,” Entrapta said, looking at the galactic map that was displayed.

“Darla, set a course for Krytis,” Adora said.

Entrapta began chattering excitedly. “Oh, a new planet. I have so many gadgets to prepare.”

Shadow Weaver placed a flat hand on Entrapta’s head to stop her movements. “You need to use your schematics and make another new spacesuit for Angella.”

“And a helmet for Catra so you know it doesn’t pinch her ears,” Adora added.

“I’ll work on it right away. Come on, Wrong Hordak.” Entrapta used her hair to pull the liberated clone along with her. He was babbling and appeared to be about to hyperventilate. Catra and Adora followed the pair out of the room.

Angella turned to Shadow Weaver. “Do you think you should be coming on this mission?” she asked quietly. She kept her voice low aware that Bow was still in the room.

“Is this another crack about my age?” Shadow Weaver asked teasingly.

“I know you’re more drained than you’re admitting,” Angella said, smoothing Shadow Weaver’s hair back away from her mask.

“You are not suggesting I stay behind?” Shadow Weaver stiffened. “There’s something on this planet that nearly defeated Horde Prime. I’m not going to let you face that alone. Do not ask me to do that,” she hissed softly.

“Adora, Bow, Entrapta, Catra, and not that it brings me much comfort, but Wrong Hordak will all be there,” Angella said, hugging Shadow Weaver. “I’m not trying to punish you by asking you to stay on the ship. I’m asking because I love you and want you safe.”

“I need to be there.” Shadow Weaver argued.

“Darling, you’re exhausted. I can see that it's taking all your energy to stay upright. Why are you being so stubborn?”

“I failed to protect you. I wasn’t strong enough or fast enough and I allowed him to take you away from me. From us,” Shadow Weaver said.

“I’m right here,” Angella said softly. She ran her fingers through Shadow Weaver’s hair and waited for her partner to finish.

“I imagined so many terrible things that he would do to you, but I never considered behavioral modification. If Horde Prime had

chipped you I don't know what I would have done." Shadow Weaver sat up and pulled back, looking into Angella's eyes.

"You would have done what you needed to do. I know you're beating yourself up over Horde Prime abducting me. You're not useless. If you truly don't feel up to it, please stay on the ship. No one will think any less of you for it."

Shadow Weaver squeezed Angella and removed herself completely from the embrace. "I would feel infinitely better if I accompanied you."

"Entrapta finished the suits," Adora said as the door opened.

"That was fast." Bow remarked across the room. He was scanning through all the Rebellion's communication frequencies, hoping someone would answer his call.

"There are plenty of suits. She just needed to modify their sizes and make wider slits for your wings," Adora said, holding up the new suit for Angella.

"Since we have some a little time before we make it to Krytis, how about you focus on turning into She-Ra?" Bow suggested.

"I agree with this plan," Shadow Weaver said.

"You would," Catra growled.

"It's crucial that Adora learns to channel her new transformation outside of dire situations." Shadow Weaver said, ignoring Catra. "Adrenaline should not be your only motivator." She stood and walked over to Adora. "Do you not recall what Madame Razz said? She-Ra is not a sword. You have the magic inside you. You need peace in order to use it. You've always had the magic inside you, Adora. You and She-Ra are the same. Just concentrate."

Adora reached out her right hand with a grunt. Her iconic sword barely flickered into existence when she felt the connection to her magic falter.

“Try again. You need to figure out your purpose.” Shadow Weaver placed her hands on Adora’s shoulder and whispered. “When all else fails, calm yourself, inhale, and focus on what you are fighting for.”

“What are you whispering about? Adora, don’t listen.” Catra stomped forward, glaring at Shadow Weaver. “Don’t try to use her for access to She-Ra’s power.”

“Catra, we have not interacted in some time, so I’ll dismiss that statement.” Shadow Weaver dropped her hands from Adora’s shoulders and clasped her hands together calmly.

“Don’t bother. You’re not doing me any favors.” Catra sneered, flicking her tail behind her.

“As if I would do a favor for you.” Shadow Weaver spat.

“Good,” Catra said.

Shadow Weaver used her height to tower over Catra. “Fine.”

Catra peered at Shadow Weaver. “Why are you trying to get the last word?”

“ *I* am not,” Shadow Weaver leaned back, crossing her arms.

“Oh, you so are,” Catra said with a smirk.

“Will you two stop?” Adora asked as her transformation into She-Ra failed again.

They responded at the same time.

“She started it!” Catra cried.

“I was instructing Adora,” Shadow Weaver said.

“Fascinating,” Entrapta cried, hovering over Catra and Shadow Weaver with her hair. She spoke into her digital recorder that was tightly grasped in a tendril of hair. “Classic case of nature versus

nurture at its best. Not related by blood yet the same mannerisms."

Shadow Weaver and Catra hissed at Entrapta, displaying their claws. They glanced at each other and turned away with a glower in opposite directions.

"Come on," Angella said, pulling Shadow Weaver away to their shared room. "We'll be near Krytis soon and you can help me get changed."

"Her impudence knows no bounds," Shadow Weaver said as soon as they were out of the room.

Angella laughed.

"Do not laugh. She is a nuisance."

Angella rolled her eyes at her partner's irritation. "All daughters can be."

"Catra is no one's daughter," Shadow Weaver said, clenching her fists.

"You don't have to act tough with me. You love both of those girls." Angella placed her hand on Shadow Weaver's arm.

Shadow Weaver scoffed. "That accusation seems completely uncalled for."

Chapter End Notes

Snarky Shadow Weaver is so fun! 😆 Next chapter down, lol. 🍾 I'm off to the next one. Until next time!

Edit: Thanks as always to anyone that take the time out to click, kudos, and review!

You Want a Revelation

Chapter Summary

More Space Adventures

Chapter Notes

Archive: Don’t copy to another site without permission

Spoilers: I’m picking and choosing what canon plot lines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, “Light Spinner” will be pretty spoilery.

Disclaimer: She-Ra and the Princesses of Power belong to DreamWorks and the wonderful Noelle Stevenson. Any and all other brand names that might appear here belong to their respective owners. I do not make any money on this story. Please don’t sue; you only stand to gain outstanding student loans for your troubles.

Author’s Note: This is inspired by fanart, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine’s song “No Light, No Light” along with Five Finger Death Punch’s “Wrong Side of Heaven.” My brain couldn’t leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

All mistakes I claim as my own.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 8: You Want a Revelation

It didn’t seem possible but somehow Krytis almost looked like a more desolate wasteland than the planet with thulite. Slimy teal mineral deposits covered every inch of its surface. Broken and decaying spires littered the landscape. After Entrapta declared the atmosphere breathable, everyone accepted an earbud and started to explore. Shadow Weaver looked around the planet, feeling an odd kinship to it. It spoke to something within her. She brushed the sensation away and tried to focus on her surroundings. She was determined to be diligent despite her exhaustion.

“How are you going along with this?” Catra asked from her right.

Shadow Weaver sighed. “With what, Catra?”

“Are we really going to just go explore a structurally unsound planet looking for something that may not even exist?” Catra asked.

“Yup,” Bow said with an easy grin.

Adora nodded unconcerned. “Uh huh.”

“You objected to returning to Etheria.” Shadow Weaver reminded Catra.

Catra crossed her arms. “Because that was a dumb plan.”

“Hey, that’s right. If it weren’t for you we’d be trying to fight Horde Prime’s armada right now.” Adora smirked, looking at Catra.

“Which means it’s your first mission,” Bow exclaimed, ruffling her hair.

“Quit it,” Catra grunted. She slapped Bow’s hand away and walked ahead of them. Adora and Bow ran behind her chanting with delight.

“You're looking piqued.” Angella fell into step with Shadow Weaver. “How are you?”

“This planet feels odd to me. Familiar and comfortable,” Shadow Weaver said, looking around.

“Entrapta said this was once a First Ones’ colony. Could you be responding to that?”

“Possibly,” Shadow Weaver said distractedly.

“Okay, the sensors indicate you should continue through that door,” Entrapta said. Wrong Hordak wailed over the earbuds and a feedback squeal had them all flinching.

“There’s no door,” Adora responded to Entrapta once the piercing noises died down.

“Data doesn't lie,” Entrapta said. “According to the map, there should be a door right in front of you.”

Catra stomped to the head of the group and pressed her hand to the wall. “You just need a door?” she asked and used her claws to cut a hole large enough for everyone to slip through. “Done. Let’s go.”

Shadow Weaver eyes tracked across the features of the next pool. “Haven’t we been here before?” she asked with squinted eyes.

“Are we walking in circles?” Angella asked.

Bow pointed to the side. “We can’t be. Look over there, it’s a new door.”

“Oh, good you found it.” Entrapta droned from the earpieces. “Take the door.”

The group followed her instruction and quickly found an empty and large hallway. A glowing door was in the distance. The more they walked the further it seemed until it felt like they had been walking for miles.

“I’m happy to announce that Wrong Hordak’s existential crisis is over.” Entrapta chirped. “Why did you get off the path I gave you?”

“What do you mean why? You told us to come through this door.” Adora hissed into her earpiece.

“I haven’t spoken to you since the last floor. Also, who is your new friend?” she asked.

“Entrapta, it’s just the five of us here,” Bow said.

“Nope, there’s definitely a sixth heat signature right behind you,” Entrapta informed them.

They turned to see a navy blue translucent figure standing behind them. Catra tackled the entity and the two immediately disappeared.

“Catra!” Adora rushed forward but spikes shot from the floor and held her at bay.

“Adora, I’m down here.” Catra’s panicked voice said. “Hurry.”

They tried to run backward and spikes appeared from every angle around them. Even as they tried to avoid projectiles by sidling against the wall, the spikes continued to flex and move toward them, keeping them hostage. Shadow Weaver felt like she was being herded. Any path they’d taken to get closer to Catra was quickly shut off. It was like Beast Island, the planet was sentient and trying to keep them lost and separated. Reaching forward, Shadow Weaver pressed her hand to the closest sharp point. It melted away and its essence spilled to the floor like dust.

“What are you doing?” Angella asked in a panic.

“It’s not going to hurt me,” Shadow Weaver said and waited for the other spikes to get closer. She looked down and focused. Magenta flames erupted around her hands. Flicking her hands in the air, she sent the magical blaze through the hallway. The

deadly spikes disappeared, instantly becoming glitters of light like fireflies across the night sky. “This planet contains magic.”

“Are you okay?” Angella asked Shadow Weaver.

The truth was the brunette was more than okay. She was also a little confused. This magic, her magic didn’t feel the same. It felt purer. Like a spark of potential just beneath the surface. There were no greedy whispers about pushing for more. There was only the power that had always been inside her. It was the power she trained and earned at Mystacor. The same magic that was immediately bullied into the background by the Shoggoth summoned during the Spell of Obtainment.

“I’d almost forgotten what it felt like to wield it on my own,” Shadow Weaver said. She closed her palm and opened it to reveal a tiny magical phoenix that screeched as it burst into flames and sparkles. Kneeling, she traced out a portal on the floor. It cut out a hole beneath them and the group quickly jumped down.

“Okay, get away from her.” Adora stood up first, reaching for the fighting staff on her back. She paused, watching as Catra was petting the entity that resembled a feline now. “Are you petting the thing that’s been trying to kill us?”

Bow cooed. “That’s so cute.”

“It’s not cute!” Catra growled annoyedly.

The entity’s colors changed from aqua and navy blue to a harsh crimson. Its mane spiked around its features. Baring its fangs, it stalked towards them. Shadow Weaver allowed two small glyphs of magic to form in front of each of her hands like a shield. The ghostly feline faltered at her display of magic.

“Don’t hurt it.” Catra rose to her feet at once. “I’m sorry I got upset. It’s something I’m working on.” She sighed.

“You are?” Adora asked with a soft smile.

Angella looked at Shadow Weaver with a raised eyebrow. Shadow Weaver extinguished the spell on her hands and dropped them to her sides.

“Yes,” Catra said then took a deep breath. “I think it responds to my emotions, so please don’t give me a hard time right now.” The smaller cat returned to her and she resumed petting it.

“Yup sorry, sorry. Continue,” Adora said, glancing at Bow.

‘So cute.’ He mouthed silently to her.

Adora nodded with a wider smile. She came closer and sat beside Catra on the floor. “You’re magic aren’t you?” She asked the planet’s native as it ducked behind Catra. “So am I.” The blonde revealed, making her eyes glow.

The smaller cat came closer sniffing Adora and determined her not to be a threat before bumping its nose against her cheek. It turned facing Catra and began to meow repeatedly.

“What?” Catra scooted backward on her hands. “It’s talking to me. Please tell me someone else can hear it talking too?”

Everyone else shook their heads in the negative.

“It must have imprinted on you, Catra.” Shadow Weaver offered.

“You were the first person to touch it.” Bow pointed out. “It trusts you.”

“Ugh, why is everything so weird with you guys?” Catra kept staring at the smaller cat. “Its name is Melog.” She told them and explained about the battle for Krytis between the First Ones and Horde Prime.

“Magic is Horde Prime’s weakness.” Shadow Weaver concluded. “The First Ones must have figured that out and started mining planets with pure magic to keep an edge in their war with him.”

“Now we know what to do and since Horde Prime hasn’t accessed Etheria’s core we can beat him,” Bow said excitedly.

“That’s why he’s chipping everyone,” Adora said. “He’s trying to maintain the hold on the planet. He thinks once he does that Etheria will be easy like the other planets.”

“We have to get back to Etheria. This knowledge is vital but useless unless we can use it to defeat him,” Angella said.

“I can’t believe I’m saying this, but maybe Shadow Weaver can use magic to like turn us invisible.” Bow suggested.

“I don’t have the magical powers to maintain a spell like that without draining a magical source,” Shadow Weaver said plainly.

“Okay, so scratch that,” Bow said.

“There must be some other way to get past his ships,” Adora wondered aloud.

“Actually, I have an idea about that,” Catra said, looking at Melog.

Adora had Darla stop several miles outside Etheria’s atmosphere. Horde Prime’s ships surrounded the planet from every angle. It was a miracle that they hadn’t been spotted against the impenetrable blackness of the space around them. Their only saving grace was that Darla was so ancient that her technology couldn’t be tracked. Catra and Melog stood side by side, staring through the glass front of the ship.

“Are you sure this will work?” Adora asked.

“Not at all,” Catra said.

“So, you want us to trust a magical being we’ve never met to use ancient powers to sneak past a massive army?” Bow asked Catra.

“Yeah, that about covers it,” Catra said with an unconcerned smirk.

Bow and Adora smiled back at her.

Melog disappeared and the ship became transparent as it moved slowly past the Horde Prime’s blockade. Once they were past Etheria’s atmosphere they landed as quickly and quietly as they could.

“We need to find the rest of the Princesses,” Adora said.

Shadow Weaver's eyes tracked over familiar surroundings. “I need to detour,” she said. “I am completely out of elemental magic and Aldehaim is not far from here,” she explained.

“We don’t have time for you to try and get your hands on more power.” Catra glared as Melog growled beside her.

“This is not about power. I’ll only be a hindrance if I cannot defend myself,” Shadow Weaver said.

“We could always leave you behind as bait.” Catra suggested.

“We’re not leaving anyone else behind,” Angella said.

Catra glanced at Angella. “Don’t you want to know where Sparkles is?”

“Glimmer is strong and smart. I know she’s okay,” Angella said softly.

“I wouldn’t ask if I had an alternative.” Shadow Weaver gripped Angella’s hand. “I also have faith that Glimmer is somewhere safe.”

“Adora, this is crazy. What about your friends?” Catra asked.

“Catra, she’s the most effective against the Horde and Horde Prime’s forces. We need her,” Adora said. “Bow, can you and Entrapa try to reach out to the Princesses? We’ll be back as quickly as we can,” she said.

Bow nodded, sitting on the gangplank. “You got it.”

When they finally arrived, Shadow Weaver was dismayed to see the door to Aldehaim was reduced to rubble.

“Horde Prime must have picked up its location on one of his scanner droids,” Adora said sadly.

“Everyone be on alert,” Shadow Weaver said, stepping through the doorway. They quickly navigated the dimly lit tunnel and reached the town square without incident.

Shadow Weaver didn’t have to touch the Runestone. The elemental magic rushed toward her. The other shards circled like the moons in orbit around Etheria. Once their orbit was done the Runestone platform sealed up. The shard on her mask and belt pulsed in time with her heart beat.

“How do you feel?” Angella asked her.

“Powerful,” Shadow Weaver drawled. “We have tarried long enough. Let’s return to Darla so we can try to find the rest of the Princesses.”

They sneaked back out of Aldehaim while Melog kept them invisible. Once on the surface, they spotted two Horde Prime bots patrolling the area. Shadow Weaver moved her arms and the bot on the left raised its razor sharp drill, plunging it into the visual lens of the second bot. The bot on the right fired its laser cannon completely missing its attacker. The two bots, now controlled by

Shadow Weaver, continued to fight each other until they were nothing more than spare parts on the forest floor. Shadow Weaver moved silently, discarding any of the green lenses. She called the metal forth, bending it along her right arm to replace her gauntlet. She added shins guards to her armor set.

The remaining metal she forged into a curved short sword. The sword broadened towards the tip with hollow divots along its razor sharp edge. Shadow Weaver twirled the blade in her hands, feeling its balance and weight. She used it to puncture the holster that usually held her brick of lead and slipped it through as a makeshift sheath. The Dark Princess felt a nearby presence, but couldn't accurately place their movements. There was no point in alerting a possible enemy to their position.

Catra's ears flicked suddenly as she looked into the woods.

"What is it?" Adora asked.

"I don't know. It just feels like someone's watching us," Catra responded.

"I don't see anything." Adora glanced into the nearby trees. "Let's go. We don't want to stick around for too long."

"No luck on communications with the other Princesses." Bow informed them as they made it back to Darla.

Adora was the first one through the moss covered door to the last known camp of the Rebellion. She exposed the campsite with a gasp. The tents were shredded and burned in places. Rations and blankets were dirtied and trampled.

"Look for any clues that may explain what happened here." Adora stepped further into the destroyed campsite and allowed everyone

in behind her.

“Oh wow. It looks like there was a great battle that happened here forcing everyone to flee!” Entrapta exclaimed, waving her ponytails in the air for emphasis.

“Thanks, Entrapta,” Adora said, kneeling next to a smudged handprint in the mud. She brushed her hand across it.

“I didn’t find anything,” Bow said, nudging a broken chair with his foot.

“Same here,” Catra said, tossing a doll behind her.

“Did you agree on a rendezvous point before leaving?” Angella asked.

“No, we didn’t think we’d be gone this long,” Bow said. He typed his trackerpad again, trying in vain to get more communications from it. “We also didn’t think Horde Prime was able to turn our friends against us. Who could expect that?”

“We cannot underestimate him again,” Shadow Weaver said, picking up Juliet’s discarded helmet. It had a massive dent on one side but no blood. It was likely used to ward off a blow.

“Erelandia is the closest town from here. If they needed to seek shelter quickly that would be the most logical place.” Bow looked up from his pad.

“What is with you guys?” Catra grunted out with a flick of her claw. “How would we get into Erelandia? You can’t just waltz in and say ‘hi have you seen the Rebellion?’”

“I spotted some plain cloaks near the Mystacor tents. It would be more inconspicuous,” Bow said, pointing to the west end of the camp.

“Alright, we have cloaks but Shadow Weaver’s mask is too recognizable.” Adora pointed out.

“We need more stealth.” Entrapta agreed as her hair brushed Angella’s wings.

“Thank you, Entrapta,” Angella said, leaning away from the curious ponytail.

“Catra, can you use Melog to hide Shadow Weaver and Angella while we go in cloaked?” Adora asked.

Catra looked away with a grumbled. “Yeah, whatever.”

“Thanks, Catra.” Adora smiled, rubbing a hand across the shorter girl’s shoulder.

Bow gathered the cloaks and they started towards Erelandia. As they crested the next hill, Shadow Weaver discreetly made a small dagger in her hand. Once she was done she hurled it into the forest beside them.

“Hey!” A familiar voice exclaimed from the tree line. “Seriously?”

“Glimmer?” Angella called out.

Glimmer teleported to her side. “Hey, Mom,” she said.

“Glimmer,” Angella kneeled and hugged her daughter with all her might. “I was so worried.”

“I’m so sorry about everything I did. This was all my fault.” Glimmer clutched her mother’s neck. “I brought Horde Prime here and now all of Etheria is in danger.”

“Glimmer!” Adora and Bow joined the hug before Angella could respond.

“I’m so happy to see you guys,” Glimmer said after she pulled away.

Shadow Weaver embraced Glimmer, taking her former apprentice by surprise. She cradled her head and scratched blunted nails

along the scalp at the base of her neck.

Glimmer frowned through her shock. “Are- are you searching for a chip?”

“Yes,” Shadow Weaver said simply, letting the young woman go once she was finished.

“I didn’t even check you,” Glimmer said, crossing her arms.

“I know you observed us long enough to conclude we aren’t chipped,” Shadow Weaver said, waving her hand dismissively.

“I had to be sure since you’re walking with one of those creepy Hordak clones and Catra.” Glimmer pointed at them both.

“It’s a bit of a long story but they are both with us,” Adora explained with a shrug.

“Okay,” Glimmer said then whistled.

“Welcome home guys.” Netossa came out of her hiding spot on the opposite side of the path. “What brings you to Erelandia?”

“We were looking for the rest of the Princesses and trying to find out news about what’s been happening,” Bow said, holding up his trackerpad.

“Going to Erelandia is a mistake,” Netossa said with a shake of her head. “They don’t trust Princesses anymore now that Spinnerella, Mermista, and Scorpia have been capturing territory for Horde Prime.” She pointed to the Horde’s insignia floating above the village.

“Perfuma’s message said we lost everyone. Who else is gone?” Adora asked them.

“Horde Prime got Aunt Casta too. She was chipped trying to save me.” Glimmer bit her lip in an attempt not to cry.

“Spinny was the first one to get chipped then she got the others. By the time we realized what was happening, it was too late.” Netossa hung her head.

“It’s not Spinnerella doing this, Netossa. He’s the evil one,” Adora said softly.

“For once,” Catra added, glancing at Shadow Weaver who stared right back.

“We can’t just leave Erelandia like that,” Glimmer said. “There's enough of us now that we can recapture the village. ”

“I’ve been tracking Spinny and she’s definitely been patrolling near Erelandia. If you go there we’ll have to face her,” Netossa said.

“Our friends are still in there. We don’t have to beat them, we just need to remind them who they are.” Adora placed a hand on her shoulder.

“Swift Wind said he felt your magic. We also need to show Etheria that She-Ra has returned,” Glimmer said, smacking her fist against her palm.

“Releasing Spinnerella from Horde Prime’s hold should also be a priority. She’s one of our most powerful Princesses,” Shadow Weaver said.

“I’ve been trying to fight Spinny for a week, I can’t defeat her,” Netossa said with slumped shoulders.

“Loss of hope is how we got to our current predicament. Desperation and loneliness are powerful tools,” Shadow Weaver said, looking into Netossa’s eyes.

“You would know.” Catra scoffed.

“I will not deny that I have perfected this. I use it because it works. It’s like a house of cards without the proper foundation.

Pluck away at it and pretty soon it falls.” Shadow Weaver mimed the action and opened her hand. “If we lose our faith, we will fail and Etheria will succumb to Horde Prime.”

“We won’t let that happen,” Adora said with a resolute stare.

“There is a reason the First Ones’ Heart of Etheria worked with all the Princesses and it’s because we are stronger together. Horde Prime has no doubt deduced this and he’s determined to separate us.” Shadow Weaver finished.

“Shadow Weaver’s right.” Bow paused with a furrowed brow. “Hopefully one day this will stop feeling weird to say out loud.”

“All your stupid lame victories did happen when you all worked together,” Catra admitted begrudgingly.

“Glimmer, Netossa, where are the other Princesses?” Angella asked.

“We have a new camp up ahead, it’s hidden pretty well. Come on,” Glimmer said, and teleported them away.

As soon as they landed, Bow found himself hanging upside down from the tree by a vine. A large cluster of foliage braided itself around the rest of the group including Netossa and Glimmer.

“Show us your necks,” Perfuma demanded.

“Perfuma it’s okay, they’re with us,” Glimmer cried, trying to wiggle from her uncomfortable position.

“Your necks, now!” Perfuma shouted her voice in near hysterics.

Frosta dropped from a tree and hopped from person to person double-checking that the back of their necks were clear of a behavior chip. “Everyone is clean.” She informed Perfuma.

Perfuma personally checked Bow and released him from the vines that were holding him captive. “Oh thank goodness it’s you!” She smushed his cheeks between her hands then rushed straight for Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver held up a clawed hand. “Do you recall our discussion about hugging?”

“I remember agreeing to disagree with your objections.” Perfuma continued forward, resting her head on Shadow Weaver’s shoulder. She used vines to move Shadow Weaver’s arms around her. “You have no idea what kind of bad karma that may have accumulated from us fighting our friends.”

Shadow Weaver knew she had no choice, she would be stuck there unless the younger woman got it all out of her system. She sighed, resigned to her fate. “There, there. We’re going to return everyone to normal.” She glared at the amused smirk Angella gave her just over Perfuma’s shoulder.

“Thank you,” Perfuma said sincerely. The vines retreated into the ground and the blonde appeared more put together. She giggled lightly and sent a spray of flower petals flying across the group of remaining Rebellion fighters.

Shadow Weaver was pulled into the air as soon as she turned toward the entrance of the hideout. “Slinky, put me down.”

Angella laughed and walked closer to the Elemental that held her partner in the air. “I’m sure he missed you.”

“It appears so.” Shadow Weaver crossed her arms tightly as she dangled from Slinky's large pincers.

Angella rubbed a hand down the Slinky's cool metal shell. "You know you have to pet him then he'll release you." she teased.

Catra stood by watching the scene in shock. She rubbed her eyes and looked again. Melog brushed its head against her leg and mewed. “It’s just weird,” she replied.

“Yeah, it took me awhile to get used to Shadow Weaver having an Elemental too,” Adora said as she got up from Swift Wind’s affectionate attack.

“I was actually talking about the bit with flower girl,” Catra responded.

“Perfuma has been helping Shadow Weaver with her anger issues,” Adora explained with a shrug.

“It looks like she’s only helping her with her hugging issues,” Catra said, glancing at Adora.

“Perfuma said Shadow Weaver is very huggable.” Adora continued dusting herself off.

“Shadow Weaver?” Catra asked in disbelief.

“Perfuma is the authority on these things. She may not like unnecessary violence but “she’s a tyrant with hugs. You better be careful she doesn’t get you too one day,” Adora teased.

Melog growled, its fur tinted with a bit of crimson. Catra bared her claws. “She better not.”

“You’ll see,” Adora said with a smirk. “Come on, it’s time for you to meet everyone.”

Catra stood and was suddenly back on the ground. It took only a second for the biting cold to give way to burning pain on her cheek. Adora turned to see Frosta glaring at Catra.

“Seriously?” Catra rubbed her face with a snarl.

“That’s right, Horde Scum.” Frosta pointed an oversized fist at Catra.

Adora placed herself in front of Catra. “Frosta, it’s a really long story but trust me Catra’s with us now.”

Frosta lowered her fists though both hands remained covered in ice. “You ruined Princess Prom. I still don’t like your face.”

“Whatever.” Catra shrugged, rubbing Melog so she didn’t immediately retaliate.

Adora chuckled. “I think she can live with that.”

“We better go inside, we need to plan quickly before Spinny moves on,” Netossa said, pointing behind her.

“What’s going on?” Frosta asked.

“We’re gonna get our friends back.” Glimmer told her.

“I have a plan to take back Erelandia but it’s going to take everyone to pull it off,” Adora said. She started putting all the battle figurines on the table across the large map that depicted Etheria.

“I’m sure you have a solid plan,” Netossa said, pointing to the back of her neck. “How will we get the chips off?”

“We would need to knock them out long enough to have Entrapta remove it.” Bow suggested.

“Oh, boy. Is that all we have to do?” Frosta asked in disbelief. “Great plan.”

Shadow Weaver studied the maps. “Adora, you said when you and Catra fought, the chip faltered when electricity came in contact with it.”

Catra looked up from the map. “Yeah, so?”

“What are you thinking?” Angella asked.

“Entrapta could modify any remaining stun batons to neutralize the connection to Horde Prime,” Shadow Weaver said, using a finger to move the Entrapta figurine across the map.

Bow stared at the table. “That could take too long.”

“We need *all* the Princesses to defeat Horde Prime. We should be able to bring back the Princesses controlled by him quickly.” Shadow Weaver insisted.

“Castaspella is also chipped.” Angella reminded her.

Shadow Weaver sighed dramatically. “I suppose we could manage to save her as well.”

“I’m sure she’d be so thankful for your overwhelming concern for her safety,” Angella replied to her partner sarcastically. “Entrapta, what do you think of this plan? Would it work?”

“Oh yeah, it could work. The amount of electricity needed to shut off the signal to the chip is slightly higher than the stun gun.” Entrapta demonstrated the minuscule amount with her hair.

Netossa eyes widened. “How much is slightly? Will it be painful for them?”

“Oh yes!” Entrapta cackled. “It’ll be excruciating but only for a moment.”

Netossa looked conflicted.

Adora gripped her shoulder firmly. “This is the best chance we’ve got.”

“What about Scorpia? Her power is electricity,” Perfuma said.

“That’s a good question. Will her chip react differently? What even is her weakness?” Frosta asked.

“I can help with this part,” Netossa smirked, standing straighter. She pulled two notebooks from under the makeshift war table. “Every Princess has a weakness. I’ve been cataloguing all the them. For example, everyone knows Spinnerella hurt her ankle when she was younger. If you keep her off balance, she’ll go down in a matter of minutes.”

“Sure, yup. We all knew that.” Adora agreed, immediately nodding.

“You knew about Spinnerella’s ankle?” Glimmer asked Adora in shock.

“Of course not. Who would know that besides Netossa?” Adora asked.

“Okay, an old ankle injury,” Glimmer turned back to Netossa with a roll of her eyes. “The rest of us aren’t that easy.”

“You don’t believe me?” Netossa laughed then scoffed. “I see a demonstration is in order.” She threw a circuit board across the room. “Entrapta’s weakness? Tech.” She explained as the Tech Princess ran after the piece of machinery. She quickly went through and proved every Princesses’ weakness before she was interrupted.

“Oh, such fun! Do me next.” Perfuma clapped excitedly.

“Perfuma, your weakness is fire but also you don’t like to use your full powers because you’re worried about hurting those you care about,” Netossa said, staring disappointedly at her.

Perfuma hummed. “Some would say that’s a positive quality.”

“It’s not,” Netossa said mockingly.

“What about Shadow Weaver?” Catra asked with a shrug.

“That’s too obvious,” Netossa answered.

Catra smirked, placing a hand on her hip. “Let me take a quick guess. It's power, right?”

“It’s Queen Angella,” Everyone except Angella, Shadow Weaver, and Catra replied.

Without warning, Netossa sent a large net hurtling towards Angella. Shadow Weaver moved immediately, cutting through the net before it could reach the queen.

“Like I said too obvious,” Netossa repeated. “Also electromagnetism and high-frequency noises.” She gestured toward her ears.

“Okay, we get it the Princesses are really weak. I’m not a Princess and you don't know me so there’s nothing in your little notebook about me,” Catra said, leaning against a pillar.

Netossa sprayed Catra with water. As the younger girl tried to escape the liquid Netossa caught her with a quickly thrown net.

Catra fell to the ground. “Point taken.” She growled. Melog meowed and pawed at the bound Catra. “Not now, Melog.”

Entrapta returned to the group, studying the circuit board. “I can try to develop a way to track and neutralize the behavioral chip signal painlessly but that’s going to take time.”

“How much time?” Adora asked.

“After I track and triangulate the exact signal frequency I need to...” Entrapta muttered to herself. “Oh yeah. It would take approximately way more time than we have currently.”

“We have a plan to free the Princesses but we don’t go forward unless everyone agrees,” Adora said, looking around the table.

“Sounds like one of your idiotic plans. I’m just going to make sure you don’t get yourself killed,” Catra said and Melog meowed in agreement.

Shadow Weaver looked up from the map. “I vote yes.” Slinky made a chirpy clicking noise beside her.

“As long and I get to punch some clones I’m in,” Frosta answered.

Perfuma looked down at the battle figurine of Scorpia. “Scorpia wouldn’t want to hurt her friends so yes.”

“I would do anything to get Spinny back so yeah let’s do it,” Netossa said.

“I’m with you,” Angella said, stepping forward.

“Best friend squad!” Bow bellowed, hugging Glimmer and Adora close.

“Entrapta modify the stun batons as quickly as you can. We have Princesses to save.” Adora called out.

“Why did working with you have to be part of the plan?” Catra snarled, slamming her claws through the back of the closest Prime bot.

“I don’t particularly relish the idea either.” Shadow Weaver sidestepped and impaled the clone shambling up behind her through the neck.

Catra leaped for another Prime bot’s weak spot and brought him down quickly. “Why are you still treating me like this?”

“Must we talk about this now?” Shadow Weaver crushed a bot beneath her hands.

“We’re saving the world. When else are we gonna have time?” Catra grunted, twisting the Prime bot’s head off. “I heard what you said when I was unconscious. Was it just more lies? Do you even know how to tell the truth?”

“Not now, Catra.” Shadow Weaver sliced three bots in half in quick succession.

Catra forcefully turned Shadow Weaver around by her shoulder. Shadow Weaver’s nails sank into Catra’s shirt and jerked her forward. A bayonet formed from her gauntlet. Catra’s eyes widened and she clawed at Shadow Weaver’s arm, leaving scratches in the armor. The blade surged forward and continued just past her ear to pierce the bot lurking behind the younger woman.

“You missed one,” Shadow Weaver said as she released Catra.

Catra huffed and smoothed down her short hair. “If I was Adora you’d just tell me.”

Shadow Weaver peered across their small area and listened for any signs of Horde clones. She suspected that was the final bot. If it all went according to plan, then Perfuma and Frosta had dispatched the bots just as quickly on the opposite side of the village. She saw flashes of pink and fuchsia and knew Glimmer and Angella had gotten all the villagers out of Erelandia. “It’s not a competition,” she finally responded to Catra.

“We were children. You were supposed to care for us and we only had each other to cling to after your bouts of abuse,” Catra said practically yelling at Shadow Weaver. “Don’t have nothing to say to that, huh? Answer me.” she hissed.

Shadow Weaver returned the metal back into their shapes serving as her pieces of armor. She straightened her back and opened her arms wide, calmly walking to Catra.

“What are you doing?” Catra asked, backing up.

“This rather dramatic display is because you want comfort, correct?” Shadow Weaver asked and continued moving towards Catra. “You keep asking for answers, Catra. I told you the truth. It is not my fault you didn’t accept it.”

“I don’t want to touch you.” Catra pushed Shadow Weaver away before the older woman could get close enough to embrace her. “You’d probably leave a shadow spell on me or something.” she shuddered and glanced away.

“Very well. Help us win this war and we’ll talk about whatever you want.” Shadow Weaver promised.

“I don’t care what you have to say anymore. Just know that when this is all over I’m going to end you.” Catra hopped onto Melog’s back and they stalked away to patrol Erelandia’s perimeter.

The sound of a nearby crash had Shadow Weaver hurrying toward She-Ra who was being blown backward through the air by Spinnerella. Netossa used a skinny net like a rope and pulled She-Ra away from the next attack.

“What happened?” Shadow Weaver asked, coming to a stop beside Netossa.

“She-Ra is holding back,” Netossa responded.

“This is no time for half measures, Adora.” Shadow Weaver chastised the hero.

“I know you’re trying not to hurt Spinnerella but you can’t hold back anymore. She won’t,” Netossa said.

She-Ra sent a blast of magic at Spinnerella. Spinnerella dodged and summoned four tornadoes that began to orbit the funnel cloud she was in.

“What is she doing?” She-Ra shouted the question to Netossa.

“I’ve never seen her do this before.” Netossa’s eyes widened at the show of power. She cringed as a market stall was tossed several feet away. “We have to stop her or she’ll destroy the village.”

Shadow Weaver honed in on the metal choker Spinnerella wore. She tightened bit by bit. The funnel cloud they were in faltered and dissipated. Spinnerella clutched at her throat with her face purpling with her efforts to breathe.

“Don’t kill her.” Netossa punched Shadow Weaver’s arm.

“I am not. I’m buying us some time. Get ready to move,” Shadow Weaver said, backing up. She watched for the moment Spinnerella was about to lose consciousness. It would give them enough time to retreat. “Go, now!”

They ran to an alley between buildings to regroup. Surprisingly, Spinnerella did not lose consciousness. She moved around unnaturally, stretching her body with a crack of her joints, and stood as if nothing was amiss. Her eyes darted across the buildings, looking for them.

“How are we gonna fight our friends?” She-Ra asked with a sigh.

“Better than this,” Shadow Weaver answered.

“I can’t just flip a switch in my head and see them as an enemy,” She-Ra argued.

“She shouldn’t have recovered that quickly,” Netossa said, trying to stifle her breathing.

“It’s Horde Prime,” She-Ra explained. “He must have forced more control over her body. He did something similar when Catra was chipped.”

Spinnerella sent a burst of gale force winds towards them. Netossa squatted and used a net to shield them from the hit. Glimmer appeared beside them.

“We need to get out of here.” Netossa wrapped up Spinnerella’s attack and threw it back at her wife.

Spinnerella dodged, sending rapid gusts of wind back. “There’s no need to attack, beloved. We can be together under Horde Prime’s light.”

“The Spinnerella I love would never want that.” Netossa shot back.

Glimmer sent a blinding beam of light at Spinnerella and weaved a binding spell around her arms.

“You know that won’t hold her for long,” Shadow Weaver said quickly.

“It’s the best chance we’ve got,” Glimmer said, teleporting behind Spinnerella. She applied the stun baton to the chip. Spinnerella cried out falling to her knees and convulsed.

“You’re hurting her.” Netossa whimpered.

“Three more seconds.” Shadow Weaver held up her hand. “Glimmer, now.”

Glimmer removed the baton and the chip was no longer illuminated. It smoked and sparked.

Netossa wrapped Spinnerella in several layers of interwoven netting and kissed her forehead. “Got you.”

Catra and Mog appeared in the twin square. A single droplet of water fell from above and landed Catra’s face followed by another and another. “Is that rain?” She asked with an annoyed frown.

“No, it is not,” Shadow Weaver said, hearing the unusual sound of rushing water a couple of moments before the water began to flood the square. “Get her to Entrapta, now!”

Gimmer, Netossa, and Spinnerella teleported away. Catra grabbed Melog and disappeared from view. She-Ra turned the sword into a lasso and dragged Mermista out of the water cyclone she was using to tower over them. Mermista encased She-Ra in a water sphere and started to another funnel of water keeping the blonde off balance. Bow shot a trick arrow, hitting Mermista across the torso with sticky green goo. She sent a burst of water towards him without looking up.

"Perfuma, Frosta, you're up," Bow said, standing from the ground.

Perfuma used a large vine to break the wave headed towards them. Frosta froze the water as Mermista tried to gain her advantage, pulling her back down to the ground. Shadow Weaver used the Water Princess' cuffs to keep her hands behind her back. Perfuma tied numerous layers of vines across her arms. Frosta started to freeze Mermista in place but the Water Princess summoned more water to weaken the ice faster than Frosta could freeze it.

She-Ra frowned. "I thought her hands were bound?"

"We can't bind her powers," Frosta said annoyed as yet another piece of ice was washed away.

"Adora, you need to finish this," Shadow Weaver said.

She-Ra drew a few lines of magic in the air and sent them rocketing towards Mermista that had just broken free. The magic collided with Mermista as she stood and she was knocked back down.

Shadow Weaver laid a foot on the prone Princess and pressed the baton to the chip. The chip went dead and Mermista was finally still. She watched the rise and fall of the Water Princess' back and lifted her to a sitting position. "Glimmer should have been here by now." She remarked.

“Sorry, I’m late. I had to escape an Erelandia villager group hug,” Glimmer said from behind them.

She-Ra pointed her sword in the air and left a Sword of Protection sigil in the sky to replace the Horde Prime claim.

With the Princesses’ recent victory in Erelandia, they decided to go back to camp and immediately regroup before Horde Prime had a chance to recover from his defeat.

“We need to see if we can save Scorpia and Castaspella,” Perfuma said, holding the Scorpia battle figurine tenderly.

“It may not be possible,” Catra said. “I remember what it was like having Horde Prime’s voice in my head. He digs his claws in and all you can think of is him. You got really lucky with Spinnerella and Mermista.”

“I know there’s still good in Scorpia. She’s a good friend and we’re gonna get through to her,” Perfuma said.

Netossa moved the figurines across the map. “I think I, Adora, Perfuma, and Catra would be the better force to go into the Fright Zone.”

Shadow Weaver watched as Glimmer walked out of their hideout, following Bow.

Angella stood quickly. “I’m going to see if everything is alright.”

Shadow Weaver nodded, watching Angella go. The ache to keep Glimmer close must be unbearable for her partner. She hardly moved unless Glimmer did as if she was afraid that Glimmer would suddenly disappear into vapor. She felt the same pining when Horde Prime had taken Angella. Her anger had nearly

gotten the better of her. The recklessness of her numerous spontaneous plans nearly rivaled Adora's. It hadn't mattered. All she wanted was to be reunited with Angella and only the threat of Horde Prime's forces stopped her from hijacking Darla and becoming an army of one.

"Change of plans guys. Bow needs to check on his dads." Glimmer announced, coming back inside.

"That's absolutely not a problem. We can handle Scorpia on our own," Adora said, glancing at the confident nods she received. "Frosta, Swifty, and Slinky can wait here with Spinnerella and Mermista in case they wake up. Bow sent a message to Sea Hawk so he may show up later. Okay, everyone, Princesses of Power mission is a go!"

Bow, Glimmer, Shadow Weaver, and Angella arrived behind a large boulder. The Library stood tall with no damage to the outside. Shadow Weaver extended her hearing as far as it could go. She heard a mechanical swish above them just as Bow reacted.

"Drones," Bow said and shot them out of the air. "Look at how close they are from my home." He put on his goggles and scanned the area. "We can go in, now. There's nothing else nearby."

"Glimmer, are you okay?" Angella asked as she noticed her daughter, moving more slowly than before.

Glimmer gave her a tired smile. "Yeah, mom. I'm fine. I just need to rest a bit."

"My presence and proximity to the Moonstone are draining you faster again," Angella concluded with a frown.

"It's okay, mom. I would rather have you here than the alternative." Glimmer hugged her mother.

“Let’s walk to the door and give you a break,” Angella said.

It was only once Bow approached the door that he noticed that it was ajar. He slowly pushed it open and gasped. The Library was empty and the display cases were all overturned. Glass crunched under their feet as they cautiously shuffled inside. Shadow Weaver’s eyes looked over the floors and walls. There was no blood anywhere in the destruction.

“Oh, no! Look at this place. This is all my fault.” Bow cried out.

“How is this your fault?” Glimmer asked.

“Horde Prime must have tracked me here and my dads got captured. I’ll never forgive myself.” Bow tugged a frantic hand through his hair as he paced. “This never would have happened if I had just become a historian like they wanted. I should have never joined the Rebellion.”

“Bow!” Glimmer shouted as she physically turned her best friend and pointed. “They left you a note.”

Bow quickly grabbed the note tape to the wall. “What did the First Ones say after they burned dinner?” he read. His face fell as he finished the last two words. “It’s ruined.”

“That’s terrible,” Angella said, pressing a palm to her face.

Glimmer glanced between her mother and best friend. “What does that mean? I don’t speak dad.”

Shadow Weaver released a huff of air from her nose then quieted. Angella looked at her intensely.

“May I help you?” Shadow Weaver returned her gaze.

“I heard that. Did you actually just laugh at that terrible joke?” Angella asked her.

“You’re hearing things in your advanced age.” Shadow Weaver shrugged.

Angella’s feathers bristled and she looked ready to throttle Shadow Weaver. “I’m immortal. There is no advanced age.”

“Mature Princess indeed.” Shadow Weaver drawled.

“That was so long ago. You’re still sore about that?” Angella asked as her face fell. “We were just joking about it.”

Shadow Weaver clasped her hands together. “Didn’t anyone ever tell you, dear? I hold my grudges rather well.” She informed Angella with a playful lilt in her voice.

“Moms cut it out.” Glimmer snapped at them and turned to the archer. “Bow, your dads left you a joke instead of telling you where they are?”

“The joke was a clue. I know exactly where they went. Let’s go. It’s not that far,” Bow said as he ran to the back of the library and pulled a book from the back shelf. They descended into a tunnel through a hidden door and found a First Ones’ ruin just on the other side of the network of tunnels running underground.

“Do you think Glimmer realized what she said?” Angella whispered to Shadow Weaver.

“It doesn’t appear so,” Shadow Weaver said.

Angella glanced at Shadow Weaver. “Are you okay with it?”

“I often wondered what our child would have looked like.” Shadow Weaver mused aloud.

“You imagined our children when we were dating?” Angella’s eyes softened.

“Many times.” Shadow Weaver admitted with a nod. “Especially after your mother told me I would be ruling with you. I assumed

we would be expected to produce an heir."

"How many did you want?" Angella asked excitedly.

"Two if the fates had wished it so." Shadow Weaver looked deeply into Angella's eyes.

Bow moved suddenly, pushing Shadow Weaver to the right. An arrow embedded in the crystal pillar she was standing in front of.

"Bow?" Lance asked.

"Sorry about the arrow. I'm still teaching him how to use this." George held up the bow. His eyes widened as he noticed the rest of the people with him. "Queen Angella!" he exclaimed as both men quickly bent at the waist in a bow.

"Your majesty, my sincerest apologies. I didn't know I was shooting at royalty." Lance babbled with his head still down. "Bow, why didn't you tell us you were bringing the queen with you?" he hissed at his son.

"Why haven't you answered any of the messages I've sent?" Bow asked with a stern frown.

"Oh, your dad's tracker pad has been on the fritz and you know we're hopeless about that sort of thing that's why we left you the note," Lance explained lightly.

"And you're here. I knew you'd punderstand," George elbowed Bow playfully.

"Don't try and distract me with puns." Bow shook his head. "I can't believe you two are out researching artifacts at a time like this."

George placed his hands on Bow's shoulders. "We weren't just researching. We actually found something."

“Come on, we’ll show you,” Lance said and walked through the small camp they made in the dark.

They traveled deeper into the cavern, crystals, and stone jutting around them at all angles from floor to ceiling as they walked. There on the back wall was an empty platform.

“Here it is,” George said, pointing at the empty room.

“Uh, here what is?” Glimmer asked.

“Eternia,” George said confidently.

A First Ones’ guide materialized in front of them. “What is your query administrator?” Light Hope asked from the platform.

“Yeah, we met her,” Bow said, looking wary.

“And she wasn’t super helpful last time.” Glimmer added.

“This looks like a different interface than the Light Hope Adora encountered.” Shadow Weaver pointed. The clothing was more in a more traditional style of the First Ones depicted on the ancient writings and drawings in Mystacor. This was probably one of the last versions of an untainted Light Hope left on all of Etheria.

“Oh, watch this,” George said, raising his fist.

“I want to do it.” Lance stopped him, pulling his arm down. “You did it last time. It’s my turn.”

“Okay,” George said, stepping back.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!” Lance screamed with a triumphant pump of his fist. A hologram sphere of constellations materialized, lighting up the room.

“Remember we said the First Ones used constellations to send and receive coded messages?” Lance asked as he and George pulled the sigils around until they fit to form a new constellation.

“We’re friends of Mara,” George and Lance said together.

“Welcome friends of Mara. There is one saved recording, shall I play it?” Light Hope asked.

“Yes,” George said.

“Hey, remaining friends of Mara. This is, Serenia. If anyone is hearing this there is a fail-safe for the Heart of Etheria at the Arxia outpost. I hope it still exists, we’ve lost all communications from them. Mara did all she could to help us win, but it still wasn’t enough. Complete our mission and stop the Heart. Squadron Grayskull signing off.”

“There’s a fail-safe? That’s excellent. We can destroy the Heart of Etheria and stop Horde Prime from using Etheria’s magic against us,” Bow said with a relieved grin.

Glimmer smiled too then frowned a little in thought. “I’ve never heard of Arxia. Do you know where it is?”

“That’s the one thing we don’t know. The first ones used different names for everything back then.” George informed them.

Angella looked at the pointedly quiet Shadow Weaver. “The fail-safe is the Crystal of Arxia that’s under Mystacor isn’t it?”

“Mom, you know what it is?” Glimmer asked.

“I saw it years ago when I was dating Light Spinner,” Angella said, smiling at Shadow Weaver. “That was one of the best nights of my life.”

“I don’t think I need to hear this,” Glimmer said, covering her ears.

“It wasn’t quite that sordid, Glimmer. Although we did wake up on the beach after sleeping together,” Shadow Weaver said.

“On the beach!? Mystacor’s beach where I play and relax?” Glimmer bit down on her lip, looking peaked. “I’m never going back.”

“Stop traumatizing her.” Angella whacked Shadow Weaver’s arm. “Glimmer, we fell asleep after our first kiss. That’s all that happened.”

“I knew it. I knew there was something I liked about you,” Lance said, smiling at them.

“Okay, so we know where the Crystal is, we just need to use it and we can end this war,” Bow said.

“It’s not that simple.” Shadow Weaver was interrupted by the tracker pad’s incoming message.

Catra was on screen, clutching the monitor. “You have to get us out of here.”

“What happened?” Bow asked.

“It was a trap. Horde Prime is here with Scorpia but also,” Catra shrieked and jumped from something behind her. “The sorcerer who keeps using her powers to flood this room with the Horde’s water supply.”

“Horde Prime is there?” Angella asked in shock.

Catra nodded. “Using Hordak’s old sanctum. He’s got Perfuma and Adora.”

“We have to go,” Angella said, looking at her daughter. “Glimmer are you okay to teleport us?”

Glimmer nodded.

“After this is over. I’d really love you to come for afternoon tea.” Lance reminded Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver nodded as she disappeared.

“What’s the plan?” Angella asked as they reappeared in the Fright Zone.

“It would be wise to get everyone out quickly,” Shadow Weaver said, ducking behind one of the melted walls in the Fright Zone.

“I’ll get everyone and we’ll teleport out. No big deal,” Glimmer said with a tired smile.

“Glimmer, you need to rest.” Angella protested. She placed a restraining hand on her daughter's shoulder.

“Mom, we can’t let them fall into Horde Prime’s hands,” Glimmer said, tugging herself out of Angella’s hold. She grabbed Bow and they disappeared.

It was a tense few moments of silence.

“She will be okay,” Shadow Weaver said, comforting her partner.

“What if she’s not?” Angella asked softly. “Horde Prime is here and so is most of the Rebellion. He could easily capture us all.”

Shadow Weaver hugged Angella to her chest. “I believe they will escape with Glimmer’s help.”

Glimmer was in front of them long enough to grab each of their hands and suddenly they were back at the latest camp. Shadow Weaver stood. Everyone looked worse for wear but no one was missing.

“I’m sick of ambushes,” Netossa said, dusting off her clothes.

“I know we weren’t able to save Scorpia or Castaspella today but we gave it our all. Let’s focus on the positives. We did save Mermista as well as Spinnerella and Entrapta is almost done removing their chips,” Adora said.

“Everyone, I have wonderful news!” Entrapta said, running forward. “With the two additional chips I have from Spinnerella and Mermista I was able to get closer to hacking Horde Prime’s signal.”

“That’s great, Entrapta,” Bow said.

“The not so wonderful thing is that in removing the chips I saw that they were digging themselves in deeper.” Entrapta’s hair created a facsimile of hands that clasped together to demonstrate. “They had almost fused with the Princesses’ nervous system. If we had waited any longer we wouldn’t have been able to remove it at all.”

“Are you saying we can’t save Scorpia and Castaspella?” Perfuma asked.

Entrapta typed on her datapad. “The success rate of your current plan without risking permanent damage to them just dropped from eighty percent to twenty percent. The stun batons won’t work anymore.”

“Entrapta, just keep working on the network until you can break through,” Adora said.

“Adora, I need to speak with you about what we found out from Bow’s fathers,” Shadow Weaver stated.

“Let’s get some rest everyone.” Adora told the rest of the group.

The rest of the Rebellion walked out leaving Angella, Glimmer, Bow, Shadow Weaver, Adora, and Catra left in the main room.

“What did you want to talk to us about?” Adora asked Shadow Weaver.

“There is a fail-safe for the Heart of Etheria under Mystacor. It will release all the magic from the Heart and give us the power we need to defeat Horde Prime,” Shadow Weaver said.

Glimmer stood at once. “Are you serious? You’re still trying to weaponize the Heart even after what happened last time?”

Shadow Weaver shook her head in the negative. “I’m not trying to weaponize or activate the Heart of Etheria.”

“You’ve known about a possible fail-safe this entire time?” Adora asked in disbelief. “Why didn’t you say something?”

“The fail-safe can only be employed at great cost just like the Heart of Etheria,” Shadow Weaver said.

“Is it a planet’s gonna explode and everyone will die type of cost?” Bow asked.

“No, it’s nothing like that,” Angella said softly.

“There has to be a catch. There’s no way Shadow Weaver would do something without a way to gain power over it, so what aren’t you telling us?” Catra asked suspiciously.

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. “My only ulterior motive is reaching the Crystal of Arxia. I was wrong about the Heart of Etheria but I’m not wrong about this. It will release all the magic in Etheria and Horde Prime won’t be able to possess it. We could use it to defeat him.”

“That doesn’t sound safe,” Bow said haltingly.

Shadow Weaver clasped her hands in front of her. “The Crystal of Arxia was built by First Ones that suspected the Heart of Etheria was not the solution everyone assumed. A living soul needs to be bound to the fail-safe and once they go to the Heart that person must take all of Etheria’s magic into themselves.”

“Why haven’t you done it then?” Catra asked. Melog bared its teeth aggressively. “You would finally have all the power you ever wanted.”

“No mere mortal can take on the fail-safe or the Heart’s magic. It needs someone with great power,” Shadow Weaver said with a shake of her head. “I couldn’t wield it if I tried.”

“Someone like She-Ra, you mean?” Adora asked quietly.

Shadow Weaver’s silence told them all they needed.

Adora bowed her head, looking at the floor. “What happens if I don’t live through it?”

“Adora, that won’t happen. You have survived so much despite the odds.” Shadow Weaver quickly walked over to Adora, holding the blonde’s hands.

“Your parenting for one.” Catra snarked.

Shadow Weaver glared at her but didn’t answer.

“What will happen?” Adora asked again.

“If the magic is too great it will still be released throughout Etheria from your sacrifice. Your friends will be free and Horde Prime will be defeated.” Shadow Weaver released Adora’s hands and brushed her a gentle hand hair.

“No!” Bow shouted. “We’re not gonna sacrifice Adora.”

“It will never work!” Glimmer said.

Catra growled angrily. “Our entire lives you’ve tried to keep us apart. Why can’t you ever let someone be happy around you?”

“I know what you’re thinking, Catra. I get no satisfaction in the facts of this. Our only other option would be to let Horde Prime

get his hands on all of Etheria's magic and I know we can all agree we don't want that." Shadow Weaver argued.

"I can't believe I started to trust you." Glimmer sneered. "You just want more power for yourself."

"I don't need more power." Shadow Weaver turned to Glimmer.

"We don't believe you," Bow said, coming to stand beside Glimmer.

"I'll do it."

"Adora, what?" Angella asked as her voice rose over the shouting.

Adora never looked up from the floor. "I said I'll do it."

Catra ran to Adora. "No, Adora. No, you don't have to do this. There has to be something else we can try. Another plan. Any other plan."

Adora glanced at her. "Catra, I-"

"This kind of sacrifice is what She-Ra was born for," Shadow Weaver said.

Catra shook her head in disgust. "You haven't changed. You ruin everything you touch! You're always gonna be toxic and evil." She and Melog shuffled away from the group.

"Catra!" Adora ran after her.

"Adora, wait." Shadow Weaver just managed to grab Adora's hand.

Adora slapped her grip away with a teary glare. "You've done enough."

Shadow Weaver reached out again as they disappeared to a dark alcove together.

Angella placed her hand on her shoulder. “Give them some time.”

“I thought it would be easier.” Shadow Weaver told her partner.

“To keep them separated? Anyone with eyes could see how much Adora and Catra care for each other,” Angella said, rubbing Shadow Weaver’s back.

“To fall back into this role.” Shadow Weaver turned to Angella. “I’ve done my research and the Crystal of Arxia is our only chance to stop Horde Prime’s plans for Etheria’s magic.”

“Is there no other way?” Angella asked tightly.

“To my knowledge, She-Ra is the only person that can withstand so much raw energy,” Shadow Weaver said resolutely.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey all! It's good to be back. Thanks for the kudos, bookmarks, reviews, and hits. Y’all rock!
>
> Do you love Shadow Weaver!? 😘 or do you LOVE Shadow Weaver? 😜 Come on over to the new discord server where we Shadow Weaver fans, stans, and simps gather in the darkness. 😈
>
> https://discord.gg/ACEcjkH

Until next time!

Some Kind of Resolution

Chapter Summary

Returning to Mystacor and other new beginnings.

Chapter Notes

Archive: Don’t copy to another site without permission

Spoilers: I’m picking and choosing what canon plot lines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, “Light Spinner” will be pretty spoilery.

Disclaimer: She-Ra and the Princesses of Power belong to DreamWorks and the wonderful Noelle Stevenson. Any and all other brand names that might appear here belong to their respective owners. I do not make any money on this story. Please don’t sue; you only stand to gain outstanding student loans for your troubles.

Author’s Note: This is inspired by fanart, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine’s song “No Light, No Light” along with Five Finger Death Punch’s “Wrong Side of Heaven.” My brain couldn’t leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

All mistakes I claim as my own.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 9: Some Kind of Resolution

The lack of wonder and magical energy of Mystacor was palpable as they teleported to one of the secret entrances Shadow Weaver utilized to get on and off the grounds when she was still an apprentice. Darkness perforated every inch of the floating island. Glimmer, Adora, Catra, Melog, Bow, Shadow Weaver, and Angella silently walked along a downed young tree with grim determination.

The gray haired sorcerer appeared in front of them before they realized she was near. She paused and opened her eyes, staring directly at their hiding spot despite not seeing them. She placed her staff on the grass and hurried off. Shadow Weaver gestured everyone forward with a wave of her hand. She led them to the main corridor and felt the presence of a lot of magical signatures. She threw her arm out, halting their advance and waited. All the remaining sorcerers filed by in a slow, droning walk.

"Where are they going?" Catra asked.

Shadow Weaver shushed her at once.

Castaspella stopped and turned toward them. Her luminescent green sclera, pierced the seemingly empty space down the hallway. Her stare was endless and searching. Finally, she blinked and continued on. Shadow Weaver gestured for them to go forward. Just as they passed the doorway to the Lunarium, she was hit with a magic beam.

"I thought I smelled the stench of an old hag amongst us," Castaspella moved her hands, calling her magic. Most of the sorcerers were on the floor seemingly unconscious while the three remaining head sorcerers stood around the Font of Magical Focus behind Castaspella, staring into nothingness.

Angella soared into the air and sent three light beams back at her sister in law. "Not this time, Castaspella."

“Coming to her rescue once again.” The sorcerer deflected the attacks with a flourish. “How predictable.”

“This isn’t you, Aunt Casta. Fight him off,” Glimmer pleaded.

“Horde Prime released me from the limits Mystacor placed on me.” Castaspella boasted. She rotated her hands. A large skull faced goat stomped out of her spell. Its head had three spiraling sets of sharp horns. Its double tail twitched agitatedly. Tossing its crimson head, it pawed the ground before charging.

“Disappointing, Castaspella. Supposed limitless magic and you conjure illusions,” Shadow Weaver said with a cough as she stood. That magical blow had definitely bruised a rib.

“An illusion? Like at Krytis?” Bow asked, holding his hands out to catch the horns. “Then it shouldn't be able to hurt us.” The goat rammed into him, knocking the breath from his lungs.

“Bow!” Glimmer cried. She teleported, catching him just before he hit one of the tall crystals around the room. She gently set him down. “Are you okay?”

“That definitely hurt.” Bow wheezed out.

“Do you like it? It was one of Micah’s specialties,” Castaspella said with a manic grin.

“Illusions? Allow me,” Catra said and leaped forward. With three swipes of her claws, the goat was dispelled with a bleat and burst of red magic.

The older sorcerer twirled her staff and sent a bolt of magic at Catra. She and Melog disappeared from sight just before it made contact. The wall exploded, destroying the lenses and ancient writings.

“I will have more power than you’ve ever dreamed of,” Castaspella said, marching up to the Font of Magic in the center. “More power than you can ever hope to have.”

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed. "You have no power. Horde Prime controls you. You're nothing more than a paltry puppet."

Castaspella yelled, sending a barrage of magical blasts at her. With a wave of her hand, Shadow Weaver made a metal shield to deflect the magic as best she could. She hurled a handful of shrapnel, catching Castaspella across the cheek. Bow stood shakily and fired a trick arrow at the apprentice with blonde dreadlocks. He rolled out of the way of another attack, sending a powerful hex that brought the archer back to his knees.

Adora rushed forward, holding her hand up. "For the Honor of Grayskull!" Her magic flickered then died out in the air. The gray haired sorcerer aimed for Adora when Catra pulled her out of the way of the attack.

"Adora, you have got to calm down. You must have a clear mind to access She-Ra," Shadow Weaver called out.

Adora ducked behind a crystal column, hiding from the dark magic attack of a younger apprentice. "It's kinda hard when people are trying to kill us." She yelled back.

"What's the matter, Adora? Is the weight of your heroics finally too much for you?" Castaspella used her index finger to trace a rune into the water. She pressed her hands together and started to chant a familiar spell. Sinister whispers echoed Castaspella's words. Above their heads, inky smoke began to fill the large diamond.

"Stop her," Shadow Weaver said frantically. "Castaspella cannot be allowed to cast the Spell of Obtainment. She will never come back from it."

"What can we do?" Glimmer asked, helping Bow fight off the blonde sorcerer.

"Glimmer, you are the only one with enough power to defeat her," Shadow Weaver said, staring at the slanted walkway.

“Entrapta said we can’t safely remove the chips anymore.” Glimmer quickly knocked out the ginger apprentice that was aiming for Shadow Weaver.

“Knock her out or bind her magic. She must not succeed.” Shadow Weaver walked toward the dark runes along the floor. Her dormant magic flared to life, sensing the power around it, but she ignored it. “Oh, Castaspella, still a little girl trying so hard to walk into my and Micah’s footsteps. Is this the best you can do?” she taunted.

“What are you doing?” Angella asked, ducking Castaspella’s angry blast of electricity.

“I am trying to distract her long enough for us to destroy the Lunar Lenses,” Shadow Weaver whispered quickly.

“That will leave Mystacor defenseless.” Angella argued.

Shadow Weaver created a mace with her shield. “Horde Prime has already taken it. We can restore them when we win.” She pointed to the lenses. “Quickly now before it’s too late.”

Angella grabbed her and flew directly to the top of the Lunarium. Shadow Weaver used her mace and shattered the first Lunar Lens. The smoke inside the diamond began to disperse as the spell shape warbled. Shadow Weaver rapidly smashed the rest of the Lunar Lenses. The spell failed and Castaspella turned her piercing gaze to the older woman.

“You’ll pay for that.” Castaspella propelled herself forward with magic.

Glimmer knocked her back with a glittery light magic attack. Castaspella was knocked back into a crystal column and slid to the floor in a daze. Bow shot another trick arrow at the blonde sorcerer. The older sorcerer spun her staff sending spell after spell at Bow, trying to free her associate. Catra appeared from thin air slamming the points of her claws into the chip on the gray haired

sorcerer's neck. The chip malfunctioned and she passed out on the floor.

Glimmer quickly bound her Aunt.

"We were supposed to be together. I tried to shield you from her poison but you just couldn't stay away." Castaspella hissed angrily at Angella when she and her partner landed on the floor. "Everyone thinks you're all sweet and innocent but they don't know you like I do."

"It is over, Castaspella." Shadow Weaver pointed to the head sorcerers that were now unconscious on the floor. "You have lost."

"I've won more than you know." Castaspella's green eyes stared at Shadow Weaver devoid of all emotion as she barked out a laugh. "Did Angella happen to tell her precious Princess how she ran to me during Micah's memorial? Of course she didn't," she said when she noticed Angella's reddening cheeks behind Shadow Weaver. "Now you've gone from fucking Micah's sister to his teacher." She tsked.

"Aunt Casta!" Glimmer gasped.

"It's a good thing he is long gone. He would be so disgusted in you, Angella." Castaspella finished her tirade as she writhed on the floor against her tightening bonds.

"And what do you think he would think of you? Micah wouldn't want you to do this." Angella grabbed Castaspella's face, forcing her to make eye contact. "You're stronger than this, Casta. Fight Horde Prime off."

Castaspella screamed as her eyes flickered from green to hazel. "Stop me. Stop me before I do more harm." She pleaded. "Quick, he's coming back. Whispering. Always whispering."

"I'm sorry," Glimmer said and blasted Castaspella in the face with magic. The sorcerer slumped to the floor.

“Are you going to be okay?” Adora asked, helping Bow stand carefully.

“Yeah, once I get some rest. What about you? Are you having trouble with She-Ra again?” Bow asked, leaning on her for support.

“I’ll figure it out,” Adora said with a weak smile.

“Piece of cake,” Catra said, pulling her claws away from the damaged chip on the blonde sorcerer’s neck. “That’s all of them.”

“We need to get to the fail-safe before Horde Prime sends reinforcements.” Glimmer said, casting a disillusionment spell on her aunt in case one of the other sorcerers happened to wake up before they returned. “We’ll be back for you,” she whispered.

The group quickly ran to the Hall of Sorcerers and stopped just after the final statue. Shadow Weaver held up her arms. “Glimmer, follow my lead. Just like I showed you.”

A glowing blue shape lifted high above them, connecting to the wall. The wall slid away to reveal a dark hallway. Glimmer and Angella each released a small orb to light their path through the tunnels.

“This looks like what almost happened in there.” Glimmer remarked, looking at the walls.

“That is an inscription about the Spell of Obtainment. It’s what gave me my umbrakinesis,” Shadow Weaver said, pointing along the wall.

“It looked evil.” Bow remarked.

“None of the texts stated outright evil. It promised to unlock a great power from Etheria’s magical core. What it actually did was forge a bond with an ancient Eldritch creature, a demon called a Shoggoth.” Shadow Weaver shrugged. “There are rumors about getting a benevolent demon in the bargain but the chance is too small to be counted.”

“Was it worth it?” Glimmer asked.

“It seemed like it at the time,” Shadow Weaver admitted. “I wanted the power needed to defeat the Horde. The Spell of Obtainment was a mistake, one for which I’ve paid the price.”

“It does seem like you’ve started to learn your lesson.” Adora agreed, walking ahead of the group. Her foot triggered a trap and fire shot from the floor.

“Adora.” Catra leaped into the fire and pushed Adora on the other side.

“Did you just jump into fire for me?” Adora asked smugly.

“No! I was just.” Catra sputtered in shock. She shoved Adora’s smiling face away. “Shut up.”

“You did.” Adora laughed. “That’s too great.”

“Glimmer, what are you doing?” Angella said, reaching out to pull her daughter away from the column of fire.

“It’s not real,” Glimmer said, pulling her hand out of the flames.

“We have to be cautious, some of the fire is very real,” Shadow Weaver said, walking through.

Shadow Weaver noticed almost immediately that Adora began to fall behind the group. “How long has it been since you were able to transform into She-Ra?” she asked, falling into step with the blonde.

Adora looked down, rubbing her hands together. “It’s been happening since the Fright Zone. What if I’m losing her?”

“She-Ra is inside you, Adora. She always has been. The only change is the added complications.” The older Princess glanced at Catra’s back.

“You don’t know what you’re talking about.” Adora looked away.

“I know very well.” Shadow Weaver gently held Adora’s face. “You and Catra are close again but as always you let her distract you and confuse your feelings.”

“It’s none of your business,” Adora said, flexing her jaw.

“The world needs She-Ra’s strength right now to save it. If you love her and you want to achieve that then you need to focus on protecting Catra. Focus on protecting her and your friends and nothing more,” Shadow Weaver said.

“I can do it.” Adora nodded.

Shadow Weaver waved her hand in Adora’s general direction. “This doubt says you can’t. You need to decide what’s more important. If She-Ra cannot defeat Horde Prime then we will all perish.”

Adora jerked out of her touch. “I will defeat Horde Prime no matter what it takes.”

“It looks bigger than I remember.” Angella stated, looking up at the Crystal of Arxia.

Adora stared at the Crystal. “So, how do we activate it?”

“It needs a password.” Shadow Weaver took Adora’s hand and placed it on the fail-safe.

“We’re friends of Mara,” Adora said confidently. The large crystal illuminated the room and split into three shards on the platform. Electricity crackled along the top of the First Ones’ glyphs.

“That’s gotta be a lot of magic. Adora, are you sure you want to do this?” Bow asked.

Adora gave a decisive nod. “I have to. What other choice is there?”

Angella started taking determined steps toward the platform. “Oh Adora, no. This isn’t your burden to bear.”

“Angella, what are you doing?” Shadow Weaver asked in shock.

“Saving the world, my love.” Angella answered.

“No, no. You can’t.” Adora stood in front of Angella. “We don’t know what it will do to you.”

Angella firmly moved Adora from her path. “Take care of each other. I love you all,” she said with a sad smile to the group.

“Mom!” Glimmer reached out but Bow restrained her.

“No!” Adora said.

"Angella." Shadow Weaver rushed forward, reaching out for her partner.

“You said no mortal can handle the magic.” Angella held Shadow Weaver’s hands. “We don’t know if She-Ra will survive either. I’m immortal.”

“Immortal does not mean invulnerable. Angella, think about this, please,” Shadow Weaver said, clinging to Angella. “No, no. I won’t let you go.”

Angella removed Shadow Weaver's hands. Shadow Weaver held onto her tighter and tighter. She tried to recapture her fully but Angella pulled away. Angella walked to the center of the split crystal. The pearly energy sparked to life, slowly rotating the trio of crystals around the queen. Angella whimpered as the golden magic seeped into her and started to sear into her flesh.

"Something's wrong!" Shadow Weaver said as the Crystal of Arxia's magic now filled the room with a warning rouge. She rushed forward and was blasted away from the platform.

"This isn't right. I'm supposed to take the magic." Adora looked at the ferocious electricity crackling along the tops of the Crystal of Arxia. "The fail-safe knows that." the blonde moved and quickly pushed Angella out of the center.

"Adora!" Catra cried.

"Mom!" Glimmer sobbed.

"I have her," Shadow Weaver said, hugging the unconscious woman to her chest. "I don't think my heart can take much more of your heroics."

She-Ra stepped out of the brilliant glow of the Crystal. The fail-safe glyph was floating just over her heart. "Let's get out of here."

Catra became noticeably more morose and brooding the closer they got to camp. She wouldn't speak to Adora and never deigned to glance in Shadow Weaver's general direction. Shadow Weaver surmised that Catra believed she only paid attention to her when she misstepped. The truth was the older woman watched Adora and Catra all of their lives even when it seemed like she wasn't there. She saw the good and bad. She had seen every success and failure. The fights, hugs, and the promises.

The Dark Princess knew nearly every move her wards would make before they made them and she was certain from Catra's mood that she would be running that night. The teen had fallen silent, not even bothering to snark her way around her emotions and it was one of the signs that she was going to slink off to hide away from everyone until she regained her bearings or until Adora coaxed her back into socializing.

Shadow Weaver looked over the still slumbering Angella and Glimmer. She-Ra healed Angella and refused to speak to Shadow Weaver unless absolutely necessary before she immediately retired for the night. Her attention was drawn to the other side of the hideout when she heard shuffling coming from the alcove that Adora and Catra claimed. Through the squinted eyes of her mask, she watched as Catra pulled on the backpack loaded with supplies. Melog's indignant but hushed caterwauling did nothing to deter her from her task. Catra walked calmly out of the camp and into the Whispering Woods.

Shadow Weaver waited a few beats before heading out behind Catra. The bushes around her rustled and she was sure Catra knew someone was following her. Her thoughts were confirmed when Catra started to run. Shadow Weaver sent a large spinning blade to sever the branch Catra was reaching for. She called the metal back to her hands when Catra tumbled to the ground. She quickly caught up with Catra and snatched her backward by the backpack's strap.

"Where could you possibly be going, Catra?" Shadow Weaver asked in a casually sweet tone.

"I'm leaving." Catra yanked herself free.

"You cannot leave. We have the fail-safe and a plan. Everyone will be needed to defeat Horde Prime," Shadow Weaver told her, reaching out.

Catra recoiled so violently it was a wonder she was still standing. "I told you not to touch me."

“You are not going to stay to find out your answers? Pathetic.” Shadow Weaver sniffed and dropped her hand.

“Is that all you care about? Adora might die.” Catra shot back, tossing the backpack to the ground in anger. “I’m not staying to watch that.”

“Pull yourself together.” Shadow Weaver said. “Now is not the time to get sensitive.”

“It’s your fault I’m like this.” Catra snarled.

“So you keep telling me.” Shadow Weaver crossed her arms with a sigh. “Are you going to keep whining about it or finally do something?”

Catra huffed. “There’s nothing to do. I’m a distraction, right? Leading Adora astray? I heard what you said to her.” She glared at Shadow Weaver.

“And your solution is to run away?” Shadow Weaver shook her head in disgust. “Seems I was right about you.”

“She won’t even notice I’m gone.” Catra’s ears flattened against her head.

Shadow Weaver was determined to keep Catra there even if she had to force the issue. They were facing Horde Prime’s army in less than ten hours. If Catra left, Adora would spend the entire battle worried about Catra and the blonde would definitely falter. Despite Catra’s interpretation, what she said to Adora was absolutely necessary. Catra was too much of a distraction for the current situation. Adora needed to focus on being She-Ra and Catra needed to swallow her pride and allow her to be the hero she was born to be. There was no more time for the dance they constantly did around each other.

Waving her hand, Shadow Weaver created a short fighting staff. The older woman was taller and her reach was further which gave her a slight advantage to Catra’s more agile movements. She

would have to keep the teen further away to maintain the upper hand if their conversation devolved into a physical altercation.

“If you think Adora will not notice your absence you’re a bigger fool than I originally thought.” Shadow Weaver pressed the staff into Catra’s chest firmly.

“It doesn’t matter.” Catra shoved the staff, looking away.

“If that were true you would be at her side instead of running away like a weak, pathetic kitten.” Shadow Weaver shoved Catra with the staff.

“I’m. Not. Pathetic. I’ve been beaten, abducted, chipped, I’m pretty sure I *died* and you don't even care.” Catra growled, pushing the staff at Shadow Weaver. “Why are you even here? You’re finally getting what you want. I’ll be gone.”

“This would be easier if you admit the real reason you are leaving,” Shadow Weaver said.

“You don’t know what you're talking about,” Catra responded. She started to walk away and Shadow Weaver swung the staff into her path, impeding her retreat. “What are you gonna do? Beat me if I don’t come back with you?” The younger woman nodded to the pole in Shadow Weaver’s hands.

Melog jumped in front of Shadow Weaver, growling menacingly. “I can take care of it myself, Melog,” Catra said, waving Melog away. Melog meowed loudly at Catra. “Move out of the way, Melog. I can defeat her.” she insisted.

“Defeat me?” Shadow Weaver chuckled lowly. “Catra, Catra always boasting with nothing to back it up.” she taunted with another tap.

Catra kicked Shadow Weaver across the clearing. The Dark Princess slid across the grass, using the staff to slow her movement. As the older woman stood, Catra leaped for Shadow Weaver’s face. Her sharp talons splayed open for her attack.

Shadow Weaver deflected her hand with a swift rap to her knuckles. Catra's other hand wrapped around the staff and she threw it away into the bushes.

Shadow Weaver called the hollow staff back across the clearing. It whistled through the air, sailing over their heads. The older woman threw a quick jab to Catra's face while she was distracted with watching the staff's path. She didn't wait to see the damage before bringing her knee into Catra's chin.

Catra clawed at Shadow Weaver, shredding the clothing beneath her fingers. She flipped her body, kicking Shadow Weaver in the face. Shadow Weaver staggered back and quickly pressed her mask back into place. She stomped forward and seized Catra's ankle as she tried to scramble away. Catra pivoted and kneed Shadow Weaver in the stomach.

"If you leave, She-Ra will fail." Shadow Weaver coughed and straddled the still recovering Catra, pushing the younger woman's face into the dirt. "I know why you're running, Catra," she stood and extended a hand. "Stay."

Catra exhaled roughly and rubbed her face free of dirt as she stared at Shadow Weaver. "What?"

"I said you need to stay. You might recall I told you in the Fright Zone that we are the same. Our emotions are primal and fierce. We are survivors. The world may beat us down and we will fight back twice as hard. It is a gift and a curse because we will never stop fighting," Shadow Weaver explained calmly. "Love is our only weakness."

Catra squinted at Shadow Weaver for what seemed like an eternity. The cautious distrust was clear on her face when she finally accepted Shadow Weaver's hand.

Shadow Weaver adjusted her grip and carefully pulled Catra to her feet. "I'm proud of you, Catra."

“Thanks,” Catra said. She immediately swayed forward, punching Shadow Weaver on the jaw. The older woman went down with a grunt and was immediately assaulted by blows from a furious Catra. Shadow Weaver felt her mask crack again, nearly breaking her nose. Years of chastisement, harsh punishments, and belittling had run its course and she had to finally deal with the fallout. She struggled and finally managed to grab both of Catra’s wrists.

“Let me go,” Catra hissed and growled above her, trying to pull her arms free. “Fight back.”

“No,” Shadow Weaver said simply. She slowly released Catra's wrists and forced herself to relax on the grass. “No more fighting.”

“You don’t care if I kill you?”

“It is no less than I deserve.”

“No. No!” Catra grabbed Shadow Weaver’s collar, lifting the Dark Princess half off the ground and shook her. “You don’t get to be the bigger person. You did this to me.”

“I am taking responsibility for what I’ve done. My own insecurities were not your fault.”

“Shut. Up.” Catra threatened lowly with a dangerous glint in her eyes.

“You did not deserve it, Catra. You were always good enough.”

“Stop talking. Shut up.” Catra dropped Shadow Weaver to the ground roughly and moved both hands to Shadow Weaver’s neck. “I hate you. I *hate* you.”

The edges of Shadow Weaver’s vision quickly got blurry and dull as her airway was restricted. Her body jerked as her brain and lungs fought to replenish the oxygen being cut off. She was grateful when Catra released her throat in favor of landing more hits, though the last fury of punches and scratches were feeble and half hearted.

“Calling me weak...stupid Heart...just looking for power.” Catra’s words were a jumble of loathing and despair. “Idiot. Why? Why couldn’t she just be selfish for...once?” she slumped forward, sobbing on Shadow Weaver.

The masked woman began tentatively bringing her arms around Catra.

“Don’t.” Catra protested as she violently wiped her eyes.

“It’s not your fault, Catra.” Shadow Weaver gently pulled Catra to rest against her collar and allowed her to fall into the embrace rather than cage her into a hug. She felt Catra relax minutely in her slackened arms and purposely left enough room for her ward to break out of her hold. “It is mine. I am sorry.”

“I hate you.” Catra choked out and her tears of anguish started anew.

“You should,” Shadow Weaver said softly. She smoothed her hand over the short hair against Catra’s scalp and hummed a peaceful tune until the teen’s breathing turned from muted sniffles and stilted purring to deepened breathing. Just as Shadow Weaver hoped, Catra’s emotional outburst had run its course and pulled the younger woman into exhaustion.

“Love hurts. Never experiencing it hurts worse than any physical pain. I do care for you. You stupid, impudent girl.” Shadow Weaver whispered into her hair. “My insolent girl.”

Melog approached the pair, nudging his way under Shadow Weaver’s arm to cuddle next to Catra.

Melog pawed at Shadow Weaver meowing urgently. She opened her eyes in time to see Melog bump his head against hers. He bit her sleeve, pulling her in the direction of the hideout.

“I understand.” Shadow Weaver stood, scooping Catra into her arms and taking great care not to wake the younger woman before she headed back to camp.

“Where have you been?” Angella asked as soon as she spotted her.

“Bonding,” Shadow Weaver stated simply.

“What happened to Catra?” Angella stopped Shadow Weaver. “Your mask is dented. You two look like you’ve been in a battle.”

“Of sorts.” Shadow Weaver yawned with a nod.

Angella's eyes widened. “Was there trouble outside? Is Horde Prime about to find us?”

“Angella, please. Give me a few moments to put Catra to bed and I will explain.”

Shadow Weaver put Catra in her sleeping bag and pulled it as close to Adora’s as she could without waking either girl. She gave Melog a scratch under his chin, watching as the cat curled up at the foot of Adora’s sleeping bag. She returned to Angella in the sitting room of the hideout. Accepting a cup of tea, Shadow Weaver all but collapsed onto a chair.

“Catra was leaving while everyone slept. I followed her outside and provoked her.”

“And that’s how you got the dented mask?” Angella peered at Shadow Weaver with a frown.

Shadow Weaver nodded. “We fought and she got the upper hand.”

“Why did you think it would be okay to have a fist fight with your child?” Angella asked her angrily.

“Catra and I can’t bake a cake together and get over the past. This was the least destructive outlet,” Shadow Weaver said, taking off her mask. She used an abandoned water bottle from the table to wash the saliva and blood from the back.

“Least destructive?” Angella looked unconvinced. “Your idea of a least destructive outlet was to hit each other to exhaustion?”

“We may never be as close as you and Glimmer. Adora may never trust me again, however I assure you Catra and I speak the same emotional language. Catra let me hug her. She cried. And I apologized properly.” Shadow Weaver savored a drink from her tea.

“I’m beginning to suspect Perfuma’s guided mediation treatment might be the best thing for you two,” Angella said, looking into her tea.

“Did you not hear what I said?” Shadow Weaver inquired.

Angella glared at her partner. “You are not punching out your feelings every time you have an argument. That’s not healthy.”

“Angella…” Shadow Weaver sighed.

Angella firmly held Shadow Weaver’s face between her index and thumb. “Promise me that the next time you’re talking you’ll try verbal communication and not violence.”

“Yes, dear.” Shadow Weaver agreed.

“Good girl.” Angella smiled smugly. She stood and cleared their cups. “Entrapta will no doubt be awake soon. Let’s have her look at your mask.”

“I can continue with this mask. I would really like to sleep for a couple of hours if I could,” Shadow Weaver said through another yawn.

“Sleep is for people that don’t worry their partners in the middle of the night.” Angella retorted as she pulled Shadow Weaver to her feet.

The Rebellion was wide awake with the anxious anticipation of the final battle. Bow and Glimmer were propped against Swift Wind as the archer plucked at the strings of a mandolin. Netossa and Spinnerella were huddled under a blanket whispering softly to one another. Just a few feet away Sea Hawk was relaying to an exasperated Mermista about his most recent adventures to defeat Horde Prime’s bots. Frosta was drifting in and out of consciousness while Emily and Slinky guarded the bound Castaspella. Shadow Weaver and Angella sat in the back of the room, hidden in an empty dark alcove.

“Everything feels so final,” Angella said, looking out over the gathered Rebellion.

“Does it? It feels just like a beginning to me.” Shadow Weaver brought Angella’s hands to the lips of her marred mask.

“No one would ever believe what a softy you are.” Angella teased.

“Only for you,” Shadow Weaver said, cuddling Angella to her side.

“So you claim.” Angella hummed, sinking into the embrace.

She-Ra walked confidently into the main room and everyone paid her their full attention. “Today is the day we take it all. Horde Prime has been trying every day to access the Heart of Etheria. With its power, he could destroy planets, galaxies, and maybe even the entire universe. We can’t let that happen. He still has our friends and allies so he knows our every move. Horde Prime has the advantage in the battle, but we have Entrapta,” she said

Entrapta rose up on her hair, floating beside She-Ra. “I’ve finally decrypted Horde Prime’s frequency. I just need to connect to his spire network and I can disrupt the signal, freeing everyone on Etheria at once.”

“Everyone, I need you to distract the Horde forces until Entrapta can hack the signal.” She-Ra told the group. She held her hand under the glyph glowing brightly across her chest. “I’m going to take the fail-safe to the Heart and destroy it, making sure no one can ever access it ever again. Today, we’re gonna defeat Horde Prime and make sure he never harms anyone again. We are ending this.”

Everyone stood cheering and clapping. Adora glanced at Catra, standing off in the darkness with her back to the group. Her grasp on She-Ra slipped and the magic flickered around her. Shadow Weaver rushed across the room, took Adora by the shoulders, and pushed her out the tent before anyone else noticed. “What’s wrong?”

“Catra.” Was the only word Adora said.

Shadow Weaver sighed.

“Don’t start with the Catra is a distraction speech, okay? I have enough to worry about,” Adora said.

“I wasn’t,” Shadow Weaver said plainly.

“Hey, Adora.” Catra walked out of the tent. “You okay?”

“Are you speaking to me now?” Adora asked bitterly.

“I’ve just been thinking about some stuff,” Catra said, avoiding her eyes.

“What happened to you?” Adora asked, reaching for her bruised face.

Catra gently moved the blonde's hand away. "I went outside for a walk last night and ran into an asshole. You know me. It was nothing I couldn't handle."

"Good," Adora said with a small smile.

"Now, are you ready to save the world one last time?" Catra asked.

"You're coming?" Adora blinked in surprise.

"Of course I am, idiot." Catra smirked. Melog purred beside her in agreement.

"I hope you didn't think you could try and sneak off without us," Bow said as he and Glimmer walked outside.

"Are you sure you want to come?" Adora asked them. "The Heart of Etheria could be dangerous for you. The Princesses will need your help more."

"Whatever lies ahead we'll face it together. It's what friends do." They embraced Adora. Bow used his arm to pull Catra into the hug as well. She ended up pressed against Adora. Catra and Adora blushed and looked away.

"I'm going with you. I made the mistake of not fighting by your side, Glimmer. All these years I've let you face what was my battle but no more. I want to be there when you kick his butt," Angella said, walking outside. She raised her hand and her fighting staff materialized into her grip.

Shadow Weaver and Adora locked eyes. The Dark Princess nodded and Adora held her hand high in the air.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" The Sword of Protection manifested in her hand and they walked away from the excitement of camp into the cold darkness of the Whispering Woods.

“What do you want to do after this is all over?” Bow asked as they walked.

“I want to eat cake with my hands and sleep for a week,” Glimmer said with a grin.

“I’m with you on the cake. I’m gonna go back to the Library and help my dads rebuild their displays.”

“We can help with that,” Glimmer said excitedly. “To quote your dads: Best Research Squad. What do you want, Catra?” she asked.

Catra pulled her gaze away from the pair of luminescent blue eyes beside her. “I enjoy cake and you guys aren’t that lame, so I guess I’ll stick around for a bit.” She turned her head back to the blonde next to her. “What about you, Adora?”

“I’m not thinking about the future right now. I just want to focus on getting the fail-safe to the Heart,” She-Ra said, hurrying her pace.

Shadow Weaver and Angella glanced at each other in concern behind the group at She-Ra’s answer. Crystal Castle loomed over them. It was a mere phantom of its former glory. The Whispering Wood’s tree roots had latched onto its corpse like vines across a lattice. When they walked into the main room they heard a smattering of disjointed automated voices coming from the hologram platform.

She-Ra pressed the fail-safe. “We’re friends of Mara. Show us where we can access the Heart of Etheria.”

The old Light Hope operating system flickered in and out of view on the platform. “Mara, M-maraaaa.” A scanner passed over She-Ra and lingered on the fail-safe. The hologram smiled. “Welcome Friends of Mara.” A door lit up in ghostly blue and slid into the ground showing an illuminated hallway covered wall to wall with First Ones’ glyphs.

Glimmer and Bow gripped each of Adora's hands while Catra grasped her shoulder. Adora smiled at each of them but beamed at Catra.

"Go on ahead. We're staying here in case any clones come snooping around," Angella said, twirling her staff.

"Be careful," Glimmer said to her mother.

"You too." Angella returned. She rested against her staff after the teens disappeared from view. "What do you want to do after this is finished?" she asked.

"I want to spend a fortnight in bed with you," Shadow Weaver said seriously. She made a sharp shortsword and flipped it over in her hands, testing the weight.

"Do you think you'll need that much rest?" Angella said with twinkling eyes.

"I didn't say anything about resting," Shadow Weaver growled playfully.

"What is that on the floor?" Angella asked, then gasped. "That's Horde Prime's signature green."

"Horde Prime is going for the Heart. We have to warn Adora," Shadow Weaver said urgently and ran down the hall in search of the teenagers.

"Adora!"

"Adora, wait!"

Angella stopped in front of Glimmer, wiping away her tears. "What happened? Where's Adora?"

"She said she had to go on without us. She said her emotions were too jumbled to focus on saving us." Glimmer explained, looking for any signs of her friend.

“That damned girl.” Shadow Weaver snarled with a shake of her head.

“What’s all this?” Bow asked as the hall glowed an eerie green all around them.

“Horde Prime is infecting the planet and going after the Heart of Etheria.” Shadow Weaver explained.

“Oh no, he’s captured Entrapta too.” Bow’s trackerpad chimed urgently. “We set up a relay in case anything went wrong with her signal. She hasn’t completed the final download.”

“What? Then that means everyone is still chipped,” Catra said.

“Bow, you’re the only one that can hope to follow Entrapta’s plan. You have to go back,” Angella said. “We’ll find Adora and make sure she reaches the Heart.”

“I promised I’d look out for her. I’m gonna do that now whether she wants me to or not,” Catra said confidently.

Glimmer grinned, hugging Catra. “Take care of her Horde scum.”

“That’s the plan, Sparkles,” Catra said, returning the hug.

Bow and Glimmer hugged a surprised Shadow Weaver. “Take care of them,” Bow said.

“I will.” Shadow Weaver brushed a hand atop both of their heads. “Be careful you two.”

“Of course. We can’t miss the wedding,” Glimmer said cheekily as she pulled back.

Shadow Weaver blinked. “Wedding?”

“Oh, did you think dating my mother would be fun and games?” Glimmer frowned playfully with her hands on her hips. “There are

appearances to be kept. She's the Queen of Bright Moon and you have a family to take care of."

Angella laughed. "She's right," she said, placing a tender hand on Shadow Weaver's shoulder.

"It would be an honor and a privilege to marry you, Angella. If you'll have me?" Shadow Weaver turned and bowed. She held out her hand.

Angella nodded rapidly. "I love you."

"And I you," Shadow Weaver said tenderly.

Glimmer gave them a huge smile. "Mom, keep her in line."

"I'll try my best," Angella said.

"I'm sorry again about everything I've done," Glimmer said softly.

Angella shushed Glimmer. "I love you, just go win."

Bow nodded. "We will. We're the Best Friends Squad."

Melog meowed.

"Get them there safe, okay?" Catra petted Melog's head tenderly.

Glimmer, Bow, and Melog teleported away, leaving Shadow Weaver, Catra, and Angella in the glowing hallway. A loud, shrieking roar echoed down the hall.

"Adora!" Catra ran toward the sound.

Shadow Weaver gripped the sword in her hand. She and Angella were just behind Catra. A towering monster stood over Adora. Its six beady eyes glowed menacingly. Barbed tentacles slithered down from its open, drool slicked mouth. It leaned its head down to gore Adora with the curved ridge on its snout but Catra's claws shattered one of the eye lenses on its face.

Catra sailed through the air and landed in front of Adora. “Hey, Adora.”

“Catra? You can’t be here.” Adora breathed heavily as she frowned in confusion. “How can I save you if you're here?”

“Get Adora to the Heart. I can catch up.” Catra crouched suddenly, dodging the lunging arm from the Guardian.

Adora stood on unsteady legs to stop Catra but Shadow Weaver caught her. She used her sleeve to wipe the sweat from the blonde’s tired brow.

“You’ve come too far to give up now.” Shadow Weaver told her.

“You can’t let Catra sacrifice herself,” Adora said, trying to move toward the Guardian.

Shadow Weaver held her firm and glanced behind her. “I have no intention of doing that.”

Angella sent a blinding flash at the guardian and flew up, catching Catra. She landed next to Shadow Weaver and Adora. “Catra, take Adora and run to the Heart of Etheria now.”

Catra accepted Adora’s weight. She dug in her heels as Shadow Weaver tried to push them through the doorway. “What about you?”

“We’re going to put this beast down,” Angella said.

The monster was recovering from the brief blindness. Its growl thundered through the room.

“The First Ones made it too powerful. You can’t defeat it,” Adora said, struggling to stay upright.

“Alone we cannot, but together we can defeat anything,” Shadow Weaver said, pointing her sword at them carefully. “The same as the both of you. You were always meant to be here together.”

“We can’t just leave you,” Catra protested.

“There’s no more time,” Shadow Weaver said. She put her hand on her mask and hesitated. She removed the mask and dropped it to the floor. “Be safe my girls.” She whispered with a watery smile.

The Dark Princess pushed them roughly through the doorway in the direction of the Heart and peeled up panels of the floor, barring reentry to the room. Angella flew overhead, pummeling the guardian with light rays. The queen heaved the fighting staff and severed two reaching tentacles with her magic. She dove out of the way of its toxic blood and tried to shove the crescent peak through its tough hide.

Shadow Weaver hacked off the tiny vestigial legs that helped the Guardian scuttle along the floor. The monster screeched in pain and fell on Shadow Weaver, covering her in its blood. She didn’t have any strength to move her legs.

Angella was by her side immediately. She cupped her face with both hands and kissed Shadow Weaver. “Use my energy.”

At once Shadow Weaver felt the pull of power. She closed her eyes and concentrated. A trilling song filled her head and her heart. It soon rose louder to a deafening crescendo. The song imbued her with purpose. Angella and Shadow Weaver were encased in sparkling ivory light. Shadow Weaver felt lighter than air as the monster’s broken body floated above her. She beckoned their combined power into her magical core and shot it at the monster. The flash and the Guardian’s pained squeal was intense. Once the energy dissipated, Angella and Shadow Weaver were finally visible again.

“We did it,” Shadow Weaver said with a smile.

“Do you think you can walk?” Angella asked, helping Shadow Weaver stand.

“I’ll be okay,” Shadow Weaver said, straightening her back. They stumbled as a quake shook the tower. “What is it now?”

“Don’t worry about that,” She-Ra said, cutting through the metal barrier. “This ends now.” She waved her hand over Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver felt her strength return to her. She gripped Angella’s hand and followed She-Ra outside.

“Don’t you want your mask?” Catra asked her in surprise.

“It was destroyed in the blast,” Shadow Weaver said, pointing to the broken remnants on the floor. “I’m tired of hiding. The world will just have to get used to me. All of me.”

“Damn straight,” Angella said with a proud smile.

Shadow Weaver and Angella followed She-Ra and Catra out of the castle. The ground continued to vibrate violently as they exited into the valley where the Rebellion fought.

Horde Prime stood high at the top of the canyon. “Beg for Horde Prime’s forgiveness, Etheria, for you have chosen darkness!” He thrust his arms up, clutching both of Entrapta’s ponytails in a tight fist.

The toxic green virus split the ground apart. The Rebellion held each other in terror as the sickening glow slunked toward them. All at once, the vile green faded away to a golden light from every side.

“No, it can’t be.” Horde Prime grunted in disgust.

He dropped Entrapta and flinched back from the beads of magic floating in the air, giving the atmosphere a gilded sheen. She-Ra walked out ahead to the battlefield, leaving flowering weeds and grass along the ground behind her. She stopped Horde Prime’s destruction with a wave of her sword.

Glimmer nudged Bow and they looked at her with matching grins. She-Ra smiled back and thrust her sword up. A flood of rainbow magic collided with Horde Prime's lurking ship, the Velvet Glove, turning it into a grand oak tree just out of Etheria's atmosphere. She flipped the sword and plunged it into the ground. She flooded Etheria with pure magic, restoring the planet to its former glory. She-Ra's face became a mask of grim determination as she walked to the cliff where Horde Prime stood. Her sheer magical aura caused him to fall to his knees.

Horde Prime sneered with a growl. "I will rise again. I am eternal."

"No, It's time for you to go and you will never return." She-Ra vowed, grabbing his face. She calmly allowed her magic to seep into Hordak's borrowed body.

Horde Prime's dark soul tried to flee the purity of the white light and was eradicated with a burst of energy. The clones looked around in confusion and wonder. One by one they realized they were no longer attached to Horde Prime's hive mind. They huddled together and stared down at the Rebellion in fear.

As soon as the flash of light cleared everyone began to celebrate their victory over Horde Prime. Spinnerella and Netossa stood together, observing everyone. Spinnerella laughed as Netossa dipped her with a kiss. Swift Wind clopped by them, singing a victory song with rhythmic beeping from Emily, low rumbling from Slinky, and Melog pouncing happily behind them.

The Rebellion finally took notice of an unmasked Shadow Weaver standing beside Catra and Angella. Their conversations, whooping, and cheering slowly died down. Scorpia approached them with Frosta balanced on her shoulders. She set the younger Princess on the ground and straightened once more. Perfuma leaned against Scorpia.

Catra rubbed her arm awkwardly, stepping forward. "Hey, Scorpia. Look, I just wanna say…" She was suddenly pulled off the ground by Scorpia's hug. "There it is." she groaned out.

“You know I’m a hugger.” Scorpia answered with a wide smile. Catra returned a relieved closed mouth one.

“Thank you, for trusting us.” Perfuma gave Shadow Weaver an encouraging smile and placed a flower crown of roses and daisies on her head. She smiled and pulled Shadow Weaver closer to the rest of the group. The rest of the Princesses gave her looks of simple acceptance. No traces of malice or disgust.

“Princess hug!” Frosta declared, hugging Catra’s back.

Perfuma hugged Scorpia who was still holding Catra in the air. Angella pressed Shadow Weaver into the group embrace and held her partner from behind. Everyone laughed delightedly and separated. Shadow Weaver had never felt more accepted in her life.

“I’m so glad you’re here!” Entrapta babbled excitedly to Hordak as they made their way across the valley.

Sea Hawk and Mermista were a few feet away, staring lovingly into each other’s eyes. Mermista glanced at the odd pair and back to the rest of the Rebellion. “Are we just okay with this or…?” She trailed off.

Castaspella appeared in the valley, stalking toward them angrily. Shadow Weaver called the spare magic to her hands and moved quickly to meet her in the middle.

“It’s okay. The war is over.” Angella’s hands covered Shadow Weaver’s and pulled them from their offensive position. “The chips are deactivated.” She pointed to the ground at the trashed behavioral modifiers.

“And just when I was considering thanking you.” Castaspella said, eyeing the glare aimed at her.

“I did save your life and your pretty little head. It’s the least you could do.” Shadow Weaver raised an eyebrow.

“You should be apologizing to me.” Castaspella’s nostrils flared. “I can’t believe you destroyed the Lunar Lenses -what do you mean pretty?”

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes. “It’s an expression.”

“Castaspella, I’m sorry.” Angella stepped closer to her sister in law. “I should have never left you to grieve Micah alone.”

“It’s me,” Castaspella admitted. “I was so bitter of living up to Micah’s memory I never told you what I felt.”

Angella shook her head with a frown. “I suspected your feelings. It was unfair of me to-”

Castaspella grabbed Angella into a tight hug. “We were both hurting.”

“That’s no excuse,” Angella said into Castaspella’s shoulder.

“It is for me.” Castaspella smiled sadly as she released Angella. She turned to Shadow Weaver. “Take care of her or else.”

“If I ever hurt her intentionally I expect you to do your worse,” Shadow Weaver replied evenly.

“You bet I will.” Castaspella lingered, staring at Shadow Weaver expectantly.

The taller woman cocked her head to the side. “Was there something else?”

Castaspella crossed her arms. “Are you ever going to apologize?”

“I won’t apologize for saving your life, but I do regret it came at the cost of the Lunar Lenses,” Shadow Weaver said.

“Thank you, Shadow Weaver,” Castaspella said, patting her hand and walked away.

“You’re welcome,” Shadow Weaver called after her. She smirked at the rude gesture she received from Castaspella in return. Y-shaped pupils watched as Adora, Catra, Glimmer, and Bow walked to the tall hill overlooking the rest of the Etherian landscape.

“It’s finally over,” Angella said, hugging Shadow Weaver from behind.

“Yes, I believe it finally is,” Shadow Weaver said as her eyes tracked a flock of birds flying over the gorge into the radiant and twinkling Etherian sky. The released magic of Etheria was more glorious than she could have ever imagined. Everything was brighter and there was a permanent rainbow of colors across the horizon. “I’m glad that I was able to see it with you.”

Chapter End Notes

So, we’ve reached the end of the war but not the end of the fic. I'm putting some finishing touches on the epilogue and will post as soon as it's finished.

As always thanks so much for every and all kudos, review, hits, and support I've gotten!

Until next time!

Epilogue: You Are the Morning When It's Clear

Chapter Summary

It has been one year since the end of the war.

Chapter Notes

Archive: Don't copy to another site without permission

Spoilers: I'm picking and choosing what canon plot lines make it in here, but if I had to put an exact time stamp on it, anything after Season 2, "Light Spinner" will be pretty spoilery.

Disclaimer: She-Ra and the Princesses of Power belong to DreamWorks and the wonderful Noelle Stevenson. Any and all other brand names that might appear here belong to their respective owners. I do not make any money on this story. Please don't sue; you only stand to gain outstanding student loans for your troubles.

Author's Note: This is inspired by fanart, gay thoughts, insomnia, and two songs: Florence and the Machine's song "No Light, No Light" along with Five Finger Death Punch's "Wrong Side of Heaven." My brain couldn't leave well enough alone after I binged watched the series and now we have this insane premise. Some scenes have been pulled directly from the show. Enjoy!

All mistakes I claim as my own.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Epilogue: You Are the Morning When It's Clear

Etheria was finally at peace. It was like a new planet since it's magic had been restored. Loads of flourishing plant life covered nearly every inch of its surface. It was a dizzying feeling to feel the very air charged with unrestrained power and Shadow Weaver was extremely grateful to have lived through it. She especially enjoyed the hosts of animals that emerged from their previously magicless hibernation to see the new dawning of the rejuvenated Etheria. Flocks of new and exotic birds took flight across the horizon every morning. Swift Wind took his time to fly to every end of Etheria to learn as much as he could from each organism that now roamed the planet.

The Best Friend Squad barely rested one week after the final battle with Horde Prime before they were off again on their adventure to restore magic to the universe. Their adventures soon caused magical beings from all over the galaxy to flock to Etheria to witness the planet that not only was successful in defeating Horde Prime, but also had the purest magic in all of the known universes. All too soon, the teens missed their home planet and returned to finish healing Etheria.

Shadow Weaver walked confidently through the halls of Bright Moon's palace. The golden, beaded headpiece that served as her crown twinkled merrily in the light that shined on the pearl inlays of the crescent moon across her forehead.

"Your majesty," the two guards said, inclining their heads. They tapped their spears on the floor and opened the double doors to the dining room.

"Hello, darling. How are the plans coming with the Victory Ball?" Angella stood, greeting her wife.

Shadow Weaver kissed Angella gently and sat in the empty chair next to her. “It would be finished by now if Castaspella did not insist on nitpicking every decision I make.”

“The ball is later today. What could she possibly be changing?” Angella pushed a dish of sliced fruit in front of Shadow Weaver.

“She fired and rehired the gardener then worked herself in a ridiculous state when I wouldn't agree that eggplant sashes would look better on the back of the chairs than the azure sashes we've already ordered.” Shadow Weaver sipped from the nearby glass of wine.

“I would have thought you and Castaspella had finally learned to work together after collaborating on Mystacor’s revamped lesson plan,” Angella said, looking through her small stack of reports.

“That only lasted until she somehow got it in her head that I'm using Aldehaim to compete with Mystacor.” Shadow Weaver revealed, nibbling on a slice of kiwi. “I am done trying to explain the difference to her.”

Shadow Weaver’s efforts to restore Aldehaim went far smoother than she anticipated. Several sorcerers from Mystacor volunteered their magic to clear the gloom and decay from the stone post haste. With Aldehaim finally cleaned, Shadow Weaver proposed plans to create an institution that catered to magical students that wanted to learn ancient and advanced magics.

The Dark Princess didn’t expect the interest she received from the inhabitants in Mystacor much to Castaspella’s chagrin. There were a few finishing touches needed before the idea would be officially announced across all of Etheria. Horde Prime’s tall, sterile spires were now commonplace in the shining Etherian landscape. The Princess Alliance decided to leave the spires intact for emergency broadcasting. Entrapta was ecstatic for a new project and rewrote the code so it would only respond to the Princesses’ authorization.

“Castaspella can be a bit much but she’s an excellent party planner,” Angella said, signing the last scroll. She set aside the stack and ate a couple of berries from the bowl.

“Funny, she’s the only one that believes that,” Shadow Weaver said plainly.

“Don’t be mean.” Angella laughed out.

“I am staying true to myself,” Shadow Weaver said.

“We both know you have sweetness in you,”;Angella said, feeding Shadow Weaver a blueberry.

“Only when you’re involved.” Shadow Weaver purred as she playfully flicked her tongue across Angella’s fingers.

“Don’t start.” Angella pressed her index finger firmly against Shadow Weaver’s lips. “We have a full day today. How long before you relieve Castaspella of her planning duties?”

“I am not. I am interested to see what happens when she’s left to her own devices,” Shadow Weaver responded.

“You’re not serious?” Angella asked with a shake of her head. “That’s too much for one person.”

“Miss Mystacor should be able to handle it since she is a superb party planner,” Shadow Weaver said mockingly. She dabbed at her face with the napkin and stood.

“Be careful that she doesn’t seek revenge for this stunt,” Angella warned. “Are you heading to the gardens now?” She inquired.

“Everyone is all but banished from the grounds until Castaspella has rearranged the way the grass grows,” Shadow Weaver replied with an eye roll. “I’m due for our mediation session with Perfuma. Will you meet me there before we visit George and Lance?”

“Yes, my love. I’ll see you later.” Angella agreed.

Shadow Weaver brushed her lips across Angella's, slowly deepening the kiss.

Angella chuckled, pulling away when Shadow Weaver tugged her out of her chair. "You are determined to start something."

"This is entirely your fault. You are too tempting." Shadow Weaver mumbled, kissing around Angella's high collar.

"We can't do that here." Angella pushed at her wife's shoulder with no actual effort.

"Our staff is discreet." Shadow Weaver pushed the plates further up the table away as she stepped closer to the ombré haired woman. "And more importantly they are guarding the door."

"I wouldn't be able to look at this table in the same way," Angella said, kicking her chair away to give Shadow Weaver more room to move.

"That was the idea." Shadow Weaver picked up Angella, palming her rounded derrière, and placed her on the edge of the table. Shadow Weaver pulled down the top of the other woman's leotard, exposing her breasts to the air. The brunette teased Angella's nipples and placed wet kisses across her chest, leaving nips across soft lavender skin.

The older woman moved back up to Angella's mouth and kissed her hard, rolling the stiff nipples between her fingers. The two women completely sank into the passionate kiss, no longer caring where they were. Angella's muffled moan filled the room.

"Quiet my queen, we wouldn't want anyone to interrupt breakfast." Shadow Weaver whispered against plump lips. She slid her right hand down Angella's body and gently rubbed her pussy. The winged woman felt scorching pulses of pleasure coursing through her body as Shadow Weaver brushed a thumb across her clit through the thin fabric.

“You are enjoying the danger a little too much aren’t you, my queen?” Shadow Weaver asked when she felt the quickly dampening fabric under her hand.

“We don’t have much time.” Angella breathlessly reminded her wife. She bucked against the brunette’s hand, hoping to quell the ache in her center.

Shadow Weaver ripped the leggings, moved the leotard to the side, and used two fingers to spread wetness across Angella’s sex. Once her fingers were coated, the brunette carefully slid three fingers inside Angella. The ombré haired woman bit her lip, a sustained groan caught low in her throat at the delicious stretch from those long, reaching fingers inside her.

Shadow Weaver kissed Angella again, swallowing any other sounds that might echo through the room. Angella held onto her wife’s shoulders, riding her fingers with wild abandon. Shadow Weaver matched her easily as her fingers became more soaked.

The Dark Princess pulled back, breathing heavily. “I love you. You’re simply exquisite like this.”

“I love you too,” Angella keened.

Angella was close and Shadow Weaver knew it. From the rhythmic spasming against her fingers to the way her sharp hearing caught the moment her breathless whimpers morphed into hushed sobs of pleasure. If she had more time, she would savor wringing louder sounds from her wife until someone was forced to check on the queen. At the moment she was more than content to have her come undone in this semi-public space as quickly as possible. She stroked her thumb in tight circles across Angella’s engorged clit.

Angella’s breath caught and her body tightened all over. Her blunted nails dug into Shadow Weaver's shoulders and her brow furrowed as her muscles clenched hard on the fingers buried inside her. It happened just for a moment as her body became a

flurry of movement. Her hips jogged at a frantic pace until a quick and intense wave of satisfaction overtook her. She frantically moved to kiss Shadow Weaver, their mouths not quite fitting together as she moaned out her climax.

Shadow Weaver pulled her wet fingers free and held them up to Angella's mouth expectantly. Angella tiredly locked eyes with her wife as she traced her tongue carefully over the brunette's ring finger then moved to her index to thoroughly clean it as well. She moaned as she tasted herself on the soft skin. She always left the middle for last. The queen dragged her teeth across the shiny fingertip and enveloped the digit in one smooth motion.

Shadow Weaver's eyes fluttered as she watched the display. Each suck from Angella's mouth sent a jolt down to her center. It was a sensuous torment that she readily submitted to. Unfortunately, they didn't have any more time for her to sate her own appetite.

"I have to go." Shadow Weaver groaned in frustration.

Angella released the older woman's finger with a soft pop. "I'll see you later." She winked.

"Mm, yes. Later." Shadow Weaver gently dipped her hands in the finger bowl near the centerpiece. She wiped her hands dry with the discarded napkin. "I'll go tell a guard to fetch your tailor."

"There is no need to trouble them. I will go through the Chamber of Queens tunnels to my room." The door banged open and Angella scrambled to get herself into a more presentable condition.

"I'm just gonna go be somewhere else now." Adora squeaked out red faced. She fled back down the hall. Melog scampered out behind her.

Catra threw up her hands. "Seriously? We have to eat here."

Shadow Weaver smirked. "Precisely-"

“Stop.” Catra covered her ears. “Just stop. Ugh, I’m going outside far away from this.” She exited, slamming the door shut.

Angella chuckled as she tried to pat her hair down. “You better get to your session. It’s sure to be interesting today.”

Shadow Weaver gave Angella a quick, chaste kiss. “Enjoy your morning.”

Angella looked down at her ruined clothing with a grimace. “I’ll repay you later,” she threatened playfully, swatting Shadow Weaver’s backside.

“I am looking forward to it,” Shadow Weaver said, adding an extra swing to her hips as she strode from the room.

Shadow Weaver’s steps slowed when she reached the large flower bud made of vines, flowers, and weeds. With Perfuma’s help Adora, Catra, and Shadow Weaver began to heal their relationship. They had biweekly mediation sessions as soon as the teens returned to Etheria. Catra had been the most disbelieving in the beginning but now she understood the purpose of talking out any grievances instead of running away or striking each other. They were all very thankful for Perfuma's assistance despite the odd methods she used in her lessons.

“This will simulate the womb in which we will do our healing and rebirth,” Perfuma explained as Shadow Weaver carefully walked inside the hollow structure. Adora and Catra were already inside sitting patiently for everything to begin.

Perfuma sealed the pod.

“Perfuma? Oh, whoops.” Scorpia’s claw sliced through the ‘womb.’ “I knocked too hard.”

“Scorpia, I told you I had a mediation session today.” Perfuma chided her girlfriend with a tight smile.

“I know, sorry. But Emily is in the f-l-o-w-e-r-s,” Scorpia whispered.

“I know how to spell, Scorpia,” Shadow Weaver told her, walking forward.

“Where are you going?” Perfuma asked, standing in front of Shadow Weaver.

“I am going to salvage my garden from that insufferable bot,” Shadow Weaver stated.

“Sit there and relax. We’ll repair the damage later.” Perfuma ducked through the opening and ushered Scorpia away.

“So, would this be a breech birth?” Adora asked Catra after a couple of moments of silence.

“How do you know that term?” Shadow Weaver asked.

“We answered a distress beacon and the planet thought She-Ra was an ancient fertility goddess.” Catra explained.

“An eight foot tall woman with a glowing magical sword must scream ‘let me near your children,’”Shadow Weaver said sardonically.

Adora snorted. “That’s similar to what Glimmer said.”

“Didn’t matter though she fainted when they asked her to check to see how the baby was,” Catra said, swiping her tail through the air lazily.

“I was pretty pathetic,” Adora said, crying with laughter. “Catra was the one that managed to deliver the baby.”

“All I did was catch the little parasite.” Catra shrugged.

“They were so grateful they named the baby after her.” Adora pinched Catra’s cheeks playfully. Catra gnashed her teeth and moved the blonde’s hand.

“They named the baby Catra?” Shadow Weaver asked in surprise.

“Nope,” Adora said, shaking her head. “They named him Cato.”

“Sorry for that interruption,” Perfuma returned and the flowers and vines weaved into an enclosure once more. “We’ve made a lot of progress this year. Is there anything you want to address today?”

“Besides, why Shadow Weaver felt the breakfast table was a good place to take Queen Angella this morning there’s nothing that comes to mind.” Catra glared at the older woman.

"Catra!" Adora groaned.

"Adora, this is obviously something Catra wishes to discuss," Perfuma said sedately.

"I *don't* want to talk about it!" Catra denied swiftly.

"Catra, this is a safe space." Perfuma waved her hand to indicate the structure they sat in. "It is the womb and it's here we will nourish your emotional well-being so you can emerge anew. What do you want to say?"

"It's just that…" Catra twirled a blade of grass in her fingers.

"There's no rush." Perfuma encouraged.

"I don't want to see the person that raised me having sex on a table in front of me," Catra confessed.

"Shadow Weaver, Catra feels uncomfortable about your open affections with Queen Angella...on the dining room table...where we have eaten many meals." Perfuma couldn't help but add. "Do

you think you can try to honor her wishes so she's no longer uncomfortable?"

"I can try," Shadow Weaver said.

"I think it's worse because you are like something to me," Catra mumbled.

"Catra, are you saying you're starting to see her as maybe a parental figure?" Adora asked with her signature dopey grin.

"No!" Catra looked away, flicking her tail. "Maybe," she grumbled lowly.

"Aww," Adora's eyes glittered as she grinned. "I'm so proud of you."

"I don't know what to do with these feelings," Catra said with a toss of her head. "Calling her 'mom' would be too weird."

"You're not ready to assign Shadow Weaver a title in your life and that's okay," Perfuma said softly. "Adora, do you have anything to say in response to Catra's admission?" She asked.

"I've always kind of thought of Shadow Weaver as a mom figure but I agree with Catra," Adora stated, looking at the older woman. "It would feel strange to call her mom."

"Shadow Weaver?" Perfuma inquired.

Shadow Weaver reached out for Adora's and Catra's hands. "The fact that you've even considered me a maternal figure is enough. You don't have to give me a title. Call me whatever you feel comfortable with."

"What is your real name?" Catra asked hopefully.

“Shadow Weaver.” Came the acerbic reply.

"Come on," Adora said, nudging Shadow Weaver lightly. "We mean the one Beatrix gave you. We know you must have an idea of what it is."

"Is there a good reason you need to know if I had a name before Light Spinner?" Shadow Weaver responded.

The brunette honestly should have expected the ambush ever since they spent a bonding session trying to decode her mother's last batch of holochips. It seemed to be yet another mystery the Best Friend Squad decided would be a worthwhile quest. The final clue was the eight blank spaces etched across her childhood bedroom door, but they seemed to have forgotten that.

There was silence and then Adora tentatively said, "We want to know more about you."

"We are learning more than I had ever planned on telling you in mediation." Shadow Weaver pulled away, facing forward. "A lot more." She shot a look of warning over her shoulder.

Catra held up her hand. “But…"

"Shadow Weaver is the only name you'll need to address me." She insisted.

"Perfuma said we should be open and honest with each other as this week’s exercise." Catra countered.

"Perfuma also said that we are allowed privacy until you are ready to talk about your issues," Perfuma interjected.

Catra wasn’t deterred. "Shadow Weaver *just* said we could call her whatever we were comfortable calling her."

"Catra, just as you are not ready to name Shadow Weaver as your mother, Shadow Weaver is not comfortable going by her birth name." Perfuma cleared her throat. "Is everyone okay with moving on?"

"Yes," Adora, Shadow Weaver, and Catra answered.

"Is there anything else you wish to address today?" Perfuma continued after the sustained silence. "If nothing immediately comes to mind then we'll do some centering meditation and revisit. Close your eyes." She put her shoulders back and breathed deep. "Now we will-"

Catra shrieked. "What are you doing!?" she growled at Shadow Weaver.

"Stretching," Shadow Weaver said. They were supposed to be meditating on what they had learned from each other in the session like every time before. She had gently, in her opinion, moved Catra's tail so she could comfortably sit in her pose.

"You brushed my tail on purpose." Catra accused.

"Okay, time out both of you." Perfuma stood.

"Please don't." Catra pleaded.

"We will make up right now," Shadow Weaver offered.

Perfuma turned to Adora. "You've made lots of progress today." The leaves behind Perfuma opened like a door. "You may go."

Shadow Weaver and Catra knew what was to follow now and inched toward each other like they were being forced to hug a Pooka from Beast Island.

"You will each pay each other one heartfelt compliment and you may go," Perfuma said.

"Your tactical prowess rivals my own," Shadow Weaver praised.

"Cool Princess powers," Catra said immediately after.

Catra and Shadow Weaver separated and turned to leave. Perfuma pointed back to the center, braiding a vine rope in her

hands in warning. Shadow Weaver and Catra embraced again.

"I like your hair," Catra mumbled.

"What?" Shadow Weaver asked. She was convinced she had heard incorrectly.

"You've always had kinda epic hair. It's why I prefer to keep my hair long." Catra flicked her ears, not meeting Shadow Weaver's eyes.

"Thank you, Catra," Shadow Weaver said softly.

"Please." Catra scowled. "Don't mention it."

Shadow Weaver scratched behind Catra's ear. "You have beautiful expressive eyes."

"Really?" Catra asked in surprised.

"They remind me of my own when I was still Light Spinner."

"You had green eyes," Catra said with a confused look.

"Yellow and blue make green." Shadow Weaver reminded the young woman. She rubbed a tuft of hair behind Catra's ear. She smiled, hearing the soft purrs from the girl.

"Quit it!" Catra groused with a blush, swatting at the treacherous hand. She stalked away. Melog appeared with a meow, rubbing its head against her leg as soon as she got outside. "Yes, I'm okay," she told Melog.

"This was a great session. Thank you for attending. Shadow Weaver, I will visit the garden later to repair Emily's damage. You should go; I promised Castaspella we would be cleared out about five minutes ago." Perfuma chuckled nervously. She waved her hands and the foliage melted into the ground.

“Hello Catra, Adora," Angella said, landing next to the shrinking flower pod.

"Hey, Angella," Both girls said.

"Let's go, Catra. We promised to help Bow and Glimmer hang up the streamers for the after party," Adora said, jogging back to the castle.

"You’re so good with them," Shadow Weaver said fondly.

"So are you," Angella said.

"I’m…trying." Shadow Weaver admitted. "We may never get to a good place."

“I have hope you’ll get there. Don’t pressure yourself too much on the proper place. The proper place is wherever you and Catra and Adora believe is best. You’ve said you're making progress with Perfuma’s guided meditation and mediation.” Angella held Shadow Weaver. "How was today's session?"

“It went fine until the ending." Shadow Weaver drawled, her eyes distant.

"Are you ever going to tell Perfuma you and Catra no longer find hugging each other punishment?" Angella asked.

"It makes her happy," Shadow Weaver said and glanced at her wife. She crossed her arms and immediately looked away. "Stop it."

"Whatever do you mean?" Angella bit her lip, smiling coyly at Shadow Weaver.

"I know what you're thinking, it is written all over your face."

"You're so sweet." Angella cooed, tickling two fingers down a pointed ear.

Shadow Weaver’s shriek would have echoed across Bright Moon were it not for the quick kiss Angella gave her to muffle the sound.

"I love your giggles," Angella said against her wife's lips.

A vehement glare was the only response Shadow Weaver gave to the ombré haired woman.

"What was the purpose of that humongous flower pod Perfuma sprouted in the middle of the grounds?" Angella asked, changing the subject.

“It was supposed to represent the womb.” Shadow Weaver clarified.

Angella chuckled then coughed from behind her hand when her wife's eyes narrowed. “Well, we best be off.”

"Yes." Shadow Weaver accepted Angella's hand. They began their walk to the Moonstone tower.

"Emily!" Scorpia shouted then groaned. "Perfuma, stop her! Oh boy!" She breathed heavily, resting her claws on her knees. "How did you get so fast? Did Entrapta give you another upgrade?" There was a crash and frantic beeping. "No! Come on, Emily! Shadow Weaver is going to turn you into a flower pot one day.”

“Actually based on her specifications, Emily would be unsuited to growing foliage.” Entrapta’s voice joined the ruckus.

"Entrapta, It’s not a threat if you explain the flaws to her," Perfuma said.

Shadow Weaver and Angella were soon out of earshot of the bickering young women and beeping bot.

Angella saw her wife’s long hair begin to gain volume. She squeezed her hand gently. “Tomorrow morning we will fix all the damage."

“If there is a garden to come back to,” Shadow Weaver scoffed.

“You really should just give Emily a patch of grass to roll and frolic in,” Angella suggested.

Shadow Weaver swiped a clawed hand through the air. “I will not invite intruders into my sanctuary.”

“You let Slinky dig up as much soil as he wants when he returns from his time with George and Lance," Angella said.

Shadow Weaver waved her hand. “That’s not remotely the same. Slinky is useful and sufficient. Emily is an annoyance.”

Angella kneeled and extended her arms towards her wife once they stopped under the Moonstone.

Shadow Weaver frowned. "What are you doing?"

"We are flying to the Library today." Angella lifted her arms higher toward her wife.

"Were we not coming here to teleport?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"You doubt my strength?" Angella flexed her right bicep. Her double wings opened wide on her back.

"Well, no," Shadow Weaver began.

Angella stood quickly and pivoted, scooping the older woman in a princess carry.

“Angella!" Shadow Weaver yelped as she instinctively looped her arms around the taller woman’s neck.

Angella took off into the sky. “Calm down, love,” she said softly as the sorceress clung tighter to her.

“Just how high are you planning on going?” Shadow Weaver inquired.

“Darling, this is going to be a very short flight if you don't relax your grip on my neck,” Angella said with a strained chuckle. She breathed easier when the pressure on her neck lessened. “Who would have guessed big, bad Shadow Weaver afraid of heights?”

The older woman’s eyes narrowed to slits. “I am not afraid of heights. We sleep in a suspended bed for goodness sake. I’m just not fond of *falling* from them.” She clarified.

Angella kissed Shadow Weaver's temple. “You are not going to fall from anything. I’ve got you.”

"Yes, you do. You always have." Shadow Weaver sighed contentedly.

The brunette nuzzled the nape of Angella’s neck. She smiled as she felt her wife hum appreciatively. Angella paused mid-flight and hovered them in the air as she pulled back to look at Shadow Weaver. The air around the two women became different, more electric with a pleasant buzz of heat. Angella leaned down and kissed Shadow Weaver passionately.

"Now, who’s starting something?" Shadow Weaver teased with a final peck. "We’re gonna be late meeting George and Lance for afternoon tea.”

No sooner than Shadow Weaver and Angella landed on the ground, did they find themselves knocked back down to the soft grass.

"Hello, Slinky," Shadow Weaver grunted from under the enthusiastic Elemental.

Angella petted the Elemental across his head with a small smile. "You have spent too much time away from him," she said to her

wife.

"I'll take you on an outing soon just allow me to get off the ground." Shadow Weaver promised the giddy Elemental.

Slinky allowed himself one last cuddle before he rolled back into a ball and resumed his sleep in the shade next to the Library.

"Your majesties!" Lance called out with a wave from the door. As soon as Shadow Weaver and Angella reached the door he bowed at the waist.

"Lance, I've asked you not to do that." Angella reminded the taller man. She kissed both of his cheeks in greeting.

George shook both of their hands. "He only does it because you ask him not to." He informed her.

Shadow Weaver raised her chin with a haughty smile. "Speak for yourself, Angella. I do not think I could tire from hearing a royal greeting."

"So, I have a few recipes that I just tried. Tell me what you think." Lance stated excitedly as he rushed to the kitchen.

George usher them inside and gestured for them to sit. "How have you two been?" He asked.

"Ruling is more tedious than I expected." Shadow Weaver admitted.

"Now you know why I never had any free time before," Angella said. "And it probably wouldn't be so tedious if you didn't believe you had to be so extreme with your solutions."

"My solutions are just fine," Shadow Weaver replied evenly.

Angella scoffed. "You threatened to split a cow in half to settle a livestock dispute."

"I was making a point." Shadow Weaver rolled her wrist. "If the landowners and farmers cannot learn to work together then the choice would be taken from them. I guarantee there will be no more bickering."

Lance returned to the room. He somehow had a three-tier cake stand and a serving tray impeccably balanced in each hand. "You two sound as though you've been married for decades rather than ten months," he said as he placed the tray and stand on the coffee table.

"I know." Angella agreed with narrowed eyes. "She's always been maddening." she nodded to the brunette seated next to her.

"You are one to talk, Princess." Shadow Weaver shot back.

"You're so cute together." Lance gushed with a grin.

"So are you two." Angella returned easily. "How have your expeditions been lately? Have you found anything new?"

"We can't believe it took us so long to visit the Crimson Wastes. Huntara was a wonderful guide," George said, pouring a splash of cream into his tea. "Of course the entire expedition was infinitely easier with Slinky to help us dig up the bones stuck in the sand. Thank you for agreeing to share him."

"It was no bother. If it was not for you, I might have never discovered my origins." Shadow Weaver floated the silver sugar tongs effortlessly between the bowl of cubes and her tea cup. Once she was done she used her hand to stir the spoon resting on the rim of her cup.

"Show off." Angella teased her wife.

"Speaking of which, I want to thank you again for bringing us to Beast Island." Lance passed a saucer of petit fours across the table to the queens. "It was a fascinating trip. The environment was unlike anything else on Etheria." he began.

"Honey, remember the other reason we went," George said gently to Lance after seeing the shimmer of tears in Angella's eyes.

"Angella, I'm so sorry," Lance said quickly.

"I'm okay," Angella said thickly, waving off their concern.

Shadow Weaver grasped Angella's closest hand. "I'll never apologize enough for his death."

"We've talked about this tirelessly. It's not your fault. You didn't know." Angella squeezed the brunette's hand.

"I could have done more. I could have insisted on answers." Shadow Weaver pulled Angella's hand into her lap.

"Hordak wouldn't have given a damn if you insisted. He would have sent you to Beast Island as well." Angella kissed Shadow Weaver's knuckles. "He almost did." she reminded her.

"Look what you've done now." George hissed to Lance.

"This is it. This is the day it finally happens." Lance almost shattered the teacup with the force he used to place it back on the serving tray. "I'm going to be executed by the Queen. Is there a law on hurting royal feelings?" he asked in a rush.

"No one's getting executed. I'm fine, really. Micah would want me to be happy and not dwell." Angella sniffled and wiped her eyes. "Pass me another petit four."

"That's the spirit!" Lance cried.

Shadow Weaver picked up one of the miniature pieces of coconut cake and lifted it in the air in a toast. "To King Micah."

"To King Micah!" George and Lance parroted.

"To Micah."Angella laughed, happy tears now framing her eyelashes.

Glimmer suddenly appeared next to the couch. "Mom, there's someone in Bright Moon looking for Shadow Weaver."

Shadow Weaver raised an eyebrow. "Someone asked for me by name?"

Glimmer shook her head."Not exactly. They asked for Beatrix's daughter."

Once she and Angella were seated in their thrones back in Bright Moon, Shadow Weaver nodded to the guards to let their guests in. Three figures slowly shuffled inside the throne room. They had similar gray tinged skin as Light Spinner once had and adorned face coverings from the nose down. As soon as the guest's eyes looked at the second throne, the trio gaped in shock at Shadow Weaver's unmasked face. A short, older woman walked ahead of her companions. She had tight curls of Auburn red. Just a few steps behind her was a man that appeared roughly the same age with white blonde hair and bristly eyebrows.

She bowed first when she reached the last steps in front of the thrones. "Good day your majesties. I'm Tercassi and this is my husband Hydric."

Hydric bowed beside his wife. "We came as soon as we could. There were rumors that the last Runestone was activated and we knew you still lived."

"I've been alive for some time. Didn't Beatrix tell you of her plans?" Shadow Weaver asked, glancing at the youngest of their group. His gaze was oddly hopeful and eager as he stared at her. She kept the confusion from her face as Tercassi responded.

Tercassi bowed her head. "None of the families shared their plans of escape. It was safer to decide and get out," she said sadly.

Shadow Weaver returned her attention to the couple. "Do you have any idea how many from Aldehaim are left?"

"We thought it was just us. It's been so many years, we never thought we'd see the day that we'd be reunited with a fellow Aldehaimian let alone the Runechilde. We are so glad to have found you," Tercassi said as she and Hydric straightened from their bow. The couple pulled the final figure forward. "This is Trian, our son, and your betrothed."

Trian bowed quickly, exposing the tight auburn bun on the back of his head. His neat and thin eyebrows raised as hazel eyes bored into Shadow Weaver when he stood. He stroked his trimmed beard that extended beyond his dark orange veil and none too subtly flexed his toned biceps.

Catra snorted loudly. "Well, this guy is in for some heartbreak."

"A magikat?" Trian asked excitedly, reaching for his weapon. "Allow me, my beloved. Its heart will make a wonderful token of conquest."

Shadow Weaver quickly held up her hand. She watched as Trian's grip slipped across his sword's handle without the weapon moving from its scabbard. "You will not disturb one hair on Catra's head. Any more attempts and I guarantee I'll be a widow before your hand touches that broadsword again."

Tercassi's eyes widened. "You've named it?"

Shadow Weaver stood at once. Her katana sliced the air too fast for anyone to track. Trian tugged self-consciously at the veil that wrapped his face as an inch of fabric fluttered to the floor.

"I have raised *Catra* all of her life," Shadow Weaver said, clenching the sword in her hand.

"I wouldn't exactly say raised," Catra grumbled under her breath.

"How can you allow it to see your face?" Trian’s shout of pain followed his question.

"You are lucky. A year ago I would have taken the arm," Shadow Weaver said, wiping the streak of crimson from her blade on Trian's sleeve. "That will be your last warning."

"We revoke our offer of house unity." Hydric sputtered after watching the brief altercation.

"I did not ask for it." Shadow Weaver shrugged and reached out for Angella. "I'd like you to meet my wife. Queen Angella of Bright Moon." She introduced after the ombré haired woman came to stand beside her.

"I would say it's wonderful to meet you but that wouldn't be very truthful at the moment," Angella said, glaring at the family.

"Wife?" Trian inquired faintly. "But...we were promised."

"Yes, my wife, Trian." Shadow Weaver watched as Trian's frame all but deflated. "Did you think the matching thrones were because we were sisters?" She laughed.

"I'd never thought I'd live to see the day a Runechilde would be so careless with their veil." Tercassi's sneer was heard through her mask as she leaned forward, comforting her son and tending to his cut.

Everyone but Bow and Shadow Weaver looked confused at the remark. Yes, Shadow Weaver knew better. The phrasing was unfamiliar but the tone was unmistakable. Her eyes narrowed at the insult.

"I don't like what you're insinuating," Angella stated sharply a moment later.

"Their words hold no value to me, Angella," Shadow Weaver said. Her face smoothed into an amused smirk. "Clearly you've been gone too long to have retained any resemblance of decent social

interaction," she said, turning away from the family to assist Angella back to her seat. "How else can one explain anybody wanting to willingly marry this foppish stranger?" She asked over her shoulder.

"What's going on?" Frosta asked

"I'm just as lost." Scorpia laughed nervously. "What am I missing?"

"In Aldehaim, it's taboo to show your face to anyone that's not family or your betrothed. Tercassi basically said Shadow Weaver sleeps around." Bow explained.

Castaspella frowned at the explanation.

"Oh...boy." Adora blew out a tense breath.

"Your destiny was to be one of my house and one day lead Aldehaim's army to countless victories," Tercassi revealed.

"The Kingdom you are clinging to was full of ashes and death. You think you can waltz back when it's convenient. You are over two decades too late to be remotely relevant to me. You couldn't even bother to be present during the last year of the war."

"Aldehaim is our home. What right do you have to keep us from it?" Hydric demanded.

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed. "You seem to forget that *I* am the Princess of Aldehaim. I will restore it to its former glory, whether or not that includes you will be for me to decide."

"You cannot stop us. We are its true inhabitants. Our claim is that much more valid than yours will ever be!" Tercassi shouted. "You don't even have a name."

Dark tendrils surrounded the family, blocking out the bright light in the throne room. "My name is Shadow Weaver and it would be wise for you to heed all that the moniker implies." The Dark

Queen's voice echoed through the throne room as she used her magic to tower over her captives.

"Leave Bright Moon," Glimmer said, coming to stand beside the thrones. Her fists glowed brilliantly at her side.

"Yeah, you're not needed here." Catra hissed, displaying her claws.

"Shadow Weaver already has her family." Adora glared from her place beside Catra.

"As I breathe," Tercassi whispered with a shake of her head.

"Cassi?" Hydric asked, tugging at the woman urgently.

"Don't you see it?" Tercassi asked her husband as her eyes remained on Shadow Weaver.

Hydric looked at the brunette and back at his wife in confusion. "No, I'm sorry. I don't."

"That explosive anger! That presence! That's all Beatrix right there." Tercassi sniffled with watery eyes. "I miss her."

"Mother?" Trian inquired softly, placing his hand on her shoulder.

Tercassi patted Trian's hand. "I didn't mean what I said," she told Shadow Weaver.

"Words said in the heat of anger are often the truth. One must be careful because they can never be forgotten," Shadow Weaver replied as she gradually shrank back down to her normal height.

Perfuma cooed proudly at Shadow Weaver, clutching at one of Scorpia's claws. The Flower Princess looked like she was just barely restraining herself from rushing across the room and throwing her arms around the older woman.

"You have me there. I *am* sorry I said you disregard your veil," Tercassi said solemnly.

"You should be." Shadow Weaver intoned. "You do not know me."

Hydric smiled slightly. "Beatrix would be so very proud of the woman you've become."

"Thank you," Shadow Weaver said.

Castaspella cleared her throat none too subtly.

"Would you like to come to the Victory Ball?" Shadow Weaver asked flatly.

"No, thank you." Tercassi declined. "We have intruded enough. We will speak some other time if you are amicable?"

Shadow Weaver inclined her head. "Another time," she said, watching as the family quietly took their leave.

Shadow Weaver and Angella agreed to get dressed for the ball in separate rooms to surprise each other before they were announced. She resisted the urge to wrap the sheer burgundy cape around her shoulders tighter and stepped out of the room to where Angella was patiently waiting for her. Angella looked at her and gasped.

The off the shoulder, red wine tinted dress was not Shadow Weaver's usual style. As she walked towards her wife, the cape trailed across the floor and the provocative thigh-high slit flashed a peek of her skin. White gold, winged heels adorned her feet.

"How am I going to be able to properly greet guests with you wearing that?" Angella's gaze darted from the sliver of skin exposed by the dress and back to her wife's face several times.

"If I am to suffer through this night then so are you." Shadow Weaver said, glancing over Angella's ball gown. It was a short, coral two-piece dress with a v-neck beaded bodice and a tiered full skirt.

"It was Bow's suggestion. I know my abdomen isn't as toned as his." Angella explained as she held her gloved hands elegantly in front of the gap. Her silver, rhinestoned hidden platform pumps kept her towering over Shadow Weaver.

"Quiet," Shadow Weaver said with a smile that displayed her dimples. "You look utterly enchanting, Angella."

"Thank you, my love. So do you." Angella gave Shadow Weaver a sweet kiss.

The fresh and sweet scents greeted them from the flowers braided along the stair banisters on all sides as they made their way to the second floor balcony that overlooked the ballroom. The walls were draped from floor to ceiling with luxurious fabric. An open window similar to the one in the throne room was a backdrop for the large banquet table facing the ballroom. It would be seating all the Princesses and their escorts. The room opened to the outdoor courtyard which held most of the tables of hors d’oeuvres and drinks.

"It seems Castaspella was successful in coercing the sorcerers into arranging the Bright Moon crystals into this chandelier," Shadow Weaver stated, looking at the dangling crystal strands that spiraled in a helix directly above the dance floor.

"I don't think she spent this much effort in assisting my mother with our wedding," Angella remarked.

"Do not remind me," Shadow Weaver drawled out irritably.

Angella laughed softly. "I'm sure Mother wasn't that bad."

"So you say." Shadow Weaver cocked an eyebrow at her wife. "I don't think she will ever forgive my mistake. I believe she is more offended by my conduct than you were."

"Yes, Glimmer told me what she put you through when you went to ask for my hand in marriage." Angella squeezed her hand softly.

"Nigella is a cruel woman."

"I wouldn't be surprised if you were secretly best friends." Angella eyed her wife expectantly. "Aren't you?"

"We have come to an...understanding." Shadow Weaver admitted neutrally as they stopped at their mark on the floor.

The orchestra playing ambient music stopped abruptly as Castaspella nodded to the guards standing at the top of the west staircase. The doors opened wide as the Princesses and their escorts filed inside. As the group entered, raucous applause rose through the banquet hall. Adora and Catra lead the way, followed by the rest of the Rebellion, while Frosta entered last escorted by Double Trouble. The Princesses of Power and their escorts lined up side by side and faced the balcony that held the queens of Bright Moon.

Each Princess sank into a perfect curtsey. Shadow Weaver and Angella nodded regally, accepting their gesture. When the brunette waved her hand in the air, she and Angella teleported to the top of the staircase next to Castaspella and Swift Wind, the announcer.

"Might I introduce the Queens of Bright Moon. First up is Angella, head of the Rebellion, member of the first and second Princess Alliance, daughter to Nigella the Angelic Queen of Empyrean. Next, we have our favorite queen of mean. Princess of Aldehaim, Runechilde to the Blush Sapphire, member of the second Princess Alliance, and daughter of the late General Beatrix also of Aldehaim. You loved to hate her, Shadow Weaver."

The crowd cheered as the queens disappeared again to take their place in the middle of the table. The rest of the Princesses sat and the inhabitants in the ballroom dispersed to the dozens of smaller tables with small centerpieces of opaque geometric glass that had the symbol of each Princesses' element on each side.

"Why did she allow Swift Wind to do this?" Angella groaned out quietly.

"From my understanding, it was either let Swift Wind announce the guests or he was going to do another victory song." Shadow Weaver chuckled at the sour expression on Angella's face. "Exactly. This is the path of least resistance."

Strings from the orchestra swelled in the air again and the Victory Ball was underway.

"Hello, everyone." Castaspella stood, clinking a butter knife against the closest glass. "I'd like to propose a toast. Thank you all for attending the first annual Victory Ball. It's been a delight to plan but I couldn't have done it without Shadow Weaver who has prepared a speech for us this evening." she declared, clapping politely with her champagne flute.

"I told you she would get you back somehow." Angella singsonged.

"Public speaking has never frightened me." Shadow Weaver sniffed as she stood and addressed the room. "Let us have another round of applause for our lovely event planner."

Shadow Weaver waited until the applause died down before she began. “What a difference a year makes. This memorial is a celebration of life and our triumph over evil. Etheria is at peace. Magic has been restored to our planet and we made it here by the power of teamwork, friendship, and most importantly love.”

"And Horde desertions!" Came a shout from the back of the crowd, drawing a chuckle from the partygoers.

"That is very true, Kyle." Shadow Weaver agreed. "I never planned to be in prison, awaiting transport to Beast Island but I'm glad it happened. Those events introduced me to a new venture, a new chapter in my life. Life, it seems, is random and chaotic that way. Nothing ever goes the way you planned it and as I'm sure Adora can tell you, even the most perfect of plans will fall apart.”

“Prime Horde planned for peace utilizing tyranny and destruction. I know I'm not the only one glad his plans failed. Etheria's journey to peace will be vastly different. It will involve healing, and magic, and just a touch of love. Keep in mind that healing does not happen overnight. Healing is a battle in and of itself. It is work and it is a struggle. But it's also an art that takes time and more love. And we have plenty of love gathered here so let's take a bit of time by observing a few moments of silence for those that gave their lives so that we might have a chance at this healing path.” Shadow Weaver bowed her head.

She reflected on the war and the past year. Her initial reason for escaping prison had been for revenge and wrath. It was the only thing she wanted at the time but what she gained in return was friendship, family, and the answer to questions she didn't even know she'd needed to ask.

“Thank you for listening.” Shadow Weaver said, returning to her seat.

Everyone stood, clapping uproariously and cheering. Castaspella only appeared slightly annoyed through her fond smile.

"Did you prepare a speech?" Angella accused.

Shadow Weaver frowned. "Of course not. I suspected Castaspella might attempt to place me off guard. All I did was tell the truth and speak from my heart."

"Your 'heart' is very poetic." Angella pointed out.

"Do not be jealous. I save all of my most poetic moments for you." Shadow Weaver whispered too low for anyone to hear through the cheers.

"I better," Angella said, kissing her cheek.

"I think it's safe to say Scorpia got the sangria and punch mixed up." Angella chuckled at the original shanty that Scorpia and Sea Hawk belted out from the impromptu stage in the corner of the room. Her head rested on Shadow Weaver’s shoulder.

Shadow Weaver yawned, bringing her right hand up to cover her mouth.

“I finally settled.” Angella griped, scooting closer to get comfortable once more, unintentionally brushing her hair against a grayish-green ear. She felt the resulting shiver and smirked. She reached up, hands inching forward.

“It appears you had the same issue. Seeing as how you're getting rather handsy since you have imbibed this drink,” Shadow Weaver

drawled and tilted her head away. She intercepted the gloved hand, interlacing their fingers.

"You like my hands." Angella teased. She smiled down at their joined hands. "Speaking of, everyone is distracted and most of the guests have all but gone. We can go back to our room," she said in a low voice.

Shadow Weaver felt the beginning embers of heat spark to life at the suggestive tone. She stood smoothly, tugging Angella with her. The women walked out of the room and into the hallway. Once they were clear of the doorway, they quickened their steps to their bedroom.

"You are dismissed," Shadow Weaver said as they passed the guards stationed in front of the Royal Suite.

"Thank you, your majesty," The guards answered with a bow, removing themselves from the door.

Shadow Weaver felt the solid door against her back just as the latch clicked into place. If anyone were to turn their mind to such things, they probably assumed Shadow Weaver was the aggressor in the relationship. That was only partially true. In public, the women were equals. They bickered fondly and teased each other to no end but each woman gave as good as they got. In the bedroom, however, is where Angella reigned. It was the only place Shadow Weaver truly yielded and sought instruction.

"Now if I remember correctly. I owe someone for this morning." Angella gripped Shadow Weaver's chin, bringing their faces close. Her wife's warm breath brushed across her skin. Angella tightened her hold as the brunette tried to push forward past the final minuscule distance to connect their lips.

"Patience," Angella demanded. She tilted her head and leaned closer.

Soft, silk gloves removed her cape and brushed past all the skin the older woman had on display. Shadow Weaver's heart stuttered

in anticipation for their lips to finally touch. The sensation of the feather-light movement on her lips made her chase Angella's mouth unabashedly. Angella held her at bay twice more before allowing Shadow Weaver the kiss she so craved. Tongue flicking out, Angella traced the outline of her wife's lips. Angella's mouth swallowed the sigh that escaped the older woman.

This was a dance they had participated in several times but it was no less heady. It was reminiscent of drinking her wine too fast on an empty stomach. And of falling from a great height without great planning. Shadow Weaver always lost herself in Angella's kisses. All of their kisses were endlessly thrilling. Her hands were splayed against her wife's back below her wings, pulling her closer. Angella released Shadow Weaver's face and dropped her grip to her hips as she explored her wife's mouth. Their kisses melted together, the women testing their limits needing oxygen. They parted, breathing heavily in the small space.

Wet, kiss swollen lips parted with a whimper. “Angella.”

“Tell me what you need.”

“Please, you are driving me mad.” Shadow Weaver grabbed Angella’s hand and pressed it between her legs.

As soon as she released the hand, it pulled away. Angella's hand trailed up and down the exposed defined thigh, moved beneath the opening of the dress, and held her firmly. Swiping her hand through her wife's folds, Angella held her glistening fingers in the light and licked the wetness from her gloves with a pleased moan. She grabbed the ruined fabric between her teeth and started pulling the glove off her hand.

“No, keep them on.” Shadow Weaver stuttered.

“Are you sure?” Angella purred before plunging two fingers inside her lover after a couple of eager nods.

Shadow Weaver groaned as her head fell back, thudding against the door behind her. Angella used her body to press her love

harder against the door. She planted a tender kiss across Shadow Weaver's chin. Soft lips littered kisses up her throat until she reached the older woman's ears. The ombré haired woman's tongue traced random patterns along the outer shell. Angella alternated between flicking her tongue across the pointed tip and wet kisses in response to the staccato of breaths from her lover.

Shadow Weaver was certain the demon scars had desensitized her to any form of pleasure that didn't come from power. She quickly learned Angella's masterful manipulation of her body was more intoxicating. The brunette was drunk on Angella. She felt her everywhere. Wherever her wife's soft lips made contact with her skin, sent electric pulses directly to her sex. She felt the taut coil of pleasure deep inside her about to snap.

Angella felt the pulsing of Shadow Weaver's walls against her fingers, pulling her deeper, and redoubled her efforts, swirling her thumb across the previously ignored swollen nub while curling her digits in a beckoning motion. The effect was instantaneous, her eyes hungrily feasted on the sensuous movements of her wife.

Shadow Weaver's mouth released one last broken, wordless cry. She shuddered in Angella's arms, hips twitching as the world dissolved into white noise. She clutched at the ombré headed woman in front of her as she came down from her high. Angella was her only tether and anchor to this world.

Angella smiled, thrusting her fingers lazily, coaxing the last of the aftershocks from the lithe body beneath her. Shadow Weaver became aware of her grip at once. Careful to avoid damaging Angella's skin, she removed her hands and allowed the woman to safely pull away. She glared at her hands, rubbing the two talons of her middle finger and thumb together. She usually had better control but in the throes of passion was likely to hurt Angella unintentionally.

"I had some ideas about that," Angella stated, reading her wife's expression. She eagerly cleaned her gloves with a grin and unfurled her wings. She pulled the brunette with her and

immediately placed her on their bed. “Lay back.” She beat her wings softly, hovering above her wife. The queen rucked up the skirt of her gown to expose her cunt before lowering herself onto her lover’s waiting mouth.

Swiping her tongue through copious wetness, Shadow Weaver moaned at the first taste. She angled her head up, licking like it was the last time she’d get the privilege of pleasuring the other woman.

Angella rolled her hips gradually finding her rhythm. She was careful to avoid Shadow Weaver’s ears. It felt great but she always needed a bit more sensation. “Darling,” she shifted slightly and felt that deliciously wicked muscle teasing across her entrance. “I need-”

Shadow Weaver hummed and grabbed Angella’s thighs, pulling the queen tight against her mouth. She thrust her tongue inside, extending it as far as it would go, relishing the near scream she received for her efforts.

Angella reached up, holding the tension cables that suspended the bed. She pushed down, trying her best to meet the older woman thrust for thrust. Shadow Weaver felt her claws find purchase on lavender skin. Angella hissed above her and she relinquished her grip immediately.

“Don't hold back.” Angella gasped, using her left hand to tweak her nipple.

“I don’t want to hurt you.” Was the muffled reply.

“I’ll let you know my limits.” Angella grabbed her hands, placing a hand on her hip and the other on the top of her thigh. She liked feeling the sting. She trusted the brunette to stop if something went wrong. Playing just on the edge of danger was fun.

Angella's legs clamped tight against Shadow Weaver's head as she continued rocking herself to climax.

"Yes." Angella hissed hips jogging forward again. "More."

Shadow Weaver sucked harder and scratched her hand down Angella's back.

"Oh, my love!" Angella's slumped forward, forehead resting against the cool surface of the wall behind the bed. As she relaxed, she allowed herself to fall bonelessly to the side. "Mmm. I don't want to move."

"We should. Civilized people do not sleep in ball gowns."

"Just magic them off," Angella mumbled with a yawn.

"That's just convenient, isn't it? You think magic will just solve it all?" Shadow Weaver replied sarcastically.

Angella regarded her with lidded eyes. " *You* did at one point."

A husky, pleased chuckle emanated from Shadow Weaver. "Touché." She banished their clothing with a wave of her hand. "I love you, Angella."

"I love you too, Brecilia. With all of my heart."

-The End-

Chapter End Notes

I know nobody really reads these so I'll just kinda ramble on for a bit. I know for some this may have not turned out how you wanted or how you expected. In my opinion, that's the best kind of fic. Good surprise or bad, it's an experience. You stumble into a world crafted by a fanfiction writer and they

open a door or turn on your mind to something maybe you've never seen before or could have been different. I notice there's a lot of if/then vs what if in some of my favorite fic. (One might say that's literally any piece of anything, but I digress) 😅

I don't consider myself a proficient writer. I just really wanted to read this story and thought maybe I'd bring some people that were interested too along for the ride, lol. I wrote this because I watched SPOP, overanalyzed some moments, and had some crazy questions. My questions were: what if Shadow Weaver was an Elemental Princess? How many ridiculous shenanigans would she be put through because of this? What if she and Angella were together before the Spell of Obtainment? How do I save Angella from the portal?

I wondered if there was anything remotely similar to what I wanted to read and went to the internet. I searched for a couple of hours, looking for the story that would give me my fix and I just wasn't in the mood to read what I saw at that moment. I then stumbled onto some amazing fan art featuring Shadow Weaver and Angella via google. The muses rode in on their plot bunnies and I couldn't deny them. I wrote a couple of scenes of random dialogue then expanded. Like I said before Aldehaim came to me in a dream and then I wondered: how do we get Shadow Weaver there? What happens before that? How 'good' or 'nice' could I make her without seeming like I was getting away from my own plot/outline I made and more importantly her character?

Maybe some of these questions should have never been asked and maybe there is a better way to do them but here we are at the end of over 100k words. Like whoa, 😳🤯😳 it's easily the longest thing I've ever written, not counting my dissertation. 😁 I have written and scrapped so many scenes that it's hard to tell what of my first draft ever made it into what I've posted. (Another piece of useless trivia: this started as a weird Soulmate AU) I've tried to make my fic as tight as

possible but in the end I'm only human and there may be few plot holes here and there. For me that's okay. If it bothers you I really hope it inspires more works in the pairing or atleast provokes questions.

If there's one thing I want you all to do if you haven't especially if you've once had the urge, I encourage you to write, draw, edit videos, etc. Even if it's a key smash drabble or a one sentence fanfic. Write. Even if you want to write a crack fic tearing my fic to shreds. (Do it! I love crackfic 🤣) If you have an idea about fanworks that seems too insane to work, attempt it anyway. You don't even have to post your creation if you don't want to. You never know what may come from it. It's /your/ interpretation of the source material. Be proud of it. 🤗

I'm thankful for all the reviews, the kudos, and every hit to my fic I get. Huge, huuuge thank yous to you all for making this an amazing experience. 😊

Until next time. -Oracle.

P.S. Don't fret. I do have a few more ideas for this fandom. Also, I have seen fic that I would love to read on the site and I'm really excited because I finally get a little more time to. Maybe our paths will cross again over review text or kudos. 😄

End Notes

Welp, this is my offering. This story is nearly finished and all of the chapters are this lengthy, so I hope that's not a problem for anyone. :)

If anyone would be willing to be my beta for the rest of the fic, please let me know.

I look forward to your thoughts. ;)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!